

Author's Note

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Chapter 1 – Morning of a new Dawn

Mami awoke to golden light spilling through the cabin window, warm and steady. For the first time in what felt like forever, she didn't wake with a start. There were no shadows clawing at the edges of her dreams, no aching memories to sort through, no battles to prepare for. Just... peace.

And more than peace—purpose.

She sat up slowly, brushing a few strands of hair from her eyes. The memory of the dream lingered like a melody: laughter on the lake, healing hands, magic flowing freely, and all her friends living in harmony.

Was that what happiness felt like? Not just the absence of suffering... but the genuine presence of joy?

Her eyes drifted to her soul gem, which she'd placed on the small wooden table beside her bed.

It was glowing.

Brighter than yesterday—brighter than it ever had in recent memory. Even brighter than when she first arrived in this realm and felt her heart settle for the first time in years.

Mami stared at it, eyebrows gently raised in wonder. *So this is what it's like... to not just feel at peace—but to look forward to tomorrow.*

She held it in her palm, feeling its warmth like a pulse. "Is it because I was happy?" she whispered aloud. "Because I actually enjoyed myself?"

She smiled.

Throwing on her coat, she stepped outside into the crisp morning air—and was immediately greeted by a scene so absurd, she burst into laughter.

There on the grass, Lunaria was performing her usual elegant morning stretches—graceful as a crane, eyes closed, movements slow and deliberate.

And next to her... lay what looked like a linen-wrapped mummy.

Kasumi.

Only her face and the tips of her fingers peeked out from under layers of soft white cloth. She was motionless except for the tiniest of wiggles from one arm.

Mami covered her mouth to stifle another laugh. *Of course.*

It had to be another one of Kasumi's elaborate jokes—most likely playing up her “injuries” from the boat mishap last night.

“Good morning, Mami,” Lunaria said with a serene smile, not even opening her eyes as she flowed into another stretch. “How did you sleep?”

Mami stepped into the light, her heart still buoyant from the laughter and the lingering dream. “Wonderfully,” she said. “I had a dream about the future. A happy one.”

“Oh?” Lunaria tilted her head, now watching her attentively.

Mami nodded. “It was... magical girls, all of us, living together peacefully. Laughing, training, healing—just enjoying life. No despair. No decay. Just... being.”

She paused, then held out her soul gem, glowing like morning sun through honeyed glass.

“My soul gem is brighter than it's ever been. Even brighter than when I first arrived here and felt truly at peace. I think...” She smiled, amazed. “I think it's because I was genuinely happy. Maybe feeling joy—not just avoiding pain—is what strengthens us most.”

Lunaria's gaze warmed. She nodded slowly, knowingly. “It's true. That's the part most forget—or never learn. Joy isn't a luxury. It's nourishment.”

Before Mami could say more, a muffled voice called out dramatically from the grass.

“Hellooooo? I feel like I'm being *emotionally excluded* over here.”

Mami turned, grinning. Kasumi was barely moving, her voice pitched with fake weakness. “Sure, good mental health is great and all... but what about *my* physical condition? Poor me...”

Mami walked over, hands on her hips, trying to suppress her amusement. “So this is your new strategy? Guilt-tripping us with a dramatic injury arc?”

Kasumi didn't miss a beat. “Guilt-tripping? Mami, I'm practically bedridden. You saw what the lake animals did to me last night. I've been traumatized. Scarred.”

Mami chuckled. “So that's how I beat you in a fight—recruit the ducks.”

Kasumi gasped. “Cruel! To even consider fighting someone while they're injured!”

Mami leaned closer, playful. “You're not injured. You're fine. Why don't you just heal yourself like you did after the shadow monster fight? You were up and bouncing in no time after that.”

Kasumi pouted. “Mami, please. You saw how I healed back then. It’s not normal. It requires *very* specific movements and incantations. I’d have to do something like the Jellyfish Jig while chanting ‘Pudding Solves All Problems.’”

She gestured feebly with one hand, still mostly wrapped up. “Do I *look* like I can jellyfish jig in this state?”

Mami burst out laughing, and even Lunaria—graceful and composed—let out a gentle giggle behind her.

“In my professional opinion,” Mami said, “you looked way worse after the shadow monster. You were getting flung around like a ragdoll.”

Kasumi let out a dramatic groan. “Exactly! That’s why I’m *emotionally scarred*! No one takes my suffering seriously. **Emotional damage!**”

Lunaria, now finishing her stretches, walked over and crouched beside Kasumi with a soft smile. “If that’s the case,” she said gently, “then perhaps Mami can guide you. What was the name of that lovely drill again...?”

Then, with a twinkle in her eye and far more theatrical flair than usual, Lunaria stood, threw one hand into the air, and declared in a loud, over-the-top tone:

“Welcome to Amplifying Negative Emotions — EXTREMELY HARD MODE — Unforgiving Trial by Fire — Merciless Boss Battle — Now with 50% More Emotional Destruction~!”

Mami nearly doubled over in laughter, remembering all too well how Kasumi had thrown her into that exact drill their first day. “I can’t believe you actually said all of that with a straight face back then!”

Kasumi whimpered beneath the cloth wrappings, fake tears glistening in her sad puppy eyes. “Et tu, Lunaria? How could you both be so cruel to an injured soul...”

Mami sat down beside them, basking in the warmth of their antics. There was no looming pressure. No creeping dread. Just sunlight, laughter, and the peaceful certainty that she was growing stronger—not from battle, but from joy.

“I’m really looking forward to testing my magic later,” she said. “I want to see what it can do now—when it comes from a place like this.”

Lunaria nodded with quiet assurance. “You’ll see. It’s not just the magic that changes. It’s how you carry it.”

Kasumi, still playing the martyr, gave the faintest wiggle of one hand. “Don’t forget to save a little energy for helping poor, forgotten Kasumi...”

Mami smirked. “Only if you promise to chant ‘Pudding Solves All Problems’ later.”

“I make no promises,” Kasumi said solemnly.

Lunaria stood and stretched her arms with a grin. “Shall we eat, Mami? Poor Kasumi here clearly can’t walk, so I suppose she’ll just have to lie here alone and *perish*,” she added with a teasing smirk, already turning back toward the cabin.

Mami couldn’t help but laugh—a rich, full laugh from the heart. She felt light, unburdened. Safe. Happy.

“I think breakfast sounds *amazing*,” she said. Then, looking back over her shoulder at Kasumi: “Don’t worry, we’ll bring you leftovers... *if* there’s anything left.”

Kasumi’s voice shot up in alarm. “NONONONO WAIT WAIT! Let me go in with YOOOOOOOOOU!”

As Mami and Lunaria walked toward the cabin, they paused at the door and looked back—only to see Kasumi squirming like a worm in a cocoon, inching slowly across the grass toward them.

They both burst out laughing again.

“I think it’ll take her a while,” Lunaria said, her voice light with amusement.

“Yeah, let’s eat. I’m starving,” Mami agreed, grinning as they slipped inside and gently shut the door.

“NOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOO!”

Kasumi’s wail echoed behind them as they started preparing breakfast.

The morning light poured gently into the cabin as Mami and Lunaria sat across from one another at the small wooden breakfast table. The scent of fresh bread and sweet forest berries filled the air, mingling with the warm steam rising from their cups of herbal tea.

Mami took a bite of toast, then smiled softly. “So... what kind of training will I be doing today?”

Lunaria set her cup down, her expression serene. “Today, you take your first step beyond the basics. You’ve already learned the fundamental nature of Connect. You even succeeded in shaping a fragment of the world itself—a leaf born from harmony with the plants around you. That means you’re ready.”

“Ready for... what?” Mami asked, leaning forward with interest.

“To Connect with other magical girls,” Lunaria replied. “Not just passively or through memory, but directly—with those who are willing to meet you in that space.”

Mami blinked, a flicker of excitement rising in her chest. “Wait. So I’ll be training with another magical girl today?”

Lunaria smiled, clearly amused by Mami’s not-so-subtle probing.

Mami tilted her head innocently. “Well... I just assumed it might be someone I already know.” She added with a teasing smile, “Perhaps someone who’s been keeping secrets?”

Lunaria gave a gentle laugh, folding her hands in her lap. “I admire your curiosity. But let’s take a step back, shall we? Do you remember what I told you on your first day here, about the types of training you’d encounter?”

Mami nodded. “Yes. There were tutorials, drills, and battles.”

“Correct,” Lunaria said. “And do you remember how they differ?”

Mami sipped her tea thoughtfully. “Tutorials and drills are for learning the fundamentals... and battles are where you apply what you’ve learned in real combat.”

“Exactly,” Lunaria said, eyes twinkling. “And you also may recall that in the battle category, you’re able to face not only monsters and witches—but magical girls from throughout history.”

Mami’s eyes widened slightly as the memory surfaced. “That’s right...! You said I could fight witches or even magical girls from the past. I didn’t really think about what that meant at the time.”

“Most don’t,” Lunaria said with a knowing smile. “But it’s true. The arena responds to your intent and the strength of your emotional connection. It draws upon essence—data, memory, emotional resonance. Just like how Kasumi used a portion of her own essence to create a version of herself to train you, while the real her sparred with me. **The same principle applies to any magical girl whose essence has been recorded by the arena.**”

Mami set her cup down, the soft clink echoing through the quiet cabin. “So... I could call forth anyone... Someone I know. Someone I was close to. Even if they aren’t here anymore.”

Lunaria nodded gently. “Exactly. **That’s the beauty of Connect. It’s not limited by space—or even time.** As long as there’s an emotional bond, the arena can reach for their essence.”

Mami’s heart stirred. Her thoughts drifted, unbidden, to the past. To a certain red-haired girl with fire in her step and defiance in her eyes. A partner. A friend. Someone who had slipped away too soon.

“There’s only one person who comes to mind,” Mami said softly. “Kyoko. But not the one I fought recently. I mean... the one from before. When we were still partners. When she still had hope.”

Lunaria nodded, her voice gentle. “A wise choice. That Kyoko—the one you remember, the one whose essence still resonates with you. She would share the same spirit as the Kyoko who stood by your side in battle. And because you have such a deep bond, she would be more likely to meet you halfway in Connect.”

A breath caught in Mami's throat. The thought of seeing that version of Kyoko again—of talking to her, fighting beside her, not as enemies or strangers, but as friends—it sent a warmth curling through her chest.

"I wonder what she'll be like," Mami murmured. "Will she remember us? Will she... be the same?"

"She will," Lunaria said gently. "She'll have all her memories and thoughts from the specific point in time you call her forth. She'll recognize the bond you shared—and respond to it."

Mami looked out the window. The sunlight shimmered on the lake in the distance. Somewhere in the realm, Kasumi was probably still dramatically squirming around like a half-mummified worm, but for the moment, Mami's heart was elsewhere—reaching backward, and forward, all at once.

She turned back to Lunaria, eyes glowing with resolve. "I'd like to try. I want to meet her again. And if I can... I want to see what we can become now."

Lunaria smiled with quiet pride. "Then let's begin when you're ready. The arena is waiting."

They stood together, pushing open the cabin door. Morning light spilled in, golden and fresh, brushing against the floorboards like soft paint. Lunaria stepped out first, her movements fluid and quiet, as if she were part of the realm itself.

Mami followed... but paused as a thought suddenly came back to her.

"Most don't"

"The same principle applies to any magical girl whose essence has been recorded by the arena."

"Connect isn't limited by space—or even time."

Mami's eyes widened slightly as it clicked. That meant someone—whoever created this place—had a connection with *all* those magical girls. Witches, monsters, even legends from long ago. Their essence, their data, their resonance... somehow, it had all been gathered, recorded. Preserved.

And as far as Mami knew, only two people she had met possessed the depth of knowledge—and the kind of quiet, impossible power—it would take to create something like this.

Lunaria and Kasumi.

They had to be more than just kind caretakers or guides.

"...Lunaria?" Mami asked, stepping into the morning air, her voice careful but clear.

Lunaria stopped just outside the doorway, the sun catching in her deep indigo hair. She didn't turn right away.

“You said the arena holds the essence of magical girls... from across time,” Mami continued. “That it works through emotional bonds. But that would mean someone had to form those bonds. Someone had to *gather* all of that. Did... did you and Kasumi create all of this?”

Lunaria slowly turned her head over her shoulder. Her dark eyes met Mami’s, calm and ancient, but this time—*this time*—there was a flicker of something deeper.

A softness. A sadness. Nostalgia, perhaps.

Her smile came slowly, like the reflection of moonlight in still water.

“...Maybe another time,” Lunaria said, her voice gentle, tinged with emotion Mami couldn’t quite place.

And then, for a moment, Mami stood frozen.

That *exact* response.

She remembered now. Her first night here—when she asked Lunaria who she truly was, just before the girl left her bedside.

The same words.

The same tone.

The same look in her eyes.

“*Maybe another time.*”

The déjà vu settled over her like a whisper from something ancient.

Mami didn’t press further. Not yet.

She simply stepped forward, letting the door close behind her with a quiet *click*.

The sun was rising higher now, and the sky above the clearing was a soft canvas of blue and gold.

Today, she would meet Kyoko again.

But someday soon...

She would find out the truth.

Mami and Lunaria stepped out into the soft morning light, the scent of dew still clinging to the grass, birdsong fluttering through the trees. But the peaceful scene was quickly upstaged by a sight that made Mami stop mid-step, blinking.

Kasumi was still lying where they had left her—wrapped in linen like a half-hearted mummy cosplay, her head just barely peeking out. But now, she was surrounded by a small crowd of woodland animals.

A pair of rabbits nestled at her side. A squirrel sat on her hip like it was a throne. A curious fox was curled up near her feet, swishing its tail contentedly. Birds fluttered about, occasionally landing on the

cloth that swaddled her like a blanket of defeat. One bird even hopped up and perched boldly on her forehead.

All of them were brushing, nudging, and playfully swarming her like they were comforting a wounded comrade—or maybe just enjoying her helplessness.

Mami brought a hand to her mouth, suppressing a laugh—until a glowing egg-shaped object materialized in the air and floated just beneath Kasumi’s lips. Without moving her hands, Kasumi leaned forward and bit into it like it was the most normal thing in the world.

Mami blinked. “Is she... using their essence to cook breakfast for herself?”

Lunaria hummed in amused confirmation. “It seems so.”

The floating egg made Mami’s mind flash back to her first night in the realm, when she had watched Lunaria playing harp and flute simultaneously—her lips drawing music from the flute as it hovered in the air while both hands were occupied with the harp. That same ease. That same otherworldly grace.

Even wrapped like a burrito, Kasumi somehow pulled off absurdity with style.

Just then, Kasumi spotted them. Her head tilted dramatically toward them, eyes wide and shimmering with performative despair. “How could you?” she cried, voice dripping with theatrical betrayal. “You left me to perish alone in the wilderness. Look at me! A husk of my former self!”

Lunaria smiled serenely. Mami snorted.

Kasumi gestured vaguely with her chin toward the animals. “Only *they* showed mercy. They felt so *bad* about what happened last night, they came to comfort me in my time of need.”

At her words, the fox perked its ears and let out a soft *yip*, looking pointedly at Lunaria. The squirrels chattered in what sounded suspiciously like disagreement. The birds ruffled their feathers, as if to say: *We’re not here out of pity. You’re just warm and funny to sit on.*

Lunaria glanced at Mami, lips twitching. “I don’t think they’re quite as sympathetic as she believes.”

Mami laughed—really laughed, a deep bubbling laugh from her chest. “I thought they just liked to tease her,” she said between giggles. “Not *comfort* her in her time of ‘need.’”

“I heard that,” Kasumi said dramatically, although she made no move to rise. She tilted her head back toward the fox. “See? They mock me. Only you understand me, Sir Fluffington.”

The fox promptly stood up, stretched, and trotted off with a mischievous grin.

“Traitor,” Kasumi muttered.

The squirrel on her hip scurried up her arm and tapped its tiny paw on her forehead twice, then scampered off as well. The birds fluttered upward in a swirl of motion, chirping what could only be described as giggling.

Kasumi let out an exaggerated sigh. “Even my loyal companions have abandoned me. This is the end.”

Mami wiped a tear from her eye, cheeks sore from smiling. “Kasumi,” she said, her voice still thick with laughter, “you’re absolutely ridiculous.”

“And yet you love me,” Kasumi replied without missing a beat, still perfectly unmoving under her linen wraps.

Lunaria chuckled. “Come, Mami. We should begin your training. We’ll leave the fallen hero to gather her strength.”

“You’re both monsters,” Kasumi called after them, her tone now more amused than accusatory.

“We’ll bring you a pillow,” Mami said with a grin as they walked off. “Maybe.”

“Cruel and unusual,” Kasumi murmured to the sky, her voice barely audible under the sound of a bird landing back on her head.

And as Mami followed Lunaria toward the training arena, her heart felt impossibly light. The beauty of it all—the peace, the laughter, the surreal joy—was like something from a dream.

But this wasn’t a dream.

This was real.

And it was only just beginning.

Chapter 2 – A Light Against the Dark

The bright morning light faded behind them as Lunaria and Mami stepped through the veil into the familiar arena—the same wide, circular expanse surrounded by soft green grass that shimmered under the open sky. Giant flower pods floated in the air like ornate, suspended platforms, and gentle winds swirled through the stands, rustling petals and carrying the scent of distant blossoms.

Mami took a deep breath. The air here always felt different—sharper, clearer, like it had been filtered through clarity itself.

She stepped forward into the field and looked up. This place. This stage. It was where everything changed.

Lunaria, standing beside her, turned with a calm smile. “Your soul gem is shining brighter than ever. You’ve begun to appreciate life again—its beauty, its chaos, even its simplicity. Are you ready to see how that light translates into magic?”

Mami looked down at her soul gem, aglow with a bright, radiant gold. No longer dulled by loneliness or fear, it felt like a part of her again—*whole*.

“Yes,” she said firmly. “I want to see what I can do now.”

Just then, an exuberant voice echoed across the field like a theatrical announcement.

“This—I *definitely* need to see!”

Mami and Lunaria turned their heads toward the sound, squinting up at one of the high flower pods floating above the arena.

A swirl of golden-red light exploded midair, followed by a poof of sparkly smoke and a sudden burst of confetti.

There, lying dramatically atop the flower pod, arms spread wide in triumph, was Kasumi—still swaddled head to toe in her linen mummy wraps.

Mami blinked—then burst out laughing.

“Kasumi! If you could do that, why didn’t you just teleport into the cabin this morning to eat breakfast with us?”

Kasumi’s eyes widened as if struck by divine revelation. “You’re a genius! I *should* have done that!” She gave one arm a dramatic wiggle. “Why didn’t I think of that sooner? Look at you, Mami—already applying creative magical thinking! Our teachings are finally taking root!”

Mami crossed her arms with a smirk. “If *that’s* what you call creativity, I’m starting to question everything you’ve taught me.”

Kasumi flashed a cheeky grin. “Oh yeah? Then how about *this* for creativity?” She shifted slightly, her linens rustling. “You can try... ***Welcome to Amplifying Negative Emotions — EXTREMELY HARD MODE — Unforgiving Trial by Fire — Merciless Boss Battle — Now with 50% More Emotional Destruction~!***”

Then she gave a playful wink.

“...Again.”

The air around them shivered slightly, as if the arena itself remembered.

Mami’s smile faded a touch, a visible shudder running through her as the name alone triggered vivid memories. That awful pressure. That darkness sinking into her soul gem. The helplessness she felt trying to survive in the face of the shadow monster, when everything in the arena had seemed tilted against her.

Her body tensed unconsciously.

Lunaria, sensing the shift, stepped gently in front of her. Her voice was soft but resolute. “I actually think that’s a good idea.”

Mami looked at her in disbelief.

Lunaria continued, her tone warm. “You don’t have to win. That isn’t the point. The point is to face that darkness again—not from the same place of fear or confusion, but from the clarity and strength you’ve found. You’ll be able to measure your growth. Not just your magic... but your heart.”

Mami glanced at Kasumi, who gave her a big thumbs-up and an excited wiggle from inside her wraps. She was clearly thrilled to watch the chaos unfold.

Mami sighed, then smiled. “You two have a habit of throwing me into the deep end and calling it teaching.”

“You’re still swimming, aren’t you?” Kasumi called from above.

Mami chuckled and nodded. “Alright then. Let’s do it.”

Kasumi let out an excited cheer. “Yes! This is gonna be so good!”

As if on cue, one of the flower pods floated down silently beside Lunaria. She stepped onto it with grace, giving Mami a gentle nod. “We’ll be watching. Good luck.”

Mami nodded back. “Thanks.”

The pod lifted silently into the air, rising slowly to join the others. Kasumi was already bouncing with anticipation—well, as much as a linen-wrapped body could bounce.

The air in the arena began to shift. The sunlight dimmed subtly. A low hum stirred the grass under Mami’s feet. Shadows crept along the edges of the field like ink spreading through water.

Mami stood tall, her musket already forming in her hand with a shimmer of golden light. Around her, delicate golden ribbons curled and danced in the air like they were alive, reacting to her focused energy. They shimmered with the same inner glow as her soul gem—brighter than ever, resonating with her sharpened clarity and sense of purpose.

It’s coming.

Her breath hitched as the atmosphere turned heavy. She could feel it now—the same darkness as before. It oozed from the far side of the arena, coalescing in an unnatural fog. She felt it crawl toward her, like fingers tracing the edges of her soul.

A single bead of sweat rolled down the side of her face.

This time... it’s different, she reminded herself. I’m different.

And yet... her heart pounded.

The arena darkened, inch by inch, as if a curtain of ink were being drawn over the world. The air grew cold, heavy—not with temperature, but with a weight that pressed into the bones. Then came the

smoke, rolling in like thick fog, swallowing color, light, and space until there was nothing left but shadow.

And then it *unfolded*.

The monster emerged the same way it had the first time: not by stepping forward or rising from below, but by unraveling itself from the black. As if it had always been there, waiting. A mass of moving darkness—faceless, formless, terrifying. Wings stretched into claws, then collapsed into spears, which dissolved into tendrils that shimmered with hints of mouths and fangs before curling inward again.

It was everything and nothing. Familiar—and still utterly alien.

Mami's legs shook. She instinctively took a step back, then caught herself. Her breathing was steady, but shallow. Her hand clenched tightly around the grip of her musket.

It's here again...

She braced herself, eyes flicking down toward her Soul Gem, expecting the inevitable. That creeping darkness. The corruption that had nearly overwhelmed her last time.

But—nothing.

The gem shimmered golden, unblemished. Pure.

And the monster didn't move.

It swayed in place, a silent tide of shape and distortion, but it didn't approach. It didn't lash out. It didn't even seem to notice her.

Mami narrowed her eyes.

Is it... waiting for me?

The realization struck her: the battle hadn't begun. Not fully. Not until *she* made the first move. Not until *she* declared herself ready to face it.

A part of her wanted to wait longer—to delay the inevitable. But another part, stronger now than before, told her the truth:

She had come here to prove to herself how far she had come.

Mami inhaled deeply, holding her breath at its peak, then let it go slowly. Her golden ribbons began to flutter around her, rising into the air like streamers caught in a silent breeze. Her muskets appeared one by one, orbiting her like a constellation of stars, each glowing softly in the gloom.

She raised her hand.

And then—*fired*.

The sound tore through the silence like a thunderclap. All her guns fired in perfect unison, releasing a blazing golden barrage. The blast erupted forward, colliding with the monster in a brilliant explosion that lit up the entire arena. Smoke and fire twisted in all directions. The ground beneath her feet trembled.

Mami braced herself, arms shielding her face from the shockwave. Her coat rippled wildly as wind and heat surged past her. She could feel the force of her own magic—*stronger* than anything she had released before.

When the light finally faded and the dust settled, she lowered her arms, blinking through the settling haze.

Far across the field, the shadow monster still stood—but part of its mass had been torn away. The wound was already knitting itself back together, but it had *been wounded*.

Mami's eyes widened in shock. Then, slowly, a smile broke across her face.

I actually hurt it.

It wasn't much. But it was real. *Tangible*. And nothing like the hopelessness she'd felt the first time.

From somewhere far above—out of Mami's sight, and well beyond her hearing through the thick veil of shadow—Kasumi's voice echoed with giddy excitement.

“THAT WAS SO COOL! Did you see that?! She blasted it clean in the face!! This is already a hundred times better than last time!”

In another floating flower pod nearby, Lunaria smiled softly and gave a quiet, graceful clap of her hands. “Her magic has evolved,” she murmured. “But so has she. This time, she believes in the beauty of her own light.”

She gazed down at the growing darkness beginning to seep into Mami's Soul Gem.

“But now comes the real test,” she said. “How will she carry that light... when the shadows press back?”

Back in the arena, Mami stood taller now.

But then... something shifted.

The monster turned.

Not drifting or gliding—but *twisting*, like the shadows themselves obeyed a new law of gravity. Its faceless form tilted toward her. Watching.

And then—

It moved.

A pulse of pressure rolled through the field like a wave, invisible but undeniable. Mami staggered, her heart skipping a beat.

She looked down.

Her Soul Gem was no longer clear.

Thin black veins had begun to crawl along its edges.

The trial had begun.

And this time... it saw her.

Mami braced herself, body low, breath steady—eyes locked onto the swirling black mist ahead. Her musket hovered beside her, golden light softly pulsing through its barrel, while her ribbons floated protectively around her like silent sentinels.

She remembered this.

She remembered how the monster had fought Kasumi—relentlessly, violently, with a barrage of tendrils and limbs that struck from all angles. It hadn't moved so much as *unfolded* from the shadows, its form more concept than creature. It hadn't walked or lunged—it had simply *been everywhere*, overwhelming Kasumi with a flurry of attacks that battered her like a leaf in a storm.

And Mami, standing on the sidelines, hadn't even been able to follow the motion. The monster had blurred through space, its tendrils crashing like whips of darkness from all directions. If it fought her like that now... she wouldn't last a few seconds.

The arena was silent.

The monster rippled, a distortion in the smoke.

Then—movement.

A tendril shot out of the fog, slicing through the air like a lance of shadow.

Mami saw it.

She *saw it*.

Her body moved on instinct, diving into a sidestep. The tendril snapped past her, striking the ground with a sound like breaking stone. Black mist kicked up in a wave, curling behind her as she landed in a crouch.

Her heart pounded, but her soul gem didn't react too much. Still relatively clean and steady.

It's holding back.

The realization came like a whisper in her mind.

The monster wasn't going all out like it had with Kasumi. Its movement, its timing—it was fast, but deliberate. Measured. Testing her.

Mami's eyes narrowed.

It's watching me. Judging my level. This is part of the trial... part of how the arena scales.

Another shadow twitched to her right.

Her eyes snapped toward it just as a second tendril lashed out—faster this time, sharper.

She twisted her body, but not in time to fully avoid it. The tip grazed across her upper arm.

She hissed as pain flared across her skin, hot and sharp. Blood beaded quickly, seeping into the sleeve of her outfit.

Not lethal, she thought. But getting closer.

She landed, feet skidding slightly on the blackened floor—only for the mist behind her to churn violently.

Mami's eyes widened.

What... Where... Where did it go?

Right when she formed that thought, something massive slammed into her back.

A fist—not shaped like a normal arm, but a jagged coalescence of limbs and darkness—struck her with thunderous force.

Her breath tore from her lungs as her body was launched backward like a broken doll.

The shadow monster's fist sent Mami flying through the thick shadows, crashing her into the far edge of the arena. Her body hit hard, a dull thud echoing across the field, followed by a cloud of dust and curling shadow mist. She barely managed to extend her ribbons in time to soften the impact, wrapping some around her waist and ankle to absorb the blow—though not enough.

Her back hit the ground and bounced once before she rolled to a stop, coughing as her ribs flared with pain. A faint trail of blood stained the corner of her lips. Her soul gem pulsed ominously—darker than before.

From above, Kasumi flinched so hard her linen-wrapped arms flopped against her sides. “Yikes! That *had* to hurt! That ragdoll bounce was brutal!” she cried out gleefully, like she was watching a particularly violent action scene in a movie. “She’s getting tossed around like *me* now! Beautiful~!”

Lunaria, seated calmly with her hands folded in her lap, narrowed her eyes. “Her physical form is holding, but only barely,” she said softly. “And her soul gem is already dimming. This is a true dual-front battle: body and soul.”

Down below, Mami groaned and rolled onto her side, one arm trembling as she forced herself up. Her other hand pressed against her ribs. Bruised. Possibly cracked. Blood still trickled from the scrape on her arm where the tendril had grazed her.

Then—clarity.

As she knelt there, a single realization clicked into place.

Her ribbons. One of them had been drifting beside her just before the shadow monster's punch landed—and she *felt* it. The way the ribbon shifted, the tension, the sudden pressure in the air... it was almost like a sixth sense. Her ribbon had been disturbed a fraction of a second before the punch struck.

She raised her head, golden curls a little disheveled, and looked down at her floating ribbons—still weaving around her in soft loops. If she attuned herself to them, she could use them like antennae. Sensors.

“...That might work,” she whispered, her breath catching on the pain.

She looked to her Soul Gem, which now shimmered with threads of darkness swirling within it like ink. Still manageable, but definitely worse than before. The weight of despair was creeping in again—but slower this time. She wasn’t drowning. Not yet.

She chuckled weakly to herself. “This is so unfair. Dodge or die on one side... while babysitting your emotions on the other. How in the world did Kasumi do this?”

“GET UP, MAMI!!” Kasumi shouted from above, pumping her mummy-wrapped arms in excitement. “Use the pain! Embrace the suffering! Let it FIRE UP YOUR BATTLE LUST!”

Lunaria chuckled softly beside her. “I don’t believe most people *cultivate battle lust* the way you do, Kasumi.”

Kasumi grinned and gave her a dramatic linen-wrapped wink. “Hey, it works for me.”

She leaned forward, eyes glinting as she gazed back down toward the battlefield.

“But let’s see what *Mami* does now...”

Mami groaned softly as she pushed herself upright, one hand braced against the ground, the other clutching her musket. Her limbs trembled, her ribs ached, and her vision swam—but she stood. Wobbly, disoriented, but standing.

The shadow monster rippled in the distance, its form shifting like smoke caught in a storm. It didn't advance. It waited.

Mami looked down at her Soul Gem. The black veins had spread further, curling like ink through golden glass. The weight of despair was pressing in again—slow, insidious, familiar.

No, she thought. Not this time.

She closed her eyes and reached inward.

She remembered the music—Kasumi's passionate rock performance with the student **Second Period Detention** band, wild and unapologetic, and Lunaria's serene harp and flute, ethereal and grounding. Two wildly different styles, yet somehow carrying the same message. She remembered the leaf she had shaped from nature's essence, the quiet pride of creating something gentle and real. She remembered laughter on the lake, glitter bombs in the sky, birds landing on Kasumi's head, and the warmth of tea shared in quiet companionship.

She remembered joy.

And slowly, she breathed.

The darkness in her Soul Gem pulsed once—then stilled. It didn't vanish, but its spreading slowed considerably. Her ribbons shimmered faintly, and her muskets hovered nearby, steady and luminous, responding to the shift in her emotional state. They floated more smoothly now, their movements synchronized with her breath, like extensions of her will.

Above, in the flower pods, Kasumi leaned forward so hard she nearly rolled off her perch. "She's doing it! She's actually doing it!" she cried, linen wraps flailing. "Look at that Soul Gem! It's stabilizing! She's using the good vibes! I told her fun was a weapon!"

Lunaria smiled, her voice calm but proud. "She's remembering who she is. That's the first step. The arena responds to clarity—and she's beginning to shine."

Back in the arena, Mami opened her eyes. Her gaze was steady now. Her stance firmer. Her ribbons floated like golden threads of intent, weaving through the air with quiet purpose.

Then—movement.

A tendril shot from the monster, slicing through the fog like a whip of shadow.

But this time, Mami didn't flinch.

One of her ribbons twitched—just slightly, just enough. She felt it. The pressure. The shift. The warning.

She moved.

Her body twisted in a clean, practiced dodge, the tendril missing her by inches and slamming into the ground behind her with a thunderous crack.

Mami landed in a crouch, breath steady, eyes sharp.

Above, Kasumi exploded with joy. “Now *that’s* what I’m talking about! She totally used her ribbons like sensors—dodging while keeping her Soul Gem stable? That was slick!”

Lunaria clapped her hands softly, her voice warm. “She’s beginning to apply her magic in new ways. I’m eager to see where her creativity leads next.”

Mami landed from the dodge, her boots skidding slightly across the darkened arena floor. Her breath was steady, her stance firm. *I can do this*, she thought, her eyes locked on the swirling mass of shadow ahead.

She glanced down at her Soul Gem. The veins of darkness still pulsed faintly, but they weren’t spreading uncontrollably. Not yet. The arena’s passive connection to despair was feeding into her gem, but she had a plan now—one Lunaria had taught her.

Use it, she reminded herself. *Don’t just resist the negativity. Harness it. Shape it. Let it build, then release it when the moment is right.*

She remembered the lesson clearly—how she’d learned to channel fear, sadness, and anger during her fight with Charlotte. But this was the next step: *intentional control*. Letting the emotions accumulate, storing them like pressure behind a dam, and then unleashing them in a single, devastating strike.

It was risky. The longer she held on, the more fragile her Soul Gem would become. But this arena—this fight—was the perfect place to test it. The negativity was already flowing into her. All she had to do was hold it... and wait.

The shadow monster rippled again.

And then it escalated.

Tendrils burst from the fog—not one, but many. A dozen lashes of darkness shot toward her from all directions, slicing through the air like jagged spears.

Mami’s eyes widened. *It’s scaling up.*

She moved.

Her ribbons flared outward, sensing the pressure shifts, the subtle distortions in the mist. She twisted, ducked, spun—dodging one tendril, then another, then another. Her body moved like a dancer caught in a storm, each motion guided by the faintest twitch of her golden threads.

But it was harder now. Much harder.

She grimaced as a tendril grazed her shoulder, tearing through the edge of her coat. Another slammed into the ground beside her, sending up a shockwave that knocked her off balance.

I can't focus, she realized, teeth clenched. *Not fully. Not while dodging this.*

Her Soul Gem flickered—still stable, but trembling. The negativity was building, but her control was slipping. She couldn't afford to lose focus. Not now.

Above, Kasumi was practically vibrating with excitement. “She’s dodging like a pro! Look at her go! But oof—this is brutal. That monster’s going full multi-strike mode!”

Lunaria’s gaze was calm, but her voice carried a note of concern. “She’s trying to balance both fronts—physical and emotional. It’s the hardest part of this technique. But if she can hold on longer...”

Kasumi leaned forward, eyes gleaming. “Then she’ll have enough power to *blast that thing into next week!*”

Lunaria smiled faintly. “If she times it right.”

Back in the arena, Mami slid to a stop, panting, her ribbons flickering around her like golden nerves. Her Soul Gem pulsed—darkness swirling within, but still contained.

She had to endure. Just a little longer.

Then she’d strike.

The shadow monster surged again, its tendrils lashing out faster than before—a storm of black spears slicing through the air. Mami dodged the first, then the second, her ribbons twitching with warning. But the third came too fast.

A tendril slammed into her thigh with brutal force.

She cried out, collapsing onto one knee, her musket clattering to the ground beside her. Pain shot through her leg like fire, and her breath came in short, ragged bursts.

Above, Kasumi flinched, her linen-wrapped arms jerking upward. “Oof! That hit deep! That’s a leg-breaker if I’ve ever seen one!”

Lunaria’s eyes narrowed, her voice low. “The monster is testing her threshold. It’s waiting. Watching. This is the moment it wants to see.”

Down below, Mami gritted her teeth, her hand trembling as she reached for her Soul Gem.

It was darkening fast.

The veins of shadow pulsed violently now, creeping inward like ink spilled in water. Her control was slipping. Her emotions—fear, pain, frustration—were surging. And she couldn't dodge anymore. Not with one leg.

It's now or never.

She closed her eyes and focused.

She gathered every ounce of negativity—every wound, every doubt, every memory of despair—and poured it into her Soul Gem. The pressure built like a storm behind glass. Her ribbons flared outward, her muskets hovered, trembling with power.

The monster sensed it. Tendrils shot toward her, a final barrage.

Mami opened her eyes.

And fired.

A golden explosion erupted from her position, brighter and louder than anything she'd ever summoned. Her muskets discharged in perfect unison, her ribbons spiraling outward like radiant whips of light. The blast tore through the arena, a shockwave of raw emotion and magic that sent petals flying and shadows recoiling.

The shockwave from Mami's attack tore through the arena, rattling the flower pods above and sending petals swirling like golden snow. She braced herself, arms crossed, ribbons flaring outward to shield her from the blast. The force rippled through her body, and for a moment, everything was light and sound.

Then—silence.

Mami lowered her arms slowly, her breath ragged. Her Soul Gem pulsed faintly in her palm. Much of the darkness had been burned away in the blast, but not all. Thin veins of shadow still curled within it, and the color had dulled—faded from radiant gold to a pale amber. She had spent nearly everything.

She looked up.

The smoke was clearing.

Her heart lifted—just slightly, just hopefully.

And then she saw it.

The shadow monster had taken moderate damage. Small portions of its form were torn, fragments of its mass dissolving slowly into the mist. But it remained upright—intact, alert, and utterly unfazed. Still standing. Still watching.

Mami blinked.

Then—she laughed.

A soft, surprised laugh bubbled up from her chest, and she brought a hand to her mouth in disbelief. *I'm laughing?* she thought. *I'm actually... enjoying this?*

She was proud. Not because she'd won—she hadn't. But because she'd fought with everything she had. Because she'd grown. Because she'd felt joy in the middle of chaos.

Lunaria's words echoed in her mind: *"You don't have to win. That isn't the point. The point is to face that darkness again—not from the same place of fear or confusion, but from the clarity and strength you've found. You'll be able to measure your growth. Not just your magic... but your heart."*

Above, Kasumi was practically vibrating with excitement. "THAT WAS AMAZING! Did you see that blast?! It was so *POW* and *KABLAM*! And she's laughing! She's actually laughing! I love this girl! *Embrace your battle lust!*"

Lunaria's smile was soft, her eyes shimmering with quiet pride. "She's found it. The joy in her own strength. The peace in her own chaos."

But the moment didn't last.

The shadow monster twitched.

Then struck.

A barrage of tendrils shot forward, faster than before—merciless, final.

Mami saw them coming.

She didn't move.

She closed her eyes.

Her Soul Gem pulsed once more, dim but steady.

I did my best, she thought. And I'm proud of that.

The tendrils pierced her body—one through her shoulder, another through her side, a third slicing across her ribs, and a final one through her heart. Her breath caught, her body lifted slightly from the force.

But her expression didn't change.

She smiled.

And then—darkness.

Her body crumpled to the ground, ribbons falling limp around her, muskets fading into light.

No confetti this time huh? was Mami’s last thought as her consciousness fades.

Above, Kasumi’s voice cracked. “Mami...!”

Lunaria stood, her gaze solemn. “She’s not broken. She’s transformed.”

The arena fell silent.

And Mami—unconscious, smiling—rested in the center of it all.

Chapter 3 – Echoes of Growth

A soft chant echoed through the haze of Mami’s mind.

“Pudding Solves All Problems. Pudding Solves All Problems.”

She stirred, blinking slowly as the world came back into focus. The air was warm, the breeze gentle, and she was lying on something soft—cushioned, floral, floating.

Her eyes opened fully.

She was on one of the spectator flower pods, high above the arena. Lunaria sat beside her, serene as ever, her indigo hair catching the light like silk. And just beyond her—

Kasumi.

No linen wraps. No dramatic groaning.

Just Kasumi, doing the jellyfish jig with wild abandon, arms flailing in rhythmic chaos as she chanted her absurd mantra with full conviction: “Pudding Solves All Problems!”

Mami burst into laughter, the sound bubbling up before she could stop it. “You’re actually doing it?” she wheezed, clutching her side. “You said that was your healing method this morning, but I didn’t think you’d actually—”

Kasumi spun mid-jig, pointing dramatically. “And yet here I am! Healed! Rejuvenated! Reborn through the sacred art of pudding-based recovery! And you look like you have been rejuvenated as well!”

Mami chuckled, then glanced down at her Soul Gem. It shimmered brightly—radiant, whole. As if the battle had never happened.

“How long was I out?” she asked, still smiling.

“Only a few minutes,” Lunaria replied gently. “The arena allows for real combat, real pain, real pressure—but without lasting consequences. It’s designed to push you, not break you.”

Then she added with a wink, “Just don’t get too used to that. In a real fight, consequences are very real—and very permanent.”

Mami nodded, her smile softening. “Fair point. I’ll keep that in mind.”

She turned to Kasumi, eyes twinkling. “You look well now. What happened to the linen-wraps of ‘poor, forgotten Kasumi’?”

Kasumi twirled with flair, then struck a dramatic pose. “Just as I foretold this morning!” she declared, referencing her earlier plea. “‘Don’t forget to save a little energy for helping poor, forgotten Kasumi...’ And you did, Mami! Your energy! Your grit! Your glorious battle aura! It healed me! I was at the edge of my seat the whole time!”

She bowed deeply, one arm sweeping across her chest. “I am restored. Thanks to your heroic suffering.”

Mami laughed again, shaking her head. “You are always finding joy in my suffering...”

Lunaria smiled, watching them with quiet fondness. “You did very well, Mami. Much better than your first trial. Would you like to watch a replay of the fight? It’s a good way to analyze your progress.”

Mami’s eyes lit up. “I’d love that.”

The three of them settled comfortably on the flower pod, cushions shifting gently beneath them. Lunaria raised her hand, and a soft projection shimmered into view—golden light forming a translucent screen in the air.

The replay was about to begin.

The projection shimmered to life, casting soft golden light across the flower pod. The arena replay unfolded in crisp detail—every motion, every flare of magic, every ripple of shadow.

Kasumi was immediately on the edge of her seat.

“Here it comes! Look at that stance—classic Mami, all poised and dramatic!” she cried, pointing at the screen with both hands. “Ooooh, and there’s the musket spin! Ten out of ten form!”

She flinched as the first tendril lashed out. “Yikes! That thing’s fast! I forgot how creepy it looks when it unravels like that—ugh, it’s like a haunted blender!”

Lunaria chuckled softly, then turned to Mami. “Tell me—what were you feeling here? Physically, emotionally. What was going through your mind?”

Mami watched herself dodge, ribbons swirling. “At first, I was scared. I remembered how overwhelming it was the first time. But then I realized... I could sense the attacks through my ribbons. That changed everything.”

She leaned forward slightly, eyes thoughtful. “I didn’t have to rely on sight or reflexes alone. I could focus on stabilizing my Soul Gem and let the ribbons warn me. It gave me just enough space to breathe.”

Kasumi gasped, then grinned. “That’s genius! Improvisation at its finest! You’re finally starting to think like a magical girl who *likes* being magical! I can’t wait to see what weird tricks you come up with next—ribbon radar, ribbon grappling hook, ribbon espresso machine—who knows!”

Lunaria smiled warmly. “You’re more creative now because you’re more at peace. You’re beginning to enjoy life again. And joy—joy is the root of imagination.”

Mami’s expression softened. “It reminds me of when I was little. Before everything changed. Before the accident. I used to make up stories, build little worlds in my head. I was happy. Unburdened. I didn’t realize how much I missed that feeling.”

The screen shifted—now showing the moment the monster escalated, tendrils flying in rapid succession.

Kasumi shook with glee, practically bouncing in her seat. “Ah, that’s déjà vu from my fight! Getting slapped around by a whole bunch of tendrils—*classic shadow monster behavior!*”

Mami winced. “That was my limit. I couldn’t keep up. Even with the ribbons sensing for me, I couldn’t focus on my Soul Gem and dodge at the same time. It was too much.”

Lunaria nodded. “That’s natural. Growth takes time. You’ve come far, but don’t try to leap ahead too quickly. Master the fundamentals. Build slowly. That’s how true strength is formed.”

Mami nodded, watching herself brace for the final attack.

Then came the climax—her golden explosion, the apex of her power.

Kasumi practically leapt off her seat, arms flailing in pure exhilaration. “YESSSSS! Look at that blast! That’s the kind of magical mayhem I live for! The ribbons! The muskets! The *BOOM!* That was like watching a firework show fueled by pure emotional catharsis!”

She spun once, then pointed dramatically at the screen. “That’s what I call a soul-powered supernova! Mami, you *detonated* your feelings and turned them into art! *EXPLOOOOOOSION!*”

Mami laughed softly, her eyes still fixed on the replay. The light, the force, the sheer scale of it—it was all her. Her pain, her strength, her growth.

“That... that was everything I had,” she said, voice quiet but full of pride.

The dust cleared. The shadow monster stood—damaged, but unfazed. Its form rippled with lingering distortion, but its posture remained steady, its presence undiminished.

Mami's eyes narrowed slightly. "How strong is that thing?" she asked, her voice low, curious rather than discouraged.

Lunaria's gaze remained on the fading projection, her tone calm and measured. "It's one of the most powerful battle opponents. Designed to push warriors to their limits. You're not close to defeating it yet."

She turned to Mami with a gentle smile. "But for only two days of training... you did exceptionally well."

Mami exhaled slowly, letting the truth settle in. She hadn't won. Not even close. But she had stood her ground. She had fought with everything she had. And she had grown.

Kasumi leaned back with a grin, arms folded behind her head. "That thing's a beast. As you saw, I was tossed like a sack of potatoes during our *glorious* fight. You lasted way longer than I expected—and with style. That's a win in my book."

Mami chuckled, her pride tempered with humility. "I guess I'll take that."

Lunaria nodded. "You should. Progress isn't measured by victory—it's measured by how you face defeat. And you faced it with strength, clarity, and even joy."

Mami glanced down at her Soul Gem, still glowing softly in her lap. "I did. I really did."

And for the first time in a long time, she didn't feel like she was chasing something impossible.

She felt like she was becoming someone real.

Mami nodded slowly, then flinched as the final moment played out—her body impaled by the monster's tendrils.

"Ugh. That part," she muttered. "Reminds me of when Kasumi got tossed around like a rag doll in her fight."

Kasumi grinned, eyes gleaming. "Ah yes, the glorious ragdoll phase! Nothing like a good impalement to fire up the bloodlust! I was *thriving*!"

Mami laughed, shaking her head. "You're impossible."

The projection faded, leaving only the soft hum of the flower pod and the quiet rustle of petals in the air.

Mami leaned back, thoughtful. Her gaze drifted toward the arena below, then to Kasumi—still lounging with a grin that hadn't faded since the replay began.

She remembered Kasumi's own fight against the shadow monster.

It had been... chaotic.

Kasumi had charged in with wild abandon, yelling nonsensical battle cries like "FOR THE GLORY OF PASTA!" and "I AM THE FLAME THAT BURNS THROUGH WAAAAH!" while throwing completely ordinary punches and kicks that did absolutely nothing. No magic. No strategy. Just raw, theatrical energy. At first, Mami had thought she was joking—fooling around for the sake of spectacle.

Then Kasumi collapsed on one knee, from what seemed to be from the sheer amount of negativity that gripped her.

Then the monster retaliated.

A relentless barrage of tendrils slammed into Kasumi, hurling her across the arena like a ragdoll. She crashed against walls, slid across the floor, and vanished into clouds of dust at speeds even Mami couldn't track.

And yet... there she was—standing. Covered in cuts, bruises, and disoriented, her eyes spinning like wild pinwheels. But still standing. Grinning like a "deranged, fiery freak of nature," as she would proudly call herself later.

Then, Kasumi said something that made Mami's blood run cold: all that pain, all that negativity, was fueling her battle lust.

With that, Kasumi launched herself at the shadow monster, her fist connecting with its face in a vicious strike that sent it reeling backward for the first time.

The monster retaliated, sending a storm of tendrils toward her.

But Kasumi didn't flinch. Kasumi didn't dodge.

She grabbed the tendrils as they hit her, laughing maniacally, shouting how the pain made her battle lust burn even hotter. She yanked the monster toward her with raw, unrelenting strength and, in one final, explosive movement, landed the finishing blow.

Mami still couldn't tell how much of that fight had been serious. Had Kasumi been holding back? Could she have ended it quickly if she'd wanted to? Or was that just... Kasumi?

She turned to Lunaria, curiosity blooming. "I'm wondering... how would you fight the shadow monster? You and Kasumi are so different."

Mami's gaze lingered on Kasumi, who was grinning ear-to-ear, having guessed what was about to happen next.

"Kasumi's style is... something else," Mami said, half-laughing. "First she was doing completely useless punches and kicks. And the next thing you know, she was getting completely beat up—slammed into walls, dragged through the dirt, impaled by tendrils—and somehow, she just kept going. It was raw. Brutal. Like she was feeding off the pain, turning it into fuel."

She paused, remembering the moment Kasumi grabbed the tendrils mid-attack, eyes wild, grin feral. "*Keep going! Make my battle lust burn hotter!*" Kasumi had shouted, as if the monster's assault was a gift.

"She looked like she was fooling around at first," Mami continued, "but then she pulled the monster in and ended it with a punch. I still can't tell how much of that was serious. Maybe she could've finished it quickly if she wanted to. Or maybe that *is* her serious."

Kasumi gave a theatrical shrug, clearly enjoying the ambiguity.

Mami turned back to Lunaria. "But you... I imagine your fight would be completely different. Controlled. Elegant. Like a dance."

Lunaria's smile was soft, but there was a glint of anticipation in her eyes. "I'd be happy to show you. You've only seen my magic once—when we fought, and I pushed you to the edge. That wasn't the best way to understand it."

She tilted her head slightly. "It'll be good for you to see it from the outside. To observe, not endure."

Kasumi perked up instantly, fists clenched in excitement. "Oh-ho-ho, Mami, you're in for a treat! Lunaria's style is like watching moonlight slice through fog. It's all calm and graceful until—*bam!*—the monster's crying for its mom!"

Mami chuckled, settling into the pod's cushion. "This is going to be interesting."

Below, the arena shimmered again, preparing for its next trial.

And Mami, no longer the one being tested, was ready to witness something new.

Chapter 4 – Amplify – what mastery looks like – moonlight crescendo

Lunaria stood, her long hair catching the light like flowing silk. She turned to Mami and Kasumi with a soft smile and a playful wink.

"Wish me luck."

Then, with a single fluid motion, she leapt from the flower pod.

Her descent was effortless—no stumble, no flare of magic, just gravity and grace. She landed in the center of the arena like a falling petal, her feet barely making a sound.

Mami blinked, mesmerized. “That was... elegant.”

She glanced at Kasumi with a teasing smirk. “Very different from a certain someone’s crash landings.”

Kasumi gasped, clutching her chest in mock betrayal. “Mami! You bully! I’ll have you know my landings are *performance art!*”

Mami chuckled, shaking her head.

Below, the arena began to shift.

The petals dimmed. The air thickened. Shadows crept in from the edges, curling like smoke. The temperature dropped, and the familiar pressure returned.

The shadow monster emerged—its form towering, tendrils twitching, claws gleaming in the gloom.

Mami’s breath caught. *It begins.*

Kasumi leaned forward, eyes gleaming. “Here we go...”

Lunaria faced the monster, her posture serene. She bent low into a battle stance—one leg extended, arms poised like a dancer preparing for a solo.

Then she moved.

Before Mami could blink, Lunaria was already at the monster’s side.

Her attacks were a blur of precision—elbow strikes that landed with the crispness of a snapping branch, sweeping kicks that carved arcs through the air like brushstrokes on canvas, palm thrusts that rippled with quiet force. Each movement was deliberate, beautiful, and devastating. She didn’t fight like a soldier—she danced like a storm in silk.

The shadow monster roared, its tendrils whipping outward in jagged spirals. Claws slashed through the air, its massive arm swinging with the weight of a wrecking ball. The arena trembled beneath its fury.

But Lunaria didn’t flinch.

She moved like water over stone—fluid, unyielding, impossible to grasp. A tendril shot toward her chest, and she twisted her torso just enough to let it pass, her elbow snapping upward to strike the joint of the monster’s limb. Another claw came from behind, and she spun low, her leg sweeping in a crescent that knocked the attack off course.

She didn’t block—she *redirected*. She didn’t resist—she *absorbed*. Her limbs flowed like silk threads in the wind, never stiff, never panicked. Every motion was a response, a counter, a continuation of the monster’s own aggression turned against it.

To Mami, it was mesmerizing.

Lunaria's body was a symphony of motion—each strike a note, each dodge a pause, each counter a crescendo. She didn't just fight the monster. She *understood* it. She read its movements like poetry and replied with choreography.

And through it all, she remained untouched.

Mami watched in awe. *So this is what her fighting style really looks like.*

It was nothing like the desperate clash they'd shared before—when Mami had been lost, broken, clawing her way back to herself. Back then, she hadn't been able to appreciate the artistry. Now, she could see it clearly.

Kasumi's eyes sparkled with childlike wonder. "She's so cool..."

Then Mami noticed something.

Each time Lunaria struck the monster, a faint pulse of darkness escaped its body—wisps of negativity that curled toward Lunaria, wrapping around her like smoke.

Mami leaned forward. "Is that... Dis-connect?"

Kasumi grinned. "Sharp eyes, Mami! Yep, she's using Dis-connect with every hit—siphoning the monster's negativity and storing it. She's building up for something big."

Mami's thoughts drifted back—to the moment Lunaria had saved her. When her Soul Gem had been on the verge of shattering, Lunaria had used Dis-connect to pull the despair out of her, consolidating it into her hand before delivering a single, crushing blow that knocked Mami unconscious.

Dis-connect. The ability Mami had only begun to study. The one she hoped to learn—just enough to help her friends when they needed her most.

Kasumi leaned in, voice hushed with excitement. "And this? This is just the warm-up. The monster's gonna scale up soon—just like it did with me. That's when the real fun begins."

She flashed a mischievous grin.

Mami's heart beat faster.

She was thrilled.

Then the shadow monster twitched.

And it vanished.

Kasumi's grin widened. "Here we go..."

Mami's breath caught. She remembered this pattern—how the monster had done the same against Kasumi, disappearing into the shadows only to reappear with brutal precision. That was when Kasumi had been flung across the arena like a ragdoll, limbs flying, laughter echoing.

Mami gulped. *How will Lunaria handle this?*

A blur of motion—the monster reappeared right beside Lunaria.

Its massive arm swung forward in a brutal punch.

Lunaria blocked it with both forearms, her stance firm—but the force sent her flying across the arena, her body trailing a ribbon of dust and shadow.

The monster didn't relent.

It vanished again, then reappeared behind her, striking with claws. Then again from above. Then from the side with its tendrils. Its body flickered in and out of the arena's shadows, using the darkness like stepping stones to launch a relentless, multidirectional assault.

Kasumi leaned forward, eyes wide with wonder. "It's going full berserker mode! Look at that speed! Look at those angles! This is *glorious!*"

Mami tried to follow the fight with her eyes, but it was impossible. The monster was too fast, too erratic. She could only hear the thuds—sharp impacts against the walls, the floor, the air itself. Each one made her flinch.

Was that Lunaria? Was she getting hit?

She focused harder, straining to track the rhythm of the battle. Her ears caught the echoes, her eyes darted through the shifting shadows. But it was like trying to follow lightning in a storm.

Then—after what felt like an eternity—

Lunaria landed.

Gracefully.

Her feet touched the arena floor with the softness of a falling leaf. Dust swirled around her, clinging to her robes and hair, but her body showed no signs of major damage. Just scuffs. Just dirt.

She took a deep breath and then looked up at the monster with a calm, unreadable expression.

Her body lowered into a battle pose—elegant, poised, unwavering.

Mami gasped.

The shadow monster was smaller now. Its form had shrunk, its tendrils thinner, its mass reduced. The darkness that once radiated from it had dimmed.

And Lunaria—Lunaria was *overflowing* with negativity.

It swirled around her like a dark mist, curling around her arms and shoulders, drawn into her like ink into water.

She smiled.

“Let’s end this.”

She dashed forward, her body a blur of moonlight and shadow. All the negativity she had siphoned was now consolidated into her hand—pulsing, trembling, ready.

Mami’s heart leapt. *This is exactly how our fight ended...*

Lunaria reached the monster.

And struck.

The blow landed with a thunderous shockwave—an explosion of force and emotion that rippled through the arena like a sonic boom. The petals above trembled. The shadows recoiled. The air itself seemed to pause.

Mami braced herself, arms raised.

Kasumi clutched her chest, tears in her eyes. “That was *beautiful!* The elegance! The impact! The *drama!*”

When the dust settled, the arena had returned to its original state—bright, grassy, serene, untouched by shadow. The flower pods swayed gently in the breeze. The monster was gone. In its place were purple flower petals, flowing in the wind.

Lunaria stood in the center, her robes fluttering softly.

She looked up at Mami and Kasumi, then bowed—graceful, composed, radiant.

“How was my fight?” she asked, voice light.

Kasumi erupted into cheers, clapping wildly. “Ten thousand out of ten! I’m crying! I’m *crying!*”

Mami smiled like a child, eyes wide with awe. She applauded, her heart full.

A flower pod descended from above, cradling Lunaria as she stepped onto it. It lifted her gently, bringing her to the pod where Mami and Kasumi sat.

When she reached them, Lunaria closed both eyes and gave a warm, playful smile.

“That was awesome,” Mami said, her voice still tinged with wonder. “Beautiful, even. You looked like you were dancing with the shadow monster.”

Lunaria opened her eyes, her smile playful. “I do prefer elegance over brute force.”

Mami chuckled. “It brought back some... *bad memories*, though. You were dancing around *me* the first time we fought. I couldn’t even tell where you were half the time.”

Kasumi snorted. “Oh, the trauma! The graceful torment!”

Mami turned to her with a teasing grin. “Speaking of trauma—Lunaria looks like she just stepped out of a spa. Meanwhile, *you* finished your fight covered in blood, cuts, bruises, and a swollen eye the size of a grapefruit.”

Kasumi’s eyes lit up with fiery pride. “And I felt *great*! Every bruise was a badge of honor! That swollen eye? A trophy! That fight was a masterpiece of chaos and passion!”

She looked off into the distance, clearly reliving the moment with fondness. “Ah... good times.”

Mami laughed, shaking her head. “Oh Kasumi...”

Then her tone softened. “Honestly, though... just like when you fought the monster, I couldn’t follow Lunaria’s fight. It was too fast. I could barely tell what was happening.”

Lunaria nodded thoughtfully. “Would you like to see a replay? We can slow down the part where the monster was teleporting and striking from all angles. It’s a good opportunity to study how I handled it—and how it compares to Kasumi’s approach.”

Mami’s eyes lit up. “I’d love that.”

She leaned forward, already preparing herself to absorb every detail. This wasn’t just entertainment anymore—it was a lesson. A glimpse into two vastly different styles. One born of elegance and clarity. The other of chaos and fire.

And somewhere in between, Mami was finding her own.

Chapter 4b – Battle lust vs moonlight crescendo

The projection shimmered to life once more, replaying Lunaria’s fight in slowed, elegant detail. The arena was bathed in soft light, the shadows held at bay as the three girls watched from their flower pod.

Mami leaned forward, eyes focused. “You looked so relaxed here,” she said, watching Lunaria’s graceful movements. “It’s like you were using the bare minimum—just enough to redirect or absorb the monster’s attacks. You weren’t blocking head-on, just flowing around them.”

Lunaria nodded, her expression calm. “Very good observation.”

Mami tilted her head, thinking. “It reminds me of Kasumi’s fight too. She didn’t use magic at the start either... though all she did was shout nonsense and throw normal punches and kicks that didn’t even scratch the monster.”

Kasumi burst into laughter. “Hey! Those were *strategic nonsense grunts*! You wouldn’t understand the depth of my battle poetry!”

Lunaria chuckled, covering her mouth with one hand. “It’s true. Kasumi’s style is... unique.”

Mami smiled. “But now that I think about it, you both were doing the same thing in your own way.”

Lunaria raised an eyebrow. “Do you remember the techniques I taught you before your first training?”

Mami paused, her brows furrowing slightly as she gathered her thoughts. “Well... there’s emotional and negativity control,” she began slowly. “You can use negative emotions as they come to amplify your attacks. And then there’s the more advanced version... where you store those emotions and release them at the right moment for a stronger, more explosive strike.”

She glanced at Lunaria with a soft smile. “It’s risky, though. You could lose yourself to the darkness if you’re not careful. But... I was able to do that during my fight against the shadow monster.”

Lunaria smiled and gave a small nod, encouraging her to continue.

Mami took a breath. “And second is... ah, right—magic control. Using just the bare minimum of magic when you start an attack, and then increasing it right before impact. It helps conserve Soul Gem energy and makes the attack more efficient. More powerful, too.”

She paused, then added with quiet admission, “I haven’t started applying that one yet. I’ve been focusing more on emotional control... and just trying to dodge the shadow monster’s attacks without getting overwhelmed.”

Her voice softened. “I’m trying to take it slow. Like you both told me—not rushing to learn everything at once. Just the basics, one step at a time.”

“And lastly,” she said, her voice softening, “Dis-connect. The ability to siphon magical energy—especially negativity—from others or enemies and repurpose it. I’m still trying to learn a very simplified version of it... just enough to help my friends when they’re in trouble.”

She looked down at her hands, then back up at Lunaria and Kasumi, her expression thoughtful but determined.

She looked back at the projection. “So I’m guessing you—and Kasumi, in her ridiculous way—were using the second one. Magic control. You didn’t seem to use any magic at all during the first part of your fights.”

Then her eyes lit up with realization. “Actually... in your case, Lunaria, you combined magic control with Dis-connect. You only used magic when you struck, and that magic was Dis-connect. That was the only ‘magic’ you used.”

Lunaria smiled, clearly pleased. “Excellent deduction, Mami. You’re putting the pieces together.”

Mami sat back, still amazed. “It’s incredible. You and Kasumi fought that monster without relying on magic. Just technique, timing, and control.”

Kasumi puffed up proudly, her grin stretching ear to ear. “Thank you for the compliment! You bully me so much, I almost forgot you *can* be nice.”

Mami laughed. “Only sometimes. And what about you? You tease me constantly.”

Kasumi gasped in mock offense. “That’s called *motivational banter!*”

They both laughed, the kind of laughter that only comes from shared battles and earned trust—like good friends who’ve sparred, stumbled, and grown together.

Then Kasumi leaned forward, her tone shifting to something more grounded. “As you train and grow stronger, you’ll need less magic to get the same results. Your body, your instincts—they’ll start doing the work for you. Eventually, you’ll be able to do what *you* can do now, but with little to no Soul Gem energy.”

She gave a small nod, her fiery eyes softening just enough to show sincerity beneath the bravado.

Mami smiled, touched by the sincerity beneath the chaos. “Thanks, Kasumi. That means a lot. But... I think I’m still a long way from that.”

Lunaria placed a gentle hand on Mami’s shoulder. “That’s okay. I hope I get to see the day when you do. Even if it takes a long time.”

Mami looked at both of them—her mentors, her friends—and felt something warm settle in her chest.

She wasn’t just learning how to fight.

She was learning how to grow.

The projection shimmered again, signaling the transition into the next phase of the fight.

Mami recognized the shift immediately. This was the phase where the shadow monster’s movements grew sharper, faster—its body flickering in and out of view like a living blade of darkness. It launched into a relentless assault, striking Lunaria from every angle, sending her flying back and forth across the arena at blinding speeds.

The phase where Mami couldn’t follow the fight.

Lunaria, seated beside her, gave a gentle nod. “From here on, I’ll slow the projection down. You’ll be able to see everything clearly.”

Mami turned to her, grateful. “Thank you,” she said, leaning forward, her curiosity burning. “I really want to understand what you did during this part.”

The projection pulsed softly, and the chaos began to unfold in slow motion—each movement now visible, each impact traceable.

And Mami prepared to learn.

The projection shimmered, slowing the chaos to a digestible rhythm. The shadow monster launched a brutal punch—its arm a blur of force. Lunaria blocked with both forearms, her stance firm and centered.

But the impact was immense.

Mami flinched as Lunaria was sent flying across the arena, her body trailing a ribbon of dust and shadow.

Kasumi leaned forward with gleeful anticipation. “Ohoho! Look at that glorious trajectory! We’re entering the *ping-pong phase!*”

The slowed projection continued.

The monster vanished, then reappeared behind Lunaria—claws slashing. Then again from above. Then from the side with tendrils. Its body flickered in and out of the arena’s shadows, using the darkness like stepping stones to launch a relentless, multidirectional assault.

Mami, now able to follow every frame, leaned in closer.

She noticed something.

Every time the shadow monster struck, Lunaria didn’t resist the force—she *responded* to it.

When it reappeared behind her with a vicious claw swipe, Lunaria twisted her torso mid-air, letting the momentum carry her into a half-spin. Her left shoulder dipped just enough to redirect the blow across her back, while her right arm swept upward to deflect the trailing edge of the claw. The impact sent her flying, but her body moved like a ribbon caught in a breeze—never stiff, never uncontrolled.

Then the monster appeared above her, its arm crashing down like a hammer. Lunaria tucked her legs and rotated backward, her feet catching the brunt of the strike. She absorbed the force through her calves and used the recoil to flip herself downward, arms extended like a diver preparing to land.

From the side came the tendrils—whipping, curling, unpredictable. Lunaria twisted again, her spine arching as she rotated horizontally. Her forearm intercepted one tendril, her hip caught another, and her knee deflected a third. Each point of contact was chosen with precision, based on her position in the air and the angle of the attack.

She never tried to stop the monster’s blows outright.

Instead, she allowed herself to be carried by them—redirecting, absorbing, and flowing through the chaos. Her body became a canvas of motion, each limb a brushstroke painting a response to violence.

And with every strike, more of the monster’s darkness peeled away—siphoned into Lunaria through her subtle use of *Dis-connect*. The negativity curled around her like smoke, drawn in with each graceful collision.

Even as she was hurled toward walls, the floor, and solidified shadows suspended in the air, Lunaria remained composed. Just before impact, she would twist—spinning like a gymnast mid-routine—and use a flicker of magic to soften the landing. Her feet would touch down with elegance, her body already preparing to absorb the next incoming blow.

To Mami, it was breathtaking.

This wasn’t just combat—it was choreography. A masterclass in control, timing, and restraint. Lunaria wasn’t fighting the monster.

She was *dancing* with it.

She remembered the previous night—when Lunaria had softened the boat’s fall just before it hit the water, after Kasumi had sent it flying off a ramp made by lake creatures. That same precision. That same timing.

Kasumi grinned at her, clearly enjoying Mami’s stunned expression. “She’s incredible, right? So graceful, calm, and composed—even while getting smacked around like a training dummy. It’s like watching a gymnastics show choreographed by moonlight and chaos!”

Mami could only nod, eyes still locked on the projection.

Lunaria wasn’t just fighting.

She was performing.

The slowed projection continued, each frame revealing the final crescendo of Lunaria’s performance.

The shadow monster launched one last strike, sending Lunaria hurtling toward the arena floor. But even in descent, she moved with grace—twisting mid-air, absorbing the momentum, and landing softly on her feet like a dancer concluding her final pose.

Mami leaned forward, breath held.

The monster was smaller now—its towering form reduced, its tendrils thin and sluggish. The darkness that once radiated from it had dimmed to a faint haze.

Lunaria, by contrast, was overflowing with negativity. It swirled around her like a storm held in orbit, drawn from the monster’s core and now pulsing through her body. Her eyes were calm. Her stance, poised.

She dashed forward.

The negativity condensed into her hand, spiraling inward like a vortex of shadow and emotion. Her arm drew back, her body aligned, and then—

She struck.

The finishing blow landed with a thunderous shockwave, rippling through the arena like a bell tolling the end of battle. The petals above trembled. The shadows recoiled. The very air seemed to pause in reverence.

When the dust cleared, the monster was gone.

Lunaria stood alone in the center of the arena, surrounded by bright grass and soft light. The shadows had vanished. The space was serene again—peaceful, untouched, reborn.

And then, gently, the projection faded.

The flower pod dimmed, returning the three girls to the quiet warmth of the observation chamber.

Mami exhaled slowly, her heart still racing.

She had just witnessed something extraordinary.

As the projection faded, the quiet returned to the flower pod.

Mami turned to Lunaria, her voice soft but full of gratitude. “Thank you for showing me your fighting style... and your techniques. It was beautiful. I could actually appreciate it this time—watching as a spectator, not as a desperate opponent trying to survive.”

Lunaria smiled warmly, her eyes gentle. “I’m glad. I had fun too.”

Mami glanced between Lunaria and Kasumi, her thoughts swirling. “Now that I’ve seen both of your fights in full... especially with the slow-motion parts I couldn’t follow before... I think I’m starting to understand something.”

She sat up straighter, her tone thoughtful. “You two fought so differently on the surface. Lunaria, you were graceful and composed. Kasumi, you were wild and chaotic. But underneath all that... you were doing the same thing.”

Kasumi raised an eyebrow, intrigued. “Go on...”

Mami nodded. “Neither of you relied on magic for most of the fight. Or if you did, it was the bare minimum. Lunaria only used Dis-connect when she made contact with the monster. And Kasumi...” she chuckled, “you didn’t seem to use any magic at all when you were throwing those ridiculous, comical punches and kicks that did absolutely nothing.”

Kasumi grinned proudly. “They were *spiritually charged!*”

Mami laughed, then continued. “And both of you let negativity build up inside you. I saw it—the thick, dark aura around you. Like a shadowy mist. But you controlled it. You didn’t look emotionally unstable or overwhelmed. You used it to amplify your final attacks... and that’s what defeated the monster.”

She looked down at her hands, then back up at them. “It’s amazing. You both fought in completely different ways, but the core was the same. Control. Timing. Patience. And knowing when to unleash everything.”

Lunaria gave a small nod, her expression proud.

Kasumi leaned back, arms behind her head. “We’re not so different after all, huh?”

Mami smiled. “You’re both incredible. Similar and different at the same time.”

She turned to Lunaria first. “You handled the monster exactly how I’d expect a strong fighter to. You read its attacks, protected yourself, and waited for the right moment to strike. For you, that moment was whenever it hit you—because that’s when you used Dis-connect.”

She smiled thoughtfully. “You weakened the monster while strengthening yourself. It was all so precise.”

Lunaria nodded, her expression calm.

“That’s more in line with my style,” Mami continued, her tone thoughtful. “I started using my ribbons to sense the monster’s attacks early and dodge. And I did try to soften my impact when it slammed me into the wall... but the ribbons only had the usual amount of magic I put into them when I first created them. I just leave them be unless I’m using them for an attack.”

She paused, a spark of realization lighting her eyes. “But now I get it. I should wait until right before impact—*then* pour more energy into the ribbons. That way, the protection is stronger, and I conserve magical energy.”

Lunaria smiled, her voice warm. “You’re learning quickly. That’s exactly the kind of adjustment a good fighter makes—taking what you’ve seen and applying it in your own way.”

Mami beamed at the compliment.

Then she turned to Kasumi, her tone shifting. “And you... you’re something else entirely.”

Kasumi tilted her head, grinning. “Flattered already.”

“I mean,” Mami said, laughing, “I don’t even know if what you did *counts* as a fighting style. You were getting tossed around like a lifeless ragdoll. You didn’t protect yourself at all. It was like you gave up—or were already dead!”

Kasumi burst into laughter. “That’s the *art* of it! And besides, I did not use *any* magic during that part of the fight. Optimal energy management!”

Mami recalled the moment they’d watched the slow-motion replay of Kasumi’s fight. Kasumi had bounced up and down in her seat, gleefully pointing out every hit the monster landed on her. She’d press a hand to her ribs and say, “*Oof, felt that one here!*” or gesture to her shoulder and shout, “*That trajectory was insane!*”

Mami laughed, remembering how infectious Kasumi’s energy had been. “It was brutal and honestly kind of hard to watch at the time... but thinking back on it now? It was hilarious, incredible, and weirdly entertaining.”

Then her voice dropped into mock disbelief. “And the most ridiculous part of all? You were still standing. Covered in injuries, looking like you’d been through hell—and grinning like a *deranged freak of nature*.”

Kasumi raised both arms triumphantly. “That’s the power of *burning battle lust*! The more the fight drags on, the more fired up I get—and the stronger I become!”

Mami shook her head, still laughing. “I don’t know anyone else with a fighting style like yours.”

Kasumi made a V with two fingers, winked, and brought the V over her open eye with a bright grin. “There are fighters scattered across time and space—some with styles that might rival mine in unpredictability, depending on who you ask. I hope you get to meet a few of them someday.”

She leaned in with a teasing glint in her eye. “And besides... you probably already know someone whose fighting style isn’t too far off from mine.”

Mami’s laughter faded into a thoughtful smile, her mind turning over the possibilities. *Someone I know...?*

A flicker of curiosity sparked in her chest.

Who could Kasumi be hinting at?

She looked out over the arena, now peaceful and bright. Her heart stirred with excitement. *Witches, monsters, magical girls...* All waiting. All possible.

Chapter 5 – Bonds Rekindled

The flower pods descended gently, petals folding back like curtains as the arena floor came into view. Lunaria stepped off with her usual grace, Mami followed with quiet poise—

—and Kasumi tripped.

Even though the pod was barely a foot off the ground, she managed to stumble spectacularly, landing face-first on the arena floor with a dramatic *thud*.

Mami burst into laughter. “Kasumi...” she said with teasing affection, drawing out the name like a playful scolding.

Lunaria chuckled softly, covering her mouth. “Elegant as ever.”

Kasumi popped up, brushing dust off her outfit with exaggerated flair. She gave them a thumbs-up and a wink, as if the fall had been part of her performance. “Nailed it.”

As the laughter faded, Mami’s thoughts drifted to something Lunaria had mentioned earlier.

During Mami’s first day in the realm—while Kasumi’s clone had been training her—Lunaria and the real Kasumi had sparred. A full-on clash between graceful precision and fiery chaos. But Mami hadn’t seen it. She’d only heard about it in passing.

And when she’d asked who won?

Both girls had claimed victory with absolute confidence.

Now, after witnessing their individual fighting styles in full—Lunaria’s graceful control and Kasumi’s explosive intensity—Mami could only imagine what that spar must have looked like. She smiled to herself. *I’d love to see them go at it again... now that I understand what they’re really capable of.*

Lunaria caught Mami’s expression. “Would you like to see us spar sometime?”

Kasumi leaned in with a grin. “We’ll put on a show just for you.”

“The time will come soon,” Lunaria added with a soft nod.

Kasumi cracked her knuckles, her eyes gleaming. “And I’ll win again—to dispel any lingering doubts Mami has about me!”

Mami chuckled, remembering the conversation from her first day in the realm. Both Lunaria and Kasumi had claimed victory in their spar, and when asked for her thoughts, Mami had mischievously said she thought Lunaria won—just to tease Kasumi and get a dramatic reaction.

It had worked.

Lunaria raised an eyebrow, her voice calm but pointed. “What do you mean by ‘again?’ You were like an open book. I dodged nearly everything and struck with precision. It was only a matter of time before you reached your limit.”

“Oh please,” Kasumi scoffed, waving a hand. “You’re leaving out the last part when I hit my peak. My flames were practically *singing*. So yes, it was only a matter of time—before they overwhelmed you.”

They turned to face each other, exchanging tough-girl rival stares—Lunaria with serene intensity, Kasumi with fiery defiance.

Mami laughed, watching them with fondness. Their banter reminded her of her early days with Kyoko. Back when they were partners, they’d had their own playful rivalries and competitions. Kyoko had always tried to one-up her—especially since Mami had been her mentor. Whether it was sparring, strategizing, or even snack hoarding, Kyoko had made everything a contest.

Some things never change, Mami thought, her heart warm.

With that, Lunaria and Kasumi both laughed together, their earlier banter melting into genuine camaraderie. They exchanged a firm handshake—less a gesture of competition, more a promise. A promise that their next clash would be one worth watching.

Still smiling, Lunaria turned to Mami. “Kasumi and I are heading to Kamihama. We want to look into the recent events there—and meet with Yachiyo to share what Kasumi learned yesterday.”

Mami nodded, her expression thoughtful. “Sounds important.”

Lunaria’s gaze softened. “And as for you... you’re ready now.”

Mami blinked. “Ready?”

“You can summon Kyoko,” Lunaria said gently. “From the time when you were partners—before her family died. You can train with her, learn about Connect. Like we discussed over breakfast.”

Mami’s breath caught.

Lunaria smiled warmly. “It’s also a good chance to catch up with an old friend. She’ll have all the memories, thoughts, and bonds from that time. She’ll remember *you*—as you were together.”

Mami’s heart swelled. The thought of seeing *that* Kyoko again—the one who laughed with her, fought beside her, trusted her—filled her with a quiet joy.

She nodded. “Thank you.”

Lunaria and Kasumi exchanged a glance, a silent nod passing between them.

Lunaria stepped back, her form dissolving into soft moonlight. Violet flower petals drifted gently to the ground where she had stood, shimmering faintly before vanishing into the air.

Kasumi, of course, had other plans.

She leapt into the air with a dramatic pose, arms flared wide like a performer taking her final bow. A burst of fiery petals exploded around her, followed by a shower of confetti and a sudden appearance of party streamers and tiny floating balloons. Somewhere, impossibly, a kazoo sounded.

Mami blinked, then burst into laughter. “Kasumi...”

And just like that, they were gone.

Mami stood alone in the arena, the silence wrapping around her like a soft breeze.

She turned toward the center, where the projection shimmered to life. A menu of training options appeared, glowing softly.

Her eyes scanned the list.

Learn Connect – Kyoko Sakura (Pre-Family Loss)

She pressed it.

The arena glowed. Bright lights of magical energy gathered a few meters away, swirling upward like a rising sun. The lights began to form a shape—a silhouette Mami knew by heart.

Sparkles burst outward, and there she was.

Kyoko Sakura, in her magical girl attire, standing tall and confident. The summoning looked like a transformation sequence—radiant, theatrical, and unmistakably Kyoko.

Her long crimson hair was tied high in a ponytail with a black ribbon, cascading down her back like a flame in motion. Her sharp red eyes gleamed with mischief and strength, framed by bold bangs that added to her fierce expression.

She wore a **sleeveless maroon dress** with a mandarin collar and a distinctive oval cutout at the chest where her Soul Gem shimmered. The dress flared into thick white ruffles at the hem, trailing behind her like a battle-ready cape. Beneath it, a **pleated mauve skirt** peeked out, layered over a **black corset** with white detailing that hugged her torso and emphasized her agile frame.

Her arms were adorned with **white bicep-length sleeves**, detached from the main outfit, ending in **black cuffs** buttoned neatly at her wrists. Her legs were clad in **black thigh-high socks**, tucked into

tall red boots with white cuffs and matching white symbols near the top—echoing the design of her chest cutout.

The entire ensemble radiated a sense of motion and edge—designed not just for combat, but for flair. It was theatrical, radiant, and unmistakably Kyoko: a warrior who fought with passion, pride, and a touch of rebellious charm.

Kyoko looked at Mami, her eyes warm, her grin familiar. “Sup, partner.”

Mami’s eyes filled with tears. She ran forward and hugged Kyoko tightly, arms wrapped around her like she never wanted to let go.

Kyoko blinked, surprised. “Whoa—uh, you okay?”

Mami pulled back just enough to look at her, her voice trembling with emotion. “I missed you. So much.”

Kyoko tilted her head, confused but smiling. “You’re acting way more excited than usual to see me.”

Mami shook her head gently, her voice barely audible as she whispered to herself, “Yes I am... to meet this version of you...”

She didn’t explain further. She didn’t need to.

This was a reunion with someone she’d lost—not just to tragedy, but to time, bitterness, and silence. And now, for a little while, she had her friend back.

Mami slowly let go of Kyoko, wiping the tears from her eyes with the back of her glove. “Sorry for the sudden hug,” she said with a soft laugh. “It’s just... it’s really great to see a good friend again.”

Kyoko shrugged with a grin. “No worries. You’re allowed to get mushy once in a while.”

Then, with a familiar flick of her wrist, Kyoko pulled out a snack—some kind of sweet bun, still warm. “Want one?”

Mami chuckled, the sight stirring memories. “You haven’t changed at all.”

They sat together on the grassy field of the arena, the magical glow around them fading into a peaceful stillness. The soft hum of residual energy lingered in the air, but it felt more like a lullaby than a battle cry.

As they ate, Kyoko glanced at Mami’s Soul Gem—and paused.

It was shining brighter than she’d ever seen it. A radiant gold, pulsing gently like a heartbeat, clear and unwavering.

Kyoko narrowed her eyes, sensing something deeper. “You seem... different,” she said slowly. “Peaceful. Happy.”

Then she glanced down at her own Soul Gem, which sat nestled in the center of her chest. It was still bright, still strong—but noticeably dimmer than Mami’s.

Kyoko squinted at it, then looked back at Mami’s. “Okay, what the hell,” she muttered with mock offense. “Why is yours glowing like a damn lighthouse and mine looks like it’s on low battery?”

Mami blinked, then laughed softly. “Jealous?”

Kyoko crossed her arms, pouting just enough to be funny. “A little. I mean, I’m the one who brought snacks. That should count for something.”

Mami smiled, her gaze drifting back to her Soul Gem. “I’ve had a shift in perspective lately. I’ve started to see things more clearly. I have hope now—real hope. For the future. For my friends. For myself.”

She paused, her voice growing softer. “I’ve come to appreciate life again. And I’ve started to see the beauty in being a magical girl... including the beauty in *me*.”

Kyoko’s teasing expression melted into something warmer. She leaned back on her hands, letting the quiet settle between them.

“That’s great,” she said, her voice sincere. “Did Lunaria and Kasumi have something to do with that?”

Mami’s eyes widened.

Wait... how does she know about them?

She hadn’t mentioned their names. Not once.

Do all the magical girls, witches, and monsters whose essence is recorded in the arena know about Lunaria and Kasumi?

Kyoko saw the surprise on Mami’s face and grinned, one eyebrow raised. “Surprised I know about them?”

Mami nodded slowly, her mind racing.

Kyoko winked. “Let’s just say this realm’s got more going on than meets the eye. You’re not the only one who’s been watching and learning.”

Kyoko leaned back on her hands, gazing up at the shimmering sky above the arena. “You know,” she said casually, “Kasumi and Lunaria often visit me here.”

Mami blinked. “They... visit you?”

Kyoko nodded. “Yeah. My essence is saved in the arena, right? So they connect with it. We talk. Sometimes we spar. Sometimes we just mess around. They’re fun—Kasumi especially. She’s got this chaotic energy that’s hard not to get swept up in.”

Her voice softened slightly. “But they also taught me things. Serious things. About magical girls.”

Mami’s breath caught.

Kyoko continued, her tone steady. “They told me the truth. That our souls are literally in our Soul Gems. That our bodies are just... shells. And that when we’re overcome by despair, we become witches.”

Mami’s eyes widened. *She knows.*

She looked at Kyoko, searching her face for signs of fear or sadness. “Does that... bother you?”

Kyoko turned to her with a grin, eyes gleaming. “Nah. I’m just a summon—an echo of the original me. I can’t become a witch. I’m safe here.”

Her smile faded into something more wistful. “But I hope the real me doesn’t fall into that fate. I hope she keeps fighting.”

Mami’s eyes softened. She reached out and gently placed a hand over Kyoko’s. “She will. I’ll protect her. And all my friends. When they’re in need... I’ll be there.”

Kyoko looked down at their hands, then back at Mami’s Soul Gem—still glowing like a beacon.

She nodded, her smile bright and full of trust. “I believe in you, Mami. Especially seeing how far you’ve come. That Soul Gem of yours... it’s brighter than ever. And you’re learning from the best.”

Mami smiled, her heart full. “I’m lucky to have them. And I’m lucky to have you.”

Kyoko smirked. “Damn right you are.”

They sat together in silence for a moment longer, the arena around them quiet and still—like it was holding its breath for what came next.

Mami’s eyes lit up with sudden realization.

Wait... if Kyoko’s essence is saved in the arena, and Lunaria and Kasumi interact with her... maybe she knows something. Maybe she can answer the questions Lunaria and Kasumi wouldn’t.

Her heart quickened. She turned to Kyoko, her voice eager. “Kyoko... do you know who Lunaria and Kasumi really are? Who created this realm? Did they really form bonds with all the magical girls, witches, and monsters across space and time?”

Kyoko blinked, then smiled and looked off into the distance. “No clue.”

Mami stared at her, stunned.

Kyoko shrugged. “All I know is that the essence of the real me was somehow saved in this arena. Lunaria and Kasumi can connect with those essences—just like you did to summon me. They visit sometimes. We talk, we spar, we joke around. They’re good company.”

She paused, her tone growing thoughtful. “They’re powerful. Really powerful. And they know a lot about magic. But they’re also... different. Lunaria’s all calm and graceful, like she’s floating through a dream. Kasumi’s a firecracker—loud, unpredictable, and kind of brilliant in her own way.”

Mami pouted, her shoulders slumping slightly. “So they’re still enigmas...”

Kyoko laughed, nudging her playfully. “Aw, poor Mami. You look like someone just told you Santa isn’t real.”

Mami laughed, the sound light and genuine. “I was hoping you’d have answers.”

Kyoko leaned back, hands behind her head. “Sorry, no lore dumps from me. I don’t even know when my essence was saved here.”

Mami tilted her head. “You don’t?”

Kyoko shook her head. “Time doesn’t really apply to us. We’re echoes, fragments. We exist when we’re summoned, and then we kind of ‘fade-away,’ but even then, we are still conscious. It’s weird, but very peaceful.”

Mami sighed, her gaze drifting upward toward the shimmering sky. “This realm is incredible. It’s so peaceful, so beautiful. And the arena... it’s like something out of a dream. I hope I can learn the truth someday. About this place. About Lunaria and Kasumi.”

Kyoko smiled and held out her fist. “I second that.”

Mami looked at her, then smiled and bumped her fist against Kyoko’s. “Partners again?”

Kyoko grinned. “Always.”

Kyoko leaned back, arms behind her head, chewing thoughtfully on the last bite of her snack. “So, Mami... why’d you summon me? What kind of training are we doing here?”

Mami’s expression shifted, her gaze steady. “I’m trying to learn a very small portion of Disconnect.”

Kyoko raised an eyebrow. “Disconnect?”

Mami nodded. “It’s a technique Lunaria and Kasumi told me about. It allows a magical girl to siphon negativity from another’s Soul Gem and release it back into the universe. I’m only trying to learn a sliver of it—just enough to help my friends when they’re in danger.”

Kyoko sat up straighter, intrigued. “Your friends?”

Mami smiled softly. “You don’t know them yet. I met two girls—Sayaka and Madoka. They’re still normal girls, haven’t made a contract with Kyubey. I took them with me on witch hunts to show them what being a magical girl is really like. I wanted them to understand the risks before making a decision.”

Her voice grew quiet, her eyes darkening. “But one day... I was killed. By a witch named Charlotte. Right in front of them.”

Kyoko’s eyes widened slightly, but she didn’t interrupt.

Mami continued, her voice trembling. “As I was dying... I heard a voice. Ethereal. Beautiful. It was Lunaria.”

Her eyes grew distant, remembering the moment. “She pulled me back from the edge. We fought—and I was pushed to my breaking point. Every emotion I’d buried, every fear I’d ignored... it all came crashing down. I was seconds away from becoming a witch.”

She paused, her voice trembling. “But she saved me.”

“She told me the truth. That magical girls become witches when they surrender to despair. That our fate isn’t sealed unless we let it be. But more than that... she showed me a different way to live. A way to resist that descent.”

Mami’s voice softened, almost reverent. “She taught me how to connect with nature. How to find peace—not just in the world, but within myself. That beauty exists in all life, and that we can choose to see it.”

Her gaze drifted to the horizon. “Then I met Kasumi. She’s... very different from Lunaria. Wild, passionate, unpredictable. But she taught me something just as important.”

“She taught me emotional control. How to take the negativity inside me—the fear, the anger, the grief—and turn it into strength. Not by ignoring it, but by embracing it. She showed me how to fight, yes... but also how to live. How to laugh. How to genuinely enjoy life again.”

Mami looked back at Kyoko, her eyes shining. “They’ve been training me—not just in combat, but in how to be whole. How to be *me*.”

Kyoko listened silently, her expression unreadable.

Mami continued, her voice quiet, almost fragile. “Later, Lunaria showed me my friends again. Sayaka and the current Kyoko. They had just learned the truth about Soul Gems.”

She paused, her gaze distant. “That our souls aren’t in our bodies. They’re in the Soul Gem. Our bodies... they’re just vessels. Empty shells animated by magic. We’re not human anymore. Not in the way we thought.”

Her voice trembled. “It shattered them. Sayaka—so full of idealism, so desperate to protect others—looked like the ground had vanished beneath her feet.”

“And Kyoko... she couldn’t laugh it off. She froze—like her entire world had been knocked off its axis. Her bravado didn’t just crack—it collapsed. For a moment, she looked completely shattered. Like something inside her had broken, and she had no idea how to put the pieces back together. She couldn’t speak. She couldn’t move. Just stood there, staring at her Soul Gem like it had betrayed her.”

Mami’s hands clenched slightly. “They still don’t know the rest. The darker truth. That magical girls eventually become witches when despair consumes them. That the very power we use to fight evil... is the seed of our own destruction.”

She looked down, her expression heavy. “Their minds were unraveling. I could see it. The confusion. The fear. The loss of identity. I think... one of them might become a witch soon.”

“That’s why I’m here. That’s why I summoned you. I need to learn how to connect with another magical girl. It’s the first step toward learning Dis-connect. If I can learn even a fraction of it... I might be able to save them.”

Kyoko was quiet for a long moment, eyes narrowed in thought.

Then she smirked. “So you fought Lunaria, huh? I bet it was a one-sided slaughter. You probably didn’t land a single hit.”

Mami blinked, caught off guard. “Kyoko!”

Kyoko leaned in, eyes gleaming with mischief. “I’m just saying—I can *totally* picture it. You, right before turning into a witch. All dramatic and tragic, ribbons whipping around like storm winds, guns spraying-and-praying in every direction like you forgot what aiming was.”

She smirked, clearly enjoying herself. “I bet Witch Mami would look like a giant porcelain doll—creepy smile, glassy eyes, and a cannon for a head. Probably floating around on a tea set, firing explosive macarons.”

Mami gasped, scandalized. “I would *not* fire macarons! And I do *not* look like a porcelain doll.”

Kyoko burst out laughing. “Oh come on, you’d make it look elegant. Like a dessert-themed apocalypse.”

Mami puffed out her cheeks and crossed her arms, ribbons twitching with indignation. “I’ll have you know, my aim is *exceptional*. And if I ever did become a witch—which I won’t—I’d be far more elegant than whatever dessert-themed disaster you just described.”

Kyoko burst out laughing. “There it is! That pout! Just like old times.”

Mami tried to hold her glare, but her lips twitched into a smile.

Kyoko's laughter faded into a quiet chuckle. She looked out across the arena, her voice softer now. "That's what I love about you, Mami. You always try your best. Not just to get stronger—but to help people. You took me under your wing when I was just figuring things out. You helped me navigate this whole magical girl mess. I really appreciated that."

Mami's heart melted instantly. Her eyes widened, her breath catching in her throat. She hadn't expected that. Not from Kyoko. Not after everything that happened between her and the current Kyoko.

She brought both hands to her heart, her eyes soft, her smile warm. "Thank you, Kyoko. I... I never knew you felt that way."

Kyoko shrugged, still smiling. "Well, I'm not always great at saying stuff like that. But it's true."

They sat together in silence, the arena bathed in golden light. Two echoes of friendship, rekindled in a realm beyond time.

Kyoko leaned back, arms folded behind her head, her gaze thoughtful. "You know... your description of how I'd react makes sense. I can picture my current self getting all moody and brooding for a while after learning that our bodies are just shells. That our souls are locked inside those little gems."

She paused, then added with a dry laugh, "And I can only imagine how she'd take the *other* truth. The one about magical girls becoming witches. That'd probably break her all over again."

Mami's expression softened, but before she could speak, Kyoko sat up and gave her a sly grin. "Anyway, I'll help you with your training. But only because it might help the real me. Don't get any ideas—I'm not doing this out of sentiment."

Mami chuckled, her eyes warm. "There it is. The bravado and rebellious streak of my student. I remember that well."

Kyoko smirked. "You trained me once. Guess it's time I returned the favor."

She stood and flicked her wrist toward the air. A shimmering projection screen materialized in front of them, hovering just above the grass. On it appeared a list of drills—each one designed to help Mami learn how to connect with another magical girl. Some were physical, others emotional, and a few looked downright strange.

Kyoko gestured toward the screen. "Alright, here's what we've got. Empathy resonance drills, synchronized movement exercises, shared memory simulations, and a few combat-based ones where we have to sync our attacks."

She smirked, eyes glinting. "There's even one where we have to hold hands and walk through a nightmare together. Or the trust fall exercise—though I'm not catching you if you fall. And don't even ask about the one where we have to sing in harmony to unlock a spell."

Mami raised an eyebrow. “You’re joking.”

Kyoko grinned. “Only halfway. Connection’s not just about magic. It’s about trust. Vulnerability. You want to learn Disconnect? You’ve gotta start by letting someone in.”

Mami scanned the list, her heart steady but determined. This was the next step. And she wasn’t alone.

Chapter 6 – Into the Nightmare

Mami stood before the projection screen, eyes scanning the list of training drills. Her gaze paused on one in particular.

“Hold hands and walk through a nightmare together” *Recommended for beginners.*

She blinked. “Wait... this is recommended?”

Kyoko leaned over her shoulder, casually chewing on a piece of dried fruit. “Told ya. Halfway joking.”

Mami’s eyes narrowed, her thoughts drifting to Lunaria and Kasumi. Every so-called “beginner” lesson they’d given her had been anything but gentle.

The first time she met Lunaria, they fought. Lunaria had pushed her to her absolute breaking point—emotionally, physically, spiritually. Mami had come within moments of becoming a witch.

And Kasumi? Her idea of training was throwing Mami straight into an advanced battle against a shadow monster, while the arena itself passively corrupted her Soul Gem at an alarming rate. No warm-ups. No warnings. Just chaos and survival.

Beginner drills, Mami thought wryly, always end with me near death.

She narrowed her eyes at the screen. *So why is this one labeled “recommended”?*

A flicker of caution stirred in her chest—but then she glanced at Kyoko, who was watching the screen with a curious grin and zero concern.

Lunaria and Kasumi aren’t here, Mami reminded herself. This is Kyoko’s arena. It should be fine.

She took a breath, steadying herself. Whatever this nightmare was, she’d face it. And she wouldn’t be alone.

Mami turned to her, brows raised. “Are you okay with this?”

Kyoko shrugged, her grin tugging wider. “Yeah. I’m curious too. I mean, what kind of training starts with a nightmare and ends with a beginner badge?”

Mami hesitated, then nodded. “Alright. But... we’re not holding hands.”

Kyoko snorted. “Agreed. That’d be awkward. I’m not the mushy type.”

Mami smiled. “Neither am I.”

They both looked back at the screen, the option glowing softly as if waiting for them to accept.

Kyoko cracked her knuckles. “Let’s see what kind of nightmare this realm thinks we need.”

Mami reached out and tapped the selection.

The arena shimmered, and the world around them began to shift.

Chapter 6a - The 1st room

The shimmering light faded, and Mami blinked against the sudden shift in atmosphere.

She and Kyoko now stood in a vast stone chamber, surrounded by towering yellow walls that glowed faintly under an unseen light source. The air was dry, heavy with the scent of ancient dust. Sand was scattered across the floor in uneven patches, as if swept in by forgotten winds.

Kyoko turned in a slow circle, her eyes wide. “Okay... this is new.”

Mami blinked. “Wait—*new*? I thought this was your arena.”

Kyoko shrugged, still surveying the room. “When did I say that? I just opened up the Connect Fundamentals training options for ya. The only thing I really have control over in the arena are the snacks.”

Mami stared at her. “You mean I trusted this because I thought *you* made it?”

Kyoko grinned. “Aw, that’s sweet. But also kinda reckless.”

Mami groaned, rubbing her temples. *Of course*. She’d told herself it would be fine—Lunaria and Kasumi weren’t here, so surely this wouldn’t be another trial by fire. But now she was standing in a mysterious pyramid labyrinth with Kyoko, who apparently had no idea what was going on either.

“Beginner drills,” Mami muttered. “Always end with me nearly dying.”

Kyoko snorted. “Hey, at least this one comes with mood lighting and sand. That’s gotta count for something.”

Then she gave Mami a thumbs up, her grin softening. “And hey—we’re not alone, right partner?”

Mami chuckled and returned the gesture with a smile. “Right.”

They turned their attention to the walls, lined with strange murals and symbols. Kyoko stepped closer, squinting at the carvings. “These symbols... I’ve never seen anything like them. Definitely not Japanese. Not even Latin.”

Mami followed her gaze, then paused at a mural etched into the stone. Unlike the cryptic symbols, the image was clear: a group of young people playing in a grassy field, surrounded by blooming flowers. Their faces were indistinct, but their joy was unmistakable.

Kyoko tilted her head. “That’s weird. Doesn’t really match the whole ancient tomb vibe.”

Mami frowned. “No... it feels out of place. Like a memory trapped in stone.”

They exchanged a glance, then turned toward the only visible exit—a narrow passageway carved into the far wall, half-covered in sand.

Kyoko cracked her neck. “Well, no point standing around. Let’s see what kind of nightmare this place has in store.”

Mami nodded, her voice steady. “Together.”

They stepped into the corridor, their footsteps echoing throughout the labyrinth.

Chapter 6b - The Sepulcrum of Echoes

As they stepped through the narrow passageway, the corridor opened into a vast circular chamber—so massive it made the previous room feel like a closet.

Mami and Kyoko froze in place, their eyes wide.

The room was breathtaking.

Towering yellow stone walls curved around them in a perfect ring, etched with more of the strange symbols and faded murals. The ceiling arched high above, disappearing into shadow, and the air felt ancient—like it had been sealed for centuries. Scattered sand glimmered faintly under the ambient light, giving the space a surreal, dreamlike quality.

At the center of the chamber was a wide, circular hole—its depth obscured by darkness. Just beside it stood a stone altar, weathered and cracked, perched dangerously close to the edge.

Surrounding the hole, a ring of descending steps formed a shallow basin, like the inner tiers of a coliseum. The majority of the chamber remained flat and spacious, allowing easy access to the many passageway entrances lining the outer wall. The stairs began only a short distance from the center, sloping gently downward toward the altar and the hole, giving the impression of a sunken heart within the vast room.

From above, the layout would resemble a wide disc with a shallow cone carved into its center—an ancient design that felt both ceremonial and ominous.

Kyoko let out a low whistle. “Okay... now *this* is pyramid-core.”

Mami nodded slowly, awe in her voice. “It’s like something out of a dream. Or a myth.”

As they looked around, Mami and Kyoko noticed dozens of passageways lining the perimeter of the chamber—each one identical in shape to the corridor they had just exited. Above every entrance glowed a large colored dot, softly pulsing against the stone.

The doorway they had just come through was marked with a single dot.

As their eyes moved across the chamber, they saw other entrances labeled with two, three, even five dots—each arranged in a neat vertical line above the archways, like a coded sequence. The pattern was unmistakable: the dots were incrementing, a clear progression.

Kyoko tilted her head. “Looks like a level system.”

Mami nodded. “The number of dots must represent the order we’re supposed to visit the rooms in.”

Kyoko crossed her arms. “So we just go room by room, huh? Sounds like a scavenger hunt with trauma.”

Mami glanced at the altar. “Before we dive into any more rooms, let’s check that out first. We don’t know what this training will throw at us, and at least we can see the altar. Those other rooms are still a mystery.”

Kyoko gave a nod. “Fair point. Let’s see what the creepy centerpiece has to offer.”

Together, they walked toward the center of the chamber, their footsteps echoing softly. The sand shifted beneath their boots as they descended the spiraling stairs, each step taking them closer to the altar—and whatever secrets it held.

Mami and Kyoko walked across the smooth stone floor, approaching the descending ring of steps near the center of the chamber. As they reached the top of the stairs, they paused.

From this angle, the hole at the center looked far larger than before—an immense, yawning void that swallowed light. Its edges were clean and ancient, but the darkness within was absolute. It pulsed with quiet menace, as if daring them to look deeper.

Kyoko leaned forward slightly. “Okay... that’s officially ominous.”

Mami nodded, her voice low. “It feels like it’s watching us.”

They descended the steps slowly, the air growing heavier with each level. The altar loomed ahead, cracked and weathered, its surface etched with faded symbols that shimmered faintly as they approached.

They stopped just before it, exchanging a glance.

Kyoko raised an eyebrow. “Ready?”

Mami hesitated, then nodded. “Let’s see what this thing has to say.”

Together, they reached out and placed their hands on the altar.

The moment their fingers touched the stone, the air shimmered. A projection burst forth in front of them—soft light forming a floating screen of streaming text. The letters glowed gold against the dim surroundings, appearing one line at a time.

Welcome, Mami Tomoe and Kyoko Sakura.

You have entered the **Beginner’s Connect Training** within the **Sepulcrum of Echoes**.

This space is designed to test and strengthen the bonds between magical girls.

The final trial awaits below.

When ready, you may leap into the central void to begin.

However, it is *strongly recommended* that you first explore the surrounding chambers.

Each room holds fragments of memory, emotion, and insight.

Visiting them in order will provide context and clarity for what lies ahead.

The projection faded, leaving only the quiet hum of the altar and the oppressive silence of the chamber.

Kyoko exhaled. “So... memory fragments, emotional insight, and a giant hole. Classic beginner stuff.”

Mami gave a small smile. “At least we’re not being thrown into combat right away.”

Kyoko glanced back at the passageways lining the outer wall, each marked with glowing dots. “Guess we start with the two-dots room.”

Mami nodded. “Makes sense. We just came from the one-dot room, so the next step should be there.”

Kyoko stretched her arms overhead. “Let’s hope it’s more memory and less nightmare.”

Mami nodded. “Let’s take our time. If this place is built to test connection, then we need to understand what it’s trying to show us.”

They turned from the altar, the void still looming behind them, and began walking toward the entrance marked with two glowing dots—its threshold quiet, waiting, and full of unknowns.

Chapter 6c – The 2nd room

Mami and Kyoko stood before the entrance marked with two glowing dots. They exchanged a glance, then nodded in silent agreement.

“Ready for the floor to collapse?” Kyoko muttered.

“Or a monster to jump out of the wall,” Mami added.

“Or both,” Kyoko said with a grin.

They stepped through the threshold, bracing themselves for the worst. Their minds raced with possibilities—nightmare scenarios pulled from books, movies, and stories they'd grown up with. Cursed tombs, shadow beasts, illusions that twisted reality. The pyramid had the perfect atmosphere for all of it.

But nothing happened.

No sudden drop. No flickering lights. No eerie whispers or clawed hands reaching from the dark.

Instead, the corridor led them to a room nearly identical to the one they had first appeared in. The same yellow stone walls. The same scattered sand. The same strange symbols etched into the surfaces—unreadable, alien, and ancient.

But this room had a new mural.

Mami stepped closer, her eyes scanning the ancient image. It depicted the same group of young people from the first room, still in the grassy field surrounded by blooming flowers. But this time, they were gathered around a small creature—its form abstract and stylized, rendered in an art style that felt ceremonial and old, like something carved and painted by hands long gone. The lines were deliberate yet cryptic, the colors still clear after the test of time.

The creature had large ears, a long tail, and an unreadable expression. Its proportions were strange, almost playful, yet unsettling in their ambiguity. The lines were deliberate, but the meaning was obscured—like a symbol whose significance had been lost to time.

Kyoko squinted. “Is that... an animal?”

Mami nodded slowly. “Looks like it. But it’s hard to tell what kind.”

Kyoko tilted her head. “Weird proportions. Kinda uncanny.”

They stared at the mural in silence for a moment.

Mami spoke first. “The first room showed them playing. Innocent. Carefree.”

Kyoko nodded. “And now they’re looking at... whatever *that* is. Like something’s about to change.”

Mami frowned. “It feels like a story. One we’re supposed to follow.”

Kyoko crossed her arms. “So what’s next? The three-dot room shows them signing a contract with a demon?”

Mami gave her a sideways glance. “Let’s hope not.”

They turned from the mural, the symbols still glowing faintly behind them, and began walking back toward the central chamber.

Chapter 6d – The 3rd room

The walk to the three-dot room was uneventful. No traps. No illusions. Just the quiet hum of the pyramid and the soft glow of the colored dots guiding their way.

Mami and Kyoko stepped through the threshold, their boots brushing against the sand-strewn floor. The room was familiar in layout—yellow stone walls, strange symbols etched into every surface, and another mural waiting silently on the far wall.

They approached it together.

This mural showed the same group of young people in the grassy field, still surrounded by blooming flowers. The small creature stood at the center—its form unchanged, still abstract and stylized, carved and painted with deliberate care.

But this time, a radiant light emanated from its body, enveloping the entire group in a soft, golden glow.

Floating in front of each girl—except for two—were colored circles. Each one a different hue, suspended like glowing tokens of fate.

Mami's eyes widened. Her mouth parted in silent recognition.

Kyoko stepped closer, her expression mirroring Mami's. "That light... it's coming from the creature."

Mami nodded slowly. "And those circles... they look like Soul Gems."

Kyoko exhaled. "So this is it. The contract."

Mami's gaze lingered on the mural, her heart sinking. "More girls... tricked into this life. Into fighting, suffering, and fading away."

She could already imagine what the next rooms might show. The battles. The despair. The inevitable transformation. Grief seeds, witches, isolation.

Kyoko glanced at her, noticing the sadness in her eyes. She nudged Mami gently with her elbow. "Hey. Maybe the story has a happy ending. Like yours."

Mami looked at her, surprised.

Kyoko shrugged. "You've got friends now. You're not alone. And you found a new path in life as a magical girl. Maybe this story ends with something like that too. Too early to judge a story by its first two pages."

Mami smiled, the heaviness in her chest easing just a little. "Thanks, Kyoko."

They stood in silence for a moment longer, then Kyoko pointed at the two girls in the mural who didn't have colored circles floating in front of them.

"Who do you think those two are?" she asked. "The light's touching them too, but they didn't get Soul Gems."

Mami leaned in, studying the mural more closely. "I noticed that too. They're part of the group... but something's different."

Kyoko crossed her arms. "Maybe they refused. Or maybe they couldn't."

Mami frowned. "Or maybe they were meant for something else."

The mural offered no answers—only more questions, etched in ancient stone and vivid paint.

Chapter 6e – The 4th room

The four-dot room greeted them with the same layout as the previous ones—yellow stone walls, scattered sand, and a quiet stillness that felt almost reverent. The symbols etched into the stone glowed faintly, and the mural awaited them on the far wall, vivid and colorful, barely touched by time.

Mami and Kyoko stepped closer.

The grassy field and blooming flowers returned once again, a familiar backdrop now tinged with anticipation. The group of young girls stood together, but this time, something was different.

Each girl with a colored circle floating in front of her was engaged in a distinct action, their abilities rendered in the mural with surreal, symbolic flair.

The first girl stood at the edge of the group, her form mid-transformation. Her body was part human, part something else—her limbs elongated and textured like bark or fur, her hair flowing into feathered strands that merged with the wind. Her face retained a human softness, but her eyes glowed with an animalistic intensity. Around her, objects were caught in flux: a stone that looked half-melted into wood, a flower blooming into metal, a bird with wings that shimmered like glass. The mural conveyed her shapeshifting not through motion, but through hybrid forms—each element caught between what it was and what it was becoming. It was as if the world around her bent to her imagination, reshaping itself in response to her presence.

The second girl stood with her arms raised, surrounded by a halo of levitating nature. Stones, branches, leaves, and even small animals floated gently around her, suspended in midair. Birds perched calmly on the hovering branches, their wings tucked in as if resting mid-flight. A fox curled atop a floating rock, eyes closed in peaceful sleep. The mural captured a sense of serenity and control—nothing chaotic, nothing forced. Her telekinesis was depicted as harmonious, a quiet mastery over the

physical world. The objects didn't just float—they orbited her like companions, drawn to her presence by unseen threads.

The third girl was shown touching a tree, her fingers pressed against its bark. Where her hand met the trunk, the tree shimmered with unnatural vibrancy—its bark glowing with iridescent hues, its leaves shifting color and shape. The transformation was localized: the part of the tree she touched looked alive in a new way, while the rest remained ordinary. The ground beneath her feet was similarly altered—its texture smoother, its color richer, as if infused with energy. Further away, the earth looked untouched, dull in comparison. The mural suggested her power was not just to change things, but to redefine their essence—heat, hardness, interaction. She didn't move the world; she rewrote its rules.

Mami and Kyoko stood in silence, absorbing the scene.

Kyoko tilted her head. “They're all so different. It's like the mural's showing how magic manifests uniquely for each girl.”

Mami nodded. “It's beautiful... but also overwhelming. So much power, and so many paths.”

Mami studied the rest of the group. “There are others too. Each one seems to have a different ability. It's like the mural's showing how they've grown since forming the contract.”

Scattered across the field, the other magical girls displayed a kaleidoscope of powers.

One girl stood in the center of a swirling storm, her hair whipping around her as gusts of wind spiraled from her fingertips. But this was no ordinary tempest—the wind itself seemed alive. Within its currents danced faint, translucent shapes: ghostly figures, wisps of spirit, flickering like memories caught in motion. They didn't threaten her—they played with her, circling her body in graceful arcs, brushing her arms and hair like old friends. The mural suggested her power wasn't just elemental—it was spiritual. She didn't command the weather; she communed with something older, something unseen.

Another girl danced through the air, her body seemingly untouched by gravity. Her feet barely grazed the ground, and with each movement, she left behind shimmering trails of light—ribbons of color that twisted and curled like brushstrokes across the sky. Her posture was fluid, her limbs extended in elegant arcs, as if she were performing for an audience only she could see.

The mural captured her mid-motion, arms outstretched, one leg lifted in a pirouette that defied physics. The light she left behind wasn't just decoration—it pulsed with energy, forming patterns that hinted at

emotion, memory, or perhaps even communication. Some trails glowed warm like sunlight, others cool like moonlight, and a few flickered with hues that seemed to shift depending on where Mami and Kyoko stood.

She didn't fly. She floated. She didn't run. She glided. Her power wasn't about speed or strength—it was about transcendence. The mural suggested she had become something more than physical, a being of motion and light, dancing between the boundaries of space and spirit.

A girl near the edge of the mural had her hands raised toward the sky, her posture commanding yet serene. Above her, clouds gathered unnaturally fast—thick, dark, and swirling with purpose. The sky in her portion of the mural looked different from the rest: charged with energy, streaked with flashes of light, as if nature itself responded to her call.

Unlike the girl in the center of the storm, whose winds danced with spirits, this girl's power felt elemental and raw. The clouds didn't play—they obeyed. The mural suggested she could summon rain, lightning, or even silence from the heavens. Her connection to the weather was direct, forceful, and vast—an orchestration of sky and storm.

Another girl knelt beside a patch of flowers, her posture gentle and grounded. As her fingers brushed the petals, the plants responded instantly—buds unfurled, stems straightened, and blossoms burst into full bloom with radiant color. The transformation wasn't dramatic; it was graceful, like nature simply remembered what it was meant to be.

Around her, the grass grew taller and greener, curling toward her like it recognized her presence. Butterflies hovered nearby, wings shimmering in the mural's painted light, while small animals peeked from the underbrush, drawn to her serenity. The air around her seemed warmer, softer, as if her very aura nourished the earth.

Unlike the other girls whose powers bent reality or defied physics, hers felt restorative. She didn't command nature—she harmonized with it. The mural suggested a bond not just with life, but with the essence of growth, healing, and renewal. Her magic was quiet, but profound.

One girl's shadow stretched unnaturally long behind her, curling and twisting like a living thing. It snaked across the ground in impossible directions, defying the angle of the sun depicted in the mural. The shadow's edges were jagged and fluid, shifting shape as if responding to her thoughts. In one part of the mural, it resembled a serpent; in another, a pair of wings unfurling. Though the girl herself stood still, her shadow moved independently—an extension of her will, or perhaps something else entirely. The art suggested a power rooted in darkness, in the unseen, in the parts of reality that linger just beyond the light.

Beside her, **another girl** seemed to blur at the edges, her form flickering between visibility and invisibility. Her outline shimmered, fading in and out like a mirage. One moment she was fully present, the next only a faint silhouette remained. The mural captured her mid-step, half of her body rendered in full color, the other half translucent, barely distinguishable from the background. It was as if she existed between worlds—part of the scene, yet not bound by it. Her power felt elusive, evasive, like a whisper in a crowded room. She didn't hide; she slipped through perception itself.

Each depiction was unique, stylized in the same ceremonial art style—clear in intention, yet open to interpretation. The powers weren't labeled, but the imagery spoke volumes.

Kyoko let out a low whistle. “That’s a lot of firepower.”

Mami nodded. “And a lot of stories. Each one different.”

But then her eyes drifted to the two girls who stood quietly among the group—unchanged, untouched by power. No glowing circles. No magical feats. Just ordinary expressions and stillness.

Kyoko frowned. “Those two again. Still no Soul Gems.”

Mami's gaze followed hers. “They’re part of the group, but they’re not doing anything. Not even reacting to the powers around them.”

Kyoko tilted her head. “So what’s their deal? The light from the creature hit them too. Why didn’t they change?”

Mami crossed her arms, thoughtful. “Maybe they weren’t meant to. Or maybe they chose not to.”

Kyoko raised an eyebrow. “Do you think they still have yet to awaken their powers?”

Mami hesitated. “It’s possible. Or maybe... they’re connected in a different way. Not magical girls, but still part of the story.”

Kyoko looked at the mural again. “They don’t look scared. Just... quiet.”

Mami nodded. “Like they’re watching. Waiting.”

Near the center of the mural stood **one final girl**—visibly different from the rest of the magical girls. She looked ordinary. No dramatic pose, no glowing aura, no fantastical display of power. Her clothes were simple, her expression calm. If not for the colored circle floating in front of her, she might have been mistaken for one of the two unawakened girls.

But from her outstretched hand extended a series of fine, painted lines—delicate yet deliberate. These lines reached outward, connecting to every other girl in the mural. They curved and branched like threads of light, linking her to the shapeshifter, the telekinetic, the elemental, and even the two girls without Soul Gems.

The lines didn’t bind—they flowed. They didn’t control—they connected.

Kyoko leaned in, squinting. “Huh. She’s not doing anything flashy... but those lines...”

Mami nodded slowly. “She’s connected to all of them. Even the two who haven’t awakened.”

Kyoko tilted her head. “What do you think that means? Is she their leader?”

Mami frowned, thoughtful. “Maybe. Or maybe her power is something different. Something subtle.”

Kyoko crossed her arms. “Like... emotional? Mental? Maybe she links them together somehow.”

Mami’s gaze lingered on the girl’s calm expression. “She could be the reason they’re a group. The one who holds them together.”

Kyoko glanced at the two unawakened girls. “And if she’s connected to them too... maybe she’s the key to whatever their role is.”

Mami nodded. “Maybe she’s some sort of magical girl coordinator, like Mitama in Kamihama... Or maybe she’s using Connect on them—the ability we’re trying to learn.”

They stood in silence, absorbing the implications. The mural didn’t shout—it whispered. And this girl, quiet and unassuming, seemed to be at the heart of it all.

Kyoko stretched her arms behind her back. “I think we’ve spent enough time in this room. What do you say we check out the next one?”

Mami nodded. “Yes, good idea.”

As they walked out of the room together, one thought echoed in both their minds:

The mural offered no answers—only more questions, etched in ancient stone and painted with deliberate mystery.

Chapter 6f – The 5th room

The five-dot room greeted them with the same layout as the others—yellow stone walls, scattered sand, and a quiet, humming stillness. But the moment Mami and Kyoko stepped inside, they felt the shift.

The mural on the far wall was larger, more chaotic, and more vibrant than any they had seen before. The colors were bolder, the lines sharper, the composition dense with motion and emotion. It was a battle scene.

All of the girls were present—those with Soul Gems and the two without. They stood together in a field that had transformed into something surreal and twisted. The background pulsed with abstract shapes and impossible geometry, a vivid portrayal of a witch’s labyrinth. The witch itself was rendered as a monstrous abstraction: jagged limbs, spiraling eyes, and a body that seemed to defy form. It loomed over the girls, its presence dominating the scene.

Each magical girl was shown in combat, their powers now weaponized. The shapeshifter had become a chimera of motion, her limbs morphing mid-strike, her surroundings reshaping into tools of war. The telekinetic girl hurled boulders and branches with precision, her floating companions now part of her arsenal. The girl who manipulated matter turned the ground beneath the witch into brittle glass, the air around it into searing heat.

The others fought with equal intensity—storms, shadows, light, and invisibility all converging in a coordinated assault. And at the rear, the girl who connected them all stood with her hand raised, the same threads extending from her fingers to each of the fighters. Even the two girls without Soul Gems were linked to her, though they did not fight.

Those two stood quietly at the back of the group, watching. Their expressions were solemn, their bodies still. To Mami and Kyoko, they looked like observers—present, but powerless.

Mami’s breath caught in her throat. “They’re fighting a witch...”

Kyoko nodded, her voice low. “Yeah. And those two... they’re just standing there.”

Mami’s eyes lingered on the two girls. “Why are they here? They don’t seem able to fight. Are they helping somehow through the threads?”

Kyoko didn’t answer right away. She watched the mural, her brow furrowed.

Mami’s thoughts drifted to the past. “I used to take Madoka and Sayaka with me on witch hunts. I thought... I thought they should understand what it meant to be a magical girl.”

Kyoko turned to her, listening.

“I remember the day I fought Charlotte,” Mami said softly. “They were there. They saw me die. I didn’t think... I didn’t think I’d put them in danger. But I did.”

Her voice trembled slightly. “That regret... that fear of endangering my friends... it’s what Lunaria used against me. It’s what pushed me to the edge.”

Kyoko placed a hand on her shoulder. “You were trying to protect them. You wanted them to understand. That’s not wrong.”

Mami nodded, eyes still on the mural. “I just see those two girls, and I wonder... will they end up like Madoka and Sayaka? Watching their friends die, powerless to help?”

Kyoko looked at the threads connecting them to the girl in the back. “They’re connected. That means something. Maybe they’re contributing in a way we can’t see.”

She paused. “And don’t forget—Kyubey’s light enveloped them in the earlier mural. They’re not just normal humans. They must have something. Some ability. Some role.”

Mami sighed. “I hope so. I hope they won’t have to watch their friends fall and be left behind, trying to survive in a world they weren’t meant to fight.”

They stood in silence, the mural’s intensity washing over them. It didn’t just depict a battle—it captured the weight of being a magical girl. The cost. The courage. The connection.

And as they turned to leave the five-dot room, one thought lingered in both their minds:

These girls were beginning to live the reality of magical girls—the battles, the burdens, the fragile hope. What terrible things awaited them? When would the “nightmare” begin, as promised by the title of this training?

Chapter 6g – The 6th room

Mami and Kyoko walked toward the six-dot room with heavy steps. The air felt thicker here, the silence more expectant. After the battle scene in the five-dot room, they braced themselves for tragedy—perhaps the first descent into despair, the moment when one of the girls would break under the weight of being a magical girl.

But when they stepped inside, they froze.

The mural was calm.

The grassy field had returned, blooming with vibrant flowers. All twelve girls were present, standing together in the sunlight. Their bodies showed no signs of injury, their expressions were peaceful. It was a scene of recovery, of togetherness.

Mami let out a soft breath. “They’re okay...”

Kyoko nodded, her shoulders relaxing. “No nightmare yet.”

They stepped closer, examining the mural in detail.

One girl stood slightly apart from the others, her hand extended toward the colored circle floating in front of her. A second, smaller dot—black and jagged—hovered beside it, touching the Soul Gem.

Kyoko pointed. “That’s a grief seed.”

Mami nodded. “She’s cleansing her Soul Gem. After the witch fight in the last mural.”

Kyoko looked closely at the mural and then tilted her head. “But there’s a problem.”

Mami turned to her. “What do you mean?”

Kyoko gestured at the group. “There’s only one grief seed. But ten magical girls. Not counting the two without Soul Gems.”

Mami’s eyes widened. She looked closer at the other girls’ colored dots. Some were darker than before—subtle, but unmistakable. The hues had shifted, dulled slightly, like a candle burning low.

She stepped back, stunned. “The artist... they captured it. The change in color. That’s not something you’d notice unless you understood magical girls.”

Kyoko nodded slowly. “Yeah. It’s subtle, but it’s there. I can kind of see where the nightmare’s going.”

Mami’s heart sank. “They were so happy. Playing together. Supporting each other in battle. With that many girls working in sync, they should be able to defeat almost any witch.”

She paused, her voice soft. “But they can’t sustain it. Not with only one grief seed.”

Kyoko crossed her arms. “It’s like watching a clock tick down. They’re strong now, but that strength has a cost.”

Mami nodded. “And if they don’t find more witches... if they don’t get more grief seeds...”

Kyoko finished the thought. “They’ll fall. One by one.”

They stood in silence, the mural’s quiet beauty now tinged with dread. The nightmare hadn’t begun—but the seeds of it had been planted.

Chapter 6h – The 7th room

Mami and Kyoko stood before the entrance to the seven-dot room, the air around them heavy with expectation. The last few murals had traced a delicate line between hope and dread, and both girls knew that line couldn’t hold forever.

Kyoko exhaled slowly. “This is where it’s gonna start, isn’t it?”

Mami nodded, her voice quiet. “If despair hasn’t taken root yet... it will soon.”

They had seen the signs—the subtle dimming of Soul Gems, the quiet tension beneath the surface of joy. The murals had been gentle so far, but the title of the training still echoed in their minds: *Into the Nightmare*. The descent had to begin somewhere.

As they stepped into the room, they braced themselves for tragedy. A death. A betrayal. A moment of collapse. Something that would shatter the harmony they'd seen so far.

But what greeted them was not what they expected.

The seven-dot room loomed larger than the others. Mami and Kyoko could feel it before they even stepped inside—a quiet gravity, a sense of scale. The doorway was wider, the ceiling higher, and the mural stretched across the entire chamber wall. Or rather, murals.

It was a collection of nine distinct panels, each one depicting a different witch fight.

The backgrounds were chaotic and vibrant, each labyrinth rendered with surreal artistry—twisting landscapes, impossible architecture, and bursts of color that clashed and danced. The witches were abstract monstrosities, each unique in form and menace. And in every panel, the magical girls fought together, coordinated and fierce.

But what caught Mami and Kyoko's attention was what came after each battle.

In every mural, one of the magical girls stood apart, her hand extended toward her Soul Gem. A black dot—clearly a grief seed—hovered beside it, cleansing the gem. The others stood nearby, watching, their own Soul Gems untouched.

Kyoko counted silently. “Nine fights. Nine girls. That makes ten total, with the one from the last room.”

Mami nodded. “And the two without Soul Gems are still just watching.”

Kyoko stepped closer, examining the Soul Gems. “They're a little dull... like before. But they're not getting worse. No corruption. No signs of despair.”

Mami's eyes widened. “That's it. That's what Lunaria taught me on my first night here.”

Kyoko turned to her. “What do you mean?”

Mami's voice was quiet, reverent. “She said that as long as you don't succumb to despair, you won't become a witch. That good rest, a peaceful mind, and emotional support are enough to recharge your Soul Gem. You don't need grief seeds.”

She looked at the murals again. “These girls... they must be living that way. Not intentionally, maybe. I doubt they know the dark truths of magical girls at this point. But they're doing it. They're living happily, in peace, supporting each other. And it's working.”

Kyoko nodded slowly. “That lines up with what Kasumia and Lunaria told me too. When they connect with me... it’s always about joy, play, and trust.”

Mami’s gaze lingered on the murals. “They’ve built something magical. A system that works. One grief seed per fight, shared without resentment. No despair. Just... harmony.”

Kyoko crossed her arms. “Any magical girl would envy this.”

Mami nodded, but her expression grew thoughtful. “It reminds me of what Kasumi showed me... about the Wings of the Magius.”

Kyoko glanced at her, curious.

“They wanted salvation for all magical girls,” Mami continued. “Through the APS system, through Doppels. A way to avoid becoming witches. A way to survive the curse.”

She looked back at the murals. “But the Magius were trying to rewrite the rules. To bend the system. These girls... they’re not changing anything. They’re just living differently. Happily. Peacefully. And somehow, it’s working.”

Kyoko leaned against the wall, her eyes narrowing. “The Magius had good intentions. But most of its members were desperate. Their leaders wanted control. On the other hand, these girls don’t even seem to know what despair is.”

Mami nodded. “Exactly. The Magius were fighting against the system. These girls are avoiding it entirely. Not through power. Through joy.”

Kyoko smirked. “And they’re doing it without a secret organization, without experiments, without turning people into pawns.”

Mami’s voice softened. “The Magius had a vision. A plan. But these girls... they’ve organically stumbled into something better. Something purer.”

Kyoko looked at the threads connecting the girls. “Maybe that’s the difference. The Magius wanted to save magical girls through any means necessary. But these girls... they’re just being kids. Happy. Innocent. Pure. They don’t know the truth, and maybe that’s why it works. Sometimes ignorance really is bliss.”

Mami smiled faintly. “I wonder if that’s the real answer. Not systems. Not rebellion. Just... connection.”

They stood in silence, the murals glowing softly around them. The nightmare hadn’t begun—but the contrast between hope and history was growing sharper.

Mami nodded, her voice tinged with quiet sorrow. “But these good times can’t last forever.”

Kyoko's gaze lingered on the murals, her tone low and steady. "No. The nightmare has to start somewhere."

They stood in silence, surrounded by scenes of triumph and quiet grace—nine battles fought, nine Soul Gems cleansed, and still no sign of despair. It was a fragile harmony, beautiful in its simplicity, but Mami and Kyoko knew better than to trust its permanence.

The air in the room felt heavier now, as if the murals themselves were holding their breath. The girls in the paintings smiled, stood tall, and leaned on each other—but the cracks were there, subtle and waiting.

The descent hadn't begun.

But the tension was building.

The question wasn't *if*.

It was *when*.

And as Mami and Kyoko turned toward the next room, their hearts carried the weight of that inevitability.

Chapter 7 – Descent

Mami and Kyoko wandered through the vast core chamber of the pyramid, their footsteps echoing softly against the stone. The space felt even larger now—its silence deep, its shadows long, as if the pyramid itself were holding its breath. As they walked, they speculated about the structure's scale.

"How many rooms do you think there are?" Kyoko asked, glancing up at the towering walls that stretched into darkness.

Mami looked around thoughtfully. "Hard to say. Seven so far... but this place feels like it could hold dozens. Maybe more."

Kyoko snorted. "Figures. Magical girl training never comes in small packages."

Eventually, they found the entrance to the eight-dot room—or what should have been the entrance. Instead of an open archway, they were met with a grand stone wall, tall and imposing, etched with symbols and pictographs unlike anything they'd seen in the murals. These carvings were abstract and mysterious—celestial shapes, spiraling glyphs, and strange figures that shimmered faintly in the torchlight, as if alive.

Above the sealed wall hovered a dot, but it was different from the ones they'd seen before. Richer in color, metallic in sheen. It pulsed softly, like it was waiting.

Mami reached out and touched the stone. Kyoko followed, sending a pulse of magic through her fingertips. Nothing happened.

“No reaction,” Kyoko muttered. “Not even a twitch.”

Mami frowned. “It’s locked. But why?”

They traced the carvings, admiring the artistry even as they searched for clues. The wall was beautiful—ancient and deliberate, like a gate to something sacred.

Looking around the chamber, they spotted another sealed entrance nearby—the nine-dot room. It too was blocked by a different stone wall, equally ornate, and its dot matched the eight-dot room in color and glow.

Kyoko folded her arms. “Looks like everything past seven is sealed off.”

Mami nodded. “I wonder what we need to do to access them. And what’s waiting for us inside.”

They stood in silence, the sealed doors towering before them, holding back whatever came next. The air felt heavier here, as if the pyramid itself was guarding its deepest truths.

After a few minutes, they stepped back.

“We’ve seen all the rooms we can,” Mami said softly.

Kyoko nodded. “Time to head back.”

They retraced their steps through the winding halls of the pyramid’s core. Their footsteps echoed with quiet finality, the sealed doors of the eight- and nine-dot rooms lingering in their minds—unreachable, mysterious, and waiting.

They descended the stairs to the altar, returning to the place where their journey had begun. As they reached the base, the altar responded before either of them could touch it.

A burst of light erupted from its center, forming a shimmering projection that hovered in the air. Lines of text streamed forth, glowing softly:

Congratulations, Mami and Kyoko, for visiting all seven rooms. We hope you found the journey interesting.

You are now ready to begin the test of the Sepulcrum of Echoes. This trial will strengthen your bond and teach you the art of Connect.

To begin, please jump into the hole. Don’t worry—it’s safe.

The final line appeared with a playful flourish, the font curling like a wink:

And remember: hold hands! It’s a very important part of the training. After all, you’re supposed to walk through a nightmare together!

Mami and Kyoko turned slowly to face the hole at the center of the chamber. It was wide, dark, and silent—an abyss that seemed to hum with expectation.

Kyoko squinted at it. “Safe, huh? That’s what they always say before something tries to eat you.”

Mami folded her arms. “It doesn’t look safe.”

They stared into the darkness, trying to imagine what lay below. Nightmares, surely. The murals had hinted at a descent, a breaking point. Whatever came next, it would be darker than anything they’d seen so far.

“I bet there’ll be more murals,” Kyoko said. “And I bet they won’t be so cheerful.”

Mami nodded. “The nightmare’s waiting down there. I can feel it.”

Their eyes met, then drifted to their hands.

Kyoko grimaced. “Still not holding your hand.”

Mami sighed. “Same.”

They stood at the edge of the hole, the projection fading behind them, the pyramid silent once more.

The descent was no longer a question.

It was the next step.

Mami and Kyoko stood at the edge of the hole, the last flicker of the altar’s projection fading behind them. The silence returned, deep and expectant.

They both took a deep breath, then looked at each other.

“Ready?” Mami asked.

Kyoko smirked. “Of course. You?”

Mami nodded.

Kyoko tilted her head, her grin widening. “I wonder if you’ll start panicking and squealing like a scared little girl once we’re down there.”

Mami gave her a sharp look, then grinned. “Only if you start crying and begging me to hold your hand.”

Kyoko snorted. “Not happening.”

With a shared glance and a flicker of resolve, they jumped.

Space warped around them. The descent was strange—light bent and twisted, the air shimmered, and for a moment, they couldn't tell which way was up. But to their surprise, the fall was smooth. Comfortable, even. Just another jump, like the countless leaps they'd made through witch labyrinths and collapsing rooftops.

They landed on solid ground with a soft thud.

The lower level of the pyramid stretched out before them. Towering stone walls still loomed overhead, etched with strange symbols and scattered patches of sand. But the atmosphere had changed.

The biggest difference was the lighting.

The upper level had been bathed in golden hues—warm, ancient, almost sacred. It had felt like walking through a forgotten temple blessed by sunlight, where every grain of sand shimmered with quiet reverence.

Down here, everything changed.

The light was dim and eerie, casting long shadows that danced across the stone. It was as if a glowing tiffany blue mist clung to the walls and drifted lazily over the sand, not a true fog, but a visual trick born of the strange lighting. The color gave the entire space a ghostly pallor, like the ruins of a dream long abandoned.

The air was colder now, with a damp chill that crept beneath their cloaks and settled against their skin. It wasn't just the temperature—it was the feeling. The atmosphere felt haunted, as if the very air remembered sorrow. Every breath carried a whisper of something lost.

The second difference was the layout.

Gone was the open chamber of the pyramid's core, with its sweeping visibility and grand architectural symmetry. Down here, the space had transformed into a labyrinth—tight corridors, jagged turns, and looming stone walls that rose like silent sentinels. The openness had vanished, replaced by a claustrophobic maze that seemed designed to confuse and isolate.

Several paths stretched out before them, each one veiled in shadow and mist. The lighting was too faint to see far, and the eerie tiffany-blue glow only deepened the uncertainty. The corridors twisted unpredictably, some sloping downward, others branching off at odd angles. There were no signs, no markers, no clues to guide them.

It felt like the pyramid had shifted from a place of reflection to a place of trial. Every turn could lead to revelation—or ruin. The walls themselves seemed to lean inward, as if listening, waiting for the girls to choose a path.

Mami and Kyoko stood at the threshold of the maze, knowing that once they stepped forward, there would be no clear way back.

Mami shivered. A chill ran down her spine.

Kyoko noticed immediately. She grinned and gave Mami a playful elbow-nudge. “You okay? Or are you scared already?”

Mami straightened, brushing off the chill. “I’m fine.”

Then she chuckled. “This just reminds me of that time you dragged me into the **Tower of Terror**.”

Kyoko’s eyes lit up. “Oh yeah! That haunted house roller coaster thing. You screamed like you were gonna die.”

Mami groaned. “I did not.”

Kyoko beamed. “You shut your eyes tight, clung to the bars like your life depended on it, and let out the loudest scream I’ve ever heard. I still have the pictures the amusement park took. My face looked like I was having the time of my life. Yours...”

Mami chuckled weakly, losing a bit of composure. “Please don’t remind me. I’ve grown since then.”

They both laughed, the sound echoing softly through the misty corridors.

Kyoko looked around. “So far, this place is just a haunted house. No extreme roller coaster. How bad could it be?”

Mami smiled. “Thanks for trying to soothe my nerves.”

Kyoko shrugged. “Hey, if we’re gonna walk through a nightmare, might as well start with a laugh.”

They turned toward the maze ahead, the mist curling around their feet.

The descent had begun.

Chapter 7a – the 8th mural

Before choosing a path through the maze, Mami and Kyoko instinctively turned around to see what lay behind them.

To their surprise, they found a wall—structured like the ones in the dot rooms above. It was tall and smooth, etched with strange symbols that shimmered faintly in the eerie blue light. The carvings curled and twisted like vines, ancient and unreadable, and at the center of it all was a mural.

It was unmistakably a continuation of the story from the seven-dot room.

The scene was familiar: a grassy field, blooming with vibrant flowers. The same idyllic setting from the one-dot and four-dot rooms. The girls were there again—each with a colored circle floating in front of her, engaged in distinct actions that showcased her magical abilities.

One girl shifted her form effortlessly, her body rippling like water as she transformed. Another stood calmly as rocks and plants hovered around her in a gentle orbit, her telekinetic control precise and serene. A third knelt to the earth, shaping the soil beneath her hands into intricate patterns and structures, her magic rooted and tactile.

The two girls without circles stood nearby, as always—present, but passive. They watched the others with quiet expressions, their roles still unclear, their presence more symbolic than active.

But this mural held something new.

At the edges of the scene, partially obscured by painted trees, were several figures. People. They stood at a distance, peering through the foliage. Their faces, rendered in the stylized ancient art, bore expressions that Mami and Kyoko could only interpret as shock—and horror.

Kyoko leaned in, squinting. “Who are they supposed to be?”

Mami studied the mural carefully. “They’re not part of the group. They’re outsiders. Watching.”

Kyoko frowned. “They look... scared.”

Mami nodded slowly. “I think they’re normal people. Civilians.”

Kyoko’s eyes widened slightly. “You think they saw the girls using magic?”

Mami’s voice was quiet, thoughtful. “It’s possible.”

They both fell silent, absorbing the implications.

Almost every magical girl they knew kept their powers a secret—even from close friends and family. The truth was too strange, too dangerous. Revealing it risked everything. So it was safe to assume the girls in the mural had done the same.

But now, something had changed. Someone had seen.

Kyoko crossed her arms. “If those people didn’t know about Kyubey or magical girls... then yeah, they’d be freaked out. Seeing girls shape-shift or use telekinesis out of nowhere? That’s not something you just shrug off.”

Mami nodded. “I wonder what happens next. How do the girls react? How do the people react?”

Kyoko tilted her head. “I’ve never heard of a case like this. Normal humans suddenly seeing magic. Not like this.”

Mami’s gaze lingered on the mural. “Neither have I.”

The story was shifting. The nightmare hadn't begun with despair—it had begun with exposure. And Mami and Kyoko were more curious than ever to see how it would unfold.

Mami and Kyoko turned back toward the maze, facing the many branching paths ahead. The corridors stretched in every direction, some narrow and winding, others wide and shadowed. The eerie tiffany-blue mist curled along the ground, making it impossible to see where any path truly led.

Mami tilted her head, scanning the options. “Which way should we go?”

Kyoko shrugged with a grin. “Don't sweat it. They all probably lead to the same nightmare anyway.”

Without hesitation, she pointed to a path on the left—one that twisted sharply and disappeared into the gloom. “Let's go down this one. Looks fun.”

Mami chuckled, her tension easing slightly. Kyoko's energy was infectious, even here. It warmed her to see Kyoko so cheerful, so bold, even when the air felt heavy and the unknown loomed ahead.

They stepped into the corridor.

The walls on either side were etched with ancient symbols and pictographs, swirling and curling in patterns that defied interpretation. Though unrelated to the murals above, they were mesmerizing—beautiful in their own way. The tiffany-blue glow bathed them in a soft, ghostly light, making the carvings shimmer like reflections on water.

Despite the eeriness, the artistry was undeniable.

The path twisted and turned, sometimes narrowing so much they had to walk single file. The silence was thick, broken only by the soft crunch of sand beneath their boots.

Then came the sounds.

Faint. Distant. Uncertain.

A soft rattling. A low moan.

Mami twitched, her shoulders stiffening. “Did you hear that?”

Kyoko paused, tilting her head and pressing a hand to her ear. “Yeah. Something rattling. Maybe wind? Or... something else.”

Mami glanced over her shoulder, eyes scanning the shadows. “It sounded close.”

Kyoko's voice was calm, almost amused. “Could be part of the test. Haunted house vibes, right?”

Mami nodded slowly. “Definitely fits the theme.”

They continued forward, the sounds coming and going—never loud, never clear. Just enough to keep them on edge.

Kyoko glanced at Mami. “You okay?”

Mami smiled faintly. “Just startled. It’s like that haunted maze you dragged me into once. The one with the animatronic ghosts and fake fog machines.”

Kyoko laughed. “Oh yeah. You jumped at every sound. This is way better—no cheesy props, just pure atmosphere.”

Mami chuckled. “I’ll admit, it’s effective.”

Kyoko smirked. “Well, no roller coaster yet. So how bad could it be? Although... it’d be kinda fun if the floor collapsed and we landed in a rollercoaster car that blasted off through the pyramid.”

Mami gave her a pleading look. “Please don’t give this haunted house any more ideas.”

Kyoko winked. “You want to hold my hand yet?”

“No,” Mami said flatly, the word leaving her mouth with reflexive speed.

They pressed on, deeper into the maze, the mist curling tighter around their boots and the walls closing in like a whisper.

After winding through the twisting corridor, Mami and Kyoko came upon a fork in the path. Two routes stretched ahead—both narrow, both cloaked in the same eerie mist. The tiffany-blue glow flickered along the walls, casting shifting shadows that made it impossible to tell which way was safer.

Mami slowed her pace, eyes narrowing. “This feels like a setup. There’s probably some jump scare waiting for us. Maybe an undead hand will shoot out and snatch us away the moment we get close.”

Kyoko snorted. “You’ve got a vivid imagination.”

“I’ve seen enough horror movies, mostly with you, to know how this goes,” Mami muttered, her voice tinged with dry amusement.

Kyoko grinned. “We’ll be fine. And if something does jump out, we can fight it. Honestly, a combat-based haunted house sounds kinda fun.”

Mami chuckled, warmed by Kyoko’s carefree attitude. She raised her hand and summoned a few golden ribbons, weaving them gently through the air around them. The threads shimmered faintly in the blue light, forming a subtle perimeter that pulsed with quiet magic.

Kyoko watched with a soft smile. “Is that your new sensory technique? The one you used against that shadow monster earlier today?”

Mami blinked, surprised. “You saw that?”

Kyoko nodded. “I saw the whole fight. You were awesome. That thing was powerful, but you handled it like a pro. You’ve grown so much in just two days in the realm. As expected of my mentor.”

Mami’s heart warmed at the compliment. She glanced at Kyoko, touched by the sincerity in her voice. “Thank you. That means a lot.”

She paused, then added, “I wonder what else you’ve seen in the arena. Kasumi and Lunaria sparring? Other magical girls from different times?”

Kyoko’s eyes lit up. “Oh yeah. The arena’s seen everything. Duelists with flaming swords clashing midair, girls who summon illusions to trick their opponents, others who fight with music, turning melodies into weapons. Some battles are hilarious—like the one where a girl turned her opponent’s attacks into rubber ducks. Some are wild, like when a pair of twins fought using synchronized teleportation. And some... some are just beautiful. You can feel the emotion in every strike.”

Mami smiled, her imagination painting the scenes. “Lunaria and Kasumi promised they’d spar soon so I could watch.”

Kyoko gave a beaming grin. “You’re in for a treat. Those two? Their battles are a spectacle. The rivalry, the contrasting styles and personalities! Lunaria’s precision versus Kasumi’s unpredictability—it’s like watching a dance and a storm collide. But as for who wins...” She winked. “That’s something you’ll have to see for yourself. No spoilers.”

Mami laughed. “Good. I don’t want spoilers.”

With the ribbons gently pulsing around them, the two girls stepped forward toward the fork in the path. The mist thickened slightly, curling around their ankles like a living thing.

Whatever lay ahead, they would face it together.

Chapter 7b – the 9th mural

At the fork in the path, Mami and Kyoko paused. The left corridor was unusually short—barely a dozen steps before it opened into a small chamber. Even from where they stood, they could see the faint outline of a mural on the far wall.

Mami tilted her head. “That looks like another mural room.”

Kyoko nodded. “Let’s check it out.”

They walked down the short path, the mist thinning slightly as they entered the chamber. It was built in the same style as the rooms above—smooth stone walls, ancient symbols etched into the surface, and a single mural framed in the center like a sacred window into the past.

But when they looked at the mural, their breath caught.

Mami's golden ribbons, still gently floating in the air around them, began to dim. One by one, they unraveled and faded, dissolving into the mist as if the weight of the scene had drained the magic from her fingertips. She didn't even notice—her focus was locked on the wall ahead.

Their eyes went wide. Their mouths gaped. Their hearts sank.

The scene depicted a village—likely the one the twelve girls had come from. A wide grassy field dotted with tents and simple structures. But the peaceful setting was shattered by what lay at the center.

Groups of people—twelve sets in total—were bound tightly with ropes, kneeling or sitting in clusters at the center of the village. Each group was distinct, yet unified by the same cruel fate. Their faces were drawn in stylized anguish, confusion, and fear, rendered with the expressive exaggeration typical of the ancient art style.

Mami and Kyoko quickly noticed the patterns.

Some clusters were small—just two or three figures, likely representing a single parent and a younger sibling. Others were larger, with five or six individuals of varying ages, suggesting extended families: grandparents, older brothers, younger sisters. The diversity was striking. Some figures were hunched with age, others barely more than children. A few clung to one another, their bound arms straining to reach across the ropes.

The resemblance to the twelve girls was subtle but unmistakable. The shape of a nose, the tilt of a brow, the color of a garment—each group bore visual echoes of one of the girls.

And they had been rounded up. The ropes were tight, unforgiving.

The villagers surrounding them stood with rigid postures, their expressions a volatile mix of fear, anger, and grim determination. To Mami and Kyoko, it looked like the moment after a verdict had been passed—like the villagers believed they had caught something dangerous, something that needed to be contained.

The horror wasn't just in the bindings.

It was in the implication.

The people who had witnessed the girls using magic must have returned to the village and told others. And the reaction had been swift. Not against the girls—who Mami and Kyoko have not seen in this mural yet—but against their families. The villagers had seen power they couldn't understand, and in their fear, they had turned on the ones closest to it.

And then, at the edge of the mural, stood the twelve girls.

They were distant, as if they had just returned to the village and hadn't yet been noticed. Their faces mirrored Mami and Kyoko's own expressions—shock, horror, sorrow. The ancient art style captured the moment with haunting clarity.

Kyoko stepped closer, her voice low. "Twelve groups. That's not random."

Mami nodded slowly, her eyes tracing the bound figures. "It's their families."

Kyoko clenched her jaw. "The people who saw the girls using magic must've told the others. And this... this is how they reacted."

Mami's voice trembled. "They think the girls are cursed. That their families are part of it."

It was a gut-punch—both to the twelve girls in the mural and to Mami and Kyoko themselves. The fear of being misunderstood, of being seen as something unnatural, was one every magical girl carried. And here, it had manifested in the worst possible way.

Kyoko's fists tightened. "They didn't even try to understand."

Mami's gaze lingered on the bound figures. "They saw something they couldn't explain. And they responded with fear. With punishment."

Kyoko's voice was bitter. "It's not even the girls they went after. It's their families."

Mami nodded. "They're trying to erase the source. Or what they think is the source."

She paused, her voice quieter. "It's like they're trying to cut out the roots before the tree grows."

Kyoko exhaled sharply. "They think magic is a disease. And they're purging it."

Mami's hands trembled slightly. "This is what happens when people are afraid. When they don't understand. They lash out. They punish what's closest."

Kyoko looked at the twelve girls at the edge of the mural. "And the girls... they weren't even there to defend them. They came back to this."

Mami's heart ached. "Can you imagine? Coming home and seeing your family treated like criminals. Just because of you."

Kyoko's voice was low. "I don't have to imagine. I've thought about it before."

Mami turned to her, surprised.

Kyoko shrugged, eyes still on the mural. "Back when I first got my powers. I kept it secret. Not just because of Kyubey's warnings. But because I knew... if people saw me fight, saw me use magic, they'd look at me differently. Maybe worse."

Mami nodded slowly. “I used to wonder if my parents would still love me if they knew. If they’d be proud... or afraid.”

They both stood in silence, the weight of the mural pressing down on them.

Mami whispered, “What comes next?”

Kyoko didn’t answer right away. Her eyes scanned the mural again, lingering on the villagers’ faces, the ropes, the girls frozen in horror.

“There are very few futures that make sense from here,” she said finally. “And none of them are kind.”

Mami and Kyoko stepped out of the mural chamber, the mist swallowing them once more as they returned to the fork in the path.

The sounds were louder now.

The faint rattling and low moans they had heard earlier were no longer distant whispers—they pressed closer, curling through the corridors like echoes of something restless. It was as if the maze itself had heard their thoughts, had felt the heaviness in their hearts, and was responding in kind.

But the sounds weren’t what occupied their minds.

Their thoughts were still anchored to the mural—the bound families, the horrified girls, the villagers’ grim faces. The image clung to them like a shadow, impossible to shake. They were no longer just walking through a haunted maze. They were walking through a story. One that had taken a dark turn. One they couldn’t stop reading, even if they wanted to.

At the fork, they paused.

Kyoko glanced down the remaining path, her usual spark dimmed. “We keep going?”

Mami nodded, her voice quiet. “We have to. I need to know what happens next.”

Kyoko looked at her for a moment, then gave a solemn nod. “Yeah. Me too.”

They stepped forward, side by side, their footsteps echoing against the stone. The sound was soft but sharp, like distant drums in a funeral procession. The mist curled tighter around their legs, and the walls seemed to lean in, listening.

Neither spoke as they walked.

The silence between them wasn’t empty—it was full. Full of dread, of empathy, of the weight of what they’d seen and the fear of what was coming. They were no longer just magical girls exploring a trial. They were witnesses to a tragedy unfolding in slow motion.

And the next chapter was waiting.

Chapter 7c – the 10th mural

The corridor twisted and turned, the walls pressing close as the rattling and moaning sounds grew louder. But Mami and Kyoko barely registered them. Their hearts beat faster—not from fear of the sounds, but from anticipation. A dreadful curiosity pulled them forward, like readers unable to stop turning the pages of a tragic story.

They reached another fork.

Just like before, the left path was short and led to a chamber. From the entrance, they could already see the faint outline of a mural on the far wall.

Mami and Kyoko exchanged a glance. No words were needed. They nodded and stepped forward together.

The room was larger than the last, though its structure remained the same—smooth stone walls, ancient symbols etched into the surface, and a single mural framed like a sacred relic. The tiffany-blue mist pooled low across the floor, swirling gently around their boots.

They looked up.

And their hearts broke.

Mami whispered, “No...” as her hands flew to her mouth. Tears welled in her eyes, shimmering in the dim light.

Kyoko said nothing. Her jaw clenched, fists tightening with an audible crack. Her arms trembled, her eyes burning—not just with anger, but with empathy. Her whole body was tense, as if she were holding herself back from stepping into the mural itself.

The setting was the same as before—the village, the tents, the grassy field. But the tension had exploded.

Villagers stood around the bound families at the center, their postures rigid, their faces twisted into expressions of grim resolve. Executioners punishing criminals. From their hands flew black circles and brown lines tipped with abstract red—symbols that Mami and Kyoko understood instantly. Stones. Torches.

Other villagers were in motion, chasing something. Their hands raised, weapons drawn, black circles flying. Their targets were clear.

The twelve girls.

They were running—fleeing the village, their bodies angled in motion. From each girl’s eyes drifted a trail of blue dots, tears rendered in the stylized language of the mural. The dots floated backward, stretching across the scene, encircling the bound families like a protective veil.

And from the families, more blue dots rose—tears of their own, drifting toward the girls. Each trail seemed to reach for the one girl they were connected to, forming invisible bonds of sorrow and love.

Mami and Kyoko stood frozen.

The mural was abstract, but its meaning was unmistakable. The villagers had turned violent. The families were being punished. And now, the girls themselves were being hunted.

It was a moment of heartbreak, betrayal, and helplessness.

Neither of them spoke for a long time.

Then Kyoko broke the silence.

Her voice was low, rough. “They didn’t just blame them. They tried to destroy them.”

Mami nodded slowly, her voice barely audible. “They saw magic... and thought it was evil. They didn’t understand, so they attacked.”

Kyoko’s fists trembled. “And the girls... they ran. Not because they were cowards. Because they had no choice. They couldn’t bring themselves to use their powers to kill the villagers who didn’t know what they were doing.”

Mami’s tears slipped down her cheeks. “They were trying to protect their families. Even as they watched them suffer.”

Kyoko looked at the blue trails. “They still loved each other. Even in the middle of all that.”

Mami whispered, “This is what fear does. It turns people against their own.”

Kyoko’s voice was bitter. “And it turns magical girls—who protect people from witches behind the scenes—into fugitives.”

They stood in silence again, the mural towering before them like a monument to sorrow.

The story was no longer just tragic—it was personal.

Mami’s gaze lingered on the twelve girls, her heart heavy. Then, quietly, she spoke.

“There’s something I should tell you,” she said. “About... the real Kyoko.”

Kyoko turned to her, listening.

“She lost her family,” Mami said softly. “All of them. It broke her. She became bitter, angry. She pushed everyone away—including me. We... we stopped being partners. We stopped being friends.”

Kyoko's expression didn't change, but her eyes softened. "This must've happened after my essence was saved in the arena. That sounds exactly like how I imagine I'd react... if I lost my whole family. Bitter. Closed off. Angry at the world."

She paused, her voice quieter. "I can't fully understand it—not yet. It didn't happen to me. But you... you can relate more, right Mami? Since your family died in that car crash?"

Mami nodded slowly, her gaze distant. "It was hard. The grief was one thing. But watching someone I cared about—someone I trusted—become someone I couldn't reach anymore... that was harder."

Kyoko looked back at the mural. "These girls... they'll change too. After this. You don't go through something like that and stay the same."

Mami's voice trembled. "I just hope they don't lose each other."

Kyoko turned to her, smiling gently. "Even if the real me left you... I'll always be here. In this realm. To support you."

Mami gave a warm smile through her tears. "Thank you."

She looked back at the mural. "I hope the girls do the same. That even after everything, they still find a way to support each other."

Kyoko nodded. "They deserve that. After all they've been through."

They stood together, side by side, the mural casting its quiet sorrow over them.

And then, slowly, they turned to leave the chamber.

The descent continued.

Chapter 7d – Echoes of Family

As Mami and Kyoko turned to leave the mural chamber, a sudden grinding sound echoed above them.

A massive stone slab dropped from the ceiling with alarming speed, slamming into place and sealing the exit. Dust billowed outward, and the sound reverberated through the room like a final verdict.

Mami gasped, stumbling back. "See? I told you! This is exactly what happens in horror movies!"

The rattling and moaning sounds they'd heard earlier were no longer distant—they were here. Loud. Close. As if the room itself had begun to breathe.

Kyoko remained calm, though her eyes narrowed. "Okay... yeah, this is getting creepy. But we'll be fine. If something's coming, we fight."

She summoned her spear with a flash of red light, spinning it once and planting her feet.

Mami took a deep breath, her trembling hands tightening as she summoned her golden ribbons and muskets. The weapons shimmered into existence with a soft golden glow, hovering at her sides like loyal sentinels. Kyoko's confidence helped. "Right. We fight."

The sand across the floor began to shift.

Large patches of it rippled unnaturally, as if something beneath was stirring.

Then, with a sudden eruption, grotesque figures burst forth—undead monsters, their bodies twisted and partially wrapped in ancient linen. Their limbs were stiff, their movements jerky, and their mouths hung open in silent screams.

Mami gasped and instinctively stepped back, her muskets rising into position. "Witches?" she whispered, but even as she said it, she knew they weren't. The aura was wrong. The feeling was heavier. Older.

Kyoko spun her spear and dropped into a battle stance, eyes narrowing. "Okay, definitely not your average cursed mummy."

The creatures dragged themselves forward, their heads twitching unnaturally, their joints cracking with every movement. The air grew thick with the sound of rattling and low moans, echoing off the chamber walls like a dirge.

Mami's breath caught. "They're not just monsters. They feel... wrong. Like they're carrying something with them."

Kyoko nodded grimly. "Something heavy. Something real."

And then they saw it.

The linen.

Faint patterns etched into the ancient wrappings—symbols, colors, and shapes—mirrored the garments worn by the families in the mural. The resemblance was subtle, but unmistakable.

Mami's eyes went wide. "No... it's them."

Kyoko's mouth opened in shock. "The families. Or... what's left of them."

Mami's voice was hushed. "Or maybe just echoes, created from memory, emotion, insight. These aren't just monsters. They're fragments of grief."

Kyoko nodded grimly, the grip on her lance tightening. "And they're coming for us."

The undead turned toward them, their hollow eyes locking onto the two magical girls. The rattling and moaning grew louder, more chaotic, like a chorus of suffering.

Then they charged.

Mami and Kyoko braced themselves, weapons ready, hearts pounding—not just from the threat, but from the sorrow behind it.

This wasn't just a battle.

It was a reckoning.

Kyoko lunged first, her spear slicing through the air with practiced precision. She struck the closest undead directly in the arm, the impact sending a jolt through its decaying frame. The limb cracked, and a chunk of rotted flesh tore loose.

Kyoko smirked. “Didn’t even bother to dodge. This should be easy.”

At the same moment, Mami’s golden ribbons lashed out, binding another undead in a tight weave. Her muskets fired in rapid succession, bullets piercing through the creature’s torso with clean, glowing holes.

She narrowed her eyes. “They’re not fighting intelligently. Just... mindlessly charging.”

But their initial impressions shattered in seconds.

Kyoko’s undead roared—a guttural, hollow sound—and swept its damaged arm in a wide arc. The force of the swing slammed into Kyoko’s spear, sending her flying backward. She twisted midair and landed hard against the chamber wall, boots skidding against stone.

“Okay,” she muttered, shaking off the impact. “That was not soft.”

Mami’s situation turned just as quickly. Her bullets had torn through the creature, but it didn’t falter. Instead, the ancient linen wrapped around its body began to writhe—animated by some unseen force. The fabric snapped toward her like a whip, fast and precise.

Mami’s eyes widened. “What—!”

She released her ribbons and leapt backward, narrowly avoiding the strike. The linen hissed past her, slicing through the air where she’d just stood.

Kyoko dropped down from the wall and landed beside her, spear at the ready. “These things are surprisingly sturdy for walking corpses.”

Mami nodded, catching her breath. “And that linen... it moved like my ribbons. It’s not just decoration. It’s a weapon.”

Kyoko grinned, her eyes lighting up with challenge. “Then we’ll just have to hit harder. You ready?”

Mami smiled back, her muskets glowing brighter. “Always.”

Side by side, they stepped forward again, weapons raised, hearts steady.

This wasn't just a fight.

It was a test.

And they were ready to meet it head-on.

Kyoko and Mami re-engaged, each targeting the same undead they had fought before.

Kyoko surged forward, channeling more magic into her spear. The weapon glowed with a fierce crimson light as she swung it in a wide arc. Like before, the undead didn't dodge—it simply stood there, accepting the blow.

This time, Kyoko's strike was stronger. The spear sliced clean through the creature's arm, severing it with a satisfying crack. She grinned. "See? Just needed a little more oomph."

She pressed the offensive, her movements fluid and aggressive. Blow after blow landed, and soon the undead collapsed in pieces, its linen writhing one last time before falling still.

Mami mirrored the escalation. Her golden ribbons shimmered brighter, binding her target with greater force. She twisted her hands, tightening the weave, and the pressure built until the creature's limbs began to tear. With a final surge, her ribbons sliced through the undead completely, its body unraveling into minced flesh and cloth.

Kyoko turned to Mami, smiling. "Told you it'd be easy."

Mami nodded, though her eyes remained cautious. "Maybe. But what about the others?"

Their answer came quickly.

Several nearby undead turned toward the remains of their fallen kin. Without hesitation, they surrounded the broken bodies and began to feed—gnashing, clawing, devouring the linen and flesh with grotesque hunger.

Mami's breath caught. "No..."

Kyoko's eyes widened. "What the hell..."

It was a scene of horror—abstract, stylized, yet unmistakably vile. The feeding was frantic, desperate, like animals reclaiming something lost.

When the feeding ended, the undead looked up.

Their hollow eyes locked onto Mami and Kyoko.

Then they charged.

Faster than before. Their movements sharper, more coordinated. The air pulsed with their moans, now louder, more focused.

Kyoko reacted first, swinging her spear in a familiar arc, aiming for the arm again. The blade struck true—but this time, it didn't cut cleanly. The undead roared and grabbed the spear with its partially severed limb, yanking Kyoko forward.

“Whoa—!” Kyoko gasped, surprised. She released her weapon, letting it vanish in a flash of red light, and leapt backward.

Mami faced the same struggle. Her ribbons lashed out, binding the creature tightly, but the pressure wasn't enough. The undead roared and grabbed the golden strands, pulling with unnatural strength. Mami's eyes widened. “No—!”

She released the ribbons and jumped back, landing beside Kyoko.

Both girls stood side by side, breathing heavily, eyes locked on the advancing undead.

Kyoko wiped her brow. “Okay... they're learning.”

Mami nodded. “Feeding made them stronger. Smarter.”

Kyoko summoned her spear again, grip firm. “Then we'll just have to be smarter too.”

Mami raised her muskets, ribbons swirling. “Together.”

The battle was no longer simple.

It was evolving.

And the echoes were watching.

Kyoko and Mami shifted into a defensive rhythm, dodging and parrying the undead's relentless attacks. The creatures moved with disturbing coordination now—faster, stronger, smarter. Each swing of their limbs carried weight, and their linen tendrils lashed out with eerie precision.

Kyoko blocked a strike with her spear, twisting to avoid a second blow. “They're adapting fast.”

Mami ducked under a sweeping arm, her ribbons deflecting a strike as she fired a volley of bullets into the crowd. “And feeding makes them stronger. If we keep fighting like this, the last one standing will be a monster.”

Kyoko grinned, breathless. “A monster sounds fun.”

She spun her spear and knocked back another undead, but her smile faded as she glanced at Mami. “But probably not the best idea. We don't know what else this trial has in store.”

Mami nodded. “Agreed. We need a plan.”

They retreated a few steps, giving themselves space to think as the undead regrouped.

Kyoko spoke first. “We need to stop them from feeding. That’s the key.”

Mami’s eyes lit up. “If we can keep the defeated ones out of reach...”

Kyoko snapped her fingers. “You can suspend them with your ribbons.”

Mami nodded. “And you can reinforce the structure. Your red diamond walls—they’re strong and flexible. We can build a lattice.”

Kyoko smirked. “A floating graveyard. I like it.”

Mami smiled. “It’s grim, but effective.”

They moved quickly.

The next undead fell to Kyoko’s empowered strike, and Mami’s ribbons immediately wrapped around the remains, lifting it high into the air. Kyoko summoned a lattice of red diamond walls beneath it, forming a glowing scaffold to keep it suspended.

Another undead charged. Mami weakened it with precise gunfire, and Kyoko finished it off. Again, Mami’s ribbons lifted the body, and Kyoko reinforced the structure.

As the battle continued, Mami shifted into a supportive role—her muskets firing from a distance, her ribbons weaving through the air to secure the fallen. Kyoko danced across the battlefield, her spear a blur of red light, her diamond walls rising like crystalline barricades.

They worked in perfect sync.

After a particularly clean takedown, Kyoko landed beside Mami, grinning. “This is fun. Fighting like this again.”

Mami smiled warmly, her ribbons shimmering. “It really is.”

For a moment, the weight of the trial lifted—replaced by the joy of battle, of trust, of partnership.

But the echoes still watched.

And the trial was far from over.

Chapter 7d – Trial of Family

The last undead stood alone.

Mami and Kyoko, breathing heavily but steady, looked at it together.

Kyoko twirled her spear once. “Let’s finish this.”

Mami nodded, ribbons shimmering. “Together.”

But before they could strike, the undead let out a deafening roar.

A shockwave of darkness pulsed outward—small, but sharp. Mami and Kyoko braced themselves, shielding their eyes as the wave passed over them.

Then everything changed.

The suspended remains of the defeated undead—held aloft by Mami’s ribbons and Kyoko’s diamond lattice—began to disintegrate. Dust poured from their bodies, swirling through the air like ash caught in a storm. The dust spiraled toward the final undead, encircling it in a growing vortex.

Mami’s eyes narrowed. “What’s happening?”

Kyoko stepped back, spear raised. “This isn’t normal. This is... something else.”

The dust swirl shrank slowly, compressing tighter and tighter until it collapsed inward.

And then, silence.

Standing where the undead had been was a girl.

She was beautiful in a way that felt otherworldly—like a memory given form.

Her skin glowed faintly, not with light but with presence, as if she were caught between realms. Not fully alive, not fully dead. Her features were soft and serene, framed by long, aquamarine flowing hair that shimmered like moonlight on still water. It drifted gently around her shoulders, untouched by gravity, as if the air itself was cradling her.

Her eyes were large and luminous, a pale shade of blue that seemed to hold the reflections of distant stars. They carried sorrow, but also warmth—like someone who had seen tragedy and still chose to love.

Her body was wrapped in fresh, pristine linen, woven with intricate symbols that pulsed faintly with magic. The patterns were unmistakable—echoes of one of the families in the mural. The fabric clung to her like ceremonial robes, elegant and reverent, yet simple in design. It gave her the appearance of a spirit priestess, a guardian of memory.

Around her, the air shimmered with soft sparkles—tears that had not fallen, emotions that had not faded. They hovered like fireflies, drifting in slow spirals, casting a gentle glow that made the chamber feel sacred.

She floated just above the ground, her feet never touching the stone. Her movements were graceful, deliberate, like someone dancing through a dream.

The girl bowed gracefully.

When she spoke, her voice was like wind through crystal—clear, delicate, and resonant with something ancient.

“Greetings, Mami Tomoe and Kyoko Sakura. I am **Aurellia Mizunagi**.”

She looked at them with a warm smile.

“Congratulations,” she said, her tone soft and melodic. “You’ve reached the final stage of this room’s trial. And you did so **without using connect at all**. Your teamwork and strategy were exceptional.”

Mami blinked. “Wait... what do you mean, ‘without using connect’? We fought together. We were in sync.”

Kyoko nodded. “Yeah. We coordinated everything.”

Aurellia chuckled gently. “You worked together. But you didn’t **connect**.”

She floated upward, her feet lifting from the ground, and drifted toward the mural. Her hand reached out and rested softly on one of the painted figures.

“This was me,” she said quietly.

Mami and Kyoko stepped closer, listening.

“My younger sister was one of the twelve girls. She had telekinesis. Because of **Connect**—through our bond—I can fly like this. Even now.”

She looked back at the mural, her eyes filled with sorrow.

“Some villagers saw the twelve of them—well, ten of them, really—doing strange magical things. Two didn’t have soul gems, but they stood with the group anyway. The villagers panicked. They rounded up all of us—their families. And they executed us.”

Her voice trembled, but she continued.

“In our final moments, we shouted to them. Told them to run. To be safe. To live. To support each other. To be happy. We told them we loved them.”

She paused, tears forming in her eyes. They fell slowly, drifting like sparkles through the air—just as the mural had shown.

“And through their sobs, they answered us. Their tears flowed back toward us, shimmering with magic. It was how they communicated—how they told us they loved us too.”

Aurellia’s hands gently traced the painted paths of the tears in the mural, her touch reverent, her expression distant with memory.

Mami’s hand went to her chest, her eyes glistening. “That’s... beautiful. And heartbreaking.”

Kyoko looked down, her voice quiet. “They didn’t deserve that. None of you did.”

The girl turned around, the sparkly tears now hovering around her like stars. It was breathtaking—just like the mural, where the tears of the girls surrounded their families, and the families’ tears reached back.

She smiled gently.

“Are you ready for the final part of this room’s trial?”

The sparkles brightened, forming a radiant aura around her. Orbs of water floated into the air, shimmering with light. They moved with grace and precision—telekinesis, powered by emotion, by memory, by connection.

Mami and Kyoko looked at each other and smiled.

“Bring it on,” Kyoko said, twirling her spear.

Mami nodded, her ribbons flowing. “We’re ready.”

They stepped into their battle stances, hearts steady, eyes focused.

The final phase had begun.

Before Mami and Kyoko could engage, a ripple of cheerful voices echoed through the chamber.

“Ooh, this is going to be exciting!”

“It’s been ages since magical girls got this far without using connect!”

Mami and Kyoko looked around, startled.

From above, glowing figures began to descend—spirits, radiant and serene. They floated gently through the air, their forms shimmering like candlelight in water. These were the family members from

the mural—the ones who had been executed. But here, they were smiling. Joyful. Their expressions full of anticipation.

The chamber, once heavy with sorrow, now felt like a stadium before a grand performance. The spirits gathered like spectators, watching with eager eyes.

Kyoko blinked. “Are they... cheering?”

Mami nodded slowly. “It’s like they’re excited to see what happens next.”

One of the spirits floated closer—a boy with tousled hair and a mischievous grin. He waved at Aurellia and called out playfully, “Not fair! You get to be the star of the show this time!”

Aurellia looked up at him with a teasing smile. “Then you should’ve been the last undead to survive. You were way too far in the front. Got knocked out early—again. You’re always too eager to jump into the action.”

He laughed, shrugging. “Can’t help it. I like the dramatic entrances.”

Mami and Kyoko exchanged glances, surprised.

“Wait,” Mami said. “You remember being those undead?”

Kyoko raised an eyebrow. “You were aware the whole time?”

Aurellia chuckled, her aquamarine hair drifting around her like mist. “Of course. We chose those forms on purpose. No plan, no coordination. We just wanted to see how the two of you would handle it.”

Mami’s eyes widened. “You were testing us.”

Aurellia nodded. “This trial is about more than strength. It’s about insight. Emotion. Connection. We wanted to see how you’d respond—to chaos, to sorrow, to each other.”

Kyoko smirked. “Well, I hope we passed.”

The spirits around them laughed softly, their voices like wind chimes.

Aurellia’s expression grew serene again. “You did. And now, the final part awaits.”

She floated forward, the sparkles around her intensifying. The orbs of water shimmered, rising higher, swirling in elegant patterns. The chamber grew quiet, reverent.

Mami and Kyoko stepped forward, side by side.

Ready.

Mami and Kyoko stood poised, weapons ready, eyes locked on Aurellia.

She floated calmly in the center of the chamber, her sparkly aura shimmering like starlight. Orbs of water hovered around her, drifting in slow, graceful arcs. She made no move to attack.

Seeing their anticipation, Aurellia smiled softly. “At your ready.”

Kyoko grinned, her spear already glowing. “Sure, if you say so.”

With a burst of red light, she launched herself forward. Aurellia responded by drifting higher into the air, her linen robes and aquamarine hair trailing like mist.

Kyoko leapt after her, twisting midair with practiced ease. She aimed her spear directly at Aurellia’s chest, the weapon slicing through the air with precision.

Aurellia didn’t flinch. She raised a hand, and one of the water orbs floated into the path of the spear. With a graceful gesture, she redirected the orb downward, catching the spear’s tip and guiding it gently downward.

The water flowed in a spiral, cascading like a pseudo-waterfall. It didn’t resist Kyoko’s attack—it absorbed it, carrying her momentum downward in a mesmerizing display of fluid magic.

Kyoko blinked in surprise as her body was pulled with the flow, redirected by the waterfall’s gentle force. “Okay... that’s actually kinda cool.”

Aurellia smiled. “Thank you.”

Then she moved.

With a flick of her wrist, another orb shot forward, aimed at Kyoko.

Still midair, Kyoko twisted her body in a tight spin, flipping her spear and angling the handle to intercept the attack. The orb splashed against it, dispersing into a fine mist that sparkled in the light.

“Oh no you don’t,” Kyoko muttered, landing with a controlled skid across the chamber floor.

Aurellia nodded in approval. “Quick reflexes. Clever thinking.”

While the two exchanged blows, Mami took her chance. She summoned her muskets and fired a volley of golden bullets toward Aurellia, hoping Kyoko’s distraction would give her an opening.

But Aurellia turned her head slightly, her palm facing Mami’s direction. Several of the floating orbs responded instantly, shooting concentrated jets of water—like shimmering bullets—that intercepted Mami’s attack midair.

Mami’s eyes widened. “You blocked me... while fighting Kyoko?”

Aurellia gave a playful shrug. “I’m connected to all my orbs. They respond as I feel.”

Kyoko landed beside Mami, her expression serious now.

They exchanged a glance—and then, without speaking aloud, they switched to telepathy.

She's good, Kyoko thought. Too good to brute force.

Agreed, Mami replied. We need to coordinate more precisely. She's reacting to both of us at once.

Then let's make her react to something she doesn't expect.

They nodded in sync.

This trial wasn't just about strength. It demanded teamwork, strategy—and maybe a touch of creativity.

Aurellia and the other spirits had said they weren't using connect.

Neither Mami nor Kyoko truly knew what that meant, or how magical girls were supposed to connect with one another.

But that didn't matter.

They would keep fighting—with everything they had.

Mami extended her arm, and golden ribbons shimmered into existence, floating like threads of light around her and Kyoko. They hovered with purpose—some near her, others drifting protectively around Kyoko.

I'll use these to sense incoming attacks, Mami said through telepathy, her voice calm and focused. I can't share the feedback with you in real time, but if I detect something you can't block or dodge, I'll reinforce the ribbon near you. It should be enough to soften the impact or stop it entirely.

Kyoko twirled her spear and grinned. So I just go wild while you play guardian angel?

Exactly, Mami replied. You focus on overwhelming Aurellia with your usual close-quarters combat. I'll keep watch—and see if there's anything in her fighting style we can exploit.

Kyoko's eyes sparkled. You're finally trying out that magical energy efficiency control Lunaria and Kasumi taught you, huh?

I am, Mami replied. First time, actually. No idea how well it'll go, but this is a trial. We're supposed to experiment, learn... maybe even have a little fun.

Kyoko tilted her head. If you see an opening, you could also pour energy into one of your ribbons near me and strike Aurellia. Surprise her.

Mami chuckled mentally. One thing at a time. Efficient magic use takes extreme discipline and focus—especially in a dynamic fight against an opponent with unfamiliar abilities. For now, I'll stick to protecting you.

She gave Kyoko a playful glance. Besides, pure, uninterrupted offense is what you enjoy most, isn't it?

Kyoko grinned wide. *You know it. I love scrapping freely.*

Kyoko leaned in with a teasing smirk. *But what kind of mentor and veteran magical girl are you if you can only focus on one thing instead of doing what your mentee asks?*

Mami's mental voice was amused. *Are you ready to try our strategy, or are you just here to sass me? Or do you actually have a better idea?*

Kyoko spun her spear once, eyes locked on Aurellia. *Ready.*

Aurellia floated ahead, serene and radiant, her water orbs circling like moons in orbit.

The spirits above watched in silence, their smiles gentle, their presence warm.

Mami's ribbons pulsed with golden light.

Kyoko launched forward.

The trial resumed.

Aurellia's gaze drifted toward the thin golden ribbons floating around Mami and Kyoko. Her expression was curious, almost amused.

"These threads... What are they for?" she asked, voice like wind through crystal.

Kyoko grinned midair, twirling her spear. *You'll find out soon enough.*

With a burst of red light, Kyoko launched herself upward again, spear arcing toward Aurellia's neck. Aurellia responded instantly, guiding a water orb to intercept—but this time, the water flowed upward.

Kyoko's momentum was redirected, her body flipping backward in a tight spiral. Her spear followed the motion, tip now pointing skyward past her head. The maneuver left her belly exposed—wide open for a counterattack.

Aurellia sent another orb hurtling toward Kyoko's vulnerable midsection.

Mami's eyes narrowed. One of her ribbons, floating near Kyoko, pulsed with warning. She poured magic into it, hardening the thread just in time.

The water orb splashed against the reinforced ribbon and dispersed harmlessly.

Mami allowed herself a small smile. *It worked.*

Aurellia's eyes sparkled with amusement. "You reinforced only what was needed. A good first step toward mastering efficient magical control."

Still mid-flip, Kyoko smirked. *Thanks for the save,* she said telepathically.

Now the butt of her spear was aimed directly at Aurellia. With a surge of magic, Kyoko extended it—sending the weapon straight toward her opponent.

Aurellia's eyes widened, impressed by the improvisation. She quickly summoned several water orbs in front of her, absorbing the impact and slowing the spear's extension until it stopped completely—trapped in the swirling water.

Then, without pause, Aurellia launched multiple water orbs at Kyoko in a rapid counterattack.

Mami's ribbons flared with warning. *She's trying to entrap and overwhelm you*, Mami said telepathically. *Her orbs can absorb attacks and trap objects. Now she's scaling up.*

She poured magic into multiple ribbons around Kyoko, trying to block the incoming barrage. But it was too much, too fast. Some orbs slipped through, striking Kyoko with softened but still painful force.

Kyoko twitched midair, wincing. *Ow! What was that? You trying to tickle me or bruise me?*

Mami laughed. *Sorry! Still learning. She's escalating fast.*

Aurellia smiled gently, watching Kyoko absorb the hits. Even softened, they had landed.

Kyoko narrowed her eyes and shortened her spear, freeing it from the watery trap. She twisted midair, still riding the momentum of her backflip, and slashed at Aurellia's leg.

Aurellia moved to intercept again—but Kyoko was ready.

She grinned, shifted her momentum, and changed the direction of her swing at the last moment. Her spear missed the water orb entirely and sliced toward Aurellia's side.

Aurellia's eyes widened again. Kyoko was adapting.

She summoned water orbs to her flank, forming a shimmering “water armor” just in time. Kyoko's strike landed with force, sending Aurellia flying—but the armor absorbed the shock. No visible damage.

She let herself be carried by the force of the blow, drifting like a leaf in wind.

Kyoko landed beside Mami, panting lightly.

She's got insane reflexes, Mami said, analyzing. *She can apply telekinesis in so many ways. That water armor formed instantly, right where you hit. And she let herself get flung to reduce the impact. As long as she's airborne, it's hard to land a solid hit.*

Kyoko nodded, eyes still locked on Aurellia. *Yeah. Fighting her up close is like trying to punch a cloud.*

The trial was far from over.

But Mami and Kyoko were learning.

And adapting.

Cheers erupted from above.

The spirits—family members once depicted in tragedy—now floated like radiant spectators, their voices full of joy and excitement.

“They landed a hit!”

“They’re improvising beautifully!”

“Such synergy! And they haven’t even **connected** yet!”

Mami and Kyoko glanced upward, surprised by the enthusiasm.

They’re impressed, Kyoko said telepathically. Guess we’re putting on a good show.

Apparently, Mami replied. But what do they mean by ‘connect’? My ribbons are supporting you. We’re coordinating attacks. Isn’t that enough?

Aurellia, still hovering gracefully, caught the puzzled expressions on their faces and chuckled softly.

“There’s a difference between simply working together and truly connecting as magical girls. You’ve both been told how to connect—more than once, actually.”

Mami and Kyoko exchanged a glance.

What does she mean? Kyoko asked. *When were we taught that?*

I don’t know, Mami replied. We’ve been through training, rituals, even that altar room. The murals just tell a story. We couldn’t make sense of the symbols... What could they be talking about?

Maybe we missed something, Kyoko mused. Doesn’t matter. We’ll figure it out later. For now—let’s go all out. We’ve seen enough to understand Aurellia’s general attack and defense patterns.

Her eyes gleamed with determination. *Use your ribbons for offense this time. Try to bind her while I engage. If we can ground her, we might actually do some damage—limit her movement options. And she only has so many water orbs. If we hit her from multiple directions at once, we might occupy all of them and find an opening.*

Mami nodded. *Good plan. I’ll also start charging a shot. If I see an opening, I’ll unleash it.*

Kyoko launched forward again, her spear glowing with crimson energy.

Mami’s ribbons shifted, some remaining defensive, others slithering through the air like golden serpents—ready to strike.

Aurellia watched them both with serene focus, her water orbs swirling faster now, responding to the rising intensity.

The spirits above cheered louder, their excitement growing.

The trial was entering its final phase.

And though Mami and Kyoko hadn't connected...

They were getting closer.

Kyoko launched herself again, eyes sharp, tracking Aurellia's movements. She slashed at her opponent, watching closely for the telltale shimmer of a water orb.

Aurellia responded, sending a much larger orb than before. Kyoko gasped—her spear couldn't pivot fast enough to avoid it.

The weapon struck the orb and was redirected diagonally downward, dragging Kyoko's momentum with it. Her back began to turn, gradually exposing her to a counterattack.

Just then, Mami activated the ribbons surrounding Kyoko, sending them lashing toward Aurellia in an attempt to bind her.

Aurellia's eyes flicked toward the incoming threads. She summoned several water orbs and expanded them just enough to intercept each ribbon, dispersing their energy before they could reach her.

Some of her water orbs are occupied now, Mami said telepathically. *Go—unleash your barrage.*

Kyoko grinned. *On it.*

She manifested a red diamond wall midair, halting her downward momentum. Aurellia's eyes widened slightly, impressed by the sudden shift in tactics.

With her back still exposed, Aurellia sent the remaining water orbs toward Kyoko.

Kyoko pushed against the red diamond wall, narrowly dodging the incoming water orbs. They shot past her and disappeared into the distance, trailing faint ripples of magic as they went.

Looks like those are out of play for now, Kyoko thought.

She repositioned the wall beneath her feet, using it as a stable platform to regain her stance—and launch forward again, ready to press the advantage.

Her spear aimed straight for Aurellia's chest.

Aurellia responded with a water orb, absorbing the impact and slowing the spear until it stopped.

Kyoko smirked. *Not this time.*

She shifted her weapon into a segmented staff, bending its parts to curve around the orb. Aurellia's eyes widened—Kyoko's weapon was more flexible than she'd anticipated.

Kyoko then morphed the staff into a whip and lashed it toward Aurellia's side.

Aurellia quickly repurposed the orb that had missed and formed a water armor in the whip's path.

Kyoko saw the move coming and changed her whip back into a segmented staff mid-strike. One segment hit the armor, but the others curved around, aiming at multiple points on Aurellia's body.

Excellent work, Mami said, smiling.

Aurellia smiled too, her voice calm but impressed. "You're putting real pressure on me. Well done."

She expanded her water armor, covering her entire body in a shimmering shield to block the incoming strikes.

Kyoko chuckled. "Thanks for the compliment, Aurellia."

But you haven't seen everything yet, she added silently, her eyes gleaming with anticipation.

She shifted her segmented staff into chains, the links glowing red as they wrapped tightly around Aurellia's body.

Aurellia's eyes widened as the chains locked in place.

We got her! Kyoko said telepathically.

Binding successful, Mami replied, her voice full of excitement.

Kyoko flung Aurellia toward the ground. She landed with a heavy thud, her water armor absorbing most of the shock—but not all of it. Aurellia let out a sharp gasp as the impact rippled through her body.

Mami's ribbons surged forward, binding her further, layering magical restraints over the chains.

Now! Kyoko shouted telepathically.

On it, Mami replied.

She raised her giant musket, golden energy swirling around it like a vortex. With a cry of focus, she fired an empowered **Tiro Finale**, the blast roaring toward Aurellia with unstoppable force.

At the same moment, Kyoko—now airborne directly above—transformed her chains back into a spear. She extended it downward, the tip aimed at Aurellia's belly, channeling every ounce of strength she had into the strike.

The two attacks converged.

Aurellia, bound and grounded, braced herself.

"Excellent work," she said softly, eyes closing with a serene smile.

The chamber lit up in a brilliant flash of golden and crimson light—Mami's empowered Tiro Finale from below, Kyoko's extended spear strike from above, both colliding with precision and force.

Above, the spirits erupted in cheers.

Their voices rang out like bells, echoing through the chamber with joy and pride.

“They did it!”

“What a combo!”

“They’re incredible!”

Laughter and applause filled the air, radiant and celebratory.

Among them, Aurellia’s older brother leaned back with a playful smirk. “C’mon, Aurellia—getting bound like that? Still, well done, Mami and Kyoko!” he said with a chuckle, voice full of admiration.

But you’re not done yet... he added silently, his grin deepening.

He watched the scene unfold, eyes twinkling—already aware of what was coming next.

Kyoko landed beside Mami. They exchanged grins and gave each other a quick thumbs up—victory pulsing in their veins.

Together, they turned toward the battlefield, eyes locked on the thick veil of smoke ahead, waiting for it to clear.

“I can’t imagine her coming out of that unscathed,” Kyoko said, her voice low with anticipation.

“Me neither,” Mami replied. “But let’s wait and see.”

Both of them braced again, muscles tense, magic humming at the ready—preparing for whatever came next.

As the dust began to clear, Mami and Kyoko leaned forward, eyes wide.

Their mouths dropped in disbelief.

Floating at the center of the crater, Aurellia hovered calmly—surrounded by jagged layers of rock and sand, encasing the parts of her body where their attacks had landed.

Above, the spirits chuckled at the stunned expressions below. Aurellia’s older brother laughed outright. “You should see your faces,” he said, grinning. “She’s full of surprises.”

Aurellia smiled gently. “Your attack was powerful. Beautifully executed. I’m genuinely impressed.”

With a soft pulse of magic, she released the energy holding the rock and sand together. The barrier crumbled and fell naturally to the ground, scattering like dust.

She floated upward again, her voice calm and clear. “Water isn’t the only thing I can control.”

She gestured to the debris below. “When you slammed me into the ground, I used the surrounding rock and sand to form a barrier. Unlike water, rock doesn’t flow or reshape easily—but it’s far sturdier. And when infused with magic, it becomes incredibly strong.”

Mami and Kyoko’s eyes went wide.

That’s right, Kyoko said telepathically. The magical girl in the mural—the one with telekinesis—she had rocks, plants, all kinds of things floating around her.

We were so focused on the water and the tears, Mami replied. We didn’t think about the rest. Of course Aurellia—she’s the telekinetic girl’s sister, and shares a bond with her through connect—would be able to do it too.

Aurellia nodded, as if hearing their thoughts. “Always be aware of what’s on the battlefield. Even the smallest things can tip the balance—if you use creativity.”

She paused, her expression softening. “I was hoping you’d figure out how to connect. But it seems that won’t happen in this fight.”

Her voice grew firmer. “So it’s time to end this.”

Suddenly, Mami’s ribbons pulsed with warning.

She sensed movement—fast, fluid, and familiar.

Kyoko, she said urgently. Behind us.

Kyoko turned, eyes wide. “No way... those are the water orbs from earlier. The ones that missed me.”

She clenched her fists. *I thought they were out of commission. But she saved them. She planned this.*

Crafty thinking, Mami agreed. Incredible foresight.

She poured magic into every ribbon she had, weaving a dense net of golden threads to intercept the incoming barrage.

Aurellia smiled. “Good reaction time. But it’s not enough.”

She raised her hand.

“Water,” she said, “can flow through anything.”

The orbs twisted midair, reshaping themselves into thin streams. They slipped through the gaps in Mami’s ribbons like liquid blades.

Mami and Kyoko gasped.

They had no defense left.

The water struck their necks with high pressure—precise, controlled, and overwhelming.

Their vision blurred.

Their limbs weakened.

Consciousness began to fade.

Did we fail the beginner connect training? Kyoko asked, her voice flickering in Mami's mind.

Mami laughed weakly. *All the “beginner trainings” in this realm have overwhelmed me.*

Above, the spirits erupted in applause.

Their cheers echoed through the chamber—not in mockery, but in celebration.

Of effort.

Of growth.

Of a battle fought with heart.

And though Mami and Kyoko had lost the fight... they had done remarkably well without using **connect**.

As consciousness slipped away, the two magical girls collapsed onto the ground—smiling brightly.

Not in defeat.

But in joy.

Proud of their teamwork.

Grateful for the challenge.

And happy they had fun.

Chapter 8 – Second Special Trial: ***The Ribboned Spear of Flaming Regret vs. The Sixfold Witchstorm of Ultimate Doom!***

Mami's eyes fluttered open.

Kyoko stirred beside her.

They sat up slowly, blinking at the soft glow surrounding them. Their bodies felt light—energized, as if the battle had never happened.

They turned their hands over and saw their soul gems resting gently in their palms, glowing bright and pure.

Kyoko raised an eyebrow. “We’re... fine?”

Mami nodded, stunned. “More than fine.”

Floating nearby, Aurellia and the spirits hovered close, their expressions warm and welcoming.

Kyoko stood and stretched. “So... did we fail the magical girl connect beginner trial? Are we getting sent back to the arena for a redo?”

Aurellia and the spirits burst into laughter.

“It’s nothing like that,” Aurellia said, smiling.

“Technically,” she continued, “you did fail—since you didn’t use **connect** at all during the fight. Almost every other magical girl group who’s done this training used connect during their battle. For them, that fight is the only test.”

She gestured toward the chamber walls. “Afterward, those groups see a few more murals and a projection of a past event to illustrate what connect can truly do.”

“But since you two haven’t connected yet,” she added with a mischievous wink, “there’ll be a **second test** later.”

Her grin widened. “And I’m pretty sure you’ll resort to connect in that one... albeit unintentionally.”

She chuckled to herself, clearly picturing the chaos she expected to unfold.

“But despite that,” she said warmly, “you two pushed me further than most—even without connect. You should be proud. That’s the result of your training with Lunaria and Kasumi... and the bond you already share as friends and partners.”

Mami’s heart skipped at the mention of Lunaria and Kasumi. Her thoughts raced with questions—questions Kyoko couldn’t answer when she was summoned.

Mami’s heart skipped at the mention of Lunaria and Kasumi. Her thoughts raced with questions—questions Kyoko couldn’t answer when she was summoned.

She stepped forward, eyes bright with urgency. “How do you know Lunaria and Kasumi? Did they connect with you? And... are you aware of when or how your own essences were saved in the arena? Who are they really?”

Aurellia chuckled, amused by Mami’s curiosity. “Countless magical girls have asked us the same.”

She floated closer. “Lunaria and Kasumi visited us often. They’d chat, play, spar, and train. Just like Kyoko here.”

She turned to Kyoko with a fond smile. “Kyoko, Kasumi, Lunaria, us, and many others have met and interacted before.”

Mami turned to Kyoko, eyes wide. “Wait—you knew these spirits? Then why did you act surprised during the training? And at Aurellia’s fighting style?”

Kyoko and Aurellia smiled in unison.

“It’s not dishonesty,” Aurellia explained. “When we enter this training, we agree to have our memories of each other’s abilities temporarily erased. It keeps the fight organic and fair.”

She gestured to the chamber. “Once the training ends, those memories return—along with new ones you’ve made. After all, this arena is built from saved essences and memories across space and time.”

She gave Kyoko a nod. “Even we were surprised by her performance.”

Mami blinked, absorbing the revelation. “So... I could repeat trainings with my memory wiped, and it would feel like the first time? And afterward, I’d get my old memories back—and compare my growth?”

“Exactly,” Aurellia said, her voice full of warmth. “That’s one of the many beauties of this realm. Endless opportunities to grow—fresh, organic, fun, and exciting.”

Mami’s eyes sparkled.

Her heart swelled with excitement.

The possibilities stretched out before her like a constellation.

And her wish to bring her friends here...

Had never felt stronger.

Aurellia floated gently, her voice calm but full of pride. “Lunaria and Kasumi are strong. Extremely so. Much stronger than me—and stronger than any of the spirits here.”

Mami nodded, eyes wide with admiration. “They’re amazing, then. I haven’t even seen them fight at full strength yet. I can’t wait to watch them spar like they promised.”

Aurellia smiled. “Their sparring matches are a spectacle. You’ll see. It’s not just power—it’s poetry.”

Kyoko and the other spirits nodded in agreement, their expressions fond.

“But despite all that,” Aurellia continued, “they’re both incredibly fun to be around.”

She leaned in slightly, her tone playful. “Tell me, Mami—what did Kasumi look like this morning?”

Mami blinked, then laughed. “She was wrapped completely in linen—except for her face and the tips of her fingers. She looked like a very comical mummy, squirming like a worm in a cocoon just to move around.”

Her laughter faded into a gasp as her eyes widened.

She looked around at Aurellia and the spirits—each one wrapped in pristine linen cloths.

“You don’t mean...”

Aurellia burst into laughter and nodded. “Yes. Kasumi predicted you’d choose the connect training today, so she met with us to plan a little surprise.”

“She asked if we could wrap her in linen,” Aurellia continued, “partly to play up her ‘injuries’ from the boat incident last night... but mostly to hint at the theme of your training—a trial in a haunted pyramid, with undead.”

She gave a mischievous wink. “And we made sure to tie her up extra tight. That’s why she couldn’t really move and had to squirm around like that. It was our way of teasing her.”

Mami chuckled, shaking her head. “Not just animals... even the saved essences in this arena love to tease Kasumi.”

Kyoko snorted. “She kind of asks for it.”

The spirits giggled, their linen wraps fluttering like ghostly robes in the air.

Aurellia’s smile softened. “It’s part of what makes this realm so special. Power and playfulness. Growth and joy. All woven together.”

Aurellia’s continued, her voice taking on a gentle cadence. “Lunaria is the opposite of Kasumi. Where Kasumi is fiery, unpredictable, and playful... Lunaria is graceful. Elegant. Gentle. Calming.”

The spirits around her nodded in agreement, their linen wraps fluttering like petals in a breeze.

“Her presence alone brings peace,” Aurellia continued. “But her music... her flute and harp... it’s something else entirely. When she plays, it feels like your worries melt away. Like the world exhales.”

Kyoko smiled. “Even the rowdiest spirits quiet down when Lunaria plays.”

Mami’s eyes glistened as memories surfaced.

“I remember,” she said softly. “The first night I arrived in this realm... I heard her music. I didn’t even know who she was yet, but I was mesmerized.”

She paused, her voice growing more tender. “And during my negativity endurance training... when I was at my lowest... it was her music that pulled me out. It felt like she was reaching into my heart and lifting me up.”

She smiled, remembering another moment. “And at the Kamihama school talent show—when she performed with the orchestra. All of us magical girls... we were touched. It felt like she was speaking directly to each of us through her music.”

Aurellia nodded. “That’s Lunaria. She doesn’t just play notes—she plays emotions. Memories. Hope.” The chamber grew quiet, the spirits basking in the shared reverence.

Aurellia’s gaze drifted toward the murals etched into the chamber walls.

“As for your other question, Mami,” she said gently, “about when or how our essences were saved in the arena... let’s just say it was a long time ago.”

She gestured subtly to the pyramid’s ancient architecture, the worn stone, the timeless carvings. “You’ve probably guessed that already. This place has history—layers of it.”

Then, her voice slowed.

Her eyes lowered, cutting direct contact with Mami and Kyoko.

Her expression softened, almost wistful.

“As for whether Lunaria and Kasumi connected with all of us... and who they truly are...”

She paused.

“I cannot say.”

The words hung in the air—ambiguous, elusive. Was it uncertainty? Or a choice not to reveal?

Mami and Kyoko exchanged a glance.

She’s holding something back. I can feel it in my gut, Kyoko said telepathically.

Or maybe she genuinely doesn’t know, Mami replied. *But either way... those two are more than they seem.*

She paused, her thoughts sharpening.

Her answer... and the way she looked away—it’s just like Lunaria. Every time I ask Lunaria about herself, she gives me that same gentle deflection. So perhaps...

Her voice trailed off in Kyoko’s mind, the implication clear.

Aurellia and the spirits knew more.

Somehow.

Aurellia looked up again, her smile returning like sunlight breaking through clouds.

“Enough of this serious talk,” she said brightly. “Let’s discuss what’s next for you two.”

She and the spirits raised their hands in unison. The massive stone slab that had sealed the chamber began to rumble, slowly retracting into the ceiling.

Mami and Kyoko sighed in relief.

They could finally leave this room.

Aurellia floated toward the exit, her linen wrap trailing like a ribbon. “Continue down the path you were on. You’ll see a few more murals—continuing the story of the twelve girls.”

She turned back with a mischievous wink. “And at the end... you’ll face a *special second trial*.”

Her voice lingered on the phrase, teasing and ominous.

“A trial designed to *force* you to learn about—and use—connect.”

Mami and Kyoko shuddered.

Special second trial? Kyoko echoed. *We already lost to Aurellia. What could be worse than that?*

And we still don’t even know how to use connect, Mami added nervously.

Aurellia and the spirits chuckled, clearly enjoying their discomfort.

“It’ll be fun for us to watch,” one of the spirits said cheerfully.

That did not help.

At all.

The chamber shimmered with fading light.

Aurellia and the spirits hovered one last time, their linen wraps fluttering like petals in a breeze. “We’ll meet again very soon,” Aurellia said warmly, her voice like wind through crystal. “Good luck in your second trial.”

The other spirits echoed her farewell with radiant smiles. “You’ve got this!” “We believe in you!” “Don’t forget to have fun!”

Then, in a breathtaking display, they began to dissolve—light sparkles rising like embers, drifting upward in slow spirals. Tears shimmered through the air, tracing gentle arcs just like the mural’s sacred exchange. It was not sorrow. It was celebration.

Kyoko and Mami stood in silence, enchanted.

Kyoko let out a low whistle. “Okay, that was seriously beautiful. I feel like I just got hugged by a constellation.”

Mami nodded, her eyes still glistening. “It’s comforting. Like they’re still with us, even after disappearing.”

Kyoko grinned, her energy returning. “Alright, I’m fired up now. Let’s go see what’s next in the girls’ story. I want to know what happened after the tears.”

Mami smiled, her voice steady. “Yes. Let’s go.”

Side by side, they walked toward the exit. The massive stone slab had fully retracted, revealing a long corridor bathed in soft golden light. The air was quiet, reverent, as if the pyramid itself was holding its breath.

As they stepped into the hallway, the walls began to glow.

New murals emerged—etched in radiant detail, waiting to be discovered.

And somewhere ahead, the second trial stirred.

Not just a test of strength.

But of connection.

Chapter 8a – the 11th mural

Kyoko and Mami continued down the corridor, the golden light guiding their steps like a gentle stream. The air was quiet, reverent, but no longer heavy. The farewell from Aurellia and the spirits had lifted something from their hearts—a weight they hadn’t realized they were carrying.

Soon, they reached another fork.

To the left, a familiar stone archway led into a chamber. The faint glow of a mural beckoned from within.

Kyoko glanced at Mami. “Another one?”

Mami nodded. “Let’s see what happened next.”

They stepped inside.

The room was quiet, the air cool and earthy. The mural stretched across the far wall, etched in vibrant hues of green and gold. It depicted a forest—lush, wild, alive. Villagers moved through the trees, their faces twisted with fear and desperation. They carried torches and stones, searching for something. For someone.

At the center of the forest, the twelve girls stood together.

Kyoko leaned in. “Look at that...”

Mami smiled softly. “They’re hiding.”

One girl shimmered faintly—her form flickering between visibility and invisibility. Her hands were raised, her magic cloaking the others in a veil of concealment. Another girl stood beside her, her shadow stretching unnaturally across the forest floor. From that shadow, illusions bloomed—phantom versions of the twelve girls darting through the trees, leading the villagers astray.

Kyoko chuckled softly. “Very clever. Invisibility and illusions—working together like that? That’s some serious tactical thinking, especially after everything that happened to them...”

Mami nodded, her gaze lingering on the mural. “And they showed mercy. Even after everything... even while being hunted.”

Kyoko tilted her head back, eyes tracing the ceiling as her voice grew quiet. “I don’t think I could’ve done that. If I were in their place... I probably would’ve slaughtered every last villager in a rage.”

Mami turned to her, eyes shadowed with sorrow. “It’s hard to imagine what they must have felt. The fear. The betrayal. And still... they chose compassion.”

They stood in silence for a moment, admiring the girls’ ingenuity and restraint.

Then Mami’s eyes narrowed. “Kyoko... look at their soul gems.”

Kyoko leaned closer. “Six of them... they’ve changed.”

Unlike the faded colors they’d seen in earlier murals, these soul gems had thick black borders—ominous, unmistakable.

Mami’s voice was quiet. “The artist knew. Dull color for magical depletion. Black border for corruption, for despair.”

Kyoko’s expression darkened. “They’re close to turning into witches.”

Mami nodded. “Very close.”

They studied the mural for a long moment, absorbing the truth it revealed. The girls had escaped one danger—but another loomed within.

Still, Mami and Kyoko didn’t feel despair.

Not anymore.

Aurellia and the spirits had shown them that even tragedy could lead to reunion, to joy, to something beyond grief.

Mami turned to Kyoko. “Ready to keep going?”

Kyoko grinned. “Always.”

They stepped out of the chamber together, hearts steady, curiosity burning bright.

The story wasn't over.

And neither was their journey.

Chapter 8b – the 12th mural

Kyoko and Mami continued down the corridor, the golden light dimming as the path narrowed. Ahead, a final doorway loomed—tall, wide, and carved with intricate patterns that pulsed faintly with magic.

Mami slowed, glancing at Kyoko. “Are you ready? Whatever this second trial throws at us... it’s going to be intense.”

Kyoko grinned, rolling her shoulders. “I’m always ready.”

They stepped through the doorway.

The room was massive—far larger than the chamber where they had fought Aurellia. The ceiling stretched impossibly high, vanishing into shadow. The air was still, reverent, as if holding its breath.

And then they saw it.

The mural.

It spanned the entire far wall, etched in breathtaking detail. The colors were vivid, the strokes deliberate. It was a climax—haunting, beautiful, and devastating.

On the left side stood six girls, their expressions frozen in shock and horror. Tears streamed down their faces, but their bodies were braced for battle. Their soul gems floated before them as colored dots, each one distinct.

- The shapeshifter girl was in her chimera form, surrounded by objects half-transformed—grass, branches, rocks—caught between nature and weaponry.
- The telekinetic girl hovered nearby, controlling the mid-transformed debris, poised to launch them with precision.
- The girl who manipulated matter altered the debris—sharpening edges, heating surfaces, darkening textures to make them more dangerous.
- Two girls stood at the rear, no soul gems floating before them. They watched, solemn and still.
- The sixth girl extended fine glowing lines from her body, connecting to each of the others—including the two without soul gems. Her magic pulsed through the threads like veins of light.

On the right side knelt six girls in despair. Their soul gem dots were almost pitch black, pulsing with a sickly glow. Dark vortexes of aura surrounded them, swirling violently like storms of anguish.

Above them loomed massive, abstract forms—witches. Each one bore a twisted echo of the girl they had once been, their powers warped into horrors.

- A witch encircled by red-black wind spirals, ghostly demonic spirits howling in her wake.
- A witch trailing jagged red-black lines that corrupted everything they touched, leaving despair in their path.
- A witch commanding apocalyptic weather—purple lightning, blood-red floods, pitch-black tornadoes, and earthquakes that shattered the sky itself.
- A witch conjuring monstrous plants—thorns, poisonous fumes, binding vines that writhed like serpents.
- A witch cloaked in shadow, weaving illusions and nightmares, her presence swallowing light.
- A witch flickering in and out of sight, warping visibility to sow chaos and fear, her strikes unpredictable and terrifying.

Kyoko gasped, her breath catching. “This mural... it’s something else.”

Mami nodded slowly, her voice hushed. “We expected someone to fall. But all six... all at once...”

Kyoko stepped closer, eyes locked on the six girls still standing. “And yet—they’re still here. Still fighting. Even after losing their family... even after watching their friends become witches...”

She clenched her fists, her voice trembling with admiration. “That’s strength. Real strength. Not just power—but resolve. Mercy. Loyalty.”

Mami’s eyes shimmered. “They didn’t give up. They didn’t run. They’re trying to save them.”

Kyoko nodded. “This is a witch battle beyond anything we’ve ever seen. Six witches at once? That’s unheard of.”

Mami’s gaze drifted to the two girls without soul gems. “And if those two can’t fight... then it’s four against six.”

Kyoko exhaled, her voice low. “I really wonder how it went... Fighting six witches at the same time...”

A sudden voice rang out, bright and unmistakable.

“You don’t have to wonder any longer!”

Kyoko and Mami spun around.

There, lying in the middle of the chamber like she had that very morning—wrapped in linen from head to toe, grinning from ear to ear—was a very familiar figure.

Kasumi.

Her voice echoed with playful challenge and excitement. “Because you’re about to find out!”

Chapter 8c – The special “punishment”

Mami blinked, stunned. “Kasumi? What are you doing here? I thought you and Lunaria went to Kamihama to meet with Yachiyo—to tell her what you learned yesterday.”

Kasumi didn’t move from her linen-wrapped sprawl. She just grinned wider, eyes twinkling. “We did. Or rather, *they* did.”

Mami raised an eyebrow. “They?”

Kasumi winked. “I’m a clone. The real me and Lunaria are in Kamihama right now, probably sipping tea and charming Yachiyo with our brilliance.”

Kyoko squinted. “Wait, you’re a clone? Again?”

Mami chuckled, her grin turning mischievous. “And wrapped in linen again? I thought my glorious battle against the shadow monster healed you.”

Kasumi snorted. “It did. That version of me was very grateful. This one? Entirely uninjured. I just like the aesthetic.”

She wiggled one arm dramatically, the linen crinkling like crumpled parchment. “Besides, it’s thematic. You’re in a haunted pyramid. I’m your mummy mascot.”

Mami rolled her eyes, laughing. “Do you remember when we first met? You threw me straight into a shadow monster fight with zero explanation.”

Kasumi nodded proudly. “One of my finest teaching moments. You were so confused. It was adorable.”

Kyoko raised an eyebrow. “So... are we about to get thrown into something again?”

Mami turned to Kasumi, her voice playful but wary. “Is this part of our ‘special second trial’? Another surprise monster? Or maybe six witches at once?”

Kasumi’s grin deepened. “Oh, it’s definitely special. And it’s going to be *awesome*. Think of it as **punishment** for **not** using **connect** yet during this training.”

Then she turned to Mami, fake tears glistening in her sad puppy eyes. “And **punishment** for being so mean to the real me this morning... Making fun of an injured soul... So cruel!”

Mami laughed. “How could I not? You were squirming like a worm in a cocoon.”

Kasumi closed both eyes and smiled brightly. “And besides... I’m not the only one excited to see what happens.”

Kyoko raised her eyebrows with a smirk. “You don’t mean—?”

“Yes, exactly!” Kasumi chirped, wiggling her arm. A shimmer of magic pulsed from her fingers, and a glowing projection bloomed in the air beside her.

Kyoko grinned. Mami gasped, bringing a hand to her mouth.

The projection showed the arena—massive, radiant, alive with anticipation. Spectators filled every space: some seated in floating flower pods, others drifting midair, and many gathered on the arena floor. Laughter and chatter echoed faintly from the image, a hum of joy and excitement.

As Mami scanned the crowd, her breath caught.

She could see them.

The families from the murals.

Each person seated with their loved ones in the pods—together, smiling, whole.

Kyoko’s voice was quiet. “They’re watching us.”

Kasumi nodded. “They’re cheering for you. For both of you.”

The projection shimmered, casting soft light across the chamber.

And the trial ahead pulsed with promise.

Chapter 8d – The Telekinetic Magical Girl

Kasumi stretched her arms dramatically, then conjured a floating microphone with a flick of her fingers. It hovered near her mouth, glowing faintly with magic.

She grinned. “Alright, everyone—how’s the arena doing tonight?!”

The projection shimmered as the crowd erupted in cheers. Laughter, applause, and excited shouts echoed through the chamber like a wave of joy. Flower pods bobbed in midair, spirits twirled with delight, and magical lights danced across the arena floor.

Kyoko and Mami couldn’t help but smile.

Mami chuckled. “This brings me back... to the talent show. You fired up the crowd with your music, your antics, and—most importantly—your energy.”

Kasumi beamed. “Great! I’m loving the energy. Keep it coming!”

She pointed at Kyoko and Mami as best she could in her tight linen-wraps—really more of a dramatic arm wiggle than an actual gesture. “But before the special second ***punishment*** begins...”

She emphasized the word with exaggerated flair, her voice bouncing with theatrical menace.

Kyoko and Mami shuddered in unison.

“**Punishment...**” Kyoko muttered.

Mami groaned. “She said that way too cheerfully.”

The crowd burst into laughter, clearly enjoying the contrast between Kasumi’s bubbly tone and the ominous implications.

Kasumi winked. “Before we begin, I want to hear from a few *special guests*.”

Mami and Kyoko exchanged a glance.

“Special guests?” Kyoko echoed.

The projection shifted.

A flower pod floated into view, carrying Lunaria—well, her clone. She held a mic with graceful ease, her voice soft and melodic. “Thank you, Kasumi, for the... energetic introduction.”

Kasumi gave a thumbs-up from her linen cocoon.

Lunaria’s pod drifted toward another, where Aurellia sat with her family. Beside her was a new face—smaller, younger, with wide amber eyes that sparkled with curiosity and mischief. Her head was crowned with soft, curly silver hair that shimmered faintly in the light, like moonlight caught in motion.

She wore a short cloak of pale blue, embroidered with tiny stars that twinkled as she moved, and her boots dangled off the edge of the pod as she kicked her feet gently, humming to herself.

Around her, several small objects floated in a gentle orbit—smooth stones, polished wood fragments, curled leaves, and tiny crystal shards. Each one glowed faintly, suspended by her magic. Resting atop the floating objects were small animals: a squirrel curled up on a leaf, a hummingbird perched on a crystal shard, a sleepy fox nestled on a smooth stone. They seemed perfectly at ease, as if Elira’s presence was a natural sanctuary.

The floating pieces shifted subtly, never colliding, moving in a slow, harmonious dance around her. It was as if her magic extended beyond combat—into comfort, balance, and quiet joy.

Mami leaned forward, her eyes wide. “That must be...”

Kyoko nodded slowly. “Aurellia’s little sister. One of the girls from the mural...”

Mami's voice dropped to a whisper, filled with awe. "She's like a walking fairy tale... It's hard to imagine someone like her standing against six witches at once..."

Lunaria smiled warmly and turned to the child. "**Elira Mizunagi**, would you like to share your thoughts on the upcoming trial?"

Elira nodded eagerly, gripping her own floating mic with both hands. Her voice was high and clear, innocent and direct.

"I think they're gonna fail."

The crowd burst into laughter again.

Kyoko's jaw dropped. Mami blinked.

Elira continued, unfazed. "But if they use connect, it'll at least be more interesting."

Aurellia chuckled beside her, placing a gentle hand on her sister's shoulder.

Kasumi, still lying flat and wrapped tightly in linen, wiggled her arms up and down excitedly. "Spoken like a true critic!"

Her linen crinkled with every movement, making her look like a very enthusiastic, magical caterpillar.

Mami groaned. "We're being roasted by a child."

Kyoko grinned. "I hope we prove her wrong!"

The arena shimmered with laughter and anticipation.

Chapter 8d – The Shapeshifter Magical Girl

Lunaria smiled and turned back to the crowd. "Thank you, Elira, for your honest and direct thoughts."

The arena erupted in cheers once more.

Elira beamed, her childish smile so bright it could melt glaciers. She waved both hands excitedly, her mic bobbing in the air beside her like a balloon on a string.

Mami and Kyoko felt their hearts soften.

Kyoko chuckled. "Okay, I can't even be mad after that."

Mami nodded. "She's too cute. Brutally honest, but cute."

Lunaria's flower pod drifted again, this time toward another nestled among the crowd. Inside sat a girl Mami and Kyoko hadn't seen before—but they recognized her instantly from the mural.

Lunaria smiled. “Now, let’s hear from our next special guest—**Sylvette Prothea!**”

The shapeshifter.

Sylvette looked older than Elira, maybe around Kyoko’s age, with a lean, athletic build and sharp, expressive features. Her hair was a cascade of shifting hues—silver at the roots, fading into deep violet tips, as if caught mid-transformation. Her outfit was a living tapestry of textures and colors, subtly shifting every few seconds: feathers blending into scales, silk into bark, metal into mist. Her eyes were a striking amber, with vertical pupils that flickered like candlelight—feral, intelligent, and playful.

She lounged in her pod with casual confidence, one leg draped over the side, her fingers idly morphing into claws and back again, as if her body was always half-listening to the world around her.

Mami’s breath caught. “She’s... mesmerizing.”

Kyoko leaned forward, eyes narrowing with intrigue. “She looks like she’s halfway between a forest spirit and a dragon.”

Mami nodded slowly. “Her magic’s practically humming off her. It’s like she’s never fully settled—always shifting, always listening.”

They watched as her fingers morphed again, her expression calm but alert—like she was tuned into a frequency no one else could hear.

Sylvette glanced their way, her amber eyes flickering with amusement. She gave a subtle nod—acknowledging them, but not inviting conversation. It was the kind of presence that didn’t demand attention... it simply earned it.

She wasn’t alone.

Surrounding her in the flower pod were several figures—her family. Mami and Kyoko recognized them immediately. These were the same spirits who had appeared during their battle with Aurellia, guiding them, encouraging them, and cheering them on. Now, in their true forms, they sat beside Sylvette with quiet pride.

One woman with bark-like skin and moss-colored hair rested a hand on Sylvette’s shoulder. A man with feathers woven into his cloak leaned forward, smiling warmly. A younger brother, perhaps, sat cross-legged beside her, watching the arena with wide eyes and a glowing stone cradled in his lap.

The pod itself shimmered with natural magic—vines curled gently around its edges, and small glowing insects flitted lazily in the air around them. It felt like a living extension of Sylvette’s power, a sanctuary of transformation and harmony.

Mami’s gaze lingered. “She’s not just powerful. She’s deeply connected.”

Kyoko smirked. “And judging by that look, she’s about to say something clever.”

Lunaria smiled. “Sylvette, do you think Mami and Kyoko will figure out how to use connect during this special second trial?”

Sylvette tilted her head, her lips curling into a sly grin. “Probably.”

She gave a mischievous wink. “Kasumi planned it out, didn’t she? She’s got a knack for pushing people into **extreme situations**. And people tend to figure things out when they’re dangling over **metaphorical lava**.”

The arena laughed and cheered.

Kasumi, still lying flat in her linen cocoon, wiggled her arms up and down excitedly, giving a dramatic thumbs-up and a wink. “Extreme situations are my specialty!”

Mami sighed, rubbing her temples. “Great. Now I’m imagining lava. Or a collapsing bridge. Or a giant monster made of shadow and regret.”

Kyoko snorted. “Or all three. At once. While blindfolded.”

Mami groaned. “Don’t give her ideas.”

Kasumi’s linen crinkled ominously.

The crowd laughed again, the energy rising like a tide.

Chapter 8d – The matter-manipulator Magical Girl

Lunaria smiled. “Thank you, Sylvette, for your insight.”

Sylvette leapt up from her pod in one fluid motion—graceful, agile, animalistic. Her body twisted midair like a cat, landing lightly on her feet with a soft thud. She gave a theatrical bow, her hair shifting colors as she moved.

The crowd erupted in cheers.

Kasumi wiggled her arms in approval. “Ten out of ten for style!”

Lunaria’s voice rang out again. “And now... to hear the thoughts of our special *final* guest.”

Mami blinked. “Final?”

Kyoko frowned. “Wait, only three? But there were six girls in the mural. Six witches, six girls.”

Mami nodded. “Where are the other three?”

Lunaria’s flower pod floated toward another pod nestled near the edge of the arena. As it approached, Mami and Kyoko leaned forward.

Inside sat a girl they hadn't seen before but they recognized her from the mural.

She was striking in a completely different way—less mystical, more surreal. Her hair was a soft coral pink, tied into two loose braids that shimmered with flecks of gold. Her eyes were a pale mint green, wide and curious, with a glint of mischief. She wore a layered tunic of shifting fabrics—some parts glossy like metal, others matte like clay, and still others translucent like glass.

But what caught their attention most was the space around her.

The area of the flower pod near where she sat looked... altered. The petals beneath her feet had turned into polished marble. The railing beside her had a velvet texture and glowed faintly with heat. A small cushion floated nearby, its surface rippling like liquid. Further away, the pod looked normal—soft petals, gentle glow, natural curves. But near her, reality itself seemed to bend and reshape.

Her family sat with her, smiling warmly. Beside her, a pair of younger twins—a boy and a girl—played with a floating cube that shimmered and changed color every time they touched it. The boy tapped it with a giggle, turning it a fiery red; the girl followed with a gentle press, shifting it to a cool blue. Their laughter echoed softly, blending with the ambient hum of magic around them.

Mirielle's parents sat nearby, their expressions proud and serene. They seemed perfectly at ease within the surreal beauty that surrounded their daughter—accustomed to the way reality bent and reshaped itself in her presence. The marble beneath her feet, the velvet-glowing railing, the rippling cushion—all of it was just part of her world.

It was clear this wasn't chaos—it was imagination made tangible. A quiet celebration of her gift.

Mami whispered, "She's the one who manipulates matter..."

Kyoko nodded. "She's like a walking science experiment. But prettier."

Lunaria smiled. "Let's hear from our final guest—**Mirielle Calden**. Mirielle, if Mami and Kyoko happen to **connect**... what kind of attacks or techniques do you think they'd be able to pull off?"

Mirielle's eyes lit up. She leaned forward, her fingers tapping the air as if sketching invisible ideas.

"Ooh, so many possibilities," she said, her voice bubbling with excitement. "Okay, imagine this—Kyoko's spear gets coated in Mami's ribbon magic, but the ribbons are hardened like crystal. So when she throws it, it spirals like a drill and explodes into binding threads on impact!"

The crowd gasped and cheered.

"Or," she continued, "Mami creates a ribbon dome, and Kyoko superheats the inside with fire magic. Instant sauna trap! Or—wait—what if they combine their magic into a whip-spear hybrid that changes temperature mid-strike? Cold snap, then burn!"

Mirielle's eyes gleamed with mischief. "Okay, okay—last one, but it's *wild*."

She leaned forward, grinning. "Mami summons a giant gun. Like, *absurdly* giant. Bigger than a house. And when she fires it—bam! It doesn't just shoot bullets. It launches *everything*."

She waved her hands dramatically, her voice rising with excitement. "First, her normal bullets. Then Kyoko's spear. Then Kyoko's whip. Then Kyoko's fragmented staff. Then Kyoko's chains. All flying out in a spiral barrage!"

The crowd gasped, then laughed.

"But wait," Mirielle added, eyes twinkling. "Then she shoots *Kyoko*."

Kyoko blinked. "She what?"

Mirielle nodded eagerly. "She loads Kyoko into the cannon like a magical missile. And Kyoko flies out—*whoosh!*—riding the path of Mami's ribbons like a rollercoaster. Loop-de-loops, corkscrews, the whole thing!"

She mimed the motion with her hands, braids bouncing. "And at the end—*bam!*—Kyoko rams into the enemy with a flaming, ribbon-powered, spear-enhanced, full-body grand slam!"

The arena exploded with laughter and cheers.

Kasumi wiggled her arms wildly from her linen cocoon. "YES. That's the kind of chaos I live for!"

Mami stared, stunned. "A giant gun?"

Kyoko grinned. "Honestly? I'd do it. This trial's been missing an extreme, adrenaline-rush rollercoaster."

Mami groaned. "Please don't. I don't want Kasumi adding more to my **punishment**."

Kyoko smirked. "Come on, it'd be fun! Just like the **Tower of Terror** ride. You said you've grown, right?"

Mami crossed her arms. "That ride *dropped* us from the clouds."

Kyoko shrugged. "Exactly. If I'm going out, I'm going out *launched*."

Mirielle giggled, clearly delighted. "That's the spirit! You just have to connect—and then the magic gets *weird*."

Chapter 8e – The second special trial: “punishment” begins

Lunaria smiled warmly. “Thank you, Mirielle, for sharing your thoughts.”

Mirielle gave a playful wink, then raised both hands. The air around her shimmered. With a flick of her fingers, dozens of tiny bursts of light erupted across the arena—miniature fireworks of shifting color and texture. Some sparkled like crystal, others rippled like water, and a few popped with soft musical chimes.

The crowd gasped, then cheered, enchanted by the display.

Lunaria laughed gently. “And with that... I hand things back to our ever-creative host. Kasumi?”

Kasumi wiggled her arms dramatically from her linen cocoon. “Thank you, thank you! Now then—Mami, Kyoko... are you ready to be ***punished***?”

The crowd roared with laughter and anticipation.

Mami sighed. “I don’t like how she says that.”

Kyoko smirked. “She’s definitely enjoying this too much.”

As Kasumi spoke, Mami’s eyes narrowed. She leaned forward. “Wait... what’s on your linen?”

Strange markings had appeared across Kasumi’s wrappings—swirling lines, jagged shapes, and chaotic symbols that hadn’t been there before. They didn’t resemble any of the patterns from the murals.

Kasumi grinned. “Oh, those? That’s my *art*! I drew what I think will happen when you two fight your opponents during the trial. I used my imagination while the special guests were talking.”

Mami and Kyoko squinted at the linen, trying to decipher the chaotic scrawl.

Kyoko tilted her head. “Is that... a spear riding a ribbon tornado?”

Mami frowned. “Or a ribbon cannon shooting a blender?”

Kasumi giggled. “There’s *more*! Hold on—let me show you the back!”

She began to wriggle, trying to flip herself over. The linen bindings made it nearly impossible. After a few exaggerated grunts and flails, she managed to roll halfway—then promptly face-planted into the floor.

The crowd erupted in laughter.

Mami and Kyoko burst out laughing too.

Kasumi turned her head toward them, one eye shut, her cheek squished comically against the petal floor. “I’m fine!”

She gave a few exaggerated wiggles, finally managing to roll over enough to reveal the back of her linen. More drawings—equally chaotic—covered the surface. Swirls, stars, explosions, and what looked suspiciously like a stick-figure Kyoko flying through a giant doughnut.

Kasumi beamed. “These are my predictions for the *end* of the second trial!”

Mami and Kyoko stared, utterly baffled.

Kasumi tilted her head. “Well? What do you think?”

Mami smirked. “It looks like chicken scratch. No one could decipher that.”

Kyoko chuckled. “I thought it was drawn by a blindfolded person using one finger while balancing on one leg.”

The arena erupted—cheers, boos, laughter, and playful shouting.

Kasumi gasped theatrically, eyes wide with mock betrayal. “How *dare* you! My art is a sacred expression of magical chaos! Just like your rude commentary on my *artful* jump landings!”

Mami and Kyoko chuckled, shaking their heads.

Kasumi’s expression shifted to a mischievous grin. “Fine. If you’re going to be *that* way...”

She raised her voice dramatically, striking a pose as best she could in her cocoon. “Then let’s begin your punishment!”

She paused for effect, then declared with theatrical flair:

“I present to you... the **Second Special Trial: *The Ribboned Spear of Flaming Regret* vs. *The Sixfold Witchstorm of Ultimate Doom!***”

The crowd exploded.

Mami’s eyes widened. “Wait—*six* witches? At once?”

Kyoko blinked. “You’ve got to be kidding.”

Kasumi winked, still half-squished against the floor. “Nope! I told ya—you don’t have to *wonder* what fighting six witches at the same time would feel like. You’re about to *live* it!”

The arena thundered with cheers, chants, and magical fireworks as Mami and Kyoko stood frozen, staring at each other in disbelief.

Kasumi raised her bound arms and began a bizarre incantation—half nonsense, half performance. “Zibba-zabba! Womp-womp! Shaka-shaka *grrrr*—fluffernoodle!” She wiggled her arms up and down

like a malfunctioning puppet, her voice bouncing between grunts, squeaks, and syllables that refused to make sense.

Mami blinked. “What is she doing?”

Kyoko whispered, “I think this *is* the spell.”

Suddenly, a sharp *ring* echoed through the arena.

A beam of light shot down from the ceiling, striking the floor with a resonant hum. Then another. And another. Six in total—each one arriving with a pulse of sound and a flash of color.

As each laser hit the ground, a magical girl appeared—kneeling on one leg, hunched over, panting, her body trembling with despair. Their soul gems were pitch black, pulsing ominously, on the verge of bursting.

The first girl had long, wind-swept hair that whipped around her face, tangled and wild. Her cloak was torn, fluttering in invisible gusts. Around her, faint ghostly shapes flickered—spirits caught in the storm, brushing her skin like memories refusing to let go. Her eyes were hollow, her breath ragged, as if the wind had stolen her voice.

The second girl hovered just above the ground, her limbs limp, her body dimly glowing with fading trails of light. Her dress shimmered with iridescent hues, but the colors were dull, flickering like dying embers. Her arms hung loosely, her fingers twitching mid-pirouette, as if she had collapsed mid-dance. Her soul gem pulsed like a broken metronome.

The third girl knelt with her arms raised weakly toward the ceiling. Her hair was soaked, her robes heavy with moisture. Thunderclouds gathered above her, swirling unnaturally fast. Her eyes were clenched shut, her face streaked with tears and rain. Lightning crackled around her fingertips, but it didn’t strike—it hovered, waiting for release.

The fourth girl was surrounded by wilting flowers and browning grass. Her hands trembled as she reached for a dying bloom, which crumbled in her palm. Her once-bright dress was faded and torn, stained with soil and ash. Butterflies lay motionless around her, their wings dulled. Her aura, once warm, now felt cold and brittle.

The fifth girl stood in eerie stillness, her shadow stretching unnaturally long behind her. It twisted and writhed like a living thing, curling around her legs and reaching toward the others. Her eyes were wide, unblinking, and her lips moved silently. The shadow pulsed, jagged and sharp, as if it were trying to speak in her place.

The sixth girl flickered in and out of visibility. Her form shimmered like a mirage, one moment solid, the next translucent. Her cloak fluttered between dimensions, and her face was half-lit, half-shadowed. She looked up briefly, her eyes unfocused, as if she were slipping between worlds and couldn’t find her way back.

Mami and Kyoko watched in horror.

Their legs trembled. Their arms shook. They were about to witness six magical girls become witches—*simultaneously*.

Kasumi turned her head toward them, one eye shut, her cheek still squished against the floor. She gave them a wink. “Good luck!”

Then—*poof!*—Kasumi vanished.

In her place, a burst of confetti exploded into the air. Party streamers shot out in every direction. Balloons inflated midair and popped with glitter. A comical party horn echoed through the arena, absurdly cheerful.

The contrast was chilling.

All six magical girls convulsed.

Their heads snapped upward toward the ceiling.

And then—they screamed.

A distorted, inhuman cry tore through the arena as their soul gems exploded, releasing six massive vortices of darkness and energy. The air warped. The floor cracked. The room twisted into a spiral of chaos—walls bending, murals distorting, the stone floor curling inward as if recoiling from the eruption.

Mami and Kyoko closed their eyes and braced themselves.

The shockwave hit like a tidal wave.

They were sent flying backward, tumbling through the air.

Mami summoned her ribbons in a flash, weaving them into a protective net that caught her mid-flight.

Kyoko slammed her spear into the ground, manifesting a red-diamond wall that shimmered with heat and force, shielding her from the brunt of the blast.

Mami’s ribbon net shimmered, straining against the lingering shockwave. Kyoko’s red diamond wall pulsed with heat, cracks spidering across its surface. Both girls dug their heels into the fractured stone floor, struggling to maintain ground.

The darkness began to settle.

The air thinned.

The vortexes of despair receded into silence.

Mami and Kyoko opened their eyes.

And gasped.

Their arms fell limply to their sides. Knees buckled. Sweat dripped down their faces. Their bodies trembled harder than before—not from exhaustion, but from sheer terror.

Before them were six witches.

Monsters born from the despair of magical girls.

The first witch, Velmira the Howling Spiral, hovered in a cyclone of red-black wind. Her body was skeletal and elongated, wrapped in tattered veils that flailed like torn sails. Ghostly spirits howled in her wake—demonic faces twisted in agony, swirling around her like a living storm. Her eyes were hollow voids, and her mouth stretched into a permanent scream. The wind didn't just blow—it *devoured*, pulling at the edges of reality.

The second witch, Ruinelle the Fractured Path, slithered across the ground, trailing jagged red-black lines that cracked and corrupted everything they touched. Her form was serpentine, segmented like shattered glass, with limbs that bent at unnatural angles. Her face was a mask of despair—no eyes, just a gaping maw that leaked ink-like shadows. Wherever she moved, the floor blackened, and the air grew heavy with dread.

The third witch, Catastropa the Skybreaker, loomed like a walking apocalypse. Her body was a towering mass of storm clouds and molten stone, her limbs crackling with purple lightning. Blood-red floods surged around her feet, and pitch-black tornadoes spiraled from her shoulders. Her head was crowned with thunder, her voice a rumble that shook the walls. Every step she took fractured the ground, sending tremors through the room.

The fourth witch, Thornaria the Blooming Maw, emerged from a nest of monstrous plants. Her body was wrapped in thorned vines, her limbs blooming with poisonous flowers that hissed and spat fumes. Her face was hidden beneath a petal-like mask, and her eyes glowed green with venomous intent. Binding vines writhed around her like serpents, lashing out at the air, hungry for prey. The scent of decay and pollen filled the room.

The fifth witch, Noctulisse the Dream-Eater, stood cloaked in shadow. Her form was barely visible—just a silhouette with glowing red eyes. Illusions flickered around her: twisted reflections, nightmare images, and impossible shapes. Her presence swallowed light, bending it inward. The murals behind her warped and faded, as if reality itself refused to look at her. She didn't move—but the fear she radiated crept forward like fog.

The sixth witch, Vexaphra the Vanishing Blade, flickered in and out of sight. One moment she was there—a jagged, insect-like figure with blade-like limbs and a fractured crown. The next, she was gone. Her movements were erratic, her strikes unpredictable. She warped visibility, distorting the space

around her like a broken lens. Her laughter echoed from nowhere and everywhere, a sound that made Mami's skin crawl.

Mami and Kyoko stood frozen.

Six witches.

At once.

Their worst nightmare made real.

Kasumi's voice echoed faintly from memory: *"You don't have to wonder what fighting six witches at the same time would feel like..."*

Mami clenched her fists, ribbons trembling.

Kyoko gritted her teeth, spear pulsing with heat.

Vexaphra vanished.

Her jagged, insect-like form flickered once—then was gone.

But her presence lingered.

A cold, eerie laugh echoed across the chamber, bouncing from wall to wall, impossible to trace. It was sharp and hollow, like glass cracking in the dark. Mami and Kyoko flinched, their spines tingling.

"She's the invisible one," Kyoko muttered.

Mami nodded grimly. "The witch of the girl who slipped between worlds."

Without hesitation, Mami summoned a web of golden ribbons, weaving them in a protective dome around herself and Kyoko. The threads shimmered faintly, tuned to sense movement, pressure, and magical distortion.

Kyoko reinforced her red diamond wall, planting her spear beside it like a lightning rod. "If she's going to strike from nowhere, we'll be ready."

But the danger didn't wait.

Ruinelle rose into the air, her serpentine body undulating like smoke. She slithered through the chamber, leaving jagged red-black trails behind her—lines that twisted and dissolved into curling wisps of black fog.

The fog drifted toward Mami and Kyoko.

When it reached them, they felt it instantly.

A cold pressure against their hearts.

Their soul gems pulsed—dimmed—then flickered with a faint black sheen.

Mami gasped. “This... this is like the shadow monster. The corruption—it’s seeping in.”

Kyoko clenched her fists. “Yeah, but much slower. That thing was constant. This is more like... a slow leak.”

She glanced at her soul gem. “Emotional control shouldn’t be too bad for now. But the real problem is physical and magical. Six witches at once? When we get tired, it’ll be easier to slip.”

Mami nodded, her breath shaky. “Then we don’t let ourselves slip.”

They both closed their eyes.

Inhale.

Exhale.

They thought of the good times.

Of laughter shared over tea.

Of rooftop sunsets.

Of sparring matches that ended in giggles and bruises.

Of the Tower of Terror ride, and Mami’s scream that echoed louder than the drop.

Their soul gems pulsed again—this time with more light.

The black haze receded slightly.

Their arms steadied. Their legs stopped shaking.

They opened their eyes.

Still surrounded.

Still terrified.

But no longer paralyzed.

Catastropha let out a guttural roar, her voice rumbling like thunder through the chamber. Bolts of purple lightning rained down from the storm clouds swirling around her body, each strike aimed with brutal precision.

Kyoko spun her spear in a blur, then hurled it skyward. The weapon caught the lightning mid-air, spinning like a turbine, absorbing and deflecting the bolts in a dazzling display of red and violet sparks.

But Thornaria was already moving.

From her nest of writhing vines, she launched a barrage of thorned tendrils toward Kyoko—razor-edged, venom-laced, and fast.

Mami's ribbons shot out, intercepting the vines just in time. The thorns hissed as they tangled with the golden threads, and Mami fired a barrage of muskets toward both Catastrophia and Thornaria, hoping to push them back.

But the bullets never reached their targets.

A red-black wind spiraled into their path, twisting unnaturally. Ghostly demonic spirits erupted from the gusts, shrieking as they surged toward Mami and Kyoko like banshees.

"Move!" Mami shouted.

They leapt in opposite directions.

The lightning and spirits collided mid-air—*BOOM!*—a blinding explosion of light and shadow that shook the walls and sent cracks racing across the floor.

Mami landed hard, skidding across the stone. "This isn't working. Staying defensive will get us nowhere."

Kyoko rolled to her feet, panting. "Agreed. We need to take one down. Together."

They scanned the battlefield.

Noctulisse was closest.

She drifted like a shadow, her form flickering between visibility and nightmare. Her red eyes glowed faintly, watching them.

"Now!" Mami shouted.

They dashed forward.

Mami's ribbons lashed out, binding Noctulisse's limbs mid-phase. Kyoko followed with a fierce leap, spear extended. Mami fired a volley of muskets, each shot landing with precision.

The impact kicked up a thick dust cloud.

Mami and Kyoko paused, breathing hard, eyes wide with hope.

"We hit her," Kyoko said, smiling.

Mami nodded. "That was clean."

But then—

Lines of shadow shot forth from the dust cloud, slicing through the air like whips. The cloud hadn't even cleared before the illusions began.

Suddenly, dozens of Noctulisses surrounded them.

Some tall as towers.

Some small as children.

All laughing—eerie, distorted, at different pitches.

Kyoko spun around. “Illusions. Has to be.”

Mami summoned more muskets, firing in every direction. Some bullets passed through phantoms. Others struck something solid.

“There!” Mami pointed. “That one flinched!”

Kyoko extended her spear, aiming for the real Noctulisse.

But just before the tip connected—

CLANG!

A jagged blade intercepted the strike.

Kyoko and Mami gasped.

For a split second, they saw it—Vexaphra’s fractured form, her blade-like limbs shimmering in and out of sight.

“She blocked it,” Kyoko whispered.

Mami’s eyes widened. “They’re working together...”

They stepped back, stunned.

Witches weren’t supposed to do this.

They were singular horrors—isolated, chaotic, trapped in their own labyrinths.

But these six...

They were coordinated.

They were strategic.

They were *working together*.

And Mami and Kyoko were in the center of it.

Kyoko grinned, eyes gleaming with fire. “If they want to play smart—then it’s time I got serious.”

“*Rosso Fantasma!*”

In a flash, illusionary clones of Kyoko burst outward, scattering across the battlefield like crimson comets. Each one moved with purpose—taunting, provoking, darting just out of reach. The witches snarled and lunged, unleashing attacks on the clones, their monstrous instincts triggered by the chaos.

Mami watched, calculating.

She could feel the fear in her chest—the weight of despair pressing against her ribs. But she didn’t push it away. She *welcomed* it. Her soul gem, still tainted by Ruinelle’s black fog, pulsed with dark energy. She focused on it, drawing the negativity inward, shaping it into strength.

“Kyoko!” she shouted. “Have one of your clones bait a witch closer to me!”

Kyoko nodded. “On it!”

One clone zipped toward Velmira, weaving through the air like a ribbon of flame. Velmira shrieked and gave chase, her weakened cyclone spiraling behind her.

Mami’s eyes narrowed. “Got you.”

She raised her musket, charged with corrupted magic—and fired.

Tiro Finale.

The blast was immense.

A golden beam laced with shadow tore through the air, striking Velmira head-on. The impact sent a shockwave rippling outward, forcing Mami and Kyoko to brace themselves mid-air. Velmira’s ghostly scream echoed through the chamber, distorted and raw.

When the dust settled, Velmira reeled.

Her cyclone of demonic wind was fractured, flickering, barely holding shape.

Kyoko landed beside Mami, panting. “Nice shot.”

Mami smiled. “We might actually pull this off.”

But then—

Something changed.

All six witches turned toward them.

Their monstrous eyes locked onto Mami and Kyoko.

And they *roared*.

A unified, primal scream that shook the walls and rattled the air. Mami and Kyoko flinched, sweat beading down their faces. Their hearts pounded.

“What was that?” Kyoko whispered.

“They’ve marked us,” Mami said. “They know we’re a threat.”

The witches moved.

Together.

Catastrophia slammed her molten fists into the ground. The floor cracked—then *heaved*, an earthquake erupting beneath Mami and Kyoko. They lost their footing, the world tilting violently.

“Jump!” Kyoko shouted.

They leapt into the air.

Mami’s ribbons flared around her, sensing a disturbance behind.

She twisted mid-air and fired a barrage of bullets backward.

The shots struck Noctulisse—but passed through her.

“An illusion!” Mami gasped.

The real Noctulisse emerged from the shadows, lunging at Mami’s exposed back.

Kyoko’s eyes widened. “Not on my watch!”

She swung her spear in a wide arc, slamming it into Noctulisse’s side and sending her flying.

Mami caught her breath. “Thanks.”

“No problem,” Kyoko said, already scanning for the next threat.

From below, Thornaria’s vines surged upward—razor-thorned and writhing. Mami’s ribbons intercepted them, tangling in a web of golden light.

But this time, the vines *spat* venomous slime bullets.

Kyoko reacted instantly, manifesting a red-diamond wall to block the barrage. The slime hissed and sizzled on impact, eating away at the surface.

She summoned more walls, layering them into a floating platform.

“Land here!” she shouted.

Mami nodded, leaping onto the crystalline floor beside her.

They stood together—breathing hard, surrounded by chaos.

But still fighting.

Just as their feet touched the crystalline floor Kyoko had conjured, a surge of red-black wind spiraled upward from below.

Kyoko's eyes narrowed. "Wait—why from *below*? This floor should block—"

She didn't finish.

The demonic spirits burst through the crystal as if it weren't there, their ghostly forms phasing through the solid surface. Cold, clawed hands latched onto Kyoko's ankles.

Mami's eyes widened. "They can do that?!"

Her breath caught. "They're spirits—they can pass through!"

Kyoko reacted instantly, slicing downward with her spear. The blade tore through the spectral arms, severing them with a hiss of vanishing mist.

But there was no time to breathe.

Above them, Ruinelle twisted through the air, her serpentine body trailing jagged red-black lines. The corrupted trails pulsed with dread, and as they passed overhead, Mami and Kyoko felt it—a *spike of fear*, sharp and sudden, stabbing into their hearts.

Their soul gems flickered.

Their breath hitched.

And then—

WHAM!

A heavy, invisible blow struck them from behind.

Vexaphra.

Neither saw her coming.

They cried out in pain as the force launched them downward, their bodies twisting mid-air.

They slammed into the cracked stone floor with a brutal thud, dust and debris scattering around them.

Kyoko coughed, blood splattering the ground.

Mami groaned, clutching her ribs, one knee pressed into the earth.

They were close—barely a few feet apart.

Both struggling to rise.

Their bodies trembled.

Their vision blurred.

The witches weren't just attacking—they were *hunting*.

And Mami and Kyoko were the prey.

The witches advanced slowly, their monstrous forms looming larger with each step. Their laughter echoed through the chamber—distorted, chilling, cold. It wasn't joy. It was hunger.

Noctulisse raised her arms, and the air around Mami and Kyoko twisted unnaturally. The temperature dropped. The light dimmed. Illusions bloomed like poisonous flowers—dark, pulsing, and alive. They didn't just surround the girls—they *invaded*.

The stone walls of the chamber melted into shifting shadows.

Mami saw herself standing alone in a ruined city, her muskets shattered, her ribbons limp and frayed. The sky above her was black, and the ground was littered with broken soul gems—each one bearing the name of someone she had failed to protect. Voices whispered from the rubble: “*You weren't enough.*” “*You let them fall.*” “*You always do.*”

Kyoko saw her younger self, clutching her father's robes, begging him not to leave. Then the scene shifted—her spear lay broken beside a lifeless Sayaka, her own hands stained with blood. Around her, the witches laughed, their voices echoing with mockery: “*You fight for nothing.*” “*You're just a stray.*” “*You never deserved her.*”

The illusions clawed at their minds.

Shadows of failure.

Echoes of loss.

The weight of isolation.

Screams filled the air—not theirs, but ones that felt like they could be. Familiar. Personal. As if the nightmares had reached into their memories and twisted them into weapons.

Ruinelle's corruption deepened the effect. Her red-black fog slithered through the illusions, amplifying every doubt, every fear. The soul gems of Mami and Kyoko pulsed erratically, flickering between light and shadow.

Mami and Kyoko stared ahead in horror.

Frozen.

The witches were closing in.

The nightmares were closing *in*.

And then—

As if by instinct, they reached out.

Their trembling hands found each other.

Fingers locked.

They pulled close, arms shaking, eyes wide as they stared into the abyss.

Then Noctulisse's illusions reached their climax.

The shadows around them surged, merging into a single, overwhelming vision—no longer separate fears, but a shared nightmare.

The chamber dissolved entirely.

Mami and Kyoko found themselves standing in a vast, crumbling battlefield. The sky above was a swirling vortex of red-black clouds, streaked with purple lightning. The ground was littered with broken weapons, shattered soul gems, and the lifeless bodies of countless magical girls—some familiar, some unknown, all twisted in agony.

In the distance, six towering witches loomed like gods of despair, their monstrous forms silhouetted against the chaos. They weren't attacking. They were watching. Waiting.

Mami looked down and saw her ribbons tangled around the fallen, unable to lift them. Her muskets lay scattered, rusted and useless. Her soul gem flickered weakly, barely holding light.

At her feet lay the broken bodies of Madoka, Homura, and Sayaka—faces pale, eyes open but lifeless. Their hands reached toward her, twisted in expressions of accusation, anger, and betrayal. Their mouths moved silently, but Mami could hear the words in her mind: *"You let us fall."* *"You were supposed to protect us."* *"You failed."*

Behind them, her parents appeared—ghostly, bloodied from the crash that took their lives. They stood in the wreckage of a mangled car, arms outstretched, eyes hollow. Her mother's voice echoed: *"Why weren't you with us?"* Her father's: *"Why did you survive?"*

Kyoko stood beside her, her spear snapped in half. Her soul gem pulsed with black veins, flickering with dread.

She saw her family—her father, mother, and little sister—standing in a ruined church, their faces twisted in grief and rage. Her father's voice thundered: *"You wished for this."* Her mother sobbed: *"You destroyed us."* Her sister clung to her broken doll, whispering: *"You said we'd be happy."*

They reached for Kyoko, hands trembling, eyes full of betrayal.

Kyoko staggered back, breath caught in her throat.

Mami's knees buckled.

The illusions wrapped around them, suffocating and relentless.

Then the sky cracked.

From above, a colossal shadow descended—an amalgamation of all six witches fused into one grotesque entity. Its face was a swirling mass of eyes and mouths, each one whispering their failures, their regrets, their deepest fears.

“You were never enough.”

“You fight for nothing.”

“You are alone.”

“You will die here.”

The voices overlapped, distorted and deafening.

The ground beneath them split open, revealing a pit of writhing shadows. Hands reached up, clawing at their legs, trying to drag them down.

Mami and Kyoko screamed.

But their hands stayed locked.

Their grip tightened.

Their arms trembled.

Their eyes shut.

And then—

Everything went white.

The nightmare shattered like glass.

The voices vanished.

The weight lifted.

Silence.

Then, through the stillness, a pair of familiar voices rang out.

The first was cheerful, bursting with energy. “Wow, it’s about time you held hands! Geez... How hard is it to follow instructions?”

A gentle chuckle followed, and a calm, soothing voice drifted in like a breeze. “Yes... it took them a while. But better late than never.”

Mami and Kyoko’s eyes fluttered open, blinking in confusion.

They were no longer in the crumbling chamber.

Soft mist swirled around them, glowing with gentle light. The air was warm, fragrant with something like blooming flowers and distant rain. The sky above was a canvas of soft clouds and shimmering hues, as if painted by emotion itself.

Standing before them were two familiar figures.

Kasumi—no longer wrapped in linen, but in her usual outfit, vibrant and confident—stood with hands on her hips, grinning like she’d just pulled off the best prank of her life.

Beside her, Lunaria stood serene, her long hair flowing like silk in the breeze, her smile gentle and knowing, eyes full of quiet joy.

Mami blinked. “What... is this? What are you two doing here?”

Kyoko looked around, still dazed. “Where *are* we?”

Kasumi winked and gave a beaming thumbs-up. “Welcome to the spiritual realm! Since you’re *finally* holding hands, you can actually learn about connecting—with each other, and with other magical girls.”

Mami and Kyoko glanced down at their hands, still tightly clasped.

They quickly let go, cheeks flushing.

“W-We weren’t trying to—” Mami stammered.

“It was just instinct!” Kyoko added, flustered.

Kasumi giggled. “Relax. You’re adorable when you panic.”

Lunaria stepped forward, her voice like a lullaby. “This realm is a reflection of your bond. You’ve reached a threshold—one that few magical girls ever cross. Here, you’ll learn what it truly means to *Connect*.”

Mami and Kyoko looked at each other.

Still confused. Still shaken.

Chapter 9 – **Connect** with the past

Mami and Kyoko stood in the misty realm, still shaken, still breathless. The nightmare had vanished, but its echo lingered in their bones.

Kyoko rubbed her temple, eyes narrowing. “Wait... so all that hand-holding stuff was part of the *training*?”

Kasumi groaned and face-palmed. “*Uh, yeah*. Why else would the connect training option in the arena projection list *and* the altar mention holding hands? Did you two seriously think that part was optional just because it sounded ‘weird’?”

Mami chuckled, a little sheepishly. “Yes. We thought it was something put there to... you know, *mess with us*. We didn’t want to make the training awkward and mushy.”

Kyoko crossed her arms, nodding. “Exactly. We’re fighters, not some rom-com duo.”

Lunaria laughed softly, her voice like wind through leaves. “You’re not alone. A lot of magical girl groups thought the same. But eventually, during the training—especially when they fought Aurellia—they’d end up holding hands. Sometimes because they remembered the instructions... but more often, it was instinct. Fear has a way of stripping down pride.”

She winked. “But you two? You’re something else.”

Mami raised an eyebrow. “Something else?”

Lunaria smiled playfully. “You both try to brute-force your way through every challenge. You coordinate, you strategize, you push yourselves to the edge. But you never *let go*. You never lean in. It took a very *special* second trial—six witches, no less—to strike enough fear into you both for that instinct to finally kick in.”

Kasumi nodded, arms crossed. “Very few magical girl pairs need a second trial of that magnitude to get them to hold hands. You two are stubborn.”

Kyoko scoffed, looking away. “We’re not stubborn. We’re just... efficient.”

Mami smiled, brushing dust off her skirt. “And maybe a little emotionally constipated.”

Kyoko groaned. “Don’t say it like that.”

Kasumi burst out laughing. “See? *Adorable*.”

Lunaria stepped forward, her tone softening. “But now that you’ve crossed that threshold... you’re ready. Ready to learn what it truly means to *Connect*. Not just in battle—but in spirit.”

Mami and Kyoko exchanged a glance.

Their eyes met.

Their hearts steadied.

And they nodded.

“*Ready!*” they said in unison.

Lunaria stepped forward, her voice gentle but clear. “Before I explain what it means to *Connect* between magical girls, we need to revisit the fundamentals—of **magic**, and of **connection** itself.”

She turned to Mami, her gaze warm. “Mami, what have you learned about magic and connect so far?”

Mami paused, her eyes drifting downward in thought.

“I’ve... come to see magic as something more than just power,” she said slowly. “Back in the grove, and by the lake... I spent time meditating. Listening. Feeling. I connected with the plants, the animals, even the water. Not just with my magic—but with my heart.”

She looked up, her voice steadier. “There’s beauty in all life. Even the smallest leaf, the quietest ripple. Magic isn’t just something we wield—it’s something we *share*. It’s everywhere. And when we slow down enough to listen... it speaks.”

Lunaria smiled, her eyes glowing softly. “That’s a beautiful viewpoint, Mami. And a wise one.”

She stepped closer. “Now tell me—how did you gather the essence of that simple herb yesterday? The one you used to create a leaf during dinner?”

Mami blinked, then nodded. “I reached out and touched the plant. I let my magic flow gently into it. I had to focus—*really* focus—not just on connecting, but on not getting lost in the beauty of it. I felt the world from the plant’s perspective. Its rhythm. Its breath.”

She paused, eyes widening. “I had to resonate with it. Sync my magic with its energy. Only then... did it share a part of its essence with me.”

Her breath caught.

Her gaze flicked to Lunaria and Kasumi.

“You both touched the plants and animals too... when you gathered ingredients for our meals.”

She turned to Kasumi, realization dawning. “That’s why the training instructions said holding hands was important. It wasn’t symbolic—it was *functional*.”

Kasumi winked and gave a thumbs-up. “*Bingo!* You’re finally putting the pieces together.”

Kyoko raised an eyebrow and sighed dramatically. “So... touching stuff is magic now? Great. Please don’t tell me I have to hold Mami’s hand *every single time* we want to do combo moves...”

Kasumi burst out laughing. “Touching with *intention*, Kyoko. With resonance. With trust. That’s where it begins.”

Mami and Kyoko glanced at each other.

Kyoko groaned under her breath. “This is gonna be so awkward...”

Mami smiled, amused. “Only if you keep complaining about it.”

Kasumi winked. “You’ll get used to it. Most magical girls do. Eventually.”

The mist around them shimmered softly.

The lesson was just beginning.

Lunaria’s voice took on a serene cadence, the mist around them shimmering with her words.

“When magical girls hold hands with the intention to *Connect*, they don’t just sync their magic. They sync their *selves*. Their core essence.”

She looked at both Mami and Kyoko with quiet intensity.

“When two magical girls truly understand each other—when there’s trust, empathy, and vulnerability—the Connect becomes powerful. Their powers aren’t just added together... they are significantly *magnified*. Their abilities don’t just combine... they evolve. You’ll gain access to each other’s magic, each other’s instincts. The abilities that emerge from a true Connect will boggle your imagination.”

Kyoko raised an eyebrow. “So it’s like fusion, but with feelings?”

Kasumi snorted. “Fusion with feelings *and* fireworks.”

Lunaria nodded. “But if there’s misunderstanding... if one side resists... the Connect weakens. Sometimes it fails entirely.”

Kasumi stepped forward, her grin widening. “Luckily, you two are the former. You’re good friends. You understand each other. You’ve been through a lot during this training—especially during the fight against Aurellia and...”

She threw her arms up with theatrical flourish.

“Second Special Trial: The Ribboned Spear of Flaming Regret vs. The Sixfold Witchstorm of Ultimate Doom!”

Mami and Kyoko burst into laughter, the memory of Kasumi shouting that title to the entire arena still fresh in their minds.

Kasumi winked. “Even through those fights, you supported each other. You kept pushing forward, no matter how overwhelming the odds. That kind of teamwork? That kind of bond? It’s rare. And it’s *special*.”

Mami and Kyoko turned to each other.

Their eyes met.

And for a moment, the world around them faded.

They saw not just a teammate—but someone who had stood beside them through every trial. Someone who had fought, cried, laughed, and endured. Someone who *understood*.

Love—quiet, unspoken—flowed between them.

Kasumi leaned toward Lunaria, whispering loudly, “*Oooohhh*, look at them.”

Lunaria chuckled, her eyes twinkling.

Mami and Kyoko blinked, suddenly aware of the silence.

They were still staring.

Still holding the moment.

They both blushed and quickly pulled back.

“W-We weren’t—” Mami stammered.

“It’s not like that!” Kyoko added, flustered.

Kasumi burst out laughing, then leaned in with a mischievous smile. “Oh, don’t worry... Pictures of both of you have been taken throughout this whole training. I think you’d *love* some of them...”

Kyoko gasped, eyes wide. “Please tell me you’re joking. If not, I don’t think I can live a few of those moments down...”

Mami turned to her with a sly grin. “Ah, so you *finally* understand how I felt when you kept all those embarrassing pictures of me at the amusement parks. Guess our Connect will be stronger than ever now~”

Lunaria laughed softly, and soon Mami and Kyoko joined in.

The mist around them shimmered brighter, responding to their joy.

The bond was growing.

And the realm was listening.

Lunaria smiled, her voice soft with anticipation. “Now, you’ll witness a projection of a past event—just as Aurellia promised. But this one is special. You won’t just *see* it... you’ll be *part* of it.”

Kasumi gave a thumbs-up, her grin wide. “You’re in for a treat. Have fun—and I’m curious what you both will get out of it.”

Before Mami or Kyoko could ask what she meant by “*part of the event itself*,” a brilliant light enveloped them.

They gasped, shielding their eyes.

The warmth of the spiritual realm vanished.

And when they opened their eyes—

They were standing at the rear of a battlefield.

The ground trembled with magic. The sky was fractured with streaks of red and violet lightning. Explosions echoed in the distance. The air was thick with tension, dread, and power.

Mami's breath caught. This is... the mural.

Kyoko focused on the scene unfolding before them. *The battle. Six girls against six witches.*

Their bodies moved—but not by their own will. It was as if their consciousness had been placed inside the roles of two girls from the past. They couldn't look down at themselves, couldn't turn their heads, couldn't even nod. Their limbs responded to some unseen rhythm, acting out a memory etched into history.

But their minds were awake.

And they could speak.

"This is extremely cool," Mami's voice echoed in Kyoko's mind, tinged with awe.

Kyoko grinned internally. *"Yeah. Looks like we're playing the role of the two girls without soul gems in the mural. Observers, just like we thought."*

They watched as the battle raged ahead, their borrowed bodies standing at the rear—still, calm, and tethered by glowing threads to the heart of the formation.

The memory was alive.

And they were inside it.

In front of them stood a girl unlike any they had seen before.

She was tall, graceful, and radiant—her outfit a flowing ensemble of silver and deep blue, embroidered with constellations that shimmered with every movement. Her long hair cascaded down her back in waves of deep violet, streaked with luminous strands of pale gold, like moonlight woven into twilight. From her back extended five glowing magical threads—two reaching behind to Mami and Kyoko, and three stretching forward to the girls in the vanguard.

Her presence was commanding, yet serene. She didn't shout orders or gesture wildly. She simply *existed*—and the battlefield moved in harmony with her.

Mami's voice echoed in Kyoko's mind. *"She must be one of the girls from the mural... but she wasn't at the arena when Lunaria asked for their thoughts before our second trial."*

Kyoko responded, thoughtful. *“Yeah. And the two girls without soul gems—the ones we’re playing—they weren’t there either. Weird, right?”*

Mami agreed. *“Very. I wonder why they weren’t invited. Or... maybe they couldn’t come.”*

Kyoko’s tone darkened slightly. *“Or maybe they didn’t want to.”*

They watched as the threads pulsed with energy, linking the six girls into a single rhythm.

Mami and Kyoko watched the battle unfold, their borrowed bodies still and observant at the rear.

But inside, they were smiling.

“Those three...” Mami’s voice echoed in Kyoko’s mind, warm with recognition.

“Yeah,” Kyoko replied. *“Elira, Sylvette, and Mirielle. The special guests from the arena.”*

They remembered Lunaria asking each of them for their thoughts before the second trial. And now, seeing them in action, it all made sense.

Elira Mizunagi stood to the left, her eyes glowing with telepathic focus. Objects around her—broken weapons, shattered stone, even fragments of witch familiars—lifted into the air and spun like satellites. She hurled them with precision, forming barriers mid-air to shield her allies and launching surprise attacks from impossible angles. She was resourceful, relentless, and always calculating.

Mami chuckled internally. *“She said she thought we’d fail... but that our fight would be more interesting if we learned Connect during it.”*

Kyoko smirked. *“Guess we proved her wrong. Sort of.”*

Sylvette Prothea was a blur of motion—her battle chimera form shifting seamlessly between predator and protector. She ran on all fours, leapt like a panther, glided like a hawk, and twisted mid-air like a serpent. Her strikes were wild but deliberate, her dodges instinctive. She danced through the witches’ attacks, always one step ahead.

Kyoko grinned. *“Sylvette said people figure things out when they’re dangling over metaphorical lava.”*

Mami replied, amused. *“She wasn’t wrong.”*

Mirielle Calden stood at the center, her hands glowing with raw power. The ground beneath the witches shimmered and warped—not by rising or falling, but by shifting its very nature. Solid stone became slick sheets of freezing ice. Hardened earth softened into deep, crumbling sand. Scorched terrain cooled into steaming mist. She altered the battlefield not by reshaping it, but by rewriting its properties—heat, texture, density, even color.

When Catastrophia unleashed a blood-red flood, Mirielle raised her arms—and the water turned into soothing steam. Molten stone lost its fury, transforming into soft, harmless clay.

Disaster became beauty.

Chaos became control.

Mami's voice was full of wonder. *"Mirielle had so many ideas about how we could fight after connecting. Crazy, fun abilities."*

Kyoko nodded. *"She's got imagination. And power to match."*

The three girls fought with intensity, each one distinct, each one brilliant.

And Mami and Kyoko watched, awestruck.

They weren't just seeing a battle.

They were seeing possibility.

Even though the three girls in the vanguard fought with everything they had—precision, instinct, and creativity—it wasn't enough.

Six witches.

Six overwhelming forces of chaos.

Thornaria's thorned vines slithered past Elira's telekinetic defenses, weaving through her barriers like serpents. One vine struck her squarely in the side, sending her flying backward. She cried out in pain, her dress torn at the point of impact, deep bloody trails carved into her skin where the thorns scraped mercilessly.

Noctulisse's illusions finally pierced Sylvette's heightened senses. A wave of psychic dread slammed into her, disorienting her mid-leap. She landed hard, clutching her arm as a sickening crack echoed through the battlefield. Her cry was sharp, primal—her chimera form faltering as pain overtook instinct.

Catastrophia unleashed a barrage of elemental devastation. The ground quaked beneath Mirielle's feet, throwing her off balance. Blood-red floods surged toward her, followed by molten stones, a pitch-black tornado, and streaks of purple lightning. She reacted with desperate precision—turning the flood into soothing stream, the molten stone into soft clay, the tornado into a gentle breeze. But the lightning was too fast. It struck her squarely, and she screamed as her body seized, paralyzed by the surge.

One by one, the girls were thrown back.

They landed near the girl with the glowing threads—injured, exhausted, their breaths ragged, their magic flickering.

Mami's voice echoed in Kyoko's mind, quiet and shaken. *"They're incredible... but this is brutal."*

Kyoko responded, her tone grim. *"Yeah. They're strong. But six witches? Even with all that power, it's too much."*

Mami's thoughts drifted. *"Elira's precision, Sylvette's instincts, Mirielle's creativity... they're all fighting with everything they have. But it's not enough alone."*

Kyoko nodded internally. *"And they only got overwhelmed by three witches. The other three didn't even attack. If they do... this fight could get a whole lot worse."*

She paused, her mental voice sharpening. *"They need something more. Something to tip the scale."*

The girl with the threads stumbled forward, her voice trembling. "Are you all okay?!"

Her glowing strands flickered with distress, reaching toward her fallen friends.

Sylvette looked up, one eye shut, her good arm cradling the broken one. "We could be better," she muttered, wincing. "But if this keeps up, we're doomed, **Hoshine Tsunagari**. All of us."

Mami and Kyoko's minds stirred at the name. **Hoshine Tsunagari**... So this was the girl with the threads. The one who hadn't appeared in the arena. The one whose name hadn't been spoken—until now.

Elira's voice rang out, soft and raw. "It hurts... my body and my heart. Why did Kyubey trick us? He never told us magical girls become witches. Why do we have to fight our friends?"

Mirielle chuckled weakly, her limbs still twitching from the lightning's aftermath. "If we go down... at least our last moments are together."

Hoshine knelt beside them, her threads dimming. Her eyes shimmered with tears.

Sylvette, Elira, Mirielle, and **Hoshine** all leaned in, their hands reaching for each other.

Fingers locked.

Magic trembled.

They didn't speak of strategy.

They didn't speak of hope.

Only one vow passed between them: *to stay together until the end.*

Their eyes met—calm, resolute, accepting whatever came next in this nightmare.

And then—

Mami's voice echoed in Kyoko's mind, stunned. *"They're... holding hands."*

Kyoko's thoughts raced. *"They're not trying to activate anything. They're just... saying goodbye."*

Mami's tone deepened. *"But this is it. This is when they discover Connect. Not through training. Not through planning. Just... through love."*

Kyoko nodded internally. *"Accidental. But real. And powerful."*

The threads pulsed.

The air shifted.

And the tide was about to turn.

Chapter 9a – The origin of Connect

The four girls sat together, hands clasped, eyes closed.

Their breaths were slow. Their expressions calm. In the face of despair, they chose unity.

Then, without a word, Mami's and Kyoko's borrowed bodies stepped forward—drawn by something deeper than instinct. Their hands reached out, intertwining with the others.

It was not a conscious choice.

It was a memory.

A moment etched into history.

The two girls without soul gems had done this once before.

And now, through Mami and Kyoko, they did it again.

Six girls.

Six hearts.

They all closed their eyes.

Not in fear.

But in peaceful acceptance.

And then—

The world shifted.

A pulse of magic surged through their joined hands, rippling outward like a wave of starlight. The threads from Hoshine's back flared brilliantly, weaving tighter, glowing brighter.

Each girl gasped softly.

Their minds opened.

Their hearts unfolded.

And they **Connected**.

Six girls.

Six souls.

Each one felt the others—truly *felt* them. Not just their magic, but their essence, the core of who they are. Their **prayers**. Their **sadness**. Their **rage**. Their **hatred**. Their **joy**. Their **pleasure**.

And finally—

Their **wishes**.

Each girl carried the same **wish**: to support each other, and to save their friends who had become witches. Not for glory. Not for revenge. But to protect others from harm. To stop the cycle. To fight for love.

Mami's voice echoed in Kyoko's mind, awestruck. *"This is just like when I connected with nature yesterday. I felt like I was the plants and animals... saw the world through their eyes. It was beautiful."*

She paused, her thoughts deepening. *"But this... this is something else. Seeing the world through other people's hearts. It's incredible. Magical. It's... connection in its purest form."*

Kyoko nodded internally, her own thoughts swirling. *"Yeah. I've never felt anything like this. It's like... we're all one. But still ourselves."*

They looked around.

Mirielle looked down at her hands, her voice soft. "What is this feeling? It's like my magic just... multiplied many times over."

Elira's eyes sparkled like a child receiving a gift too big to hold. "I feel like I could do *anything* now!"

Sylvette grinned, her broken arm still cradled but her spirit reignited. "I think I have some of your powers now. I can't wait to see what I can do!"

Hoshine's threads shimmered, dancing in the air. She looked at each of them, her voice calm and radiant. "I can feel your essences now. I can support you better. We can combine our moves. I'll keep supplying magic and attuning your soul gems. We're synchronized now."

Mami and Kyoko shared a thought, their minds in harmony.

“She’s like Mitama,” Mami said. “A magical girl coordinator.”

“Her threads help others,” Kyoko added. “Magic supply, soul gem tuning, and now... Connect.”

Mami nodded. *“She didn’t do Connect before in the mural scenes. They must’ve just discovered it here. Accidentally. But perfectly.”*

The threads pulsed again.

The battlefield held its breath.

And the tide was ready to turn.

The girls opened their eyes.

The battlefield hadn’t changed.

Six witches still loomed ahead—dark, twisted, and powerful. The fight was far from over.

But something had shifted.

Hoshine’s threads began to glow with a soft, radiant light. They flowed gently around Elira, Sylvette, and Mirielle—like silk spun from starlight.

One thread touched Elira’s side, and the deep wounds from Thornaria’s thorns began to close. The blood faded. The torn fabric mended. Her skin shimmered with restored vitality.

Another thread wrapped around Sylvette’s broken arm, glowing softly as the cracks healed. She flexed her fingers, stunned by the sudden strength returning to her limb.

A third thread coiled around Mirielle, soothing the paralysis left by Catastrophia’s lightning. Her muscles relaxed. Her breath steadied. She could move again.

All three girls gasped, looking down at themselves—fully healed, fully restored.

Hoshine smiled, her voice filled with wonder. “Whatever we did earlier... it gave me new supporting abilities. I can feel it. I can *do* it. I’m excited to try them out.”

Elira turned to the others, her eyes wide and sparkling with childlike curiosity. “What should we call... whatever *that* was?”

The girls fell silent.

They thought.

They felt.

And then, together, they smiled.

“**Connect**,” they said in unison.

Mami and Kyoko smiled gently within their borrowed bodies, their thoughts intertwining.

“So this is it,” Mami whispered. “The **origin of Connect**. This is where it got its name.”

Kyoko nodded. “And it wasn’t born from strategy or power. It came from love. From unity.”

Hoshine turned to the two girls without soul gems—Mami and Kyoko. “You two, fall back. Keep supporting us with **your magical energy**.”

Their bodies responded instantly, leaping back to the rear of the formation.

Mami’s voice echoed in Kyoko’s mind. “So... *they do have magical energy. That light from Kyubey in the mural—it did something to them.*”

Kyoko agreed. “But it’s strange. All the others became magical girls. These two didn’t. Who were they, really?”

Mami pondered. “*Maybe they weren’t historical figures. Maybe they’re symbolic. Representing magical girl pairs who go through this training together.*”

Kyoko nodded. “Like us.”

At the front, Elira stepped forward, her eyes twinkling with fire and excitement—like a child about to have fun with her friends.

Sylvette cracked her knuckles, then slammed one fist into her palm with a playful, animalistic grin. A predator ready to hunt. A warrior eager to test her new edge.

Mirielle placed a hand on her chin, her smile deep and thoughtful. Her imagination raced, overflowing with ideas. She looked like a scientist on the verge of a breakthrough.

Sylvette tilted her head, eyes gleaming. “You girls ready to go crazy out there?”

Elira, Mirielle, and Hoshine all smiled brightly.

“Yes!” they said together. “Let’s go.”

The battlefield trembled.

The witches stirred.

And the true fight was about to begin.

Chapter 9b – Mirielle’s new power

The six witches stirred uneasily.

They sensed something different.

Something dangerous.

Their twisted forms twitched with discomfort, their magic pulsing erratically.

Catastropha was the first to strike—unleashing another barrage of elemental devastation. The same brutal combination that had overwhelmed Mirielle earlier.

She slammed the ground, triggering a violent earthquake. Blood-red floods surged forward. Purple lightning crackled in the sky. A pitch-black tornado spun into existence. Molten stones rained down like meteors.

But this time—

Mirielle stepped forward and smiled.

Not with arrogance.

But with curiosity.

Like a scientist about to test a new theory.

“Let’s see how the elements behave under my command now,” she said softly.

She lifted one leg and stomped.

The earthquake stopped instantly.

The molten stones cooled mid-air, dropping harmlessly as soft clay.

Mami’s voice echoed in Kyoko’s mind, stunned. “*A stomp? That’s all it took?*”

Kyoko replied, equally amazed. “*Kasumi and Lunaria weren’t kidding. Connected magical girls... their powers evolve fast.*”

Mirielle smiled, pleased with the result. “That worked! Let’s continue, shall we?”

She raised her hands, summoning threads—similar to Hoshine’s, but tinted in deep bronze and shimmering with her own elemental signature. They pulsed with energy, reflecting her affinity for matter manipulation.

Hoshine’s eyes widened. “Those are like my threads... but they feel *different*. Mirielle’s style. Her essence. I’m curious to see what they can do!”

Mirielle sent one thread toward the purple lightning.

Her arms moved apart, as if spreading a giant sheet of paper.

The thread transformed into a beautiful metallic sheet—smooth, reflective, and humming with energy.

The lightning struck it.

Instead of exploding, it danced across the surface—conducted harmlessly, redirected with elegance.

Sylvette clucked her tongue. “And now she’s using my shapeshifting abilities. But she’s also changing the *size* of objects. Interesting...”

Mirielle twirled another thread around her head like a lasso and hurled it at the tornado.

It caught.

She pulled.

The tornado unraveled instantly, transforming into a massive gust of wind that surged forward—slamming into the blood-red flood.

The flood twisted, redirected by the wind’s force.

It became a tsunami.

A massive wave, roaring toward Catastrophia.

The witch let out a distorted, demonic cry of surprise.

Her own elemental attacks—nullified, reshaped, and hurled back at her.

Elira clapped her hands together. “She’s using my telekinesis to push back the flood! Let’s go!”

Mami and Kyoko watched in awe.

“She’s using threads like Hoshine,” Mami whispered.

“And reshaping matter like Sylvette,” Kyoko added.

“She even used Elira’s telekinesis to redirect the wind and water.”

“She’s combining all their powers. This is amazing.”

Just as the tsunami was about to crash into Catastrophia, Mirielle raised her hand again.

“I wonder... what would magical purple electricity and a blood-red tsunami look like together?”

She sent the metallic sheet into the wave.

It melted seamlessly into the water, infusing it with electricity.

The result was breathtaking—and terrifying.

The blood-red torrent shimmered with purple sparks, a force of nature reborn. The air filled with the crackle of electric arcs, the rumble of thunder, the roar of wind, and the rush of surging water—all colliding in a symphony of elemental chaos.

The tsunami struck.

Catastrophra screamed—a distorted, guttural cry—as the electric current tore through her, the roaring water crushed her from all sides, and the gale-force winds slammed into her with relentless fury.

Mirielle stepped forward, her palm open.

The electric water shifted—becoming thick, heavy mud.

It hardened around Catastrophra, locking her in place.

The witch roared in desperation, thrashing.

Mirielle clenched her fist. “This is it. Farewell...”

The mud tightened.

And crushed her.

Silence fell.

Mami and Kyoko were speechless.

Mirielle, who had been overwhelmed just moments ago, had destroyed Catastrophra with ease.

“This is Connect,” Mami whispered. “This is what it can do.”

Kyoko nodded. “One girl, using the strengths of all. That was beautiful.”

They turned their gaze forward.

Elira and Sylvette were stepping up.

And the battlefield was far from done.

Elira, Sylvette, and Hoshine stood in awe.

Mirielle’s display had been nothing short of breathtaking. The sheer variety, the elegance, the raw power—it was unlike anything they had ever seen. But more than that, they saw themselves in her moves. A pulse of Elira’s precision, a flicker of Sylvette’s instinct, a thread of Hoshine’s support. Mirielle had woven their essence into her own magic.

Mirielle turned to them with a warm smile. “So... how’d I do?”

Hoshine clasped her hands together, her eyes shimmering. “If you can do *that*, there’s still hope in this fight.”

Sylvette clapped her hands, her grin wild. “That was *awesome*! My bestial blood is boiling!”

Elira bounced up and down, her energy overflowing. “That was sooo cool!”

Mirielle laughed, her heart light. “Honestly? That was *fun*. I never imagined fighting six witches could feel like this.”

The others nodded, their spirits lifted. This wasn’t just survival anymore. It was a spectacle. A moment that would be remembered.

Mami and Kyoko smiled internally, their thoughts intertwining.

“This echoes Kasumi’s spirit,” Mami said. “And what she and Lunaria taught us. Joy in hard moments. Fun in the face of fear.”

Kyoko nodded. *“Joy nourishes the soul. It breeds creativity.”*

Mami’s voice softened. *“My soul gem is so bright, Kyoko. You noticed it when I was first summoned. It’s because I’m not just at peace—I’m starting to enjoy life again.”*

Kyoko chuckled. *“One day, I’ll be the one with the brighter soul gem. I’ll be having more fun than you.”*

Mami laughed from the heart. *“Challenge accepted, partner.”*

They both felt it—the echo of the arena in the realm. A place where magical girls trained, fought, and played. Where battles were watched and rewatched. Where joy and growth intertwined.

Sylvette stretched, her movements fluid and primal—like a predator waking from slumber. She hopped around, loosening her limbs, her chimera form flickering with anticipation.

She stepped forward, eyes locked on **Noctulisse**—the witch of illusions. The one who had broken her arm earlier.

This time, Sylvette would be the hunter.

“Mind if I go next?” she asked, her voice playful, her smile sharp.

The girls grinned.

“Go for it,” Elira said.

“Show us what you’ve got,” Hoshine added.

Mirielle raised her hand for a high-five. Sylvette slapped it with a grin, then turned toward the battlefield.

The air shifted.

The hunt was on.

Chapter 9c – Sylvette’s new power

Noctulisse sensed it.

Sylvette’s gaze was locked on her—not with fear, but with hunger.

Like prey.

Sylvette licked her lips, slow and deliberate, like a feline predator ready to pounce. Her chimera form shimmered with anticipation, muscles coiled, instincts sharpened.

Noctulisse let out a guttural roar.

The battlefield warped.

Illusions spread like wildfire.

Copies of Noctulisse—some towering, some minuscule—floated around the girls, their distorted faces twisted in mockery. They laughed, high-pitched and broken, echoing through the air like shattered glass.

Her witch minions and familiars appeared next, conjured from shadow and malice, flying toward Sylvette with claws bared and teeth gnashing.

And then—

The cruelest illusion of all.

Three figures emerged from the haze.

A woman.

A man.

A young boy.

Mami and Kyoko recognized them instantly. The spirits who had stood beside Aurellia. The spectators who had sat with Sylvette in the flower pod during the arena trial.

Her family.

But twisted.

Their eyes burned with hatred.

Their mouths curled into snarls.

“You hid the truth from us,” they hissed in demonic voices. “You got us killed. And now we’ll drag you to **hell** with us.”

Sylvette stared at them.

Calm.

Unshaken.

She sighed and face-palmed. “Wow. So Noctulisse is bringing my family into this now? That’s... pretty low.”

She stepped forward, her chimera form flickering with golden light.

She looked at the illusions of her mother, father, and younger brother—and smiled.

“I know that’s not how you felt,” she said softly. “I heard your voices before you died. You told me to keep living. To stay healthy. To support my friends. And most importantly...”

Her voice grew stronger.

“You told me you still loved me. After everything.”

The illusions snarled louder, their forms flickering.

Sylvette’s eyes narrowed.

“That illusion is useless against me.”

Sylvette dropped to all fours.

Her chimera form shimmered, muscles rippling beneath her skin. She looked at the illusion of her family with a calm, almost amused smile.

“Let’s get rid of the elephant in the room, shall we?”

Then she dashed forward.

Fast.

So fast that every illusion around her let out a startled yelp.

The shadows scrambled.

Her family’s twisted forms conjured dark shadow rocks and flaming torches, their demonic voices dripping with hatred.

“Let’s see how *you* like being stoned and burned alive!”

They hurled the projectiles at her.

Sylvette grinned wide, her tail whipping around like a serpent. She swiped the rocks and torches mid-air, sending them flying in all directions.

“Let’s test this out,” she said, eyes gleaming.

She focused—and the objects hovered.

Then, with a flick of her mind, she sent them flying toward the illusions of witch minions and familiars.

The impact was explosive.

Mini bursts of light and shadow erupted as the illusions screeched and scattered.

Her family stared at her, stunned. “What did you just do?!”

Then their rage returned. “Why don’t you just *submit* and *die* already?!”

Sylvette sighed.

She moved again—fluid, graceful, primal. Her body shifted between forms: feline, avian, serpentine. She dodged every attack with ease, her motions a dance of instinct and precision.

She closed the distance.

Right next to them.

They looked at her, wide-eyed.

Sylvette’s voice was low, steady. “You can go back to ***hell*** where you belong... fakers.”

She raised her claws.

And with one powerful swipe, she tore through the illusion.

The false family let out a final, distorted scream.

And faded.

Sylvette darted across the battlefield, her chimera form shifting fluidly—feline grace, avian speed, serpentine precision. She struck illusion after illusion of Noctulisse, each one vanishing in a puff of shadow, only to be replaced by another.

Her eyes burned with passion.

Her smile was wild.

She was a predator on the high of a hunt.

Mami and Kyoko watched in awe.

“Her movements are incredible,” Mami whispered. *“She’s faster, sharper... more instinctive.”*

Kyoko nodded. *“But why is she only hitting illusions? Her senses should be able to find the real Noctulisse by now.”*

“Did her bestial instincts take over?” Mami wondered. *“Is she just chasing the thrill?”*

Noctulisse seemed to share their thoughts.

Her illusions laughed—distorted, mocking, confident.

The unease she'd felt earlier had vanished.

She was no longer prey.

She was the hunter.

Or so she thought.

Sylvette paused.

She landed gracefully, dusting off her fur with a flick of her paw.

She smiled.

"It's finally ready," she said.

Mami and Kyoko exchanged thoughts. "*Ready? What's ready?*"

Sylvette looked around at the countless Noctulisse illusions.

"Let me teach you a rule of nature," she said, her voice calm and sharp. "Some predators toy with their prey. Some do it to wear them down. Others... do it to make them feel safe."

She grinned. "I'm the latter."

She raised her claws.

Shadow magic swirled around them—dense, potent, charged with illusion energy.

Mami and Kyoko gasped.

"*She's been absorbing illusion magic this whole time,*" Mami said.

"*She's going to use it,*" Kyoko added. "*To create something new.*"

Sylvette clapped her claws together.

Then slammed one paw into the ground.

"Let's go," she said. "Illusion manipulation!"

The battlefield warped.

But this time—it was Sylvette's illusion.

A lush jungle erupted from the shadows, vines and trees overtaking Noctulisse's dark realm. The air filled with the cries of beasts—lions, wolves, hawks, serpents. They charged forward, tearing through Noctulisse's witch familiars and minions.

And beside Sylvette—

Three figures.

Her family.

Uncorrupted.

Radiant.

Each bore animalistic features—claws, tails, wings—reflections of Sylvette’s chimera soul.

Mami and Kyoko smiled internally.

“That’s her family,” Mami whispered. “The way she remembers them.”

“The way they truly were,” Kyoko added.

Sylvette looked at them with love. “If you want to use my family in an illusion... this is how you do it.”

They nodded.

And charged forward with the beasts.

The clash was swift and brutal.

Noctulisse’s illusions shattered.

Then—

A sound like breaking glass echoed through the realm.

The illusion space fractured.

Shards of shadow fell like snowflakes, vanishing as they touched the ground.

Sylvette stood tall.

Ahead of her, the real Noctulisse trembled—eyes wide, body backing away in fear.

Mami and Kyoko were stunned.

“She used her shapeshifting,” Mami said. “Mirielle’s matter manipulation. Hoshine’s support.”

“She created illusions,” Kyoko added. “Real ones. Ones that fought.”

They both smiled.

“The possibilities of Connect... are endless.”

Noctulisse turned to flee.

Her shadowy form twisted and recoiled, illusions scattering like smoke.

Sylvette sighed, her voice tinged with disappointment. “Where was that confidence from earlier? It’s no fun to hunt prey that gives up like that.”

She spread her wings wide, feathers shimmering with magical energy.

“Play time is over.”

With a powerful flap, a barrage of feathers shot forward—sleek, sharp, and glowing. They tore through the air and impaled Noctulisse mid-flight.

The witch cried out in pain, her illusions faltering.

Sylvette swept her wings in a graceful arc toward herself.

The feathers responded.

They dragged Noctulisse through the air, pulling her closer with relentless force.

Noctulisse screamed, summoning shadows to anchor herself—grabbing at the ground, the walls, anything to stop her descent.

Sylvette raised both arms, palms open to the sky.

From the surfaces Noctulisse tried to cling to, threads erupted—similar in form to Hoshine’s, yet unmistakably Sylvette’s. They pulsed with wild, primal magic. Some unfurled like gnarled tree branches, others curled like supple flower stems, and still others lashed out like thick jungle vines.

Each thread moved with instinctive precision, intercepting the shadows and severing every grip Noctulisse tried to hold.

Noctulisse was helpless.

She hovered before Sylvette, trembling.

Eyes wide.

Like prey about to be devoured.

Sylvette smiled. “This is goodbye.”

She clapped her claws.

The feathers impaling Noctulisse expanded—growing massive, piercing through her entire form.

Noctulisse’s body distorted, bloated with needle-like feathers.

She let out one final, broken cry.

And went limp.

Mami and Kyoko watched in stunned silence.

“Incredible,” Mami whispered. “*She showed complete dominance.*”

“*And the illusion part...*” Kyoko added. “*That was a spectacle... Beautiful...*”

Sylvette turned to the others and gave a thumbs up.

All the girls returned it with bright smiles.

Hoshine clasped her hands, her voice soft. “That fight was... beautiful. I never thought I’d use that word to describe a battle. But those illusions... they were moving.”

Elira nodded enthusiastically, her head bobbing like a child. “That jungle was so pretty! It felt just like the one around our village. Before all the bad things happened.”

Mirielle placed a hand to her lips, thoughtful. “Illusion control... very interesting. I *have* to test that out later.”

The girls stood together, their spirits lifted.

Two witches down.

Four to go.

Chapter 9d – Elira’s new power

Elira bounced on her heels, her eyes sparkling with excitement.

She beamed like a child whose turn had finally come after waiting patiently in a long line—brimming with joy, barely able to contain herself.

“My turn now!” she chirped brightly. “The best for last!”

The other girls chuckled, their hearts warmed by her innocent, unfiltered enthusiasm.

Mami and Kyoko shared a laugh internally, remembering how blunt Elira had been during their second trial—no hesitation, no filter. “*I think they’re gonna fail,*” she had said back then, with the pure honesty only a child could wield.

Sylvette grinned and gave Elira a playful wink. “Good luck, Elira. Just don’t go *too* crazy, okay?”

Elira giggled and nodded.

Sylvette leapt back, landing gracefully beside the others.

Elira turned her gaze toward **Thornaria**—the witch who had struck her earlier with a brutal lash of thorned vines.

Her expression shifted.

Still smiling, but now with purpose.

“Thornaria’s a bad plant monster,” she said, her voice soft but firm. “Nothing like the beautiful flowers back home.”

She closed her eyes for a moment, letting the memories bloom.

The jungle.

The scent of blossoms.

The flower crowns she used to weave—delicate loops of color and fragrance, gifts for her friends and family.

And lastly, the memory of her friend.

The one who could summon petals with a whisper, coax vines to dance, and create entire gardens with a flick of her hand.

The friend who had become **Thornaria**.

She opened her eyes.

They gleamed with warmth.

And fire.

“Let’s change that,” she whispered.

Thornaria roared, her twisted form writhing with fury.

She had seen two witches fall—easily, humiliatingly.

This time, she would not be next.

Thorned vines shot out toward Elira, dripping with a viscous purple liquid that hissed as it touched the ground. Clouds of sickly green spores billowed outward, thick and choking.

Mami and Kyoko watched with sharp focus.

“Poison,” they thought in unison.

Thornaria was taking this fight seriously.

Elira pinched her nose with one hand, her cheeks puffed out in protest. “That weird green cloud thingy smells *bad!*” she said, her voice comically muffled.

“I don’t wanna smell it!”

Still holding her nose, she raised her free hand and pointed forward.

Rocks, leaves, branches—everything around her began to stir.

They flew toward the incoming vines.

Thornaria laughed, a chilling sound.

She had seen this before.

She twisted her vines like serpents, slithering around the objects with ease—just like last time, when she had struck Elira down.

But Elira grinned mischievously.

She let out a child-like battle cry—nasal and funny, like a kid pretending to be a warrior.

And then—

The objects changed.

The **rocks** began to glow—red, orange, yellow, green, blue, violet. The colors transitioned fluidly, like a living rainbow. Light, liquid, and gas emanated from them, swirling in radiant harmony.

The rocks hovered near the vines.

The vines burned.

The purple fluid evaporated instantly.

Then the rocks exploded—mini bursts of color and heat, obliterating the vines nearby.

The **leaves** multiplied, joining together in a radiant sun-like pattern. Their colors shifted—winter’s frost, spring’s bloom, summer’s blaze, autumn’s gold. They spun rapidly, slicing through the poisonous vines with ease. The wind they generated blew the toxic fumes away from the girls, clearing the air.

The **tree branches** sprang to life.

They grew larger, sprouting new limbs, pulsing with vitality. When they touched the vines, they glowed—soft, warm, magical.

The vines didn’t burn.

They changed.

They integrated.

The branches absorbed them, transforming them into harmless extensions of the tree.

Symbiosis.

Mami and Kyoko gasped internally.

“She’s manipulating nature,” Mami whispered. “Visible light. Seasonal cycles. Symbiosis.”

“It’s like she’s re-creating the world,” Kyoko added. *“Through the eyes of a child.”*

Elira stood in the center of it all, her nose still pinched, her eyes gleaming.

She wasn’t just fighting.

She was *playing*.

Exploring.

Creating.

And the battlefield had become her canvas.

Elira smiled, her nose still pinched between her fingers.

Her voice came out muffled and playful. “Time to get rid of that stinky smell!”

She knelt down like a child ready to play in a grassy field, placing her free hand gently onto the earth.

Then she let out another childlike battle cry—nasal, silly, and full of joy.

The rainbow rocks, the sun-patterned leaves of every season, and the symbiotic tree branches all fell to the ground in unison.

Mami and Kyoko watched, curious.

“What’s she doing?” Mami wondered.

“Is she really going to clean the poison?” Kyoko asked.

As the objects touched the soil, they began to change.

They took root.

They bloomed.

From each one sprouted flowers—dozens, hundreds—of every color, shape, and size. Petals shimmered like gemstones. Stems curled like ribbons. Leaves danced in the breeze.

Each flower released a soft, rosy cloud.

The cloud spread gently, overtaking the sickly green spores and neutralizing them completely.

Then it touched the purple poison.

The fluid shimmered, transformed into clean, clear water that soaked into the earth—nourishing the new garden.

Elira released her nose and took a deep breath.

Her eyes closed.

She exhaled slowly, happily.

“This is the plant smell I love,” she whispered. “The smell of home...”

Behind her, the other girls closed their eyes too.

They inhaled.

They exhaled.

And they smiled—remembering the scent of peace, of safety, of life before everything went wrong.

Elira opened her eyes and looked at Thornaria.

Her gaze was soft, nostalgic.

“Do you remember this?” she asked gently. “This is what you used to do. As a magical girl. Can we live like that again? Can we play together again?”

Thornaria growled.

Her twisted form writhed in fury.

She had just watched her poison be turned into perfume—her vines into flowers—by a small child.

Whether she didn’t understand Elira’s words or simply refused to hear them, it didn’t matter.

She rejected them completely.

Elira looked down, sadness in her eyes.

She bent and brushed her fingers across one of the flowers she had created.

“That’s too bad,” she said softly. “Looks like my old friend is gone. All that’s left is a witch. A shell.”

She stood.

Her expression shifted.

Gentle.

Resolute.

“If we can’t go back to the way things were... then this is goodbye.”

She paused.

“But at least I tried.”

Thornaria roared, her fury blooming into violence.

From the grassy field beneath Elira, poisonous thorned vines erupted—twisting, writhing, encircling her like a carnivorous plant preparing to devour its prey.

Mami and Kyoko gasped internally.

“She can summon plants from anywhere there’s nature?” Mami thought.

“And the ground beneath Elira is fair game...” Kyoko added. *“That’s terrifying.”*

The vines hissed and spat.

Sickly green fumes poured out, thick and choking.

Bullets of purple poison fluid shot toward Elira, followed by lashing vines that cracked like whips.

The green fog grew denser.

Elira vanished from sight.

Her voice rang out—coughing, strained, as if in pain.

The hissing sound of poison echoed through the field.

Mami and Kyoko’s hearts raced.

“Is she okay?” Mami whispered.

Their eyes turned toward the other girls.

But none of them moved.

They stood calmly, smiling.

No panic.

No fear.

Just trust.

Complete trust in Elira.

Then—

A few more heavy coughs.

And Elira’s voice rang out, playful and mischievous.

“Just kidding!”

The green fumes shimmered.

They transformed into rosy pink perfume, soft and fragrant.

Elira reappeared—smiling brightly, her body covered in purple poison fluid. Steam hissed from her skin where the fluid touched, and thorned vines wrapped tightly around her.

Mami and Kyoko stared in disbelief.

“How is she okay?” Kyoko asked.

Elira looked at Thornaria, her eyes filled with nostalgia.

“That’s a cool ability,” she said gently. “Summoning plants around someone... it reminds me of my friend. Before she became you.”

She smiled softly.

“She used to surprise us with flowers and trees—just out of nowhere. Sometimes she’d make a vine trip one of us as a joke. It was fun. It was her way of playing.”

Elira’s voice grew quiet.

“Play time is over.”

She let out another childlike battle cry—nasal, silly, and full of heart.

The purple fluid around her shimmered.

It turned rosy pink—beautiful, sparkling.

The vines touching it hissed and burned, melting away.

Where they fell, flowers bloomed—dozens of them, vibrant and alive.

Elira stood untouched.

Thornaria reeled in shock.

Her assault had done nothing.

Elira looked at her, eyes soft.

“Goodbye,” she said.

Like a child saying farewell to a friend moving far away.

She placed both hands on the ground.

Her final battle cry rang out—tinged with sadness and memory.

From the earth, Elira’s own vines sprouted.

They surrounded Thornaria, releasing rosy pink clouds of perfume and spraying a mist of clear, sparkling water and rosy pink fluid.

Thornaria screeched—fearful, surprised.

Mami and Kyoko watched in awe.

“She’s copying Thornaria’s moves,” Mami whispered.

“Just like a child learning from others,” Kyoko added. *“Exploring the world through imitation.”*

The rosy clouds, water, and fluid enveloped Thornaria.

She let out one final scream.

And wilted.

From her remains, flowers bloomed—beautiful, radiant.

A grave.

A tribute.

Elira walked up to it.

She knelt, gently patting the flowers and the earth.

“I hope you can rest in peace now,” she whispered.

Mami and Kyoko felt their hearts warm.

Elira had fought like a child—squeezing her nose, mimicking nature and others, letting out silly battle cries.

But she had also loved like a child.

She had reached out.

She had remembered.

She had mourned.

In a world where magical girls were often broken, jaded, and hollowed by despair, Elira had retained something precious.

Wonder.

Empathy.

And the courage to use them.

Chapter 9e – The origin of: Welcome to Amplifying Negative Emotions — EXTREMELY HARD MODE — Unforgiving Trial by Fire — Merciless Boss Battle — Now with 50% More Emotional Destruction~!

Elira ran toward the others, her arms wide, her smile radiant.

“I did it!” she cheered.

The girls laughed, surrounding her with pats on the head, high-fives, and warm congratulations.

Even the bodies Mami and Kyoko inhabited moved on instinct—running forward to give Elira fist bumps, as if the joy of connection had reached even deeper than thought.

They turned together, facing the battlefield.

Three witches remained.

But they were no longer confident.

They stared at the girls with dread, slowly backing away.

Then—

A voice.

Ominous.

Slithering.

“So much negativity here... yes, yes... good.”

Everyone froze.

Even the witches.

The air darkened.

Shadows crept in from every direction, thickening, pressing down like a suffocating blanket.

The pressure grew.

Mami’s breath caught.

She reached out telepathically. *“Kyoko... this feeling... is it the shadow monster from the arena?”*

Kyoko’s eyes narrowed. *“It’s familiar. Too familiar. I’ve felt it before. I fought it. Watched others try. But... maybe it’s just a coincidence?”*

They both hesitated.

The shadows consumed the battlefield.

The sky dimmed until it looked exactly like the arena during the infamous trial—when Mami, Kasumi, and Lunaria had faced the monster.

The voice returned.

Louder.

Heavier.

“Six witches... together... in one place. Unheard of. I can finally manifest.”

The shadows surged.

They enveloped the three remaining witches.

Screams rang out—confused, terrified, echoing with a rawness that pierced the air.

Then the shadows reached the remains of the three defeated witches.

The battlefield trembled.

The pressure and negativity intensified.

The girls watched in horror.

Elira clutched Sylvette’s arm, her earlier joy replaced by childlike fear. “What’s happening?” she whispered.

Sylvette’s predator instincts flared. Her body tensed, tail flicking anxiously. “Something ancient,” she muttered. “Something wrong.”

Hoshine stepped forward, her threads twitching involuntarily. “The magic here... it’s being rewritten,” she said, voice laced with dread. “This isn’t just fusion. It’s corruption.”

Mirielle narrowed her eyes, her analytical mind racing. “The elemental balance is collapsing. This thing... it’s feeding on the witches’ essence.”

Mami and Kyoko exchanged thoughts again, now with urgency.

“Kyoko,” Mami said, *“I’m sure now. This isn’t coincidence. This is the shadow monster. The one from the arena.”*

Kyoko’s response was instant. *“You’re right. This pressure, the way the shadows behave—it’s the same nightmare. The same entity.”*

“It’s manifesting because of the six witches,” Mami continued. *“Their combined negativity... it’s the perfect catalyst.”*

Kyoko's tone sharpened. *"A monster born from the essences of multiple witches... No wonder it's so powerful. So full of despair."*

The shadows thickened.

From above, a colossal form descended.

A grotesque fusion of all six witches.

Its face was a swirling mass of eyes and mouths, constantly shifting, never settling.

The girls staggered back.

Elira whimpered, clutching her flower crown. "It's scary..."

Sylvette growled, shielding Elira instinctively. "Stay behind me."

Hoshine's threads flared defensively, forming a protective weave around the group.

Mirielle's hands glowed, ready to manipulate matter—but even she hesitated.

The pressure was suffocating.

The witches' screams began to merge—distorted, layered, until they sounded like one entity.

Their features fused.

Their magic twisted.

And then—

The form stabilized.

Before them stood the shadow monster.

The girls' knees buckled.

Bodies shook uncontrollably.

Their eyes widened in horror.

Mami and Kyoko stared.

"And there it is," Mami said. "Kasumi's pride and joy. 'Welcome to Amplifying Negative Emotions — EXTREMELY HARD MODE — Unforgiving Trial by Fire — Merciless Boss Battle — Now with 50% More Emotional Destruction~!'"

Kyoko laughed, despite the tension. *"Sounds about right. Beginner for Lunaria and Kasumi means impossible mode."*

Mami chuckled. *“Kasumi did say she and Lunaria believe in the deep-end method. Start with the hardest challenge so you know what true mastery looks like. Afterwards, the actual beginner training would begin.”*

She paused, her gaze steady.

“As intense as it is... their teaching has made me grow. I’ve seen levels of strength I never thought possible. Levels I want to reach one day.”

Kyoko nodded, her tone teasing. *“I’ve grown too. Every time they visit me and the other essences in the arena, I learn more. That said, I refuse to fall behind you, Mami.”*

“Right back at you, partner!”

They both shared a laugh, deep from the heart.

“This battle, this training,” Kyoko said, “absolutely amazing. We’re seeing the origins of so much. Connect. The shadow monster. The story of magical girls—beautiful and tragic.”

Mami agreed. *“Let’s keep watching. Let’s see what the shadow monster does.”*

The shadow monster stood before them.

A grotesque fusion of six witches, its form pulsing with negativity. Its face—a swirling mass of eyes and mouths—shifted constantly, never settling, never still.

The battlefield was silent.

The air was thick with dread.

Elira clung to Sylvette’s side, her flower crown trembling in her hands. *“It’s like a nightmare that doesn’t wake up...”*

Sylvette crouched low, her claws extended, tail lashing. *“This thing... it’s not alive. It’s hunger. It’s hatred.”*

Hoshine’s threads hovered protectively, her eyes scanning the monster’s form. *“It’s rewriting magical patterns. I can’t trace its origin. It’s like it’s made of everything and nothing.”*

Mirielle’s gaze was sharp, her mind racing. *“It’s a paradox. A fusion of chaos. It shouldn’t exist—but it does.”*

The girls stood together, shaken but united.

Sylvette stepped forward, her claws flexed, her tail rigid.

Her voice was steady—but it came at a cost.

Every instinct in her body screamed to flee, to vanish into the shadows, to survive.

But she resisted.

She stood tall, fighting against the primal urge to run.

“What are you?” she demanded. “What are you doing here? What did you do to the six witches?”

The shadow monster responded with laughter.

Distorted.

Powerful.

Confident.

It echoed across the battlefield, vibrating through the ground, through the girls’ bones, through the very air.

Then it spoke.

Its voice was layered—many voices speaking in eerie harmony—but still clear, unmistakable.

And beneath those voices was something deeper.

Something ancient.

Something that had watched despair evolve for centuries.

****“I am the echo of despair.**

The residue of every broken promise.

I am what remains when hope is devoured.

Born not of flesh, but of feeling—

Of sadness, rage, and hatred.

Here, six witches fell.

But their hatred rose.

Their grief congealed.

Their magic twisted.

I did not just consume them.

They became me.

Just one chapter in my endless history.

I am the culmination of suffering.

The final form of fury.

**The lingering hatred in all things.
The shadow that grows when light is lost.
You call yourselves connected.
But I am what connects all pain.
And I am *hungry*.”****

The girls stood frozen.
The ground beneath them pulsed with shadow.
Mami and Kyoko felt it too—deep in their souls.
“*That voice,*” Mami whispered. “*It’s not just speaking. It’s invading.*”
Kyoko nodded. “*It’s feeding on emotion. On memory. It’s not just a monster—it’s a mirror.*”
The shadow monster loomed.
And the final battle was about to begin.

The shadow monster laughed again.
Not with joy.
But with amusement.
As if watching powerless worms squirm beneath its gaze.
It tilted its head, eyes and mouths shifting in grotesque rhythm.
“Congratulations,” it said, voice layered with many tones—some mocking, some oddly sincere.
“You’ve done it. What did you call it again... ah, yes. *Connect.*”
It gave a slow, theatrical bow.
Mocking.
But not without a trace of genuine praise.
“No other magical girl has done what you did. To synchronize your powers... your very selves.
Impressive. Truly impressive. You have my genuine praise.”
The girls exchanged glances—flattered, yes, but still on high alert.
The monster straightened, its form rippling with shadow.

“But as with all things,” it continued, “**whether they are good or bad depends entirely on what you do with them.**”

Mami’s eyes widened.

Flashbacks surged through her mind—lessons from Lunaria and Kasumi.

Negativity isn’t always evil, Lunaria had said. It’s dangerous, yes. But if you can harness it... if you can control it... it can amplify your strength. It can protect others.

Kyoko nodded, her thoughts syncing with Mami’s. “*I guess even enigmatic arcane monsters can share the same philosophy as people.*”

Mami chuckled softly. “*The universe is full of mysteries.*”

The girls tightened their stances.

Ready to strike.

Sylvette, sweat dripping down her face, body trembling, stepped forward.

“What are you talking about?” she demanded. “What does ‘good or bad’ have to do with Connect?”

The monster’s shadow mouth widened into a grin.

A cruel, evil smile.

It sent chills down every spine.

“I already told you,” it said.

Then it repeated the final stanza of its introduction.

Slower.

Emphasized.

**“You call yourselves connected.
But I am what connects all pain.
And I am hungry.”**

Suddenly—

A sharp, heavy feeling surged through the girls.

Elira, Sylvette, Hoshine, Mirielle looked down at their soul gems.

Their mouths dropped.

The gems were darkening—corrupted with negativity at an alarming speed.

Elira clutched her chest. “Why does my heart feel heavy? Why does my soul hurt? I’m scared...”

Sylvette staggered, her limbs sluggish. Her instincts—once sharp—were now clouded by despair. Mirielle’s eyes glazed, her mind fracturing under the weight of emotion. “My thoughts... they’re slipping...”

Hoshine gasped, her threads unraveling. “I can’t hold the weave... I can’t attune your gems...”

She turned to the two girls without soul gems—the ones whose bodies now carried the consciousness of Mami and Kyoko.

“How are you two feeling?” she asked, desperate.

The girls’ bodies turned slowly, their expressions grim.

But Mami and Kyoko weren’t in control.

They were merely passengers—watching through borrowed eyes, unable to move on their own, only able to communicate telepathically.

And yet, the girls spoke.

Automatically.

As if repeating a script written long ago.

“We feel it too,” Mami’s host body said, her voice hollow, echoing the words spoken in the past.

“Heaviness. Dread. Negativity. Even without soul gems.”

Kyoko’s host followed suit, her gaze locked on the shadow monster. “What are you doing to us, to them?” she asked—not Kyoko’s own voice, but a memory reenacted.

The shadow monster leaned closer.

Its form loomed, vast and suffocating.

Its voice deepened, vibrating through the ground.

“Good question,” it said, almost amused. “I think you can start to guess the answer.”

It crouched lower, eyes swirling like a vortex of despair.

“I am using **Connect**... to synchronize with your soul gems. To corrupt them. With pain. With negativity.”

The girls’ eyes went wide.

Stunned.

Connect—the very power that had saved them—was now being used against them.

Mirielle, barely holding on, whispered, “Why? What’s your goal?”

The monster sighed.

“How many times must I repeat myself?”

It looked directly at her.

And spoke.

Slowly.

Ominously.

“And I am hungry.”

The girls gasped.

And collapsed to their knees.

The puzzle pieces clicked into place.

Mami and Kyoko shared their thoughts, their minds racing.

“It corrupts soul gems,” Mami said. “Turns magical girls into witches.”

“Then absorbs them,” Kyoko added. “Makes them part of itself.”

“Just one chapter in its endless history,” Mami whispered. “It’s done this before. Many times.”

“It’s not just a monster,” Kyoko said. “It’s a culmination. Of sadness. Of rage. Of hatred.”

Then Mami’s mind flashed back to her experiences in this realm.

And a realization struck her like lightning.

“Kyoko,” she said, “this... this is the origin. The reason the arena can corrupt soul gems. It’s all because of this monster.”

Kyoko nodded, her mental voice sharp. *“Makes sense. The arena’s corruption trials, the soul gem decay simulations... they’re not just random mechanics. They’re modeled after this thing.”*

“Whoever created the arena,” Mami continued, “must have connected with the shadow monster somehow. They understood it. Enough to recreate its powers. Its pressure. Its hunger.”

Kyoko’s tone turned thoughtful. *“That’s terrifying. But also... brilliant. To take something this destructive and turn it into a training tool? That’s insane foresight.”*

Mami remembered asking Lunaria directly that morning.

“Did you and Kasumi create this realm? The arena? Did you connect with all the magical girls and witches whose essences are saved here?”

Lunaria had smiled softly.

Her usual gentle deflection.

“...Maybe another time.”

No denial.

No confirmation.

Just mystery.

Kyoko chuckled mentally. *“Classic Lunaria. Always keeping the big answers tucked away like puzzle pieces.”*

Mami smiled. *“Still... it makes me admire them even more. To face this monster, to defeat it with such ease and style, to understand it, and then use it to help others grow? That’s mastery.”*

Kyoko agreed. *“And now we’re walking the same path. Even if we’re just spectators in this moment.”*

Mami’s gaze turned toward the shadow monster.

“It’s one of the most powerful battle opponents,” she recalled Lunaria saying. *“Designed to push warriors to their limits.”*

And now, she understood.

The arena wasn’t just a battlefield.

It was a mirror.

A forge.

A place where magical girls could confront despair—and learn to rise above it.

And through that, Mami realized how far she’d come.

Only two days of training.

And she had stood against this monster.

Even if only for a few minutes.

Even if it had been heavily suppressed.

It was still a testament to her growth.

A glimpse of the strength she was beginning to unlock.

Kyoko felt it too.

She could sense Mami’s pride, her quiet determination—so much like her own.

And of course, Kyoko’s rivalry instincts kicked in.

She couldn't resist.

"I refuse to fall behind you, Mami," she teased telepathically, her tone sharp but warm. "I'll be the one to defeat it one-on-one first!"

Mami laughed, the sound echoing in their shared thoughts.

"You're on, Kyoko."

The shadow monster, upon seeing complete despair on the girls' faces, clapped its shadow claws.

Laughing.

Delighted.

"Wonderful! You've figured it out," it said. "Yes. I corrupt magical girls' soul gems. I turn them into witches. I make them part of me."

It rose higher.

Its form expanding.

"I have done this throughout history. And with each chapter... I grow. In strength. In negativity."

Elira, Sylvette, Hoshine, and Mirielle knelt on the battlefield.

Their bodies trembled.

Their minds reeled.

Too shocked to move.

Too broken to fight back.

Elira clutched her flower crown, tears streaming down her cheeks. Her voice trembled, barely audible.

"So I'm going to become like... Thornaria? My telekinesis twisted into a weapon of death and destruction? I don't want to hurt anyone..."

Sylvette's claws scraped the ground, her tail limp. Her body felt heavy, her instincts dulled to a whisper.

"I can't... I can't feel my strength anymore," she muttered. "It's like something's eating me from the inside. Like I'm about to break."

Mirielle stared ahead, eyes unfocused, her thoughts unraveling like threads in a storm.

"I can't calculate... I can't think... I can't breathe..."

Hoshine's threads faded into the air, drifting like tears caught in the wind.

"So this is how it ends," she whispered. "Us becoming witches... just like the friends we fought moments ago. Can things get any worse? Why? What did we do to deserve this..."

Mami watched through borrowed eyes.

And the scene struck her with eerie familiarity.

She turned to Kyoko, her thoughts trembling.

"Kyoko... this looks exactly like that moment. When Madoka, Sayaka, and... the current you... realized the truth. That magical girls aren't human. That their souls are in the gems. That their bodies are just shells."

She remembered it vividly—Lunaria's projection from earlier, showing her what was happening to her friends in Mitakihara. The heartbreak. The collapse. The silence that followed.

Kyoko's mental voice was quiet, heavy with memory.

"The scene of magical girls breaking... it's a familiar one. Played out across history. And every time, it hurts just as much."

The shadow monster loomed above them.

Its swirling mouths curled into a grin.

It could feel their despair.

And it fed on it.

"Let go," it said, voice dripping with mockery. "Succumb to the negativity. It's less painful that way. Quicker. Easier."

It leaned closer.

"This is my final act of kindness," it hissed. "A mercy. A gift."

The girls didn't respond.

They couldn't.

But then—

The two girls without soul gems stirred.

The ones whose bodies carried Mami and Kyoko's consciousness.

They felt the weight of negativity too.

But not in the same way.

Not as deeply.

Not as destructively.

And from that difference, they found strength.

Their bodies moved.

Their voices rose.

“We know it hurts,” Mami’s host said, voice shaking but firm. “We feel it too. But you have to keep fighting.”

Kyoko’s host stepped forward, fists clenched. “Better to fight and lose than to lose without trying. Watching you turn into witches... that would be too much to bear.”

Their words cut through the fog.

A flicker of light in the darkness.

The girls looked up.

Eyes wide.

Hearts trembling.

And for the first time since the corruption began—

They felt something else.

Hope.

Chapter 9f – Last Stand, Celestial Limit Break - Wishing Starfall Nova!

Elira, Sylvette, Hoshine, and Mirielle stirred.

Slowly.

Painfully.

They rose to their feet—barely.

Their bodies trembled, weak and shaking.

Their minds fogged, soul gems darkened, breaths ragged.

Sweat and tears streaked their faces.

But they stood.

The shadow monster watched them.

Its swirling eyes narrowed.

Its mouths curled into unreadable shapes.

Scorn flickered across its form—disgust at the sight of such fragile, broken beings.

But beneath that—

A flicker of something else.

Pity.

Admiration.

It sighed.

A low, rumbling sound that echoed like thunder.

It shook its shadowy head.

“The process would be far less painful,” it said, voice layered and slow, “if you simply accepted your inevitable fate.”

It leaned forward, looming.

“But I must admit... I’m impressed you can still stand. If you can even call those pathetic, trembling stances *standing*.”

It raised one clawed limb.

And motioned.

A taunting gesture.

“Very well,” it said. “If you wish to suffer... then come. *Try me.*”

Mami and Kyoko watched through borrowed eyes.

Their thoughts raced.

“It’s powerful,” Mami said. “Too powerful. When it fights seriously, I can’t even track its movements. It’s like watching a blur of destruction.”

Kyoko nodded. *“I remember. Lunaria and Kasumi had to slow down the recordings of their own fights—frame by frame—just so you could process what was happening. I had to do the same. Otherwise, it was impossible to learn anything.”*

“If it fights like that here,” Mami whispered, “the girls won’t stand a chance. It’ll be over in seconds.”

Kyoko’s tone was grim, but steady. *“And yet... they’re still standing. Even after everything. That means something.”*

Mami agreed.

They couldn’t intervene.

They couldn’t help.

But they could witness.

And they could believe.

Excitement and dread swirled in their hearts.

The shadow monster loomed.

The girls stood.

And the next moment would decide everything.

Elira, Sylvette, Hoshine, and Mirielle moved.

Barely.

Their bodies were weak, trembling.

Their minds fogged.

Their soul gems darkened.

But they fought.

Elira raised her hands, her telekinesis flickering. Objects around her floated—slowly, clumsily—barely coordinated, as if resisting her will.

Sylvette dropped to all fours, her chimera battle form unstable. Her limbs shifted between beast and human, her footing heavy, her movements sluggish.

Mirielle reached out to the matter around her, trying to reshape it. But everything she touched flickered—oscillating between her intent and its original form, unstable and incomplete.

Hoshine’s threads extended, weaving between the girls. But they were thin. Weak. Magical energy barely flowed through them. The attunement was fragile, on the verge of collapse.

The shadow monster watched.

Its eyes flickered with amusement.

It didn't move.

It didn't need to.

It knew.

They couldn't touch it.

Not like this.

Mami and Kyoko observed through borrowed eyes, their thoughts sharp and clear.

*"They don't know anything about **emotional control**," Mami said. "Or how to use **negativity to amplify their attacks**. If they did... they could actually put up a fight."*

Kyoko nodded. "It's to be expected. They just figured out Connect. They're the first magical girls to ever do so. Even the magical girls we knew they didn't know any of this. It wasn't until we met Lunaria and Kasumi that we learned about emotional techniques. About how to weaponize despair without falling to it."

The girls launched their attack.

Elira hurled her floating objects toward the shadow monster.

Sylvette fired feathers from her wings, each one trembling mid-flight.

Mirielle focused, manipulating the projectiles—sharpening them, heating some to searing temperatures, freezing others to biting cold. She altered the heat and texture of the air around the monster, trying to destabilize it.

Hoshine pushed herself, channeling what little magic she had left. Her threads pulsed faintly, syncing the girls' soul gems just enough to hold their formation.

The attacks converged.

Mirielle flicked her fingers.

"Now!"

The projectiles lit up.

A cascade of elemental energy burst forth—fire, ice, kinetic force, shimmering light.

A beautiful display.

A final effort.

The girls smiled weakly at each other.

Hope flickered.

Maybe...

But Mami and Kyoko knew better.

They had seen the shadow monster in action.

Kyoko sighed. *“That was impressive. Especially considering the state they’re in. But...”*

Mami finished the thought. *“...it’s not enough. Not even close. If it did any damage at all, it’s negligible.”*

The explosion cleared.

The battlefield fell silent.

The shadow monster floated in place.

Unmoved.

Unflinching.

A single wisp of shadow drifted from its form—torn off, dissolving slowly into the mist.

The girls stared.

Disbelief etched across their faces.

Elira’s lips trembled. “No... that was everything...”

Sylvette’s claws lowered. “It didn’t even flinch...”

Mirielle’s eyes widened. “I calculated everything... I timed it perfectly...”

Hoshine’s threads drooped. “I gave everything I had...”

The shadow monster laughed.

A low, echoing sound that reverberated through the arena.

“What was that?” it mocked. “A breeze?”

It tilted its head, mouths curling into a grin.

“If that’s the best you can do... then I don’t even need to fight. I’ll just stay here. Wait. Watch.”

Its voice darkened.

“You’ll become witches soon enough.”

It leaned forward.

“If you want to keep struggling... keep suffering... be my guest.”

It paused.

Then smiled wider.

“At least your agony will make the show more entertaining.”

Elira, Sylvette, Hoshine, and Mirielle collapsed onto the ground.

Their bodies were spent.

Their minds frayed.

Their spirits dim.

They lay side by side, hands clasped—grasping for warmth, for connection, for something that still felt human.

Their soul gems were nearly black.

Darkened to the edge of transformation.

Just like their friends who had already become witches.

Above them, the sky was a void.

No stars.

No moon.

Just shadow.

Elira reached out with one trembling arm, palm facing upward, fingers twitching to stay extended.

Her voice was soft, fragile.

“Remember back then... before we became magical girls? We’d lie down like this together... next to the lake... and look at the stars in the night sky?”

Hoshine chuckled, her threads flickering faintly—tiny lights dancing along them like miniature constellations.

“Yes,” she said. “The night sky was beautiful. Stars twinkling like gems. Patches of color scattered across the heavens. It was... breathtaking.”

Sylvette nodded slowly, her tail lifting just enough to point upward.

“And we’d each pick a star... or a planet... or a comet... and make a wish. One by one.”

Mirielle laughed softly.

She raised her hand, sending a few sparks into the air—tiny bursts of light that bloomed into delicate fireworks.

“None of us ever expected our wishes to actually come true.”

They all nodded.

Nostalgia filled their eyes.

But so did sorrow.

Because it was after that night—after those innocent dreams—that they met Kyubey.

And made their contracts.

The beginning of their lives as magical girls.

The beginning of the end.

Elira turned her head, her childlike innocence still glowing faintly.

“Can we do it one last time?” she asked.

The others looked at her, confused.

“What do you mean?” Sylvette asked gently.

Elira smiled, eyes glistening.

“Can we make a wish upon a star... one last time? To erase this nightmare with its light?”

The girls chuckled.

Warmly.

From the heart.

Even now, Elira’s imagination was beautiful.

Mirielle’s eyes narrowed in thought.

“The stars... the sun... they burn so brightly. Even from so far away. That kind of energy... maybe it *could* defeat the shadow monster.”

She looked at the others, hope flickering in her voice.

“I think... if we go to our absolute limit... pour everything we have into an attack that mimics a star... then maybe... just maybe...”

The girls’ eyes widened.

The idea took root.

Hoshine nodded slowly.

“It makes sense. Our last attack—it was like a light show. A burst of elemental brilliance. If we refine it... amplify it...”

Elira’s eyes gleamed.

“I can use my telekinesis to launch the shadow monster into the sky. As high as I can.”

Sylvette smiled, her tail curling with purpose.

“Mirielle and I can help. I’ll shapeshift beneath it, and Mirielle can alter the matter—create a force to send it flying.”

Hoshine closed her fists.

Gently.

Resolutely.

“And I’ll support you. I’ll weave every thread I have. Unlock every ounce of magic in your soul gems. We’ll shine like stars.”

They lay there.

Broken.

But not defeated.

And for the first time in what felt like forever—

They saw light.

Not in the sky.

But in each other.

The girls lay motionless.

Hands clasped.

Eyes vacant.

As if waiting.

Waiting to become witches.

The darkness crept closer.

Their soul gems—already blackened—pulsed faintly, like dying stars.

Mami and Kyoko watched in silence.

Their thoughts heavy.

“What are they doing?” Mami whispered. *“Is this it? Is this the end of them? The end of this story from the past?”*

Kyoko didn’t answer.

She didn’t need to.

The shadow monster chuckled.

A low, rumbling sound that slithered through the air.

“Aww,” it cooed mockingly. “So you’re no longer resisting. And here I was thinking you’d put up more of a fight.”

It leaned closer, its form rippling with amusement.

“But this is good for you. Lie there. Give up. Let the darkness consume you. Become what you are destined to become, witches.”

The two girls without soul gems—whose bodies carried Mami and Kyoko’s consciousness—fell to their hands and knees.

Sobbing.

Heavy, broken sobs.

They couldn’t bear it.

They couldn’t watch their friends—the last of them—fade into despair.

If they turned into witches...

They would be alone.

Utterly alone.

Both girls looked up into the sky.

A sky swallowed by shadow.

And they screamed.

A raw, aching cry.

Mami and Kyoko’s thoughts surged.

“Please... get up,” Mami pleaded. *“Don’t leave us here. Don’t leave us alone...”*

“We need you,” Kyoko whispered. “We need each other...”

And then—

Something strange happened.

The two girls spoke.

Their voices trembling.

But clear.

And they said—

“Please... get up. Don’t leave us here. Don’t leave us alone...”

“We need you. We need each other...”

The exact words.

The exact rhythm.

As if Mami and Kyoko’s thoughts had fused with their voices.

As if, just this once, their souls were in perfect sync.

A reflection.

A resonance.

A shared desire. A shared wish.

To not be alone.

To be understood.

To be supported.

The shadow monster paused.

Its eyes narrowed.

Its mouths curled.

It felt something shift.

Something it hadn’t expected.

And the girls—

Still lying on the ground—

Stirred.

The girls lay still.

Hands clasped.

Bodies broken.

But minds united.

Their Connect was complete.

Their resolve hardened.

And then—

“Now!”

The word echoed telepathically between them.

A single spark.

A single ignition.

Hoshine’s threads flared to life.

A radiant display of sparkling constellations burst forth, weaving through the air like stardust. The threads connected all the girls—Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle, Hoshine—and the two girls without soul gems.

It looked as if they were dancing in the night sky itself.

Hoshine’s voice rang out in their minds, clear and warm.

“Don’t worry,” she said to the two girls without soul gems. “We haven’t given up. This will be our greatest attack yet. Just watch.”

Her threads shimmered, gently brushing the cheeks of the two girls—wiping away their tears like a mother’s hand.

The girls’ bodies trembled.

But they nodded.

Sniffles held back.

Hope flickering.

Mami and Kyoko watched, their thoughts racing.

“What is this?” Mami whispered. “What kind of attack are they preparing?”

“It’s beautiful,” Kyoko said. “But is it enough?”

The shadow monster tilted its head, amused.

Its voice slithered through the air.

“A pretty light show during your final moments? How thoughtful. Thanks for entertaining me until the end.”

But the girls weren’t done.

Sylvette and Mirielle moved.

Empowered by Hoshine’s threads, they tapped into every ounce of their magical power.

Mirielle pressed both hands firmly to the ground.

Sylvette raised her arms high, palms open.

They shouted—

And their voices reverberated through the arena.

Mystical.

Powerful.

Legendary.

The ground beneath the shadow monster trembled.

Then ruptured.

A colossal golem erupted from the earth—towering, radiant, forged from elemental stone and shimmering light.

The shadow monster’s eyes widened.

It hadn’t expected this.

The golem swung a massive fist.

CRACK.

The impact echoed like thunder.

The shadow monster grimaced.

“Gah!” It yelped.

Its form was hurled into the sky.

Mami and Kyoko gasped.

“Did you see that?” Mami exclaimed. “They summoned a golem. A colossal one.”

“And it actually hit the monster,” Kyoko added. “Hard. That’s no illusion. That was real damage.”

Elira moved next.

Her body glowed with the same radiant energy.

She raised one arm, palm open toward the sky.

Her childlike battle cry rang out—

But this time, it was different.

It echoed.

It shimmered.

It shook the air.

Mystical.

Powerful.

Full of heart.

She focused her telekinesis.

And the shadow monster kept rising.

Higher.

Higher.

Elira dismantled the golem mid-air, sending its fragments upward.

The rocks orbited the shadow monster like miniature asteroids.

A cosmic dance.

A celestial trap.

Mami and Kyoko watched in awe.

“They’re turning the battlefield into a starfield,” Mami said. “This is more than an attack. It’s a transformation.”

“They’re building something,” Kyoko whispered. “Something big.”

The shadow monster stopped rising.

It floated in place.

Surrounded by the orbiting rocks.

A loose sphere of elemental debris.

Its voice echoed through the sky.

Applauding.

Mocking.

“Impressive. You’ve put enough energy into this attack to send me this high. But did you really think that would be enough to defeat me?”

It chuckled.

“What’s the plan? Launch me into space? Banish me from Earth?”

Mami and Kyoko leaned forward.

Their thoughts sharpened.

Their hearts pounding.

“*This is it,*” Mami said. “*The climax is coming.*”

“*Whatever they’re planning,*” Kyoko added, “*it’s going to be spectacular.*”

Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle, and Hoshine looked at one another.

No words.

Just a nod.

Everything was in place.

They raised their arms—palms open—toward the celestial trap they had created.

Above them, the radiant cage of orbiting rocks shimmered with elemental energy, suspended in the sky like a constellation waiting to awaken.

The shadow monster looked down, its swirling eyes narrowing.

Confused.

Curious.

What were they planning?

Then—

“Hah!”

The girls shouted in unison.

Their voices reverberated through the arena, through the sky, through the threads of Connect itself.

It wasn't just sound.

It was soul.

They poured everything into the attack.

Their magic.

Their memories.

Their pain.

Their hope.

Each girl held onto the same wish:

To create a **star of hope and change**.

To defeat the shadow monster.

The rocks of the celestial cage began to glow.

First red.

Heating slowly.

The shadow monster's voice echoed across the sky, layered and distorted, as if a thousand voices were speaking at once.

"You hope to burn me away with heat?" it mocked. **"How naïve. Do you think something as simple as fire can defeat me? I am the culmination of sadness, rage, and hatred. I consume heat. I thrive in despair."**

But the girls ignored it.

They focused.

They reached deeper.

The heat intensified.

Orange.

Then yellow.

From where Mami and Kyoko watched, the celestial cage now looked like a miniature sun.

"It's beautiful," Mami whispered. *"A red star... no, a sun."*

Then the realization hit.

“Kyoko... this is why they were lying down. Reaching up. Surrounded by Hoshine’s constellation threads...”

Kyoko’s eyes widened.

“They made a wish on a star once. And now... they’re becoming that star.”

A final wish.

A final light.

The shadow monster began to shift.

Its form rippled—unstable, flickering at the edges.

The heat was real.

It could feel it.

Not just warmth.

But pressure.

Force.

Intent.

It hovered in the center of the celestial trap, surrounded by orbiting rocks glowing red, then orange, then yellow.

And it spoke again.

“UUUUHHHH! So the heat is real,” it said, with a low, rumbling tone. **“You’ve managed to ignite something. I’ll admit... I didn’t expect this much energy from you.”**

It paused.

Then chuckled.

But the laughter was thinner now.

Less confident.

“I suppose I should take this seriously.”

Its form twisted.

Dark tendrils coiled around it.

A dense barrier of shadow began to form—thick, heavy, pulsing with arcane weight.

“I am wrapping myself,” it said, voice rising, **“in the essence of those I’ve consumed. The sadness of the betrayed. The rage of the forgotten. The hatred of the broken.”**

The barrier darkened.

It pulsed.

It shimmered with a sickly glow.

“This is my armor,” the monster declared. **“Forged from despair. Hardened by centuries of suffering.”**

But then—

A flicker.

A tremble in its voice.

“...And yet...”

It hesitated.

“...This heat... it shouldn’t be reaching me.”

The barrier tightened.

The monster’s eyes swirled faster.

Its mouths twitched.

“I am the culmination of pain,” it said, louder now. **“You cannot burn away what has already been scorched by existence!”**

But the nervousness was there.

Subtle.

Growing.

The heat was climbing.

The light was intensifying.

And the shadow monster—

For the first time—

Was unsure.

The girls kept going.

Unbothered.

Unshaken.

The rocks turned blue.

Then violet.

A radiant purple star now hovered in the sky.

Mami and Kyoko gasped internally.

“This is it,” Mami said.

“The final moment,” Kyoko whispered.

The shadow monster grimaced.

“GAAAAAAAAAAAAAH!” it yelped.

Its barrier was burning away.

The girls felt it.

They celebrated silently, telepathically.

Elira: *“We’re doing it!”*

Sylvette: *“Keep pushing!”*

Hoshine: *“Don’t stop now!”*

Mirielle: *“Are you ready for the final part?”*

All: *“Yes!”*

They raised their arms higher.

The purple light intensified.

The heat surged.

Inside the celestial cage, the shadow monster screamed.

“AAAAAAAAAAAAHHHHHHHHHHHHH!”

A distorted, demonic scream.

The girls’ voices blended with it—reverberated cries of magic and will.

A cosmic symphony.

Mami and Kyoko watched, breathless.

“They’re doing it!” Mami whispered. *“They’ll win!”*

But then—

Crack.

A sound that shattered their hearts.

They knew it instantly.

Soul gems.

Breaking.

Too much power.

Too much strain.

Mami and Kyoko’s joy turned to dread.

“No...” Kyoko whispered. *“They were so close...”*

“More loss,” Mami said. *“This will be hard to watch. How will the survivors bear it?”*

Then—

The end came.

The girls closed their open hands into fists.

And shouted the name of their final attack:

“Wishing Starfall Nova!”

The celestial cage exploded.

A radiant burst of violet light.

The shadow monster’s screams stopped.

Silence.

Then—

A miniature supernova bloomed in the sky.

Brilliant.

Beautiful.

Final.

The shadows around them began to disperse.

Slowly.

Softly.

Like mist unraveling at dawn.

The oppressive darkness faded.

And above them—

The night sky returned.

Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle, and Hoshine laughed.

A joyful laugh.

Full of heart.

Full of relief.

They looked up, eyes wide, tears glistening.

Their arms flopped limply to the ground, too exhausted to move, but content to simply exist in this moment.

The two girls without soul gems fell to their knees.

Crying.

Not from sorrow.

But from happiness.

From overwhelming relief.

They crawled forward, trembling, and nestled beside their magical girl friends.

Together, they lay beneath the stars.

Looking up.

And what they saw—

Took their breath away.

Stars twinkled like gems.

Patches of color scattered across the heavens.

Nebulas blooming in violet and gold.

It was just like they remembered.
Back when life was simple.
Peaceful.
Before they became magical girls.
Before the contracts.
Before the pain.
Before they lost their family.
Before their friends became witches.
But this time—
Something new.
From the remnants of their final attack, sparkles fell.
A radiant starfall.
Drifting across the sky.
Then down toward them.
Like a blessing.
Like a farewell.
Like a promise.
Mami and Kyoko watched in awe.
Their thoughts quiet.
Their hearts full.
“It’s beautiful,” Mami whispered. “A sky reborn.”
*“A **wishing starfall...**” Kyoko said. “From their wish. From their light.”*
The girls lay together.
Breathing.
Smiling.
Congratulating one another in soft, tired voices.
Elira: *“We did it... Our wish was granted!”*

Sylvette: *“We really did...”*

Mirielle: *“It worked. The star worked.”*

Hoshine: *“We held on. We stayed connected.”*

The two girls without soul gems reached out, holding their friends’ hands.

No words.

Just warmth.

Just presence.

And above them—

The stars kept falling.

The girls basked in the moment.

Lying side by side beneath the sublime night sky.

Breathing in peace.

Bathed in starlight.

They were together.

They were not alone.

The sky above shimmered with constellations and drifting starfall—sparkles cascading from the remnants of their final attack, painting the heavens with radiant trails of violet and gold.

It was breathtaking.

It was everything they had dreamed of.

Mami and Kyoko watched in silence.

But their hearts sank.

A deep ache settled in their chests.

The girls had done it.

They had overcome so much.

Families executed.

Hunted by their own village.

Half of their group turned into witches before their eyes.

Forced to fight their former friends.

Forced to face the shadow monster—the embodiment of sadness, rage, and hatred across history.

And now, after all that...

This moment was quiet.

Beautiful.

Peaceful.

But Mami and Kyoko knew.

It couldn't last.

They remembered the sound.

The cracks.

During the final attack.

Soul gems straining under the weight of magic.

They had hoped—desperately—that maybe, just maybe, the girls would survive.

And their fears were correct.

Crack.

The sound echoed again.

Sharp.

Final.

All the girls turned toward the noise.

Eyes wide.

Breath caught.

They saw them.

Elira's soul gem.

Sylvette's.

Mirielle's.

Fracturing.

Splintering.

Breaking.

Hoshine gasped.

“No... no no no—what’s happening?!”

She scrambled toward them, threads flickering in panic.

The two girls without soul gems cried out, crawling forward.

“Elira?! Sylvette?! Mirielle?! Are you okay?! Please—say something!”

But the three girls lay still.

Their eyes open.

Their smiles soft.

Their bodies unmoving.

Mami and Kyoko screamed internally.

“No...” Mami whispered. “*Not again...*”

“*They’re learning everything,*” Kyoko said, voice trembling. “*First, that magical girls become witches when they fall into despair...*”

“*And now,*” Mami finished, “*that their souls are in their soul gems. That their bodies are just shells. And when the gem breaks...*”

“...*they die.*”

The truth hung heavy in the air.

A truth too cruel.

Too final.

And yet—

The stars kept falling.

Chapter 10 – This is farewell... legacy of friends...

Hoshine’s breath hitched.

Her voice trembled.

“J-just hold on,” she stuttered. “You’ll be alright. You’ll be okay...”

She summoned her threads again—every last strand she could muster.

They flared with desperate light, weaving through the air like frantic constellations.

She connected them to everyone.

Elira.

Sylvette.

Mirielle.

The two girls without soul gems.

The threads pulsed, glowing with urgency.

The two girls without soul gems, their eyes wide with panic, reached out with trembling hands. They poured what little magical energy they had—what fragments remained—into the threads, into their friends.

Elira's soul gem glowed brighter.

So did Sylvette's.

And Mirielle's.

But the cracks kept spreading.

Thin lines at first.

Then deeper.

Wider.

Hoshine's lips quivered.

“No... no...”

She began to cry.

So did the two girls beside her.

They were starting to understand.

Starting to guess what was coming.

Elira looked at them.

Smiled.

Softly.

Gently.

“It’s too late,” she said. “We know our bodies. We know our gems. We know what this means.”

Sylvette nodded, her voice barely a whisper. “We gave everything.”

Mirielle’s eyes shimmered. “And we’re okay with that.”

Hoshine and the two girls clutched their hands.

Tightly.

Desperately.

Each girl held both hands of one other.

As if holding on could stop time.

As if touch could rewrite fate.

They sobbed louder.

The kind of sobbing that breaks the air.

That muffles words.

That drowns reason.

“No... that can’t be true...”

“Please... no...”

“You’ll be okay...”

“Just rest... we’ll find a way...”

“Please... don’t leave us here...”

“Don’t leave us alone...”

Their voices were muffled.

Choked by grief.

The words of humans watching their closest friends die.

Hoping it was a nightmare.

Hoping they’d wake up.

But the stars kept falling.

And the soul gems kept cracking.

Elira, Sylvette, and Mirielle gently tightened their grips.

Their fingers barely moved—weak, trembling.

But it was enough.

A final gesture.

A final connection.

Hoshine and the two girls without soul gems felt it.

The fading strength.

The fragile warmth.

Like someone barely able to hang on.

Like the last flicker of a flame.

Chapter 10a - Elira's farewell

Elira was the first.

Her voice was soft.

Childlike.

But steady.

She looked up at the night sky, her gaze tracing the falling stars like they were old friends returning home.

“I used to dream about flying,” she said. “Not with wings. Just... floating. Drifting through the stars. I thought if I could reach high enough, I’d find a place where everything was peaceful. Where people didn’t hurt each other. Where wishes didn’t come with prices.”

Her fingers twitched faintly in the hands that held hers.

“I remember lying by the lake with all of you. Looking up at the sky and picking stars to wish on. I always picked the brightest one. I thought it would hear me better.”

She chuckled softly, breath catching.

“My wish was simple. I wanted everyone to be happy. I didn’t understand what that really meant back then. I thought happiness was just... smiles and laughter. But now I know it’s more than that. It’s being together. It’s being understood. It’s being held when you’re falling apart.”

Her eyes glistened, tears catching the starlight.

“I never found that perfect place in the stars. But tonight... this sky... this moment... it’s close enough.”

She turned her head slightly, looking at Hoshine and the two girls beside her.

“You gave me that. All of you. Even if it’s just for a little while.”

Her grip weakened.

But her smile remained.

Chapter 10b - Sylvette’s farewell

Sylvette was next.

Her voice was deeper.

Grounded.

But gentle.

She stared up at the stars, her tail curling faintly beside her, the motion slow and deliberate—like a final breath drawn with care.

“I spent so much of my life trying to be strong,” she said. “To protect others. To fight back. To be the shield when everything else was falling apart.”

Her grip tightened slightly in the hands that held hers.

“But strength... it’s a strange thing. People think it’s about power. About claws and teeth and standing tall. But I’ve learned that real strength is quieter. It’s in the moments when you choose to stay. When you choose to hold someone’s hand even when you’re scared.”

She blinked slowly, her eyes shimmering with tears.

“I remember when we were hunted. When we lost our families. I remember the nights we didn’t sleep, because we were afraid of what we’d become. I tried to carry all of that. I thought if I just kept going, I could carry everyone’s pain too.”

She turned her head slightly, looking at Hoshine and the two girls beside her.

“But I couldn’t. No one can. And that’s okay.”

Her voice softened.

“I’m proud of what we did. Of what we became. Not because we were strong... but because we stayed together. Because we kept believing in each other.”

She smiled.

A quiet, tired smile.

“And if this is the end... then I’m glad I get to spend it with all of you. Under this sky. Holding your hands.”

Her grip weakened.

But her presence lingered.

Like a guardian watching over the stars.

Chapter 10c - Mirielle’s farewell

Mirielle was last.

Her voice was calm.

Measured.

But full of emotion.

She lay still, her fingers barely curled around the hands that held hers, her gaze fixed on the sky as if trying to memorize every star before she left.

“I always wanted to understand,” she said softly. “Everything. The world. Magic. People. I thought if I could just learn enough, I could fix things. Make sense of the chaos. Make things better.”

She paused, her breath shallow but steady.

“I studied everything I could. Patterns. Elements. Emotions. I thought knowledge would protect us. That if I could just predict the pain, I could stop it before it happened.”

Her lips trembled.

“But pain isn’t a puzzle. It’s not something you solve. It’s something you feel. Something you carry. And sometimes... something you share.”

She turned her head slightly, her eyes meeting Hoshine’s.

“I used to think magic was just a tool. A system. A force to be mastered. But now I know—it’s a reflection. Of who we are. Of what we feel. Of what we’re willing to give.”

Her voice grew quieter.

“But even with all I’ve learned... I never figured out how to stop death. I never found the spell that could undo loss.”

She smiled faintly.

“But I did find something else. I found you. I found all of you. And in the end... that’s enough.”

“I got to share this moment. With all of you.”

Her grip weakened.

Her voice faded.

But her presence lingered.

Like a quiet thought that stays with you long after the words are gone.

The three girls lay still.

Their soul gems dimming.

Their hands still held.

And above them—

The stars kept falling.

Chapter 10d – Best wishes to Hoshine

The soul gems of Elira, Sylvette, and Mirielle continued to crack.

Hairline fractures deepened.

Light flickered.

Time was slipping.

They didn’t have much left.

But they had enough.

Enough for one last goodbye.

They turned their eyes to Hoshine.

The girl who had held them together.

Who had kept the threads of their souls from unraveling.

Elira spoke first.

Her voice was faint.

But warm.

“Hoshine... you were always the one who kept us close. Even when we were falling apart. You tied us together with your magic, but more than that... with your heart.”

She smiled, tears glistening.

“You reminded me that even when everything feels broken, we can still be whole. Just by being together.”

Sylvette followed.

Her voice was low.

Steady.

“Hoshine... you were our anchor. When I lost control of my form, when I felt like I was slipping into something monstrous... you pulled me back. You reminded me I was still me.”

She blinked slowly.

“You gave me strength. Not the kind I used to chase. But the kind that matters.”

Mirielle was last.

Her voice was quiet.

Measured.

“Hoshine... you were the thread between logic and emotion. Between chaos and clarity. You helped me understand that magic isn’t just about control. It’s about connection.”

She looked at her gently.

“You were the one who made Connect real. Not just as a spell. But as a truth.”

All three girls smiled.

Their grips weakening.

Their light dimming.

But their words—

Their love—

Held strong.

Chapter 10e – Best wishes to the 2 enigmatic girls without soul gems – path to strength

The stars above shimmered in silence.

The soul gems of Elira, Sylvette, and Mirielle continued to fracture—light flickering, magic fading.

But their eyes remained clear.

Their hearts full.

They turned to the two girls beside them—the ones without soul gems.

The ones who had stayed.

The ones who had never left.

“Wait... will this be it?” Mami thought, her heart pounding beneath the weight of sorrow and hope.

“Will we finally learn who these two girls are?”

“Hopefully...” Kyoko’s thoughts swirled. *“Too many questions. Too few answers...”*

Elira spoke first.

Her voice was faint.

But warm.

“You’ve always been there,” she said. “Even though you were different. Even though you didn’t have soul gems. You stayed. You fought. You cried with us.”

She smiled, tears glistening like stardust.

“I’m sorry we dragged you into this. You didn’t deserve this pain.”

Sylvette followed.

Her voice was low.

Steady.

“You were our light in the dark. You reminded us what it meant to be human. To be vulnerable. To be brave even though you cannot fight.”

She blinked slowly, her tail curling faintly.

“I’m sorry we couldn’t protect you from this world. From what we became.”

Mirielle was last.

Her voice was quiet.

Measured.

“You were the unknown in our equation. The variable we couldn’t define. But you were never just placeholders. You were real. You mattered.”

She looked at them gently.

“Your presence during our darkest times helped more than you know. Thank you... truly.”

Mami and Kyoko sighed internally.

“Wow...” Mami thought. “*No mention of their names at all...*”

“*Are they real?*” Kyoko wondered. “*Or just symbolic figures for magical girl pairs who go through this trial?*”

To their disappointment, the mystery remained.

Then—

Hoshine, through heavy sobbing, tried to speak.

Her voice cracked.

“I-it’s my fault,” she said. “I was the one who dragged them into this... *my wish...*”

Mami and Kyoko froze.

“*Her wish?*” Mami whispered. “*She made a wish that involved them?*”

“*But they’re not magical girls,*” Kyoko said. “*So what did Kyubey give them?*”

The questions multiplied.

But the answers remained hidden.

Elira, Sylvette, and Mirielle laughed.

Genuinely.

From the heart.

“You’re not alone in this, Hoshine,” Elira said. “We all made choices.”

Sylvette nodded. “We all carry responsibility.”

Mirielle smiled. “If we could go back... we’d do things differently.”

They turned to the two girls without soul gems.

“You may not have soul gems,” Elira said. “And you **may not seem** to have special magical powers...”

Mami and Kyoko leaned in.

“‘**May not seem**’?” Mami echoed.

“So they *do* have something?” Kyoko thought.

“...but we believe in you,” Sylvette continued. “You can still grow strong. Strong enough to protect the ones you love.”

“You just need to find your own path,” Mirielle said. “Your own way to grow. To shine.”

Elira gave one last childish smile—so warm it could melt the coldest heart.

Her voice was like a child imagining a superhero who could solve anything.

“Grow stronger than any of us... and stronger still! Strong enough to protect everyone you love without losing anyone!”

The two girls without soul gems trembled.

Tears streaming.

Hands clutching tightly.

And above them—

The stars kept falling.

Chapter 10f – Elira, Sylvette, and Mirielle Dies

The soul gems of Elira, Sylvette, and Mirielle cracked again.

Thin fractures deepened into jagged lines.

Their light flickered like candle flames in the wind.

Their deaths were near.

But their eyes remained open.

Their smiles gentle.

They looked at Hoshine and the two girls without soul gems—those who had stayed, those who had held their hands through the storm.

And they spoke.

Together.

In perfect harmony.

Repeating the words once whispered to them by their families.

Words spoken through tears.

Through final embraces.

Through execution chains.

“Stay safe. Live. Support each other. Be happy.”

Their soul gems pulsed once more.

Hanging by a thread.

And then—

“Most importantly...”

Their voices trembled.

But their eyes shone.

“...we love you.”

A single tear fell from each of their faces.

Slow.

Silent.

Sacred.

And when those tears touched their soul gems—

Shatter.

The gems broke.

Light burst.

Their grips loosened.

Their arms fell limp.

Their eyes closed.

But the smiles remained.

Soft.

Peaceful.

Final.

They died in happiness.

In connection.

In love.

Their final tears floated upward, suspended in the air like shimmering droplets of memory.
They surrounded their bodies.
Surrounded Hoshine and the two girls.
Just like the trail of tears from the mural.
A sacred echo.
A mirrored moment.
Hoshine collapsed forward, sobbing uncontrollably.
The two girls without soul gems clung to her and to each other, their cries raw and broken.
They stuttered through their grief.
“No... please...”
“Come back...”
“You were everything...”
“I can’t... I can’t do this without you...”
Their words were muffled.
Choked by sorrow.
It was heart-wrenching to watch.
Mami and Kyoko could barely breathe.
Their thoughts were silent.
Their emotions too heavy to name.
The tears of the three girls surrounded them now, mingling with the tears of the fallen.
And above them—
The starfall continued.
Gentle.
Endless.
The scene was ethereal.
Beautiful.
Otherworldly.

A tapestry of grief and grace.

Mami and Kyoko were at a loss for words.

And yet—

They knew.

This moment would stay with them forever.

Chapter 11 - The light that follows

The light faded slowly, like the last glow of twilight slipping beneath the horizon.

Mami felt her body again—her real body. Not the simulated form she had inhabited during the mural trial, but her own familiar self. Her limbs were no longer stiff with grief or frozen in awe. She could move freely, breathe deeply, and feel the soft pulse of her soul gem nestled against her chest.

The spiritual realm welcomed her back with its gentle hues and drifting mist. The clouds above shimmered with soft light, casting a warm glow across the marble floor beneath her feet. The air was still, but not empty—it carried a quiet reverence, as if the realm itself understood what they had just endured.

She turned to Kyoko, who was already stretching her arms overhead, blinking as if waking from a long, vivid dream. Her movements were slow, deliberate, like someone returning from a place far beyond the reach of words.

They had returned.

The simulation was over.

And yet, the emotions lingered—etched into their hearts like constellations.

Even as the light of the simulation faded and the spiritual realm embraced them once more, Mami and Kyoko remained suspended in the quiet gravity of what they had just witnessed. The warmth of the realm wrapped around them, but it couldn't soften the ache that still pulsed in their chests.

Mami blinked slowly, her eyes shimmering with unshed tears. She didn't try to hide them. There was no need to. The sorrow she felt wasn't shameful—it was sacred. The final moments of Elira, Sylvette, and Mirielle played again in her mind like a lullaby woven from memory and grief. Their smiles. Their words. Their tears. It was too much to forget. Too beautiful to let go.

Beside her, Kyoko rubbed at her eyes with the heel of her palm, muttering something under her breath. Her usual bravado had dimmed, replaced by a quiet vulnerability she rarely showed. She sniffed once, then twice, and tried to clear her throat as if that would erase the lump forming there.

Mami glanced at her, a soft smile tugging at her lips.

“Are you crying?” she asked gently, voice teasing but affectionate.

Kyoko scoffed, though her voice cracked slightly. “No. You’re crying.”

“I saw you wipe your eyes.”

“I saw you *not* wipe yours.”

They looked at each other.

And laughed.

It was a quiet laugh—tired, tender, and full of understanding.

“I guess we’re both soft,” Mami said, her voice barely above a whisper.

Kyoko shrugged, her gaze drifting upward toward the glowing clouds. “After seeing something like that... I think it’s okay to be soft.”

Mami nodded, her hand resting lightly over her soul gem. “They were so brave. So full of love. I don’t think I’ve ever seen a farewell like that.”

Kyoko’s voice was low. “They didn’t just fight. They connected. All the way to the end.”

The silence that followed wasn’t empty.

It was full.

Full of memory.

Full of meaning.

And as the mist swirled gently around them, the emotions they carried settled deep into their hearts—like stars that would never fade.

The quiet of the realm held them for a moment longer, until—

A voice.

Muffled.

Mumbling.

“...no, the glitter goes inside the volcano... not the marshmallows...”

Mami blinked.

Kyoko tilted her head.

Another voice followed, equally nonsensical.

“...tell the moon jellyfish to stop dancing, they’re waking up the pancakes...”

The contrast was so jarring, so absurd, that it pulled both girls from their solemn reverie.

They turned toward the source of the sound.

And there she was.

Kasumi.

Curled up in a loose bundle of blankets, dressed in soft sleepwear patterned with tiny stars and other fiery motifs. Her hair was tousled, her limbs sprawled in every direction, and her face was scrunched in the kind of deep, chaotic sleep only dreamers knew.

She snored softly.

Shifted.

Tossed.

Turned.

And continued to mumble incoherent phrases into the air, her voice rising and falling like a child narrating a dream no one else could see.

“...don’t feed the sparkles to the cloud whales... they’ll get indigestion...”

Kyoko blinked slowly, then let out a quiet laugh.

Mami pressed a hand to her mouth, trying not to giggle.

“She must have been out for a while,” Kyoko said, her voice low and amused. “How long do you think we were gone?”

Mami shook her head, still smiling. “Long enough for her to start dreaming about glitter volcanoes and jellyfish pancakes, apparently.”

The solemnity of the moment softened.

Not erased.

But gently cradled by the absurdity of Kasumi’s sleep-talking.

It was a reminder that even in the wake of sorrow, life continued.

And sometimes, it was silly.

“You’ve finished the simulation. Welcome back.”

The voice was calm and melodic, like wind brushing through leaves.

They turned toward the sound.

Lunaria appeared gracefully, her form materializing from the soft clouds like a dream given shape. Her long hair shimmered with starlight, and her robes flowed like water, glowing faintly with the colors of the realm.

Mami's heart lifted at the sight of her.

Kyoko smiled. "Lunaria. It's good to see you again."

Lunaria returned the smile, her eyes warm and knowing. "And you as well. You've been gone quite a long time. As you can see..." she gestured toward the sleeping Kasumi, "it's now evening in the realm."

Mami and Kyoko chuckled softly.

Kasumi rolled over, hugging a pillow that hadn't been there moments ago. "No... don't feed the moon jellyfish... they're allergic to sparkles..."

Lunaria's expression turned playful. "Would you like to punish her for falling asleep during your training?"

Kyoko tilted her head. "Punish her?"

Lunaria raised a hand, and a dozen magical markers floated into view—each one glowing with a different color and effect. Sparkles, glitter, glowing ink, even one that left behind musical notes.

"She did call this trial your punishment," Lunaria said with a mischievous smile. "Perhaps it's time to return the favor."

Mami's eyes lit up.

Kyoko grinned. "Oh, I like this."

They approached the sleeping Kasumi, markers in hand, but paused just before reaching her. The soft glow of the realm bathed her in a gentle light, and for a moment, neither of them spoke.

Kasumi's face was serene.

Her breathing slow and even.

Her usual fiery energy—so full of motion and mischief—had melted away, replaced by a quiet stillness that made her look almost angelic. Her hair fanned out across the pillow like strands of orange-red rays at sunset, glowing softly in the ambient light of the realm. Her lips were parted slightly as she mumbled nonsense in her sleep, the words drifting into the air like fragments of a dream only she could see.

"...no, the pancakes are sacred... don't let the jellyfish wear hats..."

Kyoko crouched beside her, tilting her head.

"She looks... peaceful," she said softly. "Not like the usual chaos tornado we know."

Mami nodded, her gaze tender. “It’s kind of charming, isn’t it? Like seeing a storm take a nap.”

Kyoko smirked. “A nap with glitter volcanoes and jellyfish hats.”

They both chuckled quietly.

There was something endearing about seeing Kasumi like this—unguarded, dreaming, completely at ease. It reminded them that even the most energetic souls had moments of stillness. And in that stillness, there was beauty.

“I almost feel bad for drawing on her,” Mami said, though her voice betrayed the smile tugging at her lips.

“Almost,” Kyoko echoed, already eyeing the markers.

They exchanged a glance.

And then—

“I’m thinking swirls around the eyes,” Mami said thoughtfully.

“Lightning bolt mustache,” Kyoko added.

Lunaria giggled. “Don’t worry—this Kasumi is a clone. It won’t affect the real one. But I’m quite certain the real Kasumi will have a hilarious reaction when she finds out what you did to her counterpart.”

Mami and Kyoko burst into laughter.

“Let’s make it count,” Kyoko said.

“Let’s make it art,” Mami replied.

And with that, the markers began to dance.

The markers hovered in the air, glowing softly in the evening light of the realm. Mami selected one with a shimmering gold tip, while Kyoko reached for a deep crimson that sparkled faintly with flecks of silver. They knelt beside Kasumi, who remained blissfully asleep, her breathing steady, her limbs occasionally twitching as she mumbled more dream fragments into the air.

“...the jellyfish are wear hats... the pancakes are running away...”

Kyoko snorted. “She’s really committed to this jellyfish thing.”

Mami giggled, carefully tracing a swirl near Kasumi’s temple. “I’m starting to think she’s dreaming in glitter.”

As they worked, Lunaria stepped closer with a pen of her own, her presence calm and radiant. The soft glow of the realm seemed to follow her, casting a gentle shimmer across the marble floor. She knelt beside Kasumi with quiet grace, selecting a marker that sparkled with pale yellow light.

Without a word, she began to draw—her strokes delicate and deliberate. On Kasumi’s forehead, she sketched what looked like a moon made of cheese, complete with tiny craters and a whimsical smile.

Mami paused mid-sparkle, watching with amusement. “Is that... cheese?”

Lunaria smiled, her eyes twinkling. “Of course. A moon made of cheese. It felt appropriate.”

Kyoko snorted. “You’re worse than us.”

Lunaria tilted her head, feigning innocence. “I’m simply contributing to the masterpiece.”

Then, her voice softened, shifting from playful to thoughtful.

“What did you think of the simulation?” she asked, her gaze drifting between them. “The battle depicted in the final mural... the six girls against the six witches. What stayed with you?”

Mami paused, her marker hovering just above Kasumi’s cheek. Her gaze drifted for a moment, as if she were still seeing the scene play out in her mind.

“It was... overwhelming,” she said quietly. “Not just the battle itself, but everything around it. The emotions. The connections. The way they held each other even as they were falling apart.”

Kyoko nodded, drawing a jagged lightning bolt across Kasumi’s upper lip. “It wasn’t just a fight. It was a farewell. A promise. They weren’t trying to win—they were trying to stay together.”

Kasumi stirred suddenly, her head rolling to the side just as Kyoko finished her mustache. The line dragged across her cheek, turning the lightning bolt into something more abstract.

Kyoko blinked. “Okay, that’s... avant-garde.”

Mami laughed, then quickly added a few stars around the new shape to make it look intentional.

Lunaria smiled, her eyes thoughtful. “Did it change how you see yourselves? As magical girls?”

Mami considered the question, her hand moving slowly as she added a trail of sparkles across Kasumi’s forehead.

“I think... I’ve always seen myself as someone who had to be strong. Composed. A protector. But watching them... I realized strength isn’t just about holding everything together. Sometimes it’s about letting yourself be held.”

Kyoko leaned back, examining her work. “I used to think fighting was the only way to prove I was worth something. That if I kept surviving, it meant I was doing it right. But those girls... they didn’t survive. And they were still more connected than I’ve ever felt.”

Kasumi mumbled again, her voice muffled by the pillow.

“...don’t let the volcano eat the glitter... it’s too spicy...”

She rolled over, smearing part of the design across her cheek.

Mami gasped. “No! That was the best part!”

Kyoko burst out laughing. “She’s sabotaging her own makeover!”

Lunaria chuckled softly. “She does have a talent for chaos.”

The three of them continued drawing, the conversation flowing between laughter and reflection. The markers danced across Kasumi’s face, leaving behind a tapestry of stars, swirls, and other comical symbols—each one a quiet echo of the emotions they carried.

Lunaria’s voice grew softer.

“Do you think you’ll carry what you saw with you? Into your next battles?”

Mami nodded slowly. “I think I have to. It wasn’t just a story. It was a truth. One I didn’t know I needed.”

Kyoko’s voice was quiet. “They didn’t just fight witches. They fought despair. Together. That’s what I want to remember.”

The mist around them shimmered gently, as if the realm itself was listening.

And Kasumi, still dreaming, whispered one last phrase into the air.

“...the jellyfish are singing again... tell them to use the glitter microphones...”

Mami and Kyoko looked at each other.

Then laughed.

And kept drawing.

The markers continued their dance across Kasumi’s face, leaving behind a tapestry of glittering swirls, stars, and whimsical symbols. The moon made of cheese sat proudly on her forehead, framed by constellations of musical notes and lightning bolts. Every few moments, Kasumi stirred—rolling slightly, mumbling nonsense, dragging her cheek across the marble floor and smearing a carefully drawn spiral into a streak of glitter.

“...the jellyfish singing with the glitter microphones... the walruses are dancing...”

Kyoko groaned, lifting her marker. “She just erased the comet trail I was working on.”

Mami giggled. “It’s okay. We’ll call it a shooting star now.”

Lunaria watched them with quiet amusement, her gaze soft and thoughtful. Then, as Mami leaned in to add a tiny heart near Kasumi’s temple, she spoke again.

As the markers continued their whimsical dance across Kasumi’s face, Mami’s hand slowed. Her gaze drifted from the glittering swirl she was drawing to the soft mist surrounding them. Something had been stirring in her thoughts since the simulation ended—something she couldn’t quite shake.

She looked up at Lunaria, her voice quiet but steady.

“Lunaria... I’ve been thinking about the origin of Connect. And that shadow monster—the one in the simulation that corrupted the soul gems. What was that really? How does the arena mimic something so... invasive?”

Kyoko glanced over, nodding slowly. “Yeah. That thing in the simulation... it felt just like the one in the arena. Same darkness. Same pressure. Same soul gem corruption. It wasn’t just a visual—it felt like it was crawling inside us.”

Lunaria chuckled softly, her expression warm and knowing. “Almost every magical girl group asks about that. It’s one of the most unsettling parts of the trial. And one of the most important.”

She sat back on her heels, her fingers resting lightly on her lap. The mist around her shimmered faintly, as if the realm itself leaned in to listen.

“The shadow monster in the arena is created from the essence of the real one you saw in the simulation,” she began, her voice calm and melodic. “An ancient force of distortion. Its power wasn’t in destruction, but in connection. It didn’t shatter soul gems outright... it linked to them. Slowly. Quietly. It whispered into their cores, unraveling them from within.”

Mami’s brow furrowed. “So the arena is using that essence? Recreating the corruption?”

“In a controlled way,” Lunaria said. “The simulation is designed to show you what that kind of connection feels like. Not just the pain—but the vulnerability. The way despair can masquerade as unity. It’s the other side of the coin.”

Kyoko frowned, her marker paused mid-air. “That’s... twisted.”

Lunaria nodded gently. “But necessary. To fully understand Connect, you must also understand its shadow—so you can recognize it. Resist it. Protect yourself from it.”

She looked at them both, her gaze thoughtful.

“You felt Connect through the two girls without soul gems. What did it feel like to you?”

Mami and Kyoko fell silent.

Their markers hovered.

Their thoughts turned inward.

Mami spoke first, her voice soft. “It felt like... we saw the world through their hearts. Through everyone’s hearts. Not just their magic, but their essence. Their very core.”

Kyoko nodded slowly. “It was like our souls were syncing. Not just our powers—but our emotions, our memories. We understood each other without speaking. It was... otherworldly.”

Lunaria smiled, her eyes glowing faintly. “That’s a beautiful answer.”

She leaned forward slightly, her tone deepening.

“Connect is more than a spell. It’s a resonance. A state of being. When magical girls truly open themselves to one another—not just in battle, but in vulnerability—they create a bond that transcends magic. It’s not just about fighting together. It’s about feeling together.”

Mami’s eyes softened. “So it’s not just a tool. It’s a truth.”

“Exactly,” Lunaria said. “And the shadow you saw... it uses that truth, but for its own ends. It twists it. It connects through fear. Through doubt. Through isolation disguised as unity.”

Kyoko exhaled slowly. “That’s why it felt so familiar. It wasn’t just attacking us. It was mirroring us.”

Lunaria nodded. “And that’s why the trial matters. To see both sides—both good and bad. To choose which connection you’ll carry forward.”

Mami’s voice was quiet, thoughtful. “The shadow monster said the same thing to the girls. That whether something is good or bad depends on how you use it.”

Lunaria chuckled softly. But her eyes—usually serene—held something else. A flicker of emotion. Nostalgia? Sorrow? Reflection? Mami and Kyoko couldn’t quite place it.

“Correct,” she said. “But the ‘good’ for the shadow monster is the ‘bad’ for magical girls.”

Kasumi stirred again, dragging her cheek across the floor and smearing the moon-cheese into a glittery blur.

“...the walruses are dancing with me... one... two... three...”

Kyoko groaned. “She’s ruining my masterpiece.”

Mami smiled faintly, but her thoughts lingered.

There was more to ask.

More to uncover.

And Lunaria’s answers—while beautiful—always seemed to stop just short of clarity.

Mami and Kyoko exchanged a glance.

Then Kyoko leaned forward, her tone casual but probing.

“You seem to know a lot about this,” she said. “More than just what’s in the training.”

Mami followed her lead, her voice thoughtful. “And about the two girls without soul gems. Who were they? Were they real people from the past? Or just characters added to the mural to represent us?”

Kyoko nodded. “It was kind of eerie. Seeing the world through them. Like we were meant to.”

Lunaria smiled warmly, her expression serene.

“I’ve heard that question many times,” she said. “Other magical girl groups were curious too. Each had their own interpretations.”

She paused, her gaze drifting toward the mist that curled gently around them, glowing faintly in the soft evening light. The silence that followed felt intentional—like the realm itself was holding its breath.

Then she looked back at them.

“Some believed the girls were echoes—fragments of magical girls who once existed but were erased from history. Others, like you, thought they were symbolic, created by the realm to reflect the emotional state of whoever entered the trial. A few even believed they were future versions of themselves, sent backward to guide their own hearts.”

She tilted her head slightly, her voice softening.

“And still others think they are past reincarnations. Ancestors whose stories were woven into the mural long before you arrived. That the connection you felt wasn’t just emotional—it was ancestral. A memory passed down through soul gems and spirit.”

Mami’s eyes widened slightly, the idea settling into her thoughts like a whisper.

Kyoko leaned back, thoughtful. “That’s... kind of beautiful. And kind of creepy.”

Lunaria chuckled, then glanced at the sleeping Kasumi, who had just rolled over and mumbled something about dancing walruses and glitter volcanoes.

“If Kasumi hadn’t fallen asleep,” Lunaria said with a playful smile, “she would’ve told those magical girl groups that the two girls were actually camerawomen—recording the story so that they, and now you, could watch it.”

Mami and Kyoko looked at Kasumi and laughed.

“As always, Kasumi...” Mami said fondly.

Kyoko cocked her head, half-serious. “But they couldn’t be camerawomen... right? Did someone back then wish for some weird ancient camera thing?”

Lunaria laughed, her voice light and melodic. “You’d be surprised what people have wished for.”

Then she tilted her head again, her expression returning to its usual calm.

“Your interpretation—that they represent you—is a good one. And I encourage you to think more on it.”

Her words were gentle.

But her eyes shimmered with something else—like a ripple across still water. A flicker of something unspoken. Not deception, but distance. As though she stood just beyond the reach of full truth.

Mami and Kyoko didn’t speak aloud.

But their thoughts aligned.

She’s dodging again.

Just like when I asked about her.

And the realm.

They exchanged a glance.

And in that glance—

A silent telepathic message passed between them.

We need to keep digging.

Kasumi stirred again, dragging her cheek across the floor and smearing the moon-cheese into a glittery blur.

“...the pancakes are sacred... don’t let the volcano eat the sparkles...”

Kyoko sighed. “She’s ruining my masterpiece.”

Mami smiled faintly, but her eyes remained on Lunaria.

The mystery was deepening.

And they planned to unravel it—one truth at a time.

The final strokes were drawn.

Mami added a delicate trail of stars across Kasumi's cheek, while Kyoko finished her jagged lightning bolt mustache with a flourish. Lunaria, ever graceful, had contributed a moon made of cheese—now slightly smeared but still proudly perched on Kasumi's forehead.

The three girls stepped back in unison, markers hovering beside them like satisfied artists admiring their canvas.

And what they saw—

Was hideous.

Atrocious.

An abomination.

Kasumi's face was a chaotic masterpiece of glitter, swirls, symbols, and questionable geometry. Her cheeks were covered in mismatched constellations, her forehead bore a crooked moon with a smile that looked vaguely sinister, and her chin had somehow become the battleground for a war between musical notes and lightning bolts.

Kyoko blinked. "Okay... I don't remember drawing that third eye."

Mami covered her mouth, trying not to laugh. "I think it was supposed to be a flower."

Lunaria tilted her head. "It's evolved. Into something... else."

They stared for another moment.

Then all three burst into uncontrollable laughter.

It was the kind of laughter that came from deep in the chest—unfiltered, unstoppable, and full of release. The kind that made your stomach ache and your eyes water. The kind that only came after sorrow had passed and joy had returned.

The sound echoed through the realm, bouncing off the mist and clouds like music.

And then—

Kasumi stirred.

Still half-asleep, she mumbled one last sleep-talking phrase, her voice muffled by the pillow.

"...who's laughing at the walruses... they're doing their best..."

She blinked slowly, her eyes half-opening, squinting at the blurry shapes in front of her.

Mami, Kyoko, and Lunaria were still laughing, barely able to speak.

"Did you sleep well?" Mami managed between giggles.

"Welcome back," Kyoko wheezed.

Lunaria smiled, her voice soft and amused. “You’ve missed quite the art session.”

Kasumi’s eyes shut again.

For a moment, they thought she was going back to sleep.

Then—

“GOOD MORNING MAMI AND KYOKO!”

Kasumi launched herself forward with a burst of energy, arms wide, and tackled both girls into a tight hug.

Mami yelped.

Kyoko gasped.

They were still laughing, still breathless, and now completely squished.

Kasumi beamed, her voice rapid-fire. “Did you finish the trial? Was it cool? Did you cry? Did you see the mural? Did you meet the girls? Did you—”

Mami and Kyoko flailed slightly, motioning for her to loosen her grip.

“Can’t... breathe...” Kyoko wheezed.

Kasumi gasped dramatically. “Oh no! I’m sorry!”

She jumped back with flair—

And promptly tripped over her own blanket.

Face-first.

Straight into the marble floor.

The sound echoed like a drumbeat.

Mami and Kyoko burst into fresh laughter, joined by Lunaria’s gentle giggle.

Kasumi popped up a moment later, completely unfazed, her face still covered in glitter and chaos.

She struck a pose, hands on her hips, eyes sparkling.

“Well!” she declared. “Now that I’m awake and fabulous—how did your ***punishment*** go?”

Kyoko was the first to speak, still grinning from the laughter but now with a spark of excitement in her eyes.

“That punishment,” she said, “was awesome.”

She paused, then laughed at herself. “Never thought I’d describe punishment that way.”

Her voice carried the thrill of battle, the kind that lingered in the bones long after the fight was over.

“The combat part was insane. Six witches at once? I didn’t see that coming. It overwhelmed us, yeah—but it was a real challenge. The kind that makes you want to get stronger. I want to try it again.”

She turned to Mami, her expression softening.

“Now that we know Connect,” she added, closing both eyes and smiling brightly.

Mami laughed warmly, her heart touched by Kyoko’s words. There was something deeply affirming in Kyoko’s desire to fight alongside her again—not just as comrades, but as partners.

“I’d love that,” Mami said, her voice gentle. “Let’s do it again. But this time... with Connect.”

Kasumi clapped her hands dramatically. “Awwww! You two are so sweet I’m getting cavities!”

Mami turned to her, her tone shifting into reflection.

“The simulation was... deep,” she said. “Moving. Tragic. It taught us so much—about Connect, about the shadow monster, and about a history lost to time. It wasn’t just a story. It spoke to my soul.”

Kasumi gasped theatrically, clutching her chest as if wounded.

“Nooo! I failed!” she cried. “Punishment isn’t supposed to be *awesome, fun, and moving*! It’s supposed to be pain and suffering and dramatic screaming!”

She dropped to her knees, raising her arms to the sky. “I need to rethink this Connect training ‘special second test’ immediately!”

Kyoko snorted. “You’re the only person I know who’d complain about a punishment being too meaningful.”

Lunaria chuckled, her voice like a breeze through leaves. “I think you’ve created something quite unique, Kasumi.”

Mami smiled, shaking her head. “So... what did you do while we were in the simulation?”

Kasumi’s eyes lit up.

She gave a grin so mischievous, so wide, that Mami and Kyoko instinctively leaned back.

Kyoko narrowed her eyes. “Oh no.”

Mami’s voice was cautious. “Kasumi...”

Kasumi leaned forward, her grin growing.

“Did you... plan a third test?” Mami asked.

“Or do we have to fight six shadow monsters now?” Kyoko added.

Kasumi didn’t answer.

She just kept grinning.

Lunaria chuckled softly, her eyes twinkling. She knew exactly what was coming.

And whatever it was—

It was going to be very, very Kasumi.

Kasumi didn’t reply right away.

She just kept grinning.

That same wide, mischievous grin—stretched across her glitter-covered, marker-stained face. It was no longer just hideous. It was haunting. Not in a scary way, but in the way a haunted clown might smile before unleashing chaos.

Mami and Kyoko stared at her, growing increasingly nervous.

Kyoko leaned slightly toward Mami. “Why is she still grinning like that?”

Mami whispered back, “I don’t know. But I don’t like it.”

Lunaria, standing serenely nearby, continued to smile—clearly amused by the tension.

Finally, Kasumi’s grin softened into a normal smile. She sat up straighter, her eyes still twinkling with mischief.

“Well,” she said sweetly, “do you remember what I told you after your fight with the six witches? Right before you went into the simulation?”

Kyoko blinked. “Uh...”

Kasumi’s eyes sparkled. “About how pictures of both of you have been taken throughout the whole training?”

Kyoko froze.

Her face went beet red.

Sweat began to drip down her temple.

Her eyes widened in horror.

“No,” she whispered. “You were joking. You *had* to be joking.”

Mami turned to Kyoko with a sly smile. “I wouldn’t mind seeing those pictures.”

Kyoko's head snapped toward her. "Mami—no."

Mami's smile widened. "After all, you *do* love showing me pictures of myself screaming on roller coasters. And you store them *securely*, too. Now I'll finally understand how you felt when you had those pictures. And you'll understand how I felt every time you rubbed it in."

Kasumi clapped her hands. "That's great, Mami! I *knew* you'd love to see them!"

Kyoko groaned. "No, no, no..."

Kasumi raised her hand, and a shimmering projection appeared in the air—like a floating screen woven from light and memory.

The first image appeared.

Kyoko and Mami mid-battle against the linen mummies. Their faces frozen in expressions of pure shock and confusion. Kyoko's mouth was open in a half-scream, Mami's eyes wide as she tripped over a pile of enchanted bandages.

Kasumi gasped dramatically. "Behold! The noble warriors—defeated by laundry!"

Lunaria chuckled softly. "That was a very expressive moment."

The next image flickered into view.

Their fight against Aurellia.

Kyoko mid-air, her limbs flailing as she was knocked back by a blast. Mami ducking, her hair flying wildly, her face twisted in a mix of panic and disbelief.

Kasumi pointed. "Here we have Kyoko doing the 'flying squirrel' maneuver. And Mami's signature 'wind tunnel panic' expression!"

Kyoko curled up slightly, her arms hugging her knees.

"I'm dying," she muttered.

Mami laughed, eyes sparkling. "So *this* is how it feels. No wonder you did it, Kyoko. It feels *great*."

Kyoko didn't respond.

She just buried her face in her arms.

Kasumi continued.

The final image appeared.

The climax.

Mami and Kyoko, overwhelmed by the six witches, grabbing each other's hands, eyes squeezed shut, mouths wide open in a synchronized scream.

Kasumi gasped. “The grand finale! The ‘we’re-about-to-die-hold-my-hand’ pose! Iconic!”

Lunaria smiled. “A very heartfelt moment. And very loud.”

Mami laughed so hard she had to wipe tears from her eyes. “We look so silly.”

Kyoko peeked out from behind her arms. “Now I know how you felt, Mami. I’m sorry. I’m so sorry.”

Mami patted her shoulder. “It’s okay. You’ll survive. Probably.”

Kasumi beamed, clearly proud of her presentation.

And somewhere in the realm, the echoes of their laughter lingered—bright, warm, and full of life.

Kasumi clapped her hands once, theatrically, as if concluding a grand performance.

“Well!” she said brightly. “Now that that’s over... let’s continue.”

She gestured to the soft glow of the realm around them. “As Lunaria mentioned, it’s evening now. That simulation part takes a long time. You two were in there for quite a while.”

Mami and Kyoko glanced up at the sky, where the clouds had deepened into hues of lavender and silver. The realm’s light had shifted—gentle, quiet, like the world was winding down.

Kasumi leaned in, eyes sparkling. “And while you were in the simulation... everyone in the arena cheered.”

Kyoko lifted her head slightly, eyes still wide.

Kasumi grinned. “They *loved* how you fought the six witches. Especially that last part. You know, the screaming, the hand-holding, the dramatic climax...”

Kyoko groaned and buried her face deeper into her arms.

“I don’t know if I can ever face those people again,” she muttered. “Their essences are saved in the arena. They’ll remember. They’ll tease me into oblivion.”

Mami chuckled warmly, patting Kyoko’s back. “It wasn’t *that* bad.”

Lunaria smiled gently. “You’ll be fine, Kyoko. Everyone has embarrassing moments. They’re part of the journey.”

Kasumi nodded, her tone surprisingly thoughtful. “You should treat those moments as badges of honor. They show your history. Your life. Your growth.”

Kyoko peeked out from her arms, skeptical.

Kasumi continued, her voice soft but steady. “And you know what else? You can *use* them. Embarrassment is a negative emotion, right? That means it can amplify your attacks. Or help you build

endurance against negativity. You can channel those memories—yes, even the silly ones—because they’re tied to fighting side-by-side with Mami. A close friend. That emotional comfort will help you in future battles against the shadow monster or any arena trial where your soul gem absorbs negativity.”

Her eyes flared with fire.

“And lastly,” she added with a grin, “you can use it to fire up your battle lust! Just like me!”

Mami and Lunaria both chuckled.

Kyoko blinked. “I... don’t know how to respond to that.”

Mami smiled, her voice warm. “It actually reminds me of what Lunaria taught me yesterday. About how all knowledge connects—pun intended.”

She looked at Lunaria. “Even though this training was for Connect, what we learned can be applied to other techniques. Like the ones you and Kasumi taught us.”

Lunaria’s eyes softened. “Well said, Mami.”

Kasumi nodded, her grin turning sincere. “Looks like you are able to **connect the dots** now, eh Mami?”

Mami blushed slightly, but her smile remained.

Kyoko groaned again, still curled up.

Kasumi leaned over and whispered, “Don’t worry. I’ll make sure your battle lust is legendary.”

Kyoko whimpered.

And the laughter returned.

Kasumi leaned back, her voice slipping into a more thoughtful rhythm.

“After you entered the simulation,” she said, “everyone in the arena returned to the **dream-realm**. You know, the place where the essences rest when they’re not summoned. That’s where Dream-Kyoko here goes too, when she’s not active.”

Mami’s eyes softened as she listened, her thoughts drifting inward.

She remembered what Kyoko had told her earlier that day—about how summoned souls “exist” when called, and then fade away, though still conscious. It was strange. Peaceful. Like being awake inside a dream.

What is that realm really like? Mami wondered. How does it differ from the realm I’m in now?

She imagined it—a quiet place, woven from memory and emotion, where the echoes of magical girls lingered like stars in a sleeping sky.

Could I visit that realm? she thought. *To see Kyoko again when she's not summoned? To speak with the three girls from the simulation... Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle. To ask Aurellia and the families about their lives, their choices, their dreams.*

Her heart stirred with questions.

So many questions.

But she didn't interrupt.

Kasumi continued, her voice brightening again.

"Before they left, everyone voiced their desire for you two to do another challenging fight tomorrow—but this time using Connect. You're already strong together without it, so they're *very* curious what abilities you'll unlock when you fight as one."

She grinned. "Mirielle's imagination got everyone excited. She started describing all sorts of wild possibilities."

Mami's own imagination began to stir.

She pictured herself and Kyoko standing back-to-back against a towering enemy, their magic swirling together like twin comets. She imagined synchronized attacks—Kyoko's fire laced with Mami's golden ribbons, spiraling into a blazing cyclone. She saw herself shielding Kyoko with a barrier that pulsed with shared emotion, while Kyoko launched a counterstrike powered by their bond.

Her voice grew dreamy. "We could combine our magic mid-air... or create a shared field that amplifies both our strengths. Maybe even summon a temporary fusion form..."

Kyoko's eyes widened.

She sat up, then stood, slamming her fist into her open palm to loosen up.

"Okay. Yeah. I *have* to do that fight tomorrow," she said, her voice fired up. "I need to gain back some credibility with the arena crowd. If we put on a good show, they'll be less likely to tease me. And maybe I'll stop seeing that screaming picture in my nightmares."

Kasumi's grin turned mischievous.

"Oh? You seem pretty confident that you and Mami can put on a good show with Connect..."

She leaned in slightly.

"Maybe I'll prepare a *very* nasty fight for you tomorrow. Something extra spicy. Something that'll make that screaming picture look *graceful*."

Kyoko froze.

Mami laughed.

Lunaria chuckled, her eyes twinkling.

Kyoko groaned. “I regret everything.”

Kasumi winked. “Too late.”

And once again, laughter filled the realm.

Kasumi stretched her arms overhead with a satisfied sigh.

“Well, that’s pretty much all that happened,” she said cheerfully. “Oh—and I fell asleep, as you can tell.”

She smiled sheepishly, eyes twinkling.

“I was planning on a short nap but... well, you know how that goes.”

Mami chuckled, then tilted her head thoughtfully.

“Kasumi,” she said, “can I ask you something?”

Kasumi perked up. “Of course!”

Mami glanced at Kyoko, who leaned in, equally curious.

“Who were the two girls without soul gems?” Mami asked. “Kyoko and I think they were characters added to the mural to represent us—people watching the story unfold. Lunaria told us some interpretations from other magical girl groups. She also said what *you* told them. But I want to hear it from you.”

Kasumi didn’t hesitate.

She raised a finger dramatically, her voice ringing with theatrical flair.

“Obviously,” she declared, “they were camerawomen—recording the story so that people could watch those events!”

Kyoko blinked.

Mami raised an eyebrow.

Kasumi grinned, then softened her tone with warmth.

“Besides, you know the phrase, right? ‘The camerawoman never dies.’ Those two girls survived, didn’t they? So it checks.”

Kyoko and Mami burst into laughter, clapping their hands in amusement.

“That’s... actually clever,” Kyoko admitted between giggles.

Mami nodded, smiling. “You’re impossible.”

As the laughter echoed through the realm, Mami and Kyoko exchanged a glance.

And in that glance—

A silent telepathic message passed between them.

She answered exactly how Lunaria said she would.

So she really did tell other magical girl groups the same thing.

And we don’t sense any deception.

Kasumi’s smile was playful, but her eyes held sincerity. There was truth in her words—abstract, perhaps, but not empty.

And most importantly—

Her eyes shimmered with something else.

A flicker of emotion.

Just like Lunaria’s had.

Not sadness. Not joy. Something quieter. Deeper. Something Mami and Kyoko couldn’t quite pinpoint—like a memory too distant to name, or a feeling that hadn’t yet found its words.

Mami and Kyoko’s imaginations stirred.

Who were those two girls, really?

And what role do Lunaria and Kasumi play in all of this?

The questions lingered. Still unanswered.

Mami and Kyoko turned to Kasumi with warm smiles.

“Thanks for your answer,” Mami said sincerely. “We’ll think more about it. Once we’ve had time to reflect... would you and Lunaria be open to discussing it with us again?”

Kasumi nodded enthusiastically. “Of course!”

Lunaria smiled gently. “We’d love to hear your interpretations. Every magical girl sees something different—and that’s what makes it beautiful.”

Kyoko gave a playful grin. “Well, in return for your answer, Kasumi... I think you should take a picture of yourself.”

Kasumi blinked. “A picture? Why?”

Kyoko smirked. “You know... since your answer was all about camerawomen and recording. It’s only fair.”

Mami chuckled, catching on instantly.

Lunaria chuckled too—but there was a faint hint of uneasiness in her laugh.

Kasumi, now curious and slightly suspicious, manifested a projection of herself.

She leaned in.

Zoomed.

And froze.

Her face looked... veeeery strange.

Kasumi burst out laughing. “What is *that*?! Who is that?! What happened?! That face is a hideous abomination!”

She zoomed in further, still laughing—until the realization hit.

Her laughter slowed.

Then stopped.

Her eyes widened in horror.

“That’s... *my* face?”

She touched her cheek, then her forehead, then her chin—each movement exaggerated and theatrical.

“No... no no no... what *is* this?! What *happened* to me?! Why is there a moon made of cheese on my forehead?! Why does my chin look like a musical battlefield?!”

Mami, Kyoko, and Lunaria laughed uncontrollably.

Lunaria’s laugh, however, sounded a little more... uneasy.

Kasumi turned to them with sad puppy eyes, tears forming at the corners—making her already chaotic face look even more absurd.

“How could you laugh at a time like this?” she cried. “Your good friend is in *extreme turmoil*! In *embarrassment*! This is a tragedy! **Emotional damage!**”

She turned to Kyoko with mock betrayal. “I thought you understood me!”

Kyoko wheezed. “I do. That’s why this is so funny.”

Kasumi narrowed her eyes. “Another punishment session is in order.”

Mami and Kyoko stopped laughing.

Their giggles turned into nervous chuckles.

Lunaria chuckled too—but it was very weak. Very uneasy...

Kasumi noticed.

She turned slowly to Lunaria, eyes glowing with fiery intent.

“This must’ve been *your* idea, right?” she said. “You told them to draw on my face while I was sleeping.”

Lunaria took a step back, sweat forming on her brow. “I... I don’t recall...”

Kasumi grabbed a fistful of pens in each hand.

“The mockery. The betrayal. It’s time for *revenge!*”

With a battle cry, she charged.

Lunaria yelped and turned to run. “Kasumi! Wait! We can talk this out!”

“No talking!” Kasumi shouted. “Only *artistic justice!*”

The chase was short-lived.

Kasumi tackled Lunaria to the ground, straddling her triumphantly.

“Let’s see how *you* like it when I decorate your face!”

Lunaria squirmed. “I’m sorry! I’m so sorry! Mami! Kyoko! Help me!”

Mami and Kyoko laughed, watching the chaos unfold.

“Good luck,” Mami said cheerfully.

Kyoko nodded. “We believe in you.”

What followed could only be described as a chaotic free-for-all wrestling match.

Kasumi rolled, twisted, and turned with Lunaria, pens flying, limbs flailing. Every time she got a mark on Lunaria’s face, she shouted triumphantly.

“Behold! The swirl of vengeance!”

“Feel the fury of the glitter comet!”

Lunaria screamed playfully, trying to dodge each stroke.

“Nooo! Not the lightning bolt mustache!”

Mami and Kyoko doubled over in laughter.

Kyoko wiped a tear from her eye. “Mami... does this count as the promised fight between Lunaria and Kasumi?”

Mami giggled. “It’s more intense than I expected.”

Eventually, the wrestling stopped.

Both girls lay on the ground, panting, sweating, and covered in marker streaks.

Kasumi stood up proudly, arms raised like a victorious gladiator.

“I have completed my masterpiece!” she declared.

She turned to Mami and Kyoko. “Well? What do you think of my glorious art?”

Mami and Kyoko looked at Lunaria’s face.

And burst into laughter.

It was hideous.

Atrocious.

An abomination.

Covered in abstract chicken-scratch art—just like the linen Kasumi decorated before their special second test.

Swirls, stars, lightning bolts, and what might have been a walrus.

Mami shook her head. “It’s... something.”

Kyoko nodded. “It’s definitely *not* nothing.”

Kasumi gasped in mock hurt. “Why does no one appreciate my art?!”

And once again—

Laughter filled the realm.

Bright.

Chaotic.

And full of love.

Once the laughter faded and the realm settled into its soft evening glow, Mami’s voice returned—gentle, thoughtful.

“Kasumi,” she said, “Lunaria... can I ask one last question?”

Kasumi, still catching her breath from the glitter-fueled wrestling match, nodded with theatrical flair. “Of course! Hit me with your deepest curiosity!”

Lunaria smiled, brushing a streak of silver ink from her cheek. “We’re listening.”

Mami glanced at Kyoko, who gave a subtle nod. Then she turned back to them.

“There were three special guests in the arena,” Mami said slowly. “The ones you asked for their thoughts before our second trial; three of the magical girls who fought against the six witches. But... there were six girls total fighting the six witches. Not counting the two girls without soul gems—since they’re enigmas, maybe symbolic—where was **Hoshine**?”

Kyoko leaned forward, her voice low. “Yeah. Why wasn’t she there with the others? Why wasn’t she in the arena?”

The question hung in the air like mist.

Kasumi’s expression softened. Lunaria’s smile faded into something quieter. Both of them looked upward, toward the lavender sky where clouds drifted like memory.

“Hoshine’s essence...” Lunaria began, her voice barely above a whisper, “is not saved in the arena.”

Kasumi nodded, her tone unusually subdued. “She can’t be summoned like the others. She doesn’t rest in the dream-realm. She’s only visible through the simulation.”

“She’s part of the mural,” Lunaria added. “But not part of the archive.”

Silence followed.

Mami and Kyoko exchanged a glance.

And in that glance—a telepathic thread sparked to life.

She’s not saved? Mami thought. *But she was the emotional center. The one who held them together.*

Exactly, Kyoko replied. *She was the thread. The heart. If she’s not in the archive... does that mean she didn’t survive? Or that she was never meant to be summoned?*

Or maybe... Mami hesitated. *Maybe she gave something up. Something that made her untraceable.*

Kyoko’s thoughts darkened. *Could her wish have kept her from being saved in the arena?*

She did mention it, Mami added. *Near the end of the simulation. She blamed herself for what happened to the two girls without soul gems. Said it was her wish that dragged them into it.*

They both looked up at the sky, mirroring Kasumi and Lunaria.

The clouds shimmered faintly, as if listening.

Kasumi spoke again, her voice gentle.

“Some stories aren’t stored. They’re remembered. Not by systems. But by hearts.”

Lunaria nodded, her tone quiet and reverent.

“The simulation is different from the arena. It doesn’t store souls the way the archive does. It draws from something different—an emotional imprint left behind. A resonance. The Hoshine you saw... she exists through memory, through history. Not through summoning.”

Mami’s hand drifted to her soul gem, her fingers brushing the surface like she was trying to feel something just beyond reach.

Kyoko clenched her fist softly, her gaze still fixed on the sky.

They didn’t speak aloud.

But their thoughts stirred.

“So does this mean the creator of this realm and the arena didn’t know Hoshine?” Mami wondered.

“From my understanding of what Lunaria told me this morning, the creator had to connect with every magical girl, witch, and monster to store their essence in the arena. I had a hunch that Lunaria and Kasumi were the creators... and Lunaria, as usual, deflected my question.”

Kyoko’s thoughts flickered. *“Assuming you’re right—and that they did create this realm—then yeah... it would mean they weren’t present in the mural story when it happened. Which is weird. Because they know it so well. Like they lived it. Or watched it.”*

“Or remembered it”, Mami added. *“Not from experience. But from something deeper.”*

Kyoko groaned internally. *“Arg! This is all getting confusing!”*

Mami chuckled softly. *“Tell me about it.”*

But beneath the confusion, something else pulsed.

A quiet certainty.

They both knew—

Hoshine’s story wasn’t over.

It was just harder to reach.

And maybe, just maybe...

They’d find a way to reach her.

Chapter 11a– Sayaka’s descent

Kasumi stretched her arms overhead, her smile returning with playful brightness.

“Well then,” she said cheerfully, “let’s head back to the arena. We’ve got something to show you, Mami—about how things are currently going with your friends at Mitakihara.”

She turned to Kyoko with a wink.

“You can watch too, Kyoko. You’ll get to see what your real current self is like.”

Mami’s heart stirred.

She hadn’t seen Madoka, Sayaka, or the current Kyoko since the day before—when the truth about soul gems had shattered their understanding of themselves.

They were so shocked, she thought. Madoka looked like her world had cracked open. Sayaka completely froze up. And Kyoko...

She glanced at the Kyoko beside her.

Not this Kyoko. The other one. The one who lost her family. The one who severed ties with me. She looked like she’d been emotionally hit by a truck.

Kyoko’s expression was unreadable, but her voice was steady.

“I’m curious too,” she said. “I want to see what I’ve become. What I’m like now. After everything.”

Lunaria raised her hands, her robes shimmering with soft light.

“Then let us begin.”

A warm glow enveloped them—gentle, radiant, like sunlight filtered through petals. The realm shimmered, and the air shifted around them like a sigh.

When the light settled, they found themselves nestled together inside a massive flower pod. Its petals curved around them like a cradle, glowing faintly with hues of peach and gold. The air was fragrant, the floor soft beneath them, and the ceiling above opened to a sky of shifting constellations.

Lunaria waved her hand, and a projection bloomed into view—like a floating orb of memory, pulsing with light and emotion.

Kasumi nudged Kyoko with a grin.

“Hey, snackmaster. Want to summon us a feast? You know, to ease the tension.”

Kyoko smirked. “You just want an excuse to eat.”

Kasumi gasped. “How dare you accuse me of such truth!”

Kyoko chuckled and raised her hand.

A swirl of magic shimmered in the air—and then, with a soft pop, a spread of food appeared around them. Bowls of fruit, trays of pastries, skewers of grilled vegetables, fizzy drinks, and a suspiciously large pile of glitter-dusted popcorn.

The girls lit up with glee, each grabbing something as the projection began to glow brighter.

Mami held a warm cup of tea in her hands, but her eyes were fixed on the orb.

Kyoko munched on a skewer, her gaze sharp.

The orb pulsed once—then opened.

The projection shimmered, shifting scenes like pages turning in a memory.

It showed Kyoko—current Kyoko—walking beside Sayaka through the outskirts of Mitakihara, a bag of apples slung casually over one shoulder. The sky above them was bright and clear, the sun hanging high—noontime. Neither girl spoke, but their pace was steady, purposeful.

Kyoko reached into the bag and pulled out an apple, biting into it with a loud crunch. The sound echoed faintly in the quiet streets, a small defiance against the silence between them.

Sayaka walked with her arms folded, her gaze fixed ahead. Kyoko didn't look at her, but the way she chewed—slow, deliberate—suggested she was thinking. Processing.

Dream-Kyoko leaned forward, eyes narrowing.

“...I know this path,” she murmured. “They’re heading toward the church.”

Mami's breath caught.

Her fingers tightened around her teacup, knuckles pale.

She knew what that church meant.

What it had once been.

What it had become.

That was her father's church, Mami thought. That was where everything fell apart. Where Kyoko's family...

Her grip trembled.

That was the day we severed ties.

She glanced at the Kyoko beside her—the summoned one. The one from before the tragedy. The one who hadn't lived through it.

Kyoko noticed.

She turned to Mami, her expression calm, her voice steady.

“I'll be fine,” she said. “I already know a bit of what happened later. You told me when I was first summoned, remember?”

Mami blinked, surprised by the gentleness in her tone.

Kyoko gave a small wink.

“And besides,” she added, “I can’t become a witch from too much negativity. So you don’t have to worry about me going berserk and beating you up.”

Mami laughed, the tension in her chest loosening just a little.

“Oh? You’re very confident if you think your witch form could beat me up.”

She leaned back, her voice playful.

“Maybe we should try that sometime. I wonder if this arena can create hypothetical witch forms of magical girls...”

She turned to Lunaria and Kasumi, her eyes gleaming with curiosity.

Kasumi’s grin widened instantly.

“Ooooh, now *that’s* an idea.”

Lunaria chuckled, her eyes twinkling with something unreadable—amusement, perhaps, or something deeper.

“It would be... interesting, wouldn’t it? I wonder...”

Kyoko raised an eyebrow. “That’s not a no.”

Mami smirked, sipping her tea. “Sounds like a maybe.”

Kyoko crossed her arms, mock-serious. “I don’t know. I think my witch form would be all fire and teeth. You’d probably get singed before you could even summon your ribbons.”

Mami tilted her head, unfazed. “And I think mine would be elegant and terrifying. You’d be too busy admiring the aesthetics to dodge the attack.”

Kasumi clapped her hands, eyes gleaming.

“You girls seem *very* hyped for this! Maybe one day you’ll get to see something like that...”

Lunaria smiled, serene as ever.

“Right... Perhaps...”

The air in the flower pod shifted—just slightly. A breeze that wasn’t there before. A flicker of something unspoken.

Mami and Kyoko glanced at each other.

Not fear.

Not certainty.

But curiosity.

And somewhere in the petals around them, the realm seemed to listen.

The projection pulsed again, drawing their attention back.

Kyoko and Sayaka were nearing the church.

The air in the flower pod grew quieter.

But the laughter lingered—soft, warm, and full of love.

Even as the past approached.

Even as the truth waited.

They were ready.

Or at least... they were together.

The projection shimmered, then sharpened.

Kyoko—current Kyoko—stood at the edge of a crumbling courtyard, Sayaka beside her. The sun hung high overhead, casting long shadows across the cracked stone path. A bag of apples swung lightly from Kyoko's hand.

She stopped in front of a pair of weathered wooden doors, their paint long faded, their hinges rusted.

“Here we are,” she said quietly.

Sayaka glanced at her, then at the building.

They stepped inside.

The church was a ruin.

Broken stained glass littered the floor like fallen stars. Wooden beams sagged overhead, some snapped entirely. Dust hung in the air, catching the sunlight in slow, drifting spirals. The pews were splintered, the altar cracked. It was silent—no hymns, no voices, no warmth.

In the flower pod, Dream-Kyoko leaned forward, her eyes wide with quiet disbelief.

“...It looks terrible,” she murmured. “Compared to what I remember... the vibrant atmosphere, the people, the light...”

She paused, her voice softening.

“But I guess that makes sense. If my entire family is dead.”

Mami glanced at her, heart aching.

Kyoko didn't look back. Her gaze remained fixed on the projection.

Inside the church, Sayaka turned to current Kyoko.

“Where are we?” she asked.

Kyoko didn't answer right away.

She looked up—toward the shattered ceiling, the sky beyond.

Then she spoke.

"This was my father's church," she said. "We used to live here. All of us. My mom, my little sister... him."

Her voice was steady, but her grip on the apple tightened.

"For a while, it was good. We were happy. My dad preached, people came, we had food, laughter, warmth."

She took a bite of the apple—harder this time.

The crunch echoed through the empty space.

"But then he was excommunicated. For his beliefs. They said he was too radical. Too strange. People stopped coming. They stopped listening."

Her jaw clenched.

"He didn't say anything wrong. If they'd just listened with open minds, open hearts... they would've seen. He was right."

Sayaka said nothing.

She just watched Kyoko, her own soul still heavy from yesterday's revelation—that magical girls were souls in gems, their bodies mere shells.

Kyoko reached into the bag and tossed an apple toward her.

"Here," she said with a grin. "Take it. Eat."

Sayaka caught it, but didn't bite.

She held it in her hand, staring at it like it might answer something.

Kyoko continued.

"Then Kyubey showed up. Said he could grant me a wish. In exchange for becoming a magical girl."

She looked down at the apple in her hand, then back at Sayaka.

"I didn't want my family to suffer anymore. So I wished for people to listen to my father again. To hear him. To believe in him."

Her voice softened.

"And they did. They came back. In droves. The church was full again. My dad was happy. We had food. We had hope."

In the flower pod, Dream-Kyoko sat up straighter.

“This,” she said quietly, “is the last part I remember. The last part I lived.”

She looked at Mami, then at the projection.

“Everything after this... I haven’t experienced. Not really. But I’m ready.”

Her voice didn’t waver.

“I’m ready to face the tragedy that’s coming.”

Mami reached out, gently resting her hand on Kyoko’s.

Kyoko didn’t flinch.

She just watched.

As the story continued.

The projection held steady, the image of the ruined church bathed in noontime light.

Current Kyoko stood near the altar, Sayaka beside her, silent.

Kyoko stared at the broken stained glass, her fingers tightening around the apple in her hand. The skin creaked under the pressure.

“But all of that changed...” she said, her voice low. “On that fateful day...”

She paused.

Her grip on the apple tightened further, knuckles whitening. Her jaw clenched. The silence stretched.

Then, after a few deep breaths, she continued.

“My father eventually figured it out,” she said. “He realized the church’s success wasn’t real. It wasn’t earned. It was my wish. My magic. Not the people’s hearts.”

Her voice trembled slightly.

“He thought they were listening to lies. That everything he preached was hollow. That he was hollow.”

She looked down at the apple, then at Sayaka.

“He went mad.”

Another pause.

Kyoko’s voice dropped to a whisper.

“He killed himself. And my entire family. Everyone. Except me.”

She shed a single tear.

“I still remember the day I walked into this church and saw the bodies of my mom and younger sister. And I watched my father kill himself...”

She swallowed hard.

“It was very hard to watch. I was all alone...”

In the flower pod, Dream-Kyoko sat frozen, her expression unreadable.

Mami’s hand trembled slightly as she set down her tea.

The silence between them was heavy.

Then Mami spoke, her voice quiet.

“It’s just like the mural,” she said. “The story of the twelve girls. Their families were executed. The villagers turned on them when they found out about the magic.”

Dream-Kyoko nodded slowly.

“Ten magical girls. Two without soul gems. All hunted. All betrayed.”

She looked at the projection again, her voice bitter.

“So this is another version of it. Another reminder of how people react when they learn the truth.”

Mami’s gaze darkened.

“They don’t understand. They panic. They lash out. And we’re the ones who pay the price.”

Dream-Kyoko exhaled slowly.

“It’s not just fear. It’s rejection. Of everything we are.”

She looked at Mami.

“And it always starts the same way. With a wish. With hope.”

Mami nodded.

“And ends with loss.”

The projection held still—Kyoko and Sayaka standing in the ruined church, sunlight filtering through broken glass.

Sayaka stared at Kyoko, her expression unreadable. Her eyes were dull, almost lifeless, as if the weight of everything she’d learned had hollowed her out.

Her voice, when it came, was flat.

“That’s a sad story,” she said. “Thanks for sharing.”

She paused.

“But what was the point of telling me all this? Are you trying to get me to pity you? After what we learned yesterday?”

Kyoko didn’t flinch.

She met Sayaka’s gaze, wiped the tear from her cheek, and gave a small, forlorn smile.

“No,” she said softly. “I don’t want your pity.”

She stepped closer, her voice steady but gentle.

“I’m telling you this for *you*, Sayaka. Not for me.”

Sayaka blinked, but said nothing.

Kyoko continued.

“You’ve changed. Since yesterday. You’re quieter. You’re not arguing anymore. Not pacing. Not ranting about justice or saving people. That fire in your heart—it’s flickering.”

Sayaka looked away.

Kyoko’s voice dropped lower.

“I get it. I really do. When I made my wish, I thought I was saving my family. But it was that wish that got them killed. If I’d been selfish... maybe they’d still be alive.”

She looked around the ruined church, then back at Sayaka.

“That’s why I told you to let that witch familiar go. Let it evolve. Let us hunt it later. Yeah, stopping it early might save some people. But what about *us*? What about magical girls?”

Her voice sharpened—not angry, but raw.

“We risk our lives every day. We bleed. We suffer. And for what? For people who don’t even know what we are? Who’d turn on us if they found out?”

Sayaka’s grip on the apple tightened.

Kyoko took a breath.

“I’m sorry,” she said. “For the times I fought you. For trying to force my way of thinking on you. I almost killed you. Twice. If it weren’t for Madoka and Homura...”

She trailed off, then smiled again—warm, but tinged with sadness.

“I just want you to survive, Sayaka. That’s all. And the best way I know how... is to live for yourself. Not for anyone else. Not for ideals. Just for *you*.”

In the flower pod, Dream-Kyoko exhaled slowly.

“...That was hard to watch,” she said. “But I get it. I really do.”

She looked at Mami.

“I used to think living for yourself was selfish. But now... I think it’s survival.”

Mami’s eyes were soft, her voice quiet.

“She’s not wrong. But she’s not entirely right either.”

She looked at the projection, at the two girls standing in the ruins of a dream.

“Living only for yourself might keep you alive. But it can also leave you alone. And that’s its own kind of death.”

Dream-Kyoko nodded.

“Yeah. That’s the part she’s not saying. She *is* alone. And she hates it.”

Mami placed a hand over her soul gem.

“I want Sayaka to survive too. But I don’t want her to lose herself in the process.”

The projection shimmered, the image still frozen on Kyoko’s quiet, sad smile.

The projection continued.

Sayaka stared at Kyoko for a long moment, her expression blank, her eyes distant. Then, in a voice devoid of emotion, she spoke.

“...I appreciate you explaining your philosophy.”

Her tone was flat.

“I understand now. Why you let witch familiars go. Why you think the way you do. It makes sense.”

She paused, then added softly,

“But I’m sorry. I don’t want to live just for myself.”

She turned away.

“I’ll carve out my own path. As a magical girl.”

With that, Sayaka let the apple fall from her hand. It hit the ground with a dull thud, rolling slightly across the cracked stone floor.

She began walking toward the exit.

Kyoko’s eyes widened.

Her breath hitched.

Then rage surged.

She lunged forward, snatching the apple from the ground. In one swift motion, her chains erupted from her soul gem, wrapping around Sayaka’s body and pulling her to a halt.

Sayaka turned, her body bound, her expression unchanged.

“What are you doing?” she asked calmly. Apathetically.

Kyoko stood before her, eyes blazing.

“You don’t waste food,” she said, voice trembling. “Not in front of me.”

Sayaka blinked, unmoved.

Kyoko stared at her for a moment longer, then exhaled sharply.

She released the chains. They shimmered, then vanished into the air.

She rubbed the apple on her shirt, brushing away the dust and dirt, then gently placed it back into the bag.

“...Sorry,” she muttered. “I hate seeing food wasted. My family was starving after my dad was excommunicated. We had nothing. I guess I just... snapped.”

She looked at Sayaka again, her voice softening.

“I didn’t mean to lash out.”

Then, with a crooked smile and a flicker of dark humor, she added,

“If you waste food again, though... I may just kill you. Madoka and Homura won’t be there to save you next time.”

Sayaka stared at her, unblinking.

“Sure,” she said. “I’ll take that into account.”

The projection shimmered, the light softening as the ruined church held its silence.

Current Kyoko stood near the altar, her gaze steady on Sayaka’s retreating back. “You can carve out your own path,” she said, voice low but clear. “But what about carving it together?”

Sayaka paused.

Kyoko stepped forward, her words deliberate. “We don’t have to agree on everything—philosophy, ideals, how we live as magical girls. Fine. We can disagree. But we can still fight witches side by side. Share grief seeds. Watch each other’s backs.”

Sayaka turned slightly, her expression unreadable.

Kyoko held her gaze. “We’re not human anymore, Sayaka. No one else can understand what we carry. But you and I—we can. We don’t have to be friends. We just have to survive. Together.”

Kyoko looked down at her own soul gem, cradled in her palm. The crimson light pulsed faintly, like a heartbeat. She stared at it for a long moment, her brows furrowed.

Should I tell her? she thought. *Should I say it out loud?*

She took a breath.

Then looked up.

“When my family died,” she said quietly, “I wasn’t the same. I became bitter. Closed off. Angry.”

Her voice trembled slightly.

“I shoved everyone out of my life. Including Mami.”

Sayaka’s eyes flickered—just a hint of emotion breaking through the apathy.

“She was my mentor,” Kyoko said. “When I first became a magical girl. She taught me how to fight. How to survive. She was kind. Patient.”

She looked away.

“We severed our ties that day. I didn’t want anyone near me. Not even her.”

Sayaka’s gaze sharpened, her voice barely audible.

“Mami...”

Kyoko nodded.

“Yeah. Mami.”

She clenched her fists, arms trembling.

“And as we all know... she died.”

Her voice cracked.

“She fought alone.”

She looked up at the shattered ceiling, the light pouring through.

“If only I was still there for her,” she whispered. “She might still be alive.”

In the flower pod, Mami’s hand flew to her mouth.

Dream-Kyoko’s eyes shimmered.

“She regrets it,” Mami said softly. “She really regrets it.”

Kyoko turned to Sayaka, her voice steady again.

“So what do you think?”

She stepped closer.

“I see a reflection of myself in you. Becoming bitter. Pushing people away. Closing off.”

She paused.

“I don’t want you to end up like me. Fighting alone. Carrying regrets that never fade.”

Sayaka stared at her.

And the light through the broken glass painted them both in fractured gold.

The projection shimmered, holding the image of Kyoko and Sayaka in the ruined church, the light fractured through broken glass.

Sayaka stood still, her gaze lowered, her thoughts swirling.

Should I team up with her? she wondered. *Would it help? Would it change anything?*

She thought of Madoka. Of Mami. Of the truth they’d learned yesterday—that their souls were no longer in their bodies. That they were walking shells.

She thought of Kyoko’s story. The pain. The regret.

Then she looked up.

“I appreciate the offer,” Sayaka said quietly. “But no.”

Kyoko blinked.

Sayaka continued, her voice steady, but distant.

“I want to carve out my own path. As a magical girl. I want to save people. Be the bearer of justice. Of hope. Even if I have to shoulder the world alone.”

She gave Kyoko a small, forlorn smile.

“And besides... there are inconsistencies in your philosophy.”

Kyoko’s eyes widened.

“You said you wanted to live only for yourself. But now you want to team up with me? So what do you really believe in?”

She stepped closer, her gaze sharp but not cruel.

“And if you only lived for yourself... why do you feel regret for leaving Mami?”

Kyoko’s breath caught.

“So maybe,” Sayaka said softly, “you’re not as callous as you think you are.”

The silence that followed was heavy.

Kyoko stood frozen, stunned by the bluntness of Sayaka's words.

She had hoped—after everything they'd learned together, after the soul gem revelation—that Sayaka would want to fight alongside her. That shared pain would forge a bond.

But Sayaka was choosing solitude.

Kyoko swallowed hard.

"Please reconsider," she said. "One person can't shoulder the whole world. Look at what happened to Mami."

Sayaka nodded slowly.

"I know. But I'll be fine."

She paused, then added, "Besides... I learned something from Kyubey. Something Mami didn't know. Something that might help me in fights."

In the flower pod, Dream-Kyoko leaned forward.

"...What did Kyubey tell her?"

Mami's eyes narrowed, concern flickering.

"Whatever it was... it probably comes with a cost."

Kyoko in the projection looked startled.

"What did Kyubey tell you? You still trust him? After everything?"

Sayaka shook her head.

"I don't trust him completely. But he explained it in more detail than when he first told me about becoming a magical girl."

She looked down at her soul gem, her voice quiet but steady.

"He said our souls were removed from our bodies to protect us. That our bodies now are just shells—vessels that can take far more damage than a normal human ever could. And then..."

She hesitated, her fingers brushing the gem's surface.

"...he touched my soul gem. Just for a moment. And simulated what it would feel like if I still had a normal human body—if I took a witch's attack without that protection."

Her eyes darkened.

"The pain was... unbearable. I couldn't move. Couldn't breathe. It felt like I was being torn apart from the inside."

She looked up at Kyoko.

“That’s what we’re spared. That’s what we endure instead. I need to test it in a real fight. But if it’s true... it changes everything.”

Kyoko stared at her, stunned.

Sayaka turned toward the exit.

“Farewell, Kyoko.”

And she walked away.

Kyoko didn’t move.

She just watched her go.

In the flower pod, Dream-Kyoko exhaled slowly.

“...She’s really going to do it,” she murmured. “She’s going to fight alone.”

Mami’s voice was quiet, heavy with sorrow.

“She’s trying to be strong. But she’s carrying too much.”

She looked at Dream-Kyoko.

“And Kyubey... whatever he told her, it’s not just strategy. It’s manipulation. It always is.”

Kyoko nodded.

“She’s walking into something dark. And she doesn’t even know it yet.”

The projection dimmed, the church fading into soft light.

And in the flower pod, the girls sat in silence.

Watching.

Worrying.

And waiting.

The projection shifted.

Now it showed Sayaka sitting on a park bench beneath a canopy of golden leaves. The early afternoon light filtered through the trees, casting soft shadows across her school uniform. She smiled as Hitomi approached, but Mami and Dream-Kyoko could see it clearly—

That smile was a mask.

“She’s trying to act normal,” Mami murmured. “Trying to pretend everything’s fine.”

Dream-Kyoko nodded. “She’s cracking underneath. I can feel it.”

Hitomi sat beside Sayaka, her tone polite but direct.

“Thanks for meeting me. I wanted to talk about something important.”

Sayaka tilted her head, still smiling. “Sure. What’s up?”

Hitomi took a breath.

“I know you like Kyōsuke.”

Sayaka’s smile faltered.

Hitomi continued.

“But I can’t keep my feelings bottled up anymore. I like him too.”

Sayaka’s world stopped.

The projection held her frozen expression—eyes wide, lips parted, breath caught in her throat.

Not now, Sayaka thought. Not after everything. Not after learning I’m not even human anymore.

Hitomi kept speaking, unaware of the storm inside Sayaka.

“Out of respect for our friendship, I’ll give you until the end of school tomorrow to confess to him. If you don’t... I will.”

Sayaka didn’t respond.

Hitomi frowned slightly. “Are you okay?”

Sayaka chuckled weakly, her voice thin.

“It’s nothing. I’m just... nervous about confessing. That’s all.”

Hitomi smiled warmly.

“Well, good luck. But if you dawdle too long... Kyōsuke will be mine.”

She stood and walked off.

Sayaka remained seated.

The projection lingered on her trembling hands, her legs shaking, her eyes staring down at herself.

Her soul gem pulsed faintly—its light clouded, muddy.

In the flower pod, Mami leaned forward.

“Her soul gem... it’s changing.”

Dream-Kyoko’s voice was tight.

“She’s starting to descend.”

Then—

A voice.

“Sayaka!”

Madoka ran into view, her face lit with concern.

“Are you okay? I’ve been looking for you. After everything we learned yesterday... I just wanted to check in.”

She paused, noticing Sayaka’s trembling form, her vacant eyes.

“What’s wrong? Can I help?”

Sayaka blinked, her mind barely registering Madoka’s voice.

Then she stood—and threw her arms around her.

She sobbed.

Loudly. Uncontrollably.

Madoka held her, stunned by the sudden collapse of the girl who had always tried to be strong.

“I don’t know what to do anymore,” Sayaka cried. “I’m about to lose the love of my life. The person I gave up my humanity for.”

Madoka’s eyes widened. “What do you mean?”

Sayaka pulled back slightly, her hands gripping Madoka’s shoulders, her eyes red and overflowing.

“I wished for Kyōsuke to get better. So he could play the violin again. That was my wish.”

She looked down at herself—at her hands, her uniform, her trembling legs.

“But now I know... I’m not human anymore. My body’s just a shell. My soul is in this gem.”

She held up her soul gem, its light flickering like a dying star.

“And just now, Hitomi told me she likes Kyōsuke too. She’s giving me until tomorrow to confess. If I don’t... she will.”

Madoka was speechless.

Sayaka’s voice dropped to a whisper.

“I can’t bring myself to do it... to confess to Kyōsuke in this body.”

She looked at her hands again, as if they no longer belonged to her.

“How could I? How could I tell him I love him when I’m not even... real?”

She sobbed again, her voice raw and broken.

“How is fate so cruel? The irony of it all. I wished for someone else’s sake... and now I’m losing him.”

She looked up at Madoka, tears streaming down her face, her smile trembling.

“Maybe Kyoko’s right. Maybe living only for yourself is the way to survive.”

Madoka’s lips parted, but no words came out.

She could only whisper, “Sayaka...”

Her voice trailed off, heavy with sorrow.

Sayaka took a few deep breaths, trying to steady herself.

“Thank you,” she said. “For listening.”

Madoka nodded, her heart aching.

“You’re strong,” she said. “Stronger than anyone I know.”

But inside, she wasn’t sure.

Sayaka stretched her arms, rolling her shoulders.

“Want to join me for a witch hunt?” she asked. “I’m testing out a new fighting technique today.”

Madoka blinked, surprised.

“...Sure.”

And the two girls walked off together.

In the flower pod, Mami and Dream-Kyoko sat in silence.

“She can’t even see herself as worthy of love anymore,” Mami whispered.

Dream-Kyoko’s voice was tight.

“She’s slipping. And she’s trying to fight harder to make up for it.”

Mami nodded.

“But fighting harder won’t fix what’s breaking inside.”

The projection shimmered.

And Sayaka’s descent continued.

The projection shifted again.

Sayaka and Madoka walked side by side toward the witch's labyrinth, the afternoon light dimming as the air grew heavier. The path was familiar—one they'd walked many times before. But this time, it felt different.

Madoka glanced at Sayaka, her heart aching.

Sayaka wasn't smiling. She wasn't talking. Her steps were mechanical, her gaze distant—fixed somewhere far beyond the twisting path ahead. A far cry from the cheerful girl who used to walk beside Madoka with a spring in her step, chattering endlessly about music, life dreams, and love.

Back then, their walks to school were filled with laughter and light. Sayaka would gush about Kyōsuke's violin performances, tease Madoka about her crushes, and dream aloud about becoming a hero—someone who could protect others and make the world better.

Now, she was silent.

Madoka glanced at her, heart heavy.

Where did that girl go? she wondered. *What happened to the spark?*

The silence between them was louder than any scream.

She's fading, Madoka thought. *What should I do?*

At the labyrinth's entrance, they saw Kyoko waiting, her lance resting against her shoulder.

Kyoko blinked in surprise.

"Sayaka? Madoka? Didn't expect to see you two here."

She looked at Sayaka, hesitant.

"Are you okay with us going in together?"

Sayaka's voice was flat.

"I don't mind."

Kyoko nodded, though her eyes lingered on Sayaka's expression.

They entered the labyrinth together.

Inside, the world twisted—walls pulsing with surreal patterns, gravity bending, sounds echoing from nowhere. Witch familiars swarmed, shrieking and lunging.

Kyoko and Sayaka fought side by side.

Their coordination was sharp. Efficient. Sayaka blocked, Kyoko struck. Kyoko swept wide, Sayaka followed up. They made good progress.

Kyoko grinned, panting slightly.

"Nice work, Sayaka. We're a good team."

Sayaka didn't look at her.

"Yeah. Sure."

She moved on.

Kyoko's smile faded.

Madoka watched from behind, her concern deepening.

They're working together, she thought. But Sayaka's not really here. She's just... moving.

Expressionless. Robotic. A husk.

Madoka turned to Kyoko.

"What happened to her? Since yesterday?"

Kyoko gripped her lance tighter, her knuckles pale.

"She's breaking. I can feel it. She's not the same girl who fought and argued with me yesterday. She's... hollow."

Madoka's heart sank.

In the flower pod, Dream-Kyoko leaned forward.

"This isn't teamwork," she said. "It's just proximity."

Mami nodded.

"When we trained together, we connected. We trusted. This... this is just survival."

The projection shifted.

They reached the witch's chamber.

A grotesque creature loomed ahead—its body a writhing mass of tendrils, jagged symbols, and pulsing voids. The air was thick with malevolence, vibrating with a soundless pressure that made the walls tremble.

Kyoko stepped forward, her lance gleaming in the dim light.

"Sayaka," she said, steady but cautious, "let's coordinate. We should—"

But Sayaka didn't wait.

She leapt.

Straight into the witch's grasp.

Kyoko and Madoka gasped in unison.

"Sayaka!" Madoka cried, voice cracking. "It's not safe!"

Kasumi leaned forward, eyes gleaming with a mix of thrill and dread.

“Ohoho... reckless. Dangerous. But fascinating.”

She tilted her head, watching intently.

“I wonder what she’ll do with the info Kyubey gave her. About magical girl bodies being shells. More durable. Less pain...”

The witch responded instantly.

Tendrils lashed out—dozens of them—whipping through the air with a sickening hiss. They struck Sayaka mid-air, impaling her through the arms, the legs, her abdomen, her shoulders. Her body jerked violently with each impact, suspended like a marionette in a web of agony.

Madoka screamed.

Kyoko’s eyes widened in horror.

“No—!”

She lunged forward, but Sayaka snarled, her voice guttural.

“I don’t need your support!”

The tendrils retracted, flinging Sayaka’s body to the ground like discarded meat.

She lay there for a moment.

Then—

She stood.

Her magical girl outfit was torn, the fabric shredded and hanging in tatters. Bloodless gashes crisscrossed her limbs—deep, jagged wounds that would have been fatal to any normal human. Her body was riddled with damage, yet she stood upright, her posture eerily steady.

But she looked... intact.

Physically.

Her eyes, though—

Madoka recoiled, hand over her mouth.

Sayaka’s gaze was wild. Unhinged. Her pupils dilated, her expression twisted into a grin that didn’t reach her soul.

She laughed.

Loudly.

Maniacally.

“Kyubey was right!” she cried. “I feel no pain!”

Kyoko froze, her grip on her lance trembling.

“Sayaka... what’s happening to you?”

Madoka’s voice was barely a whisper, trembling with fear.

“Please stop. This isn’t good for you...”

Sayaka didn’t listen.

She charged again.

The witch’s tendrils struck her—again and again—impaling her through the chest, the neck, the stomach. Her body convulsed, but she kept moving, slashing wildly, laughing louder.

“I’m not strong,” she shouted. “So I have to fight like this! I have to survive!”

Her soul gem pulsed—dark, cloudy, corrupted. The light inside it flickered like a dying flame.

In the flower pod, Mami’s hand flew to her mouth.

“She’s losing herself,” she whispered. “This isn’t just reckless. It’s suicidal.”

Dream-Kyoko’s voice was tight, her eyes locked on the projection.

“She’s not fighting the witch. She’s punishing herself.”

Kasumi’s grin faded into a solemn line.

“She fights like I do,” she said. “Tanking damage. Pressing forward. Handling pain her own way. It *can* work... Normally I would be very fired up to see someone fighting like this...”

She looked at Sayaka’s soul gem, now nearly opaque.

“But her spirit is failing. Her heart succumbs. This kind of fighting... it only works if you’re anchored. If you’re whole.”

She sighed.

“She’s breaking. And she doesn’t care.”

Madoka stepped forward in the projection, tears in her eyes.

“Sayaka, please... this isn’t you.”

But Sayaka didn’t hear her.

She reached the witch's core and began slashing mercilessly, her laughter echoing through the labyrinth like a siren of despair.

And the others watched.

Horrified.

Helpless.

The witch let out a final, piercing cry—a sound that echoed through the collapsing labyrinth like a dying scream, raw and mournful. The world around them began to dissolve, the twisted geometry of the witch's domain unraveling into motes of light, like ash scattered in wind.

As the last remnants of the labyrinth faded, a grief seed dropped to the ground with a soft clink.

Sayaka stood alone in the center of the clearing, her magical girl outfit torn, her body riddled with wounds. Her soul gem pulsed with a sickly, dark glow—its light dim and clouded, like a storm brewing behind glass.

Kyoko and Madoka stood frozen, mouths slightly agape, unable to speak.

The witch's final cry still rang in their ears, but it wasn't just the sound of death—it was the sound of despair. Of something beautiful being torn apart.

It echoed what they felt inside.

Kyoko's voice trembled as she stepped forward, trying to steady herself.

"Sayaka... you did it. You beat the witch on your own."

She swallowed hard.

"But... are you okay? You're hurt. And your soul gem—it's getting dark. You should use the grief seed. I don't need it."

Sayaka turned slowly, her expression unreadable.

Then, without a word, she tossed the grief seed to Kyoko.

"I don't need it," she said flatly. "I've found another path."

Kyoko caught it, startled.

Sayaka continued, her voice eerily calm.

"I can nullify pain. Disregard my body. Push through any fight. I don't need purification. I don't need soul gems. I can protect everyone like this."

Kyoko stared at her, stunned.

“That’s not how this works,” she said. “Sayaka, please—use it. Before something happens.”

She tossed the grief seed back.

Sayaka caught it, looked at it for a moment.

Then dropped it on the ground.

“If you don’t want it, fine,” she said. “I’ll just throw it away.”

Madoka stepped forward, tears in her eyes.

“Sayaka, please... stop,” she begged, her voice trembling. “This isn’t healthy. You can’t just ignore your body like that. You’re still—”

Sayaka turned to her.

Her eyes were mostly apathetic.

But behind them—something darker stirred.

Contempt. Bitterness. A flicker of hatred.

Madoka froze, her breath catching.

“Sayaka...?” she whispered.

Sayaka’s voice came low and sharp, like a blade drawn in silence.

“What do you know, Madoka? How could you possibly understand?”

She stepped closer, her shadow falling over Madoka.

“You’re still human. Your body, your soul—they’re still yours. You get to be whole. You get to cry and worry and pretend you’re helping.”

She gestured to herself, her fingers trembling.

“I’m a magical girl. My body’s an empty shell. My soul’s in a rock. I’m not even real anymore.”

Her voice cracked, but her tone remained cold.

“I can’t even confess to Kyōsuke. Not like this. Not when I’m just a puppet made of flesh and magic.”

She looked down at her hands, disgust flickering across her face.

“So what’s wrong with throwing this body away? What’s wrong with using it to fight? It’s all it’s good for now.”

Madoka collapsed to her knees, sobbing.

Sayaka had never spoken to her like this.

Never looked at her like that.

But Sayaka wasn't done.

She leaned in, her voice dropping to a venomous whisper.

"If you really want to help, Madoka... then make a wish."

Madoka's eyes widened.

"Become a magical girl," Sayaka said. "Right here. Right now."

Madoka stuttered, her voice breaking.

"I... I don't..."

She couldn't finish.

She couldn't move.

She crumbled to her knees.

Sayaka scoffed, her lip curling.

"Pathetic."

She turned away.

"Go home, Madoka. You don't belong here."

Madoka reached out, her hand trembling.

"Sayaka..."

Madoka remained on her knees, her arms reaching out toward Sayaka, trembling.

She couldn't speak.

Her breath came in shallow gasps, her chest tight with grief.

That wasn't Sayaka, she thought. Not the Sayaka I know. Not the one who used to laugh with me, dream with me, protect me.

Her fingers curled slightly, as if trying to grasp something already gone.

She's slipping away... and I don't know how to bring her back.

Tears streamed down her cheeks as she watched Sayaka walk farther and farther from the girl she used to be.

And farther from the friend Madoka loved.

Kyoko stepped forward, her voice rising.

“How can you say that to her? She’s your friend! She’s trying to help you!”

Sayaka didn’t flinch.

“What did I say that was wrong?” she asked. “Everything I said is true. Madoka can’t understand what I’m feeling. No one can.”

She turned to Kyoko, her expression softening into something almost mournful.

“Maybe you were right,” she said. “Cutting people out. Living only for yourself. Maybe that’s the only way to survive.”

Kyoko’s breath caught.

“No,” she said. “That’s not what I meant. Not like this.”

She stepped forward, her voice cracking.

“Yeah, I lived alone. I pushed people away. But I still took care of myself. I still used grief seeds. I didn’t throw everything away.”

She looked at Sayaka, pleading.

“But you—you’re not even trying to survive. You’re just... giving up.”

Sayaka laughed.

Cold. Hollow.

Her footsteps echoed into the distance.

In the flower pod, Dream-Kyoko sat with her arms wrapped around her knees, her eyes fixed on the fading projection.

“I’m glad,” she whispered. “Glad to see my future self... still cares. Even after everything. Even after saying she lives only for herself.”

Her voice trembled.

“But Sayaka... at this rate...”

Mami’s eyes shimmered with tears.

“She’s in so much pain. And she’s pushing away the only people who care.”

She looked at Kyoko, her voice barely above a whisper.

“We have to find a way to reach her. Before it’s too late.”

Kyoko nodded slowly, her gaze distant.

“But how do you reach someone who doesn’t want to be saved?”

The projection dimmed.

The grief seed still lay on the ground, untouched.

And the silence that followed felt like the beginning of something irreversible.

The projection resumed.

Sayaka walked through the city at night, her footsteps echoing softly against the pavement. The streetlights cast long shadows, and the world around her felt hollow—buildings silent, windows dark, the air heavy with a kind of stillness that only came when something was about to break.

Eventually, she reached the park.

The same park where she and Hitomi had spoken about Kyōsuke.

But as she stepped into the clearing, another wave of memories washed over her.

This was the place where she and Madoka used to spend their afternoons.

Picnics under the cherry blossoms.

Chasing each other through the grass, playing tag until they collapsed in laughter.

Sharing secrets, dreams, and fears.

Talking about love and life and what they wanted to be when they grew up.

Sayaka walked slowly to the bench and sat down.

The wind rustled the leaves.

She stared at the empty playground.

Then she broke.

Her shoulders trembled, her hands clenched in her lap.

“I was so stupid,” she muttered. “So stupid...”

Her voice cracked.

“I hurt her. I hurt my best friend. I looked at her with bitterness... jealousy... even hatred.”

She buried her face in her hands.

“And Kyoko... I pushed her away too. She tried to help me. She was the only one left who understood. And I threw her away.”

She looked up at the sky, her eyes shimmering with tears.

“Now I’m really alone.”

From a distance, Homura watched.
She stood in the shadows, her expression unreadable.
But her eyes softened.
She had seen this before.
Too many times.
Sayaka's descent was not new to her.
But it never hurt less.
"So the spiral begins again," she murmured. "Sayaka..."
Her voice was quiet. Almost mournful.
In the flower pod, Dream-Kyoko leaned forward, her voice tight.
"Sayaka... she's remembering what she lost. What she threw away."
Mami's eyes were wet.
"She's not just grieving. She's punishing herself."
Kyoko nodded slowly.
"She thinks she deserves this. That being alone is the price for her mistakes."
Mami whispered, "But no one deserves to feel that way."
Then Mami fell silent, her gaze drifting toward Homura's silhouette in the projection.
She put a hand to her chin, her thoughts swirling.
"And then there's Homura..." she murmured. "'The spiral begins again.' She said **again**."
Her eyes narrowed.
"She's watching Sayaka like she's seen this before. Like she knows exactly what's coming..."
Mami's voice dropped to a whisper.
"Does she mean Sayaka is about to become a witch? If so... how does she know? None of us knew. Not even the current Kyoko."
She stared at Homura, her heart beginning to race.
"Just who is Homura?"
Then, like a thread tugged loose from memory, something surfaced.

Mami's eyes widened.

She remembered what Lunaria had told her on her first night in the realm.

'Homura has been through more than you can imagine. Someday you will understand.'

At the time, Mami hadn't paid it much mind. Lunaria had been speaking about the truth of magical girls, about a new way to live—about resisting despair. And Mami had been too overwhelmed, too focused on survival.

But now...

She looked around at the others in the flower pod.

Lunaria. Kasumi. Dream-Kyoko.

They all looked back at her.

Their expressions were soft. Knowing. Silent.

"They know something," Mami thought. *"They've seen something. Something I haven't."*

Her gaze returned to Homura.

"Hopefully I'll understand someday," she whispered. "Maybe... when I bring Homura into this realm."

The flower pod pulsed gently around them.

And the mystery deepened.

The projection dimmed.

Then faded away.

Silence settled over the flower pod, soft and heavy. Mami and Dream-Kyoko sat quietly, both deep in thought, the echoes of Sayaka's descent still lingering in the air like smoke after a fire.

Mami turned to Lunaria and Kasumi, her voice low but urgent.

"It looks like I don't have much time left," she said. "If Sayaka's soul gem continues to darken... I have to learn that small portion of disconnect. The one that lets me siphon the darkness and disperse it back into the universe as energy. Before it's too late."

She looked at Lunaria, eyes pleading.

"How hard is it to learn?"

Lunaria's expression softened, her eyes tinged with sorrow.

“Unfortunately... it’s not simple,” she said gently. “You only learned about connect today. And while you’ve felt what it’s like—through the simulation, through the consciousness of a girl who connected—you haven’t actually used it yourself.”

She paused.

“And disconnect... even just that small portion you’re talking about... it’s not something you can master in a few days.”

Mami’s heart sank.

Her shoulders slumped, her gaze falling to her lap.

“I might not learn it in time,” she whispered. “I might not be able to help her...”

Dream-Kyoko reached out, placing a hand on Mami’s shoulder.

“Hey,” she said softly. “Don’t spiral. You’re trying. That matters. And you’re not alone.”

Mami looked up, her eyes shimmering.

Kasumi stepped forward, her gaze bright and encouraging.

“There’s another way,” she said. “Another path to help Sayaka.”

Mami blinked, hope flickering in her chest.

“There is?”

Kasumi smiled.

“What Lunaria and I are seeing and doing in Kamihama today... it’s interesting. Strange. But promising. It’s possible that whatever comes from our adventures there could help you save Sayaka.”

She paused.

“But we won’t know for sure until tomorrow morning.”

Mami nodded slowly, her voice steadier.

“Thank you,” she said. “That means a lot.”

She looked at Kasumi, curious.

“But what exactly do you mean by ‘whatever comes from your adventures’? What’s happening in Kamihama?”

Lunaria chuckled softly.

“It would take too long to explain right now,” she said. “And honestly... we’re still not sure how it’ll end.”

She stepped beside Kasumi.

“The real us will return later tonight. We’ll talk with you in the morning. Everything will be clearer then.”

Kasumi gave a playful wink.

“And don’t forget—tomorrow morning is the big fight. You and Dream-Kyoko, showcasing your powers with connect. You better be ready.”

Mami chuckled, the tension in her chest easing.

Dream-Kyoko grinned, her eyes gleaming.

“Oh, we’ll be ready.”

The two girls reached out and clasped hands—firm, steady, a promise.

A promise to put on a good show.

Kasumi, Lunaria, and Dream-Kyoko stood, their expressions warm.

“It’s been a long day,” Kasumi said. “You should rest.”

Lunaria nodded. “Good night, Mami.”

They faded away in a shimmer of sparkles, dissolving into the arena’s light.

And Mami found herself standing once more in front of the cabin.

She looked up at the stars.

Then smiled.

Her heart was still heavy.

But it was warmed.

She clung to hope.

And stepped inside, ready to wind down for the night.

Mami stepped into her room and closed the door behind her.

She looked at the bed and smiled.

This was the first night she’d spent alone in this realm.

But it didn't feel like the kind of loneliness she used to know—those long, hollow nights in her apartment, when the silence pressed in like a second skin and the only sound was the ticking of a clock she no longer needed.

This was different.

Tomorrow, she would fight. Not alone, but with someone she trusted—Kyoko, from before the tragedy. The Kyoko who still believed in people. The Kyoko who still believed in her.

And Kasumi and Lunaria would return too. Hopefully with good news. A way to save Sayaka before it was too late.

She would see friends tomorrow.

Friends.

Something she never truly had when she was a magical girl.

Mami yawned, her eyelids heavy. Today had been long—full of action, learning, and emotion.

She crawled into bed, pulled the covers over her, and let her body relax.

Sleep came quickly.

And with it, dreams.

Chapter 11b– Mami's dream – alternate ending to the mural story

She was standing in a forest clearing, the sky above her painted in the same hues as the mural—deep crimson, gold, and violet. The air shimmered with magic.

Beside her stood Kyoko.

But not the current Kyoko from her memories.

This was Dream-Kyoko, still burning with fire.

They were the two girls from the mural.

But this time, they were themselves.

And they remembered everything.

They watched as the villagers turned on the magical girls—on them. Their families were dragged into the square. Accused. Condemned. Executed.

Mami's breath caught.

She reached for Kyoko's hand.

But Kyoko was already moving.

Screaming.

Furious.

She summoned her lance and charged into the crowd, striking down the villagers who came at them with torches and rocks. Her movements were wild, desperate—self-defense, yes, but also vengeance. Her strikes were precise, but her fury was uncontained.

The villagers recoiled in horror.

“She’s attacking!” one shouted. “We knew it! These girls are dangerous—evil!”

“Surround them!” another cried. “Don’t let them escape!”

More villagers poured in from the edges of the square, rallying ropes, and crude weapons. Their fear had curdled into rage, and Kyoko’s retaliation had confirmed every suspicion they’d buried beneath superstition.

Mami stood frozen for a moment, her breath caught in her throat.

Then she summoned her muskets—furious, trembling, ready to mow down the villagers just as they had done to her family.

Her hands shook.

Her heart thundered.

She could feel the rage rising, sharp and blinding, begging to be unleashed.

But then—

She closed her eyes.

Took a deep breath.

And didn’t fire.

Instead, she raised her arms—and golden ribbons burst forth, swirling around the remaining magical girls. They looped and twisted through the air, forming a protective dome that shimmered with light, shielding the girls from the chaos.

Her fury didn’t vanish.

But she chose to protect.

Not destroy.

“Run!” Mami shouted. “Get to safety!”

She turned to Kyoko, her voice sharp.

“Don’t lose yourself!”

Kyoko didn’t answer.

But her grip on the lance tightened.

And she slowed.

Just enough.

Together, they broke through the encirclement, Mami’s ribbons lashing out to clear a path, Kyoko guarding their flank. The other ten magical girls followed close behind, their faces pale, their eyes wide with shock.

They fled into the woods.

The sounds of shouting and pursuit faded behind them.

And the night swallowed them whole.

Later, around a fire, the twelve of them sat in silence.

The flames crackled softly, casting flickering shadows across their faces. The night air was cool, but the grief hanging over them was suffocating—thick and heavy, like fog that refused to lift.

No one spoke.

Some stared into the fire.

Others clutched their knees, eyes hollow.

Then Mami’s gaze drifted across the circle.

And her breath caught.

Six of the girls—quiet, withdrawn—had soul gems that were visibly clouding. The once-bright light inside them had dimmed to a murky gray, swirling with corruption. One gem in particular pulsed faintly, like a heartbeat on the edge of failure.

Kyoko noticed too.

She leaned toward Mami, voice low.

“This is it,” she whispered. “This is when they turned.”

Mami nodded slowly.

The mural's tragedy was unfolding before their eyes.

But this time—they were here.

Before the darkness could take hold, Mami stood.

"There's something you all need to know," Mami said, her voice cutting through the silence like a thread of gold.

She held up her soul gem.

Its golden glow was steady—but tinged with darkness. A quiet storm swirled inside it, the residue of grief she hadn't yet released. She didn't hide it.

"This is me," she said. "My soul. My body is just a shell."

Gasps rippled through the group.

The girls leaned forward, eyes wide, some clutching their own soul gems instinctively.

Mami looked at the fire, then back at them.

"When you fight witches... have you noticed something?"

The girls exchanged confused glances.

Mami continued.

"You get hit. You get thrown. You take damage that would kill a normal human. But you get back up. You keep fighting."

She held up her soul gem again.

"That's not luck. That's design."

She let the silence settle, heavy and still.

"Kyubey made us this way. Our bodies are shells—more durable, more resistant to pain. So we can fight witches without dying immediately."

The girls stared at her.

One of them whispered, "So we're not human anymore..."

Another said, "The villagers were afraid of us because of our powers. But if what you said is true... then we truly are different..."

Kyoko stepped forward, her voice steady but urgent.

“Yes, we are different. Our bodies are durable shells—but our soul gems are not. If you use too much magic, your soul gem will break. And you’ll die.”

More murmurs spread through the group.

“So we’re basically rocks now?”

“No... that can’t be true... What’s the point of even living?”

The soul gems of the girls began to darken at an alarming rate.

Swirls of shadow churned inside them, like ink dropped into water.

Kyoko and Mami exchanged a glance.

They nodded.

“But that’s not the worst of it,” Mami said.

She looked at each of them, her eyes firm.

“If you fall into despair... if you give up... your soul gem will explode. And you’ll become a witch.”

The girls recoiled.

“No...” one whispered. “That’s not true...”

Kyoko’s voice hardened.

“It is. That’s what Kyubey wants, to prevent the universe from ending. When a magical girl becomes a witch and their soul gem explodes, a lot of energy back into the universe. That’s why he made us. To fight. To suffer. To die.”

The words hung in the air like poison.

The girls began to tremble.

Some cried.

Some clenched their fists.

Others looked down at their soul gems, horror dawning in their eyes.

“We’re just fuel,” one of them said. “There’s no hope...”

The darkness continued to consume them.

Their soul gems pulsed erratically, on the brink of exploding.

But then—

Mami stepped forward again.

And smiled.

“There is hope.”

Kyoko stood beside her, her stance strong.

“There is another way,” she said. “A way to fight without falling.”

Mami raised her soul gem, still tainted with a bit of darkness.

“We can control our emotions,” she said. “We can use the darkness—not let it consume us, but channel it. Turn it into strength.”

She took a breath.

“Watch.”

She summoned her muskets and aimed them at the sky.

Closed her eyes.

Focused.

She reached into the grief inside her soul gem—not to erase it, but to understand it. To hold it. To shape it.

Then she opened her eyes.

“Hah!” Mami shouted.

A single, radiant shot burst from her muskets and soared into the sky.

It exploded high above them.

And from that explosion—

Sparkles drifted down like falling stars.

Soft. Luminous. Endless.

A starfall.

The same kind of starfall that had marked the end of the simulation—the moment Elira, Sylvette, and Mirielle had defeated the shadow monster.

The same starfall that had marked their final breath.

But this time—

It was a beginning.

The girls looked up, eyes wide, mouths parted in awe.

Some reached out, hands trembling, as if trying to catch the stars.

Mami held up her soul gem again.

It shone radiantly.

“See?” she said. “Bright again. You don’t need grief seeds.”

The girls stared at her.

Then at their own soul gems.

And slowly—

The corruption began to slow.

The swirling darkness within each soul gem paused, as if held back by something unseen. Not erased. Not yet lifted. But no longer accelerating toward collapse.

The fire crackled softly, casting warm light across the circle of girls.

Then Kyoko stepped forward.

“There’s more,” she said, her voice low but steady. “You can connect with each other. Not just your magic—but your very selves. The core of who you are.”

Some of the girls blinked, confused.

“What does that mean?” one asked.

“How do we do that?” another added.

Kyoko smiled.

She reached out to two girls, one with each hand, and gently invited them to take hold.

“Just trust me,” she said. “Everyone else—grab the hands of the person next to you.”

The girls hesitated.

A few glanced at each other, unsure.

What did hand-holding have to do with magic?

But slowly, one by one, they reached out.

Fingers met fingers.

Palms pressed together.

And soon, all twelve girls were holding hands—forming a circle around the fire.

Kyoko closed her eyes.

“Now,” she said, “open yourselves up. Try to connect. Not just with your magic—but with your feelings. Your memories. Your hopes. Let them flow.”

The girls obeyed.

And then—

It happened.

Magic surged between them.

A soft pulse at first, like a heartbeat shared across twelve bodies.

Then stronger.

Each girl’s mind opened.

Each heart unfolded.

They felt each other—truly felt each other.

Not just surface thoughts, but the essence beneath.

Their magic.

Their emotions.

Their very souls.

Their **prayers, sadness, rage, hatred, joy, pleasure, and wishes.**

They felt **sadness**—deep and raw—from the loss of their families, from the betrayal of their village.

They felt **rage** and **hatred**—at the villagers who had executed their loved ones, and at themselves for making the wish that led to this fate. For being seen. For being feared.

Joy and **pleasure** were faint—like echoes from a distant life.

But **prayers** and **wishes**...

They were strong.

Wishing they could go back to the days before magic.

Before grief.

Before fear.

And **praying with hope** they could live together.

Stay together.

Support each other.

The feelings swirled between them, luminous and heavy.

Each girl's thoughts became shared.

What is this feeling?

This is incredible.

I'm not alone.

They feel what I feel.

The circle pulsed with light.

And for the first time—

They understood what it meant to be connected.

The circle of girls pulsed with light.

Their hands remained clasped, but their minds were wide open—woven together like threads in a tapestry of grief, memory, and longing.

Mami's voice echoed gently through their thoughts.

Isn't this feeling incredible?

This is the technique called connect.

The girls turned toward her, eyes wide, hearts still trembling from the surge of emotion.

Mami continued, her tone soft and luminous.

When magical girls truly understand each other—when they're completely open, like we are now—this happens. Your magic, your very selves, begin to sync. Not just added together... but significantly magnified.

She looked around the circle.

Your abilities evolve. You gain access to each other's magic, instincts, and strengths. The limits of what you can do together... are only bound by your imagination.

The girls gasped.

They could feel it.

Power flowing through them—not just their own, but everyone's.

One girl whispered, *“I can feel her magic... like it’s mine.”*

Another said, *“I think I could combine mine with hers... and create something new.”*

A third murmured, *“It’s like we’re dreaming together.”*

Mami nodded.

But there’s something important to remember. If there’s misunderstanding... if one of you resists... the connection weakens. Sometimes it fails completely.

The girls fell quiet.

Then one of them said, *“That makes sense. This feeling... it’s fragile. But beautiful.”*

Another added, *“It’s like trust. You have to give it fully.”*

Mami smiled.

Now that you understand connect... I want to show you one more technique. A very advanced one.

The girls leaned in, eyes gleaming with curiosity.

“What is it?” one asked.

Mami closed her eyes.

She didn’t know how to do it.

But she imagined.

She focused.

And whispered aloud—

“Dis-connect.”

A pulse of light rippled outward.

And then—

The darkness began to move.

From each girl’s soul gem, the negativity—suffering, fury, hatred—was gently siphoned out. It didn’t vanish. It hovered, forming soft, glowing orbs above each gem.

The girls gasped.

They felt lighter.

As if a weight they hadn’t known they were carrying had suddenly lifted.

The suffocating pressure was gone.

They could breathe.

Mami opened her eyes and gestured to the orbs.

See? This is the reverse of connect. Instead of syncing magic, dis-connect siphons magical energy from a target. And that includes negativity.

She looked at the orbs.

Earlier, I used emotional control to channel the darkness in my own soul gem—to create the starfall. This is the same principle. But now... I'm doing it for you.

She smiled, a little playfully.

And since Kyubey's goal is to keep the universe from ending by constantly supplying it with energy...

She raised her hand.

The orbs shimmered.

Then drifted upward.

And dispersed.

Back into the universe.

The girls opened their eyes.

They looked down at their soul gems.

They were shining.

Radiant.

Just like Mami's.

Tears welled in their eyes—but they were tears of joy.

The joy and pleasure that had faded were now blooming again.

The sadness, rage, and hatred that had once consumed them were now quiet. Manageable.

They felt hope.

Genuine hope.

For the first time since the nightmare began—

They believed in tomorrow.

The fire crackled softly as the girls sat in a circle, their soul gems glowing with renewed light.

One by one, they turned to Mami and Kyoko, eyes shimmering with gratitude.

“Thank you,” one said. “For sharing all of this.”

Another added, “We didn’t know any of it. But now... we have what we need to keep going.”

Mami and Kyoko smiled warmly, accepting the gratitude with quiet grace.

Then Mirielle—always the curious one—tilted her head.

“How did you know all this?” she asked. “Where did you learn it?”

Mami’s and Kyoko’s expressions softened.

Their eyes grew distant, touched by memory.

They thought of Lunaria and Kasumi.

Of the nights spent training, laughing, struggling.

Of the beginner simulations that turned out to be anything but beginner.

Of the moments they were utterly defeated—and the moments they were lifted back up.

Of the way Lunaria and Kasumi had changed them.

Not just as magical girls.

But as people.

Mami and Kyoko looked at Mirielle and smiled, eyes twinkling with nostalgia.

“We learned it from two friends,” Mami said. “Very good friends.”

Kyoko nodded. “Friends who saved us. Who showed us a new way to live. A new way to think about magic, the world... and ourselves.”

Mirielle blinked.

“Who were they?” she asked. “How come I’ve never met them? And when did you need saving? Were you hiding something from us?”

Elira, Sylvette, and Hoshine leaned in, intrigued.

“We’ve never heard of these two,” Elira said.

Sylvette added, “What did they save you from?”

Hoshine frowned. “Were you going through something alone?”

The other girls echoed the questions, their voices gentle but curious.

Mami and Kyoko chuckled.

They exchanged a glance.

“They’re... complicated,” Kyoko said.

Mami nodded. “Even though we’re close, we still know very little about them. They’re enigmatic. They don’t reveal much about who they really are.”

Mirielle’s eyes lit up with fascination.

“Enigmatic friends who are secretive and seem to know everything?” she said, smiling. “Very interesting. I hope I get to meet them one day. I have so many questions.”

The other girls agreed.

They began to speculate.

“Are they magical girls?” one asked.

“Spirits?” another wondered.

“Figures that appear in dreams?” a third offered.

Mami and Kyoko smiled.

“Perhaps one day,” Mami said softly. “You’ll meet them.”

Kyoko added, “And when you do... you’ll understand.”

The fire flickered gently.

The circle of girls sat in quiet wonder.

Then Mami lowered her head slightly, brought her hands to her chest, and closed her eyes.

A heavy ache rose in her heart.

If only Lunaria and Kasumi were there back then, she thought. If only they came to save these girls... just like they did with me...

The dream held her in its warmth.

But the sorrow lingered.

Chapter 11c– Mami’s dream – saving Sayaka

The warmth of the fire faded.

The circle of girls dissolved into mist.

And Mami’s dream began to shift.

She was no longer in the forest clearing.
She was drifting—weightless, suspended in a sea of stars.
Her thoughts turned to Lunaria and Kasumi.
To their adventures in Kamihama.
To the strange, beautiful, and dangerous things they were encountering today.
And her heart whispered:
Maybe... maybe there's another path.
She knew she wouldn't be able to learn even a sliver of dis-connect in time.
But maybe Lunaria and Kasumi would find something.
Something unexpected.
Something powerful.
Her dream unfolded into vivid fragments—possibilities blooming like constellations.

In one vision, Mami found herself drifting through a vast, moonlit cathedral—its stained glass shattered, its pews overgrown with vines. The air shimmered with residual magic, and the silence was thick with sorrow.

At the center of the ruin stood Lunaria.

Her hands glowed with a strange, translucent light—neither golden nor violet, but something in between. A color that felt like memory itself.

Before her hovered a creature.

It was not a witch in the traditional sense.

It had no labyrinth.

No grotesque limbs or mocking familiars.

It was made of memory and grief—fragments of a girl's life, stitched together by sorrow. Faces flickered across its surface. Laughter. Regret. A music box tune. A broken promise.

Lunaria did not raise a weapon.

She spoke.

Softly.

Gently.

She asked the creature what it had lost.

What it still remembered.

What it still wanted.

The creature trembled.

And wept.

Its form unraveled—not violently, but tenderly.

And from its dissolution—

Petals fell.

Hundreds of them.

Soft, white, and glowing.

They drifted through the cathedral like snow.

Above, on a crumbling balcony, Kasumi watched.

Her eyes were sharp, calculating—but not cold.

Something pulsed faintly around her—a resonance, like a tuning fork vibrating in sympathy with the world.

She whispered to Lunaria, her voice echoing through the dream:

“This isn’t just purification. It’s transmutation.”

Mami’s heart leapt.

Could they be discovering a way to rewrite despair itself?

Not just cleanse it.

Not just delay it.

But change its nature.

Transform it into something else.

If this is possible, Mami thought, then maybe Sayaka doesn’t need to be saved by force. Maybe she doesn’t need to be purified or disconnected. Maybe her despair can be rewritten—transmuted—into something gentle. Something survivable.

She imagined Sayaka standing in that cathedral.

Her soul gem dark.
Her heart heavy.
But instead of being torn apart—
She would be asked what she remembered.
What she still wanted.
And maybe—
Just maybe—
She would weep.
And dissolve into petals.
Not as a witch.
But as a girl.
Still whole.
Still herself.

In another vision, Mami found herself standing at the edge of a vast leyline—an ancient artery of magical energy that pulsed through the earth like a living river of light.

It surged across the landscape, glowing with hues of silver, violet, and deep blue. The air around it shimmered, thick with emotion. Not just raw power, but feeling—grief, longing, joy, rage—all woven into the current like threads in a tapestry.

Lunaria and Kasumi stood at the river's edge.

They weren't fighting.

They were listening.

Lunaria knelt, her fingers brushing the leyline's surface. Her eyes closed, her expression serene. She whispered something Mami couldn't hear, and the energy responded—rippling outward in gentle waves.

Kasumi stood nearby, observing with quiet intensity. Something in her presence resonated with the leyline. She raised a hand, and a burst of energy rose from the flow—then shifted.

It became music.

A haunting melody, full of sorrow and beauty.

Kasumi laughed, delighted.

Lunaria opened her eyes and began to dance with the current, her movements fluid and graceful, like she was weaving with the leyline itself.

Mami watched in awe.

They weren't suppressing the grief in the leyline.

They were harmonizing with it.

Redirecting it.

Not erasing the darkness—but guiding it into a form that could be held, understood, and transformed.

Could they be learning how to reroute despair before it ever reaches the soul gem? Mami wondered.

She imagined Sayaka standing at the edge of this leyline.

Her soul gem darkening.

But instead of being overwhelmed, the grief inside her would be drawn outward—into the leyline, where it could be reshaped. Not into a witch, but into something luminous. Something survivable.

What if magical girls didn't have to carry all their despair alone? Mami thought. *What if the world itself could help them hold it?*

She imagined a future where magical girls could anchor their emotions into leyline sanctuaries—places where grief could be sung, danced, and woven into light.

Where soul gems didn't have to break.

Where Sayaka could stand in the current and feel her pain lifted—not erased, but shared.

And maybe—

That would be enough.

The dream shifted again.

Mami now stood in a vast, crystalline chamber beneath Kamihama—a place pulsing with magical infrastructure, where leyline conduits met artificial circuits in a fusion of ancient and modern design.

At the center of it all stood Lunaria and Kasumi.

They were working alongside Touka, Nemu, Alina, and the rest of the Wings of the Magius, surrounded by glowing terminals and floating data glyphs. The air buzzed with energy, not chaotic, but focused—like the hum of a spell being rewritten.

They were refining the Automatic Purification System.

And the Doppel system.

But this time, something was different.

A breakthrough had been found.

Mami watched as a simulation unfolded in the air—a magical girl whose soul gem was on the brink of collapse.

In previous iterations, this moment would have triggered a Doppel transformation.

But the side effects of that process were still unknown to Mami.

She remembered the way Mitama had spoken—carefully, almost evasively—when Kasumi showed a projection of her time in Kamihama the day before. There had been hints. Glimpses. Suggestions that the Doppel system carried consequences that Mitama could not reveal.

But now—

The system intervened.

Gently.

Precisely.

The girl transformed into a Doppel—but she remained fully conscious. Fully in control. Her emotions stabilized. Her magic surged. And when the transformation ended, she returned to herself—unharméd, unburdened.

Or in another simulation, the system didn't trigger a Doppel at all.

Instead, it rerouted the despair through a new channel—an emotional buffer that harmonized the grief before it could crystallize into corruption.

Mami's eyes widened.

This isn't just prevention, she thought. It's transformation. Intervention. A safeguard that adapts to each girl's emotional state.

And most importantly—

Every magical girl understood how it worked.

There were no secrets.

No hidden costs.

No fine print.

The system was transparent.

Accessible.

Empowering.

Touka, Nemu, and Alina worked tirelessly—alongside magical girls both within and outside the Wings of the Magius—to spread information about the new framework across the world. They held open forums, translated documentation into dozens of languages, and invited feedback from every region and faction. No voice was dismissed. No question ignored.

Together, they refined the system.

Not in isolation, but in communion.

Lunaria stood beside a projection of the framework, her presence calm and grounding. She offered gentle support and encouragement to all involved—answering questions, guiding discussions, and reminding everyone that this wasn't just a technical solution, but a philosophical shift.

Kasumi, meanwhile, was a whirlwind.

She threw out wild ideas—some brilliant, some baffling, some that exploded in spectacular failure. But her energy was infectious. Her charisma lit up every room. And even her failed experiments sparked new insights, pushing the framework into territory no one had considered before.

Mami watched all of it unfold in her dream.

She saw a future where magical girls weren't just surviving.

They were building.

Together.

Mami felt her heart lift.

If this becomes real, she thought, then Sayaka doesn't have to be saved by me. She doesn't have to be purified or disconnected. She doesn't have to fall.

The system will catch her.

And she'll rise.

She imagined a future where magical girls around the world no longer feared their own emotions.

Where despair was no longer a death sentence.

Where Doppels were not curses, but expressions—safe, powerful, and understood.

Where Sayaka could fight.

Could feel.

Could live.
And maybe—
That would be enough.

Chapter 11d– Mami’s dream – about Homura

The crystalline chamber faded.

The leyline dissolved into mist.

And Mami’s dream shifted once more.

She was standing in a quiet, empty street at twilight—near the park where Sayaka had broken down in the projection Lunaria showed her. The air was still, heavy with memory. Sayaka’s sobs echoed faintly, as if the dream were replaying the moment from a distance.

Then she heard a voice.

Homura’s voice.

Low. Steady. Resigned.

“The spiral begins again.”

The words—*spiral* and *again*—unsettled her.

They didn’t sound like metaphor.

They sounded like memory.

Like someone who had seen this before.

Mami’s breath caught.

Her dream shifted again.

She was no longer in a street, but in a vast, circular chamber filled with floating screens. Each one flickered with scenes of magical girls—some she recognized, others she didn’t. Some were fighting witches. Some were crying. Some were falling.

And in every screen—

The ending was the same.

Despair.

Transformation.

Witchhood.

Mami stepped forward, heart pounding.

Is this what Homura sees? she wondered. Simulations? Visions?

She imagined Homura standing in this chamber, watching the tragedies play out again and again. Not as a prediction. Not as a theory. But as something she had witnessed.

What if Homura has access to something like the mural simulation Kyoko and I saw? Mami thought. But deeper. Older. Wider. A record of magical girls across time. Across possibilities.

The dream shifted again.

Now Mami stood at the edge of a cliff, looking out over a vast ocean of stars.

Each star pulsed with a different future.

A different possibility.

And in each one—

Something went wrong.

Madoka was lost.

Sayaka fell.

Mami herself died.

Kyoko broke.

The spiral repeated.

Again.

And again.

And again.

Mami clutched her soul gem in the dream, its light flickering.

What if Homura's wish... she thought, whatever it was... gave her access to these visions?

She didn't know what Homura had wished for.

But she imagined it was something desperate.

Something born of love.

Something that came with a cost.

She imagined Homura seeing all of these tragic pasts and futures—trying to change things, trying to save someone, trying to break the spiral.

And failing.

Not because she was weak.

But because the spiral was stronger.

Mami's heart ached.

No wonder she's so quiet. So guarded. So cold.

She's seen too much.

And now, when she saw Sayaka descending into despair—

She didn't panic.

She didn't scream.

She simply said:

"The spiral begins again."

Because she had seen it before.

Because she knew what came next.

And because—

She was still trying to stop it.

Mami whispered into the dream:

I don't know who you are, Homura.

But I will understand you one day.

The stars faded.

The city park dissolved.

And Mami's dream began to slip away, like mist between her fingers.

She felt herself drifting—deeper now, beyond the vivid visions and imagined futures, into the soft, formless dark of true sleep.

But her thoughts lingered.

Hovering at the edge of consciousness.

There was so much she didn't know.

So much waiting for her on the other side of morning.

A kind of uncertainty that was almost... exhilarating.

What will Kyoko and I face tomorrow? she wondered, a faint smile tugging at her lips. *What kind of "horrible" fight has Kasumi prepared for us this time?*

She imagined Kasumi's mischievous grin.

The way she always said "beginner-level" with far too much enthusiasm.

She imagined herself and Kyoko, hands clasped, magic flowing between them in perfect sync. The thrill of connect. The rush of shared power. The joy of fighting not alone.

But then—

Her thoughts turned heavier.

More fragile.

Will Sayaka... become a witch?

The question echoed in her chest like a bell.

Will Kasumi and Lunaria come back with good news? Will they find another way?

And if they don't...

She didn't finish the thought.

She didn't want to.

Not now.

Not here.

The questions would still be waiting when she woke.

But for now—

She let them go.

Let them drift.

Let them rest.

And as the last threads of her dream unraveled, Mami Tomoe surrendered to sleep.

Deep.

Still.

Silent.

The night held her gently.

And the future waited.